PHIL 112: Modern Philosophy

Boğaziçi University
(Spring 2026)

Instructor: Saniye Vatansever
E-**mail:** saniye.vatansever@gmail.com
Office: John Freely, 5th Floor.
Office Hours: By appointment

Course Description: The primary objective of this course is to engage with the writings of several prominent modern philosophers, such as Rene Descartes, Thomas Hobbes, Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz, David Hume, John Locke, Immanuel Kant and John Stuart Mill. We will critically analyze the writings of these prominent modern thinkers as they attempt to answer fundamental philosophical questions about God, human nature, and morality. particular, we will debate whether moral norms possess objective validity; if so, we will analyze their foundations and the methods through which they are known. Some of the question we will try to answer this semester will include the following: Do objective and universal moral laws exist? If so, are they products of God's will, reason, our sentiments, pleasure, or social contract? By examining these seminal texts, we will therefore evaluate different philosophical theories concerning the origins of morality.

Required Texts: I will upload the PDFs of the required readings on Moodle.

Course Requirements: The course grade consists of two exams (50% each). Students must achieve a passing grade on both assignments to pass the course. A failing grade on one exam will result in an overall failing grade for the course.

Midterm Exam	50%
Final Exam	50%

Attendance Policy: I will take attendance for this class. Missing more than 10 hours of class in total will lead to a reduction of 5 points (5%) from the final grade.

Participation: You are expected to express your opinions, raise questions about the assigned material/subject and show that you have read the text carefully and thought about it before the class.

Classroom Disruptions:

Behaviors that disrupt the class (e.g. conversations with your classmates) will not be tolerated.

All electronic devices (computers, cell phones, music players, headphones, etc.) must be kept off and put away during the class.

Plagiarism and Academic Dishonesty: Since plagiarism and other forms of academic dishonesty are violations of Boğaziçi University standards, I will not tolerate any form of cheating. Students who cheat during the exam will receive an "F" for the entire course and will be referred to the university disciplinary committee.

Course Schedule

Week 1: Introduction
Introduction to the course mechanics
Descartes 1st *Meditation*

Week 2: Descartes
2nd & 3rd *Meditations*

Week 3: Descartes
4th, 5th and 6th *Meditations*

Week 4: Elizabeth of Bohemia's Letters
Descartes' Correspondence with Elizabeth of Bohemia

Week 5: Hobbes
Leviathan (ch. I-II-III-VI)

Week 6: Leibniz
The Discourse on Metaphysics (Selections)

Week 7: Leibniz
The Discourse on Metaphysics (Selections)

Midterm Exam (Date to be determined)!

Week 8: Hume
An Enquiry Into the Source of Morality (Sect. 1-2-3)

Week 9: Hume
An Enquiry Into the Source of Morality (Sect. 4-5)

Week 10: Kant
Groundwork (pg. 1-36)

Week 11: Kant
Groundwork (pg. 37-52)

Week 12: Mill
Utilitarianism (Ch 1-2)

Week 13: Mill
Utilitarianism (Ch. 3-4)

Final Exam (Date to be determined)!

OXFORD WORLD'S CLASSICS

RENÉ DESCARTES

Meditations on First Philosophy

With Selections from the Objections and Replies

Translated with an Introduction and Notes by

MICHAEL MORIARTY

OXFORD
UNIVERSITY PRESS

FIRST MEDITATION 17

OF THOSE THINGS THAT MAY BE CALLED INTO DOUBT

It is some years now since I realized how many false opinions I had accepted as true from childhood onwards,* and that, whatever I had since built on such shaky foundations, could only be highly doubtful. Hence I saw that at some stage in my life the whole structure would have to be utterly demolished, and that I should have to begin again from the bottom up if I wished to construct something lasting and unshakeable in the sciences. But this seemed to be a massive task, and so I postponed it until I had reached the age when one is as fit as one will ever be to master the various disciplines. Hence I have delayed so long that now I should be at fault if I used up in deliberating the time that is left for acting. The moment has come, and so today I have discharged my mind from all its cares, and have carved out a space of 18
untroubled leisure. I have withdrawn into seclusion and shall at last be able to devote myself seriously and without encumbrance to the task of destroying all my former opinions.

To this end, however, it will not be necessary to prove them all false—a thing I should perhaps never be able to achieve. But since reason already persuades me that I should no less scrupulously withhold my assent from what is not fully certain and indubitable than from what is blatantly false, then, in order to reject them all, it will be sufficient to find some reason for doubting each one. Nor shall I therefore have to go through them each individually, which would be an endless task: but since, once the foundations are undermined, the building will collapse of its own accord, I shall straight away attack the very principles that form the basis of all my former beliefs.

Certainly, up to now whatever I have accepted as fully true I have learned either from or by means of the senses: but I have discovered that they sometimes deceive us, and prudence dictates that we should never fully trust those who have deceived us even once.

But perhaps, although they sometimes deceive us about things that are little, or rather a long way away, there are plenty of other things of which there is clearly no doubt, although it was from the senses that we learned them: for instance, that I am now here, sitting by the fire, wrapped in a warm winter gown, handling this paper,

and suchlike. Indeed, that these hands themselves, and this whole body are mine—what reason could there be for doubting this? Unless
19 perhaps I were to compare myself to one of those madmen, whose little brains have been so befuddled by a pestilential vapour arising from the black bile,* that they swear blind that they are kings, though they are beggars, or that they are clad in purple, when they are naked, or that their head is made of clay, or that their whole body is a jug, or made entirely of glass. But they are lunatics, and I should seem no less of a madman myself if I should follow their example in any way.

This is all very well, to be sure. But am I not a human being, and therefore in the habit of sleeping at night, when in my dreams I have all the same experiences as these madmen do when they are awake—or sometimes even stranger ones? How often my sleep at night has convinced me of all these familiar things—that I was here, wrapped in my gown, sitting by the fire—when in fact I was lying naked under the bedclothes.—All the same, I am now perceiving this paper with eyes that are certainly awake; the head I am nodding is not drowsy; I stretch out my hand and feel it knowingly and deliberately; a sleeper would not have these experiences so distinctly.—But have I then forgotten those other occasions on which I have been deceived by similar thoughts in my dreams? When I think this over more carefully I see so clearly that waking can never be distinguished from sleep by any conclusive indications that I am stupefied; and this very stupor comes close to persuading me that I am asleep after all.

Let us then suppose* that we are dreaming, and that these particular things (that we have our eyes open, are moving our head, stretching out our hands) are not true; and that perhaps we do not even have hands or the rest of a body like what we see. It must nonetheless be admitted that the things we see in sleep are, so to speak, painted images, which could not be formed except on the basis of a resemblance with real things; and that for this reason these general things at least (such as eyes, head, hands, and the rest of the body) are not imaginary things, but real and existing. For the fact is that when
20 painters desire to represent sirens and little satyrs with utterly unfamiliar shapes, they cannot devise altogether new natures for them, but simply combine parts from different animals; or if perhaps they do think up something so new that nothing at all like it has ever been seen, which is thus altogether fictitious and false, it is certain that at

least the colours which they combine to form images must be real. By the same token, even though these general things—eyes, head, hands, and so forth—might be imaginary, it must necessarily be admitted that at least some other still more simple and universal realities must exist, from which (as the painter's image is produced from real colours) all these images of things—be they true or false—that occur in our thoughts are produced.

In this category it seems we should include bodily nature in general, and its extension; likewise the shape of extended things and their quantity (magnitude and number); likewise the place in which they exist, the time during which they exist, and suchlike.

From all this, perhaps, we may safely conclude that physics, astronomy, medicine, and all the other disciplines which involve the study of composite things are indeed doubtful; but that arithmetic, geometry, and other disciplines of the same kind, which deal only with the very simplest and most general things, and care little whether they exist in nature or not, contain something certain and indubitable. For whether I am waking or sleeping, two plus three equals five, and a square has no more than four sides; nor does it seem possible that such obvious truths could be affected by any suspicion that they are false.

However, there is a certain opinion long fixed in my mind, that 21
there is a God who is all-powerful, and by whom I was created such as I am now. Now how do I know that he has not brought it about that there is no earth at all, no heavens, no extended things, no shape, no magnitude, no place—and yet that all these things appear to me to exist just as they do now?* Or even—just as I judge now and again that other people are mistaken about things they believe they know with the greatest certitude—that I too should be similarly deceived whenever I add two and three, or count the sides of a square, or make a judgement about something even simpler, if anything simpler can be imagined?

But perhaps God has not willed that I should be so cheated, for he is said to be supremely good.—But if it were incompatible with his goodness to have created me such that I am perpetually deceived, it would seem equally inconsistent with that quality to permit me to be sometimes deceived. Nonetheless, I cannot doubt that he does permit it.

Perhaps, indeed, there might be some people who would prefer to deny the existence of any God so powerful, rather than believing that all other things are uncertain. But let us not quarrel with them, and

let us grant that all this we have said of God is only a fiction; and let them suppose that it is by fate or chance or a continuous sequence of things that I have come to be what I am. Since, though, to be deceived and to err appear to be some kind of imperfection, the less powerful the source they invoke to explain my being, the more probable it will be that I am so imperfect that I am perpetually deceived. To all these arguments, indeed, I have no answer, but at length I am forced to admit that there is nothing of all those things I once thought true, of which it is not legitimate to doubt—and not out of any thoughtlessness or irresponsibility, but for sound and well-weighed reasons; and therefore that, from these things as well, no
22 less than from what is blatantly false, I must now carefully withhold my assent if I wish to discover any thing that is certain.*

But it is not enough to have realized all this, I must take care to remember it: for my accustomed opinions continually creep back into my mind, and take possession of my belief, which has, so to speak, been enslaved to them by long experience and familiarity, for the most part against my will. Nor shall I ever break the habit of assenting to them and relying on them, as long as I go on supposing them to be such as they are in truth, that is to say, doubtful indeed in some respect, as has been shown just now, and yet nonetheless highly probable, so that it is much more rational to believe than to deny them. Hence, it seems to me, I shall not be acting unwisely if, willing myself to believe the contrary, I deceive myself, and make believe, for some considerable time, that they are altogether false and imaginary, until, once the prior judgements on each side have been evenly balanced in the scales, no evil custom can any longer twist my judgement away from the correct perception of things. For I know for sure that no danger or error will ensue as a result of this, and that there is no risk that I shall be giving too free a rein to my distrustfulness, since my concern at the moment is not with action but only with the attainment of knowledge.*

I will therefore suppose that, not God, who is perfectly good and the source of truth, but some evil spirit, supremely powerful and cunning, has devoted all his efforts to deceiving me.* I will think that the sky, the air, the earth, colours, shapes, sounds, and all external things are no different from the illusions of our dreams, and that they
23 are traps he has laid for my credulity; I will consider myself as having no hands, no eyes, no flesh, no blood, and no senses, but yet as falsely

believing that I have all these;* I will obstinately cling to these thoughts, and in this way, if indeed it is not in my power to discover any truth,* yet certainly to the best of my ability and determination I will take care not to give my assent to anything false, or to allow this deceiver, however powerful and cunning he may be, to impose upon me in any way.

But to carry out this plan requires great effort, and there is a kind of indolence that drags me back to my customary way of life. Just as a prisoner, who was perhaps enjoying an imaginary freedom in his dreams, when he then begins to suspect that he is asleep is afraid of being woken up, and lets himself sink back into his soothing illusions; so I of my own accord slip back into my former opinions, and am scared to awake, for fear that tranquil sleep will give way to laborious hours of waking, which from now on I shall have to spend not in any kind of light, but in the unrelenting darkness of the difficulties just stirred up.

SECOND MEDITATION

OF THE NATURE OF THE HUMAN MIND; THAT IT IS MORE EASILY KNOWN THAN THE BODY

Yesterday's meditation has plunged me into so many doubts that I still cannot put them out of my mind, nor, on the other hand, can I see any way to resolve them; but, as if I had suddenly slipped into 24
a deep whirlpool, I am in such difficulties that I can neither touch bottom with my foot nor swim back to the surface. Yet I will struggle on, and I will try the same path again as the one I set out on yesterday, that is to say, eliminating everything in which there is the smallest element of doubt, exactly as if I had found it to be false through and through; and I shall pursue my way until I discover something certain; or, failing that, discover that it is certain only that nothing is certain. Archimedes* claimed, that if only he had a point that was firm and immovable, he would move the whole earth; and great things are likewise to be hoped, if I can find just one little thing that is certain and unshakeable.

I therefore suppose that all I see is false; I believe that none of those things represented by my deceitful memory has ever existed; in fact I have no senses at all; body, shape, extension in space, motion,

and place itself are all illusions. What truth then is left? Perhaps this alone, that nothing is certain.

But how do I know that there is not something different from all those things I have just listed, about which there is not the slightest room for doubt? Is there not, after all, some God, or whatever he should be called, that puts these thoughts into my mind? But why should I think that, when perhaps I myself could be the source of these thoughts? But am I at least not something, after all? But I have already denied that I have any senses or any body. Now I am at a loss,
25 because what follows from this? Am I so bound up with my body and senses that I cannot exist without them? But I convinced myself that there was nothing at all in the world, no sky, no earth, no minds, no bodies. Did I therefore not also convince myself that I did not exist either? No: certainly I did exist, if I convinced myself of something.—But there is some deceiver or other, supremely powerful and cunning, who is deliberately deceiving me all the time.—Beyond doubt then, I also exist, if he is deceiving me; and he can deceive me all he likes, but he will never bring it about that I should be nothing as long as I think I am something. So that, having weighed all these considerations sufficiently and more than sufficiently, I can finally decide* that this proposition, 'I am, I exist', whenever it is uttered by me, or conceived in the mind, is necessarily true.

But indeed I do not yet sufficiently understand what in fact this 'I' is that now necessarily exists;* so that from now on I must take care in case I should happen imprudently to take something else to be me that is not me, and thus go astray in the very knowledge [*cognitione*] that I claim to be the most certain and evident of all. Hence I shall now meditate afresh on what I once believed myself to be, before I fell into this train of thought. From this I shall then subtract whatever it has been possible to cast doubt on, even in the slightest degree, by the reasons put forward above, so that in the end there shall remain exactly and only that which is certain and unshakeable.

So what in fact did I think I was before all this? A human being, of course. But what is a human being? Shall I say, 'a rational animal'?* No, for then I should have to examine what exactly an animal is, and what 'rational' is, and hence, starting with one question, I should stumble into more and more difficult ones. Nor do I now have so much leisure that I can afford to fritter it away on subtleties of this kind. But here I shall rather direct my attention to the thoughts that

spontaneously and by nature's prompting came to my mind before- 26
hand, whenever I considered what I was. The first was that I have a face, hands, arms, and this whole mechanism of limbs, such as we see even in corpses; this I referred to as the body. Next, that I took nourishment, moved, perceived with my senses, and thought: these actions indeed I attributed to the soul.* What this soul was, however, either I never considered, or I imagined it as something very rarefied and subtle, like a wind, or fire, or thin air, infused into my coarser parts. But about the body itself, on the other hand, I had no doubts, but I thought I distinctly knew its nature, which, if I had attempted to describe how I conceived it in my mind, I would have explained as follows: by body I mean everything that is capable of being bounded by some shape, of existing in a definite place, of filling a space in such a way as to exclude the presence of any other body within it; of being perceived by touch, sight, hearing, taste, or smell, and also of being moved in various ways, not indeed by itself, but by some other thing by which it is touched; for to have the power of moving itself, and also of perceiving by the senses or thinking, I judged could in no way belong to the nature of body; rather, I was puzzled by the fact that such capacities were found in certain bodies.

But what about now, when I am supposing that some deceiver, who is supremely powerful and, if I may venture to say so, evil, has been exerting all his efforts to delude me in every way? Can I affirm that I possess the slightest thing of all those that I have just said belong to the nature of body? I consider, I think, I go over it all in my 27
mind: nothing comes up. It would be a waste of effort to go through the list again. But what about the attributes I used to ascribe to the soul? What about taking nourishment or moving? But since I now have no body, these also are nothing but illusions. What about sense-perception? But certainly this does not take place without a body, and I have seemed to perceive very many things when asleep that I later realized I had not perceived. What about thinking? Here I do find something: it is thought; this alone cannot be stripped from me. I am, I exist, this is certain. But for how long? Certainly only for as long as I am thinking; for perhaps if I were to cease from all thinking it might also come to pass that I might immediately cease altogether to exist. I am now admitting nothing except what is necessarily true: I am therefore, speaking precisely, only a thinking thing, that is, a mind, or a soul, or an intellect, or a reason—words the meaning of

which was previously unknown to me. I am therefore a true thing, and one that truly exists; but what kind of thing? I have said it already: one that thinks.

What comes next? I will imagine: I am not that framework of limbs that is called a human body; I am not some thin air infused into these limbs, or a wind, or a fire, or a vapour, or a breath, or whatever I can picture myself as: for I have supposed that these things do not exist. But even if I keep to this supposition, nonetheless I am still something.*—But all the same, it is perhaps still the case that these very things I am supposing to be nothing, are nevertheless not distinct from this 'me' that I know* [*novi*].—Perhaps: I don't know. But this is not the point at issue at present. I can pass judgement only on those things that are known to me. I know [*novi*] that I exist; I am trying to find out what this 'I' is, whom I know [*novi*]. It is absolutely certain that this knowledge [*notitia*], in the precise sense in question
28 here, does not depend on things of which I do not yet know [*novi*] whether they exist; and therefore it depends on none of those things I picture in my imagination. This very word 'imagination' shows where I am going wrong. For I should certainly be 'imagining things' if I *imagined* myself to be anything, since imagining is nothing other than contemplating the shape or image of a bodily thing. Now, however, I know [*scio*] for certain that I exist; and that, at the same time, it could be the case that all these images, and in general everything that pertains to the nature of body, are nothing but illusions. Now this is clear to me, it would seem as foolish of me to say: 'I shall use my imagination, in order to recognize more clearly what I am', as it would be to say: 'Now I am awake, and I see something true; but because I cannot yet see it clearly enough, I shall do my best to get back to sleep again so that my dreams can show it to me more truly and more clearly.' And so I realize [*cognosco*] that nothing that I can grasp by means of the imagination has to do with this knowledge [*notitiam*] I have of myself, and that I need to withdraw my mind from such things as thoroughly as possible, if it is to perceive its own nature as distinctly as possible.

But what therefore am I? A thinking thing. What is that? I mean a thing that doubts, that understands, that affirms, that denies, that wishes to do this and does not wish to do that, and also that imagines and perceives by the senses.

Well, indeed, there is quite a lot there, if all these things really do belong to me. But why should they not belong to me? Is it not me who currently doubts virtually everything, who nonetheless understands something, who affirms this alone to be true, and denies the rest, who wishes to know more, and wishes not to be deceived, who imagines many things, even against his will, and is aware of many things that appear to come via the senses? Is there any of these things 29
that is not equally true as the fact that I exist—even if I am always asleep, and even if my creator is deceiving me to the best of his ability? Is there any of them that can be distinguished from my thinking? Is there any that can be said to be separate from me? For that it is I that am doubting, understanding, wishing, is so obvious that nothing further is needed in order to explain it more clearly. But indeed it is also this same I that is imagining; for although it might be the case, as I have been supposing, that none of these imagined things is true, yet the actual power of imagining certainly does exist, and is part of my thinking. And finally it is the same I that perceives by means of the senses, or who is aware of corporeal things as if by means of the senses: for example, I am seeing a light, hearing a noise, feeling heat.—But these things are false, since I am asleep!—But certainly I *seem to* be seeing, hearing, getting hot. This cannot be false. This is what is properly meant by speaking of myself as having sensations; and, understood in this precise sense, it is nothing other than thinking.

From all of this, I am indeed beginning to know [*nosse*] rather better what I in fact am. But it still seems (and I cannot help thinking this) that the bodily things of which the images are formed in our thought, and which the senses themselves investigate, are much more distinctly recognized than that part of myself, whatever it is, that cannot be represented by the imagination. Although, indeed, it is strange that things that I realize are doubtful, unknown, unrelated to me should be more distinctly grasped by me than what is true and what is known—more distinctly grasped even than myself. But I see what is happening. My mind enjoys wandering off the track, and will not yet allow itself to be confined within the boundaries of truth. Very well, then: let us, once again, slacken its reins as far as possible— 30
then, before too long, a tug on them at the right moment will bring it more easily back to obedience.*

Let us consider those things which are commonly thought to be more distinctly grasped than anything else: I mean the bodies we

touch and see; but not bodies in general, for these general perceptions are usually considerably more confused, but one body in particular. Let us, for example, take this wax: it has only just been removed from the honeycomb; it has not yet lost all the flavour of its honey; it retains some of the scent of the flowers among which it was gathered; its colour, shape, and size are clearly visible; it is hard, cold, easy to touch, and if you tap it with your knuckle, it makes a sound. In short, it has all the properties that seem to be required for a given body to be known as distinctly as possible. But wait—while I am speaking, it is brought close to the fire. The remains of its flavour evaporate; the smell fades; the colour is changed, the shape is taken away, it grows in size, becomes liquid, becomes warm, it can hardly be touched, and now, if you strike it, it will give off no sound. Does the same wax still remain? We must admit it does remain: no one would say or think it does not. So what was there in it that was so distinctly grasped? Certainly, none of those qualities I apprehended by the senses: for whatever came under taste, or smell, or sight, or touch, or hearing, has now changed: but the wax remains.

Perhaps the truth of the matter was what I now think it is: namely, that the wax itself was not in fact this sweetness of the honey, or the fragrance of the flowers, or the whiteness, shape, or sonority, but the body which not long ago appeared to me as perceptible in these modes,* but now appears in others. But what exactly is this that I am
31 imagining in this way? Let us consider the matter, and, thinking away those things that do not belong to the wax, let us see what remains. Something extended, flexible, mutable: certainly, that is all. But in what do this flexibility and mutability consist? Is it in the fact that I can imagine this wax being changed in shape, from a circle to a square, and from a square into a triangle? That cannot be right: for I understand that it is capable of innumerable changes of this sort, yet I cannot keep track of all these by using my imagination. Therefore my understanding of these properties is not achieved by using the faculty of imagination. What about 'extended'? Surely I know something about the nature of its extension. For it is greater when the wax is melting, greater still when it is boiling, and greater still when the heat is further increased. And I would not be correctly judging what the wax is if I failed to see that it is capable of receiving more varieties, as regards extension, than I have ever grasped in my imagination. So I am left with no alternative, but to accept that I am

not at all *imagining* what this wax is, I am perceiving it with my mind alone: I say 'this wax' in particular, for the point is even clearer about wax in general. So then, what is this wax, which is only perceived by the mind? Certainly it is the same wax I see, touch, and imagine, and in short it is the same wax I judged it to be from the beginning. But yet—and this is important—the perception of it is not sight, touch, or imagination, and never was, although it seemed to be so at first: it is an inspection by the mind alone, which can be either imperfect and confused, as it was before in this case, or clear and distinct, as it now is, depending on the greater or lesser degree of attention I pay to what it consists of.

But in the meantime I am amazed by the proneness of my mind to error. For although I am considering all this in myself silently and without speech, yet I am still ensnared by words themselves, and all 32
but deceived by the very ways in which we usually put things. For we say that we 'see' the wax itself, if it is present, not that we judge it to be there on the basis of its colour or shape. From this I would have immediately concluded that I therefore knew the wax by the sight of my eyes, not by the inspection of the mind alone—if I had not happened to glance out of the window at people walking along the street. Using the customary expression, I say that I 'see' them, just as I 'see' the wax. But what do I actually see other than hats and coats, which could be covering automata?* But I judge that they are people. And therefore what I thought I saw with my eyes, I in fact grasp only by the faculty of judging that is in my mind.

But one who desires to know more than the common herd might be ashamed to have gone to the speech of the common herd to find a reason for doubting. Let us then go on where we left off by considering whether I perceived more perfectly and more evidently what the wax was, when I first encountered it, and believed that I knew [*cognoscere*] it by these external senses, or at least by what they call the 'common sense',* that is, the imaginative power; or whether I perceive it better now, after I have more carefully investigated both what it is and how it is known [*cognoscatur*]. Certainly it would be foolish to doubt that I have a much better grasp of it now. For what, if anything, was distinct in my original perception? What was there, if anything, that seemed to go beyond the perception of the lowest animals?* But on the other hand, when I distinguish the wax from its external forms, and, as if I had stripped off its garments, consider it in all its

nakedness, then, indeed, although there may still be error in my judgements, I cannot perceive it in this way except by the human mind.

33 But what, then, shall I say about this mind, or about myself? For I do not yet accept that there is anything in me but a mind. What, I say, am I who seem to perceive this wax so distinctly? Do I not know [*cognosco*] myself not only much more truly, much more certainly, but also much more distinctly and evidently than the wax? For, if I judge that the wax exists, for the reason that I see it, it is certainly much more evident that I myself also exist, from the very fact that I am seeing it. For it could be the case that what I am seeing is not really wax; it could be the case that I do not even have eyes with which to see anything; but it certainly cannot be the case, when I see something, or when I think I am seeing something (the difference is irrelevant for the moment), that I myself who think should not be something. By the same token, if I judge that the wax exists, for the reason that I am touching it, the same consequence follows: namely, that I exist. If I judge it exists, for the reason I am imagining it, or for any other reason, again, the same certainly applies. But what I have realized in the case of the wax, I can apply to anything that exists outside myself. Moreover, if the perception of the wax appeared more distinct after it became known to me from many sources, and not from sight or touch alone, how much more distinctly—it must be admitted—I now know [*cognosci*] myself. For there are no reasons that can enhance the perception either of the wax or of any other body at all that do not at the same time prove better to me the nature of my own mind. But there are so many things besides in the mind itself that can serve to make the knowledge [*notitia*] of it more distinct, that there seems scarcely any point in listing all the perceptions that flow into it from the body.

34 But I see now that, without realizing it, I have ended up back where I wanted to be. For since I have now learned that bodies themselves are perceived not, strictly speaking, by the senses or by the imaginative faculty, but by the intellect alone, and that they are not perceived because they are touched or seen, but only because they are understood, I clearly realize [*cognosco*] that nothing can be perceived by me more easily or more clearly than my own mind. But since a long-held opinion is a habit that cannot so readily be laid aside, I intend to stop here for a while, in order to fix this newly acquired knowledge more deeply in my memory by long meditation.

THIRD MEDITATION

OF GOD, THAT HE EXISTS

I shall now close my eyes, I shall block up my ears, I shall divert all my senses, and I shall even delete all bodily images from my thought or, since this is virtually impossible to achieve, at least count them as empty and worthless; and I shall try, by conversing only with myself and looking deep within myself, to make myself gradually better known and more familiar to myself. I am a thinking thing, that is, one that doubts, affirms, denies, understands a few things, is ignorant of many others, wills this and not that, and also imagines and perceives by the senses; for as I have already remarked, although the things I perceive or imagine outside myself do not perhaps exist, yet I am certain that the modes of thinking that I call sensations and imagin-
ations, considered purely and simply as modes of thinking, do exist 35
inside me.

And this, short as it is, is a complete list of what I truly know [*scio*], or at least of what, up to now, I have realized that I know. Now I shall examine more carefully whether perhaps there are any further items of knowledge in my possession to which I have not yet paid attention. I am certain that I am a thinking thing. But do I not therefore also know what is required in order for me to be certain of something? For in this first act of knowledge [*cognitione*] there is nothing other than a clear and distinct perception of what I affirm to be the case; and this certainly would be insufficient to make me certain of the truth of the matter, if it could ever come to pass that something I perceived so clearly and distinctly was false. And therefore I seem already to be able to lay down, as a general rule, that everything I very clearly and distinctly perceive is true.

And yet there are many things that I once accepted as completely certain and obvious, that I have since realized were doubtful. What kind of things were these? The earth, the sky, the stars, and everything else I became aware of through the senses. But what did I clearly perceive here? Certainly, that the ideas or thoughts of such things were present to my mind. And even now I do not deny that these ideas exist in me. But there was something else that I was affirming, and that, because I was used to believing it, I thought

I perceived clearly, although in fact I was not really perceiving it; namely, that there were certain things existing outside me from which these ideas derived and that the ideas perfectly resembled. This was my mistake; or at least, if I was after all right in thinking this, the rightness was not due to my perception.

36 But when in arithmetic or geometry I considered something very simple and easy—for instance, two plus three equals five—surely I intuited this kind of thing at least clearly enough to declare it true? In fact, when I later judged that such things should be doubted, this was only because the thought had come to me, that perhaps some God might have endowed me with such a nature that I could be deceived even about those things that appeared supremely obvious. But whenever this preconceived opinion of God's supreme power occurs to me, I cannot help admitting, that, if indeed he wishes to, he can easily bring it about that I should be mistaken, even about matters that I think I intuit with the eye of the mind as evidently as possible. On the other hand, whenever I turn my attention to the things themselves that I think I perceive very clearly, I am so thoroughly convinced by them, that I cannot help exclaiming: 'Let whoever can, deceive me as much as he likes: still he can never bring it about that I am nothing, as long as I think I am something; or that one day it will be true that I have never existed, when it is true now that I exist; or that perhaps two plus three added together are more or less than five; or that other such things should be true in which I recognize an obvious contradiction.' And certainly, since I have no grounds for thinking that any deceitful God exists—in fact, I do not yet sufficiently know whether there is any God at all—then a reason for doubting that depends wholly on the belief in a deceitful God is very slight, and, so to speak, metaphysical. In order to remove it, then, at the first opportunity, I must examine whether there is a God, and, if there is, whether he can be a deceiver; since, as long as I remain ignorant of this matter, I seem unable ever to be certain of any other at all.*

But now it seems that, to proceed in an orderly fashion, I should
37 first divide up all my thoughts into definite categories, and examine to which of these truth and falsity can properly be said to pertain. Some of these thoughts are apparently images of things,* and to these alone the name 'idea' is properly applied: for instance, when I think of a human being, or a chimera, or the heavens, or an angel,

or God. But others have certain other forms as well; thus, when I will, or fear, or affirm, or deny, I am always in fact apprehending some thing as the subject of this thought,* but I am including something further within the thought than the mere likeness of the thing; and of thoughts of this kind some are called volitions, or affects, whereas others are called judgements.

Now, as far as ideas are concerned, if they are considered purely in themselves, and if I do not connect them with anything outside themselves, they cannot, strictly speaking, be false; for whether I am imagining a goat or a chimera, it is no less true that I am imagining one than that I am imagining the other. Again, there is no fear of falsehood in the will itself, or in the affects: for although I can desire something wicked, and even something that does not exist at all, this does not mean that it is not true that I desire it. This leaves only judgements: in these alone I must take care not to be deceived. The most glaring and widespread error that can be found in them consists in my judging that the ideas that are in me are similar to or in accordance with some things existing outside me. For certainly, if I conceived the ideas themselves purely and simply as modifications of my thinking, and did not connect them with anything else, they could scarcely give me any occasion to err.

Of these ideas, some seem to me to be innate, others adventitious,* others produced by myself. For understanding what a thing is, what 38
truth is, what thought is, is something I seem to possess purely in virtue of my nature itself. But if I am now hearing a noise, seeing the sun, feeling the heat of a fire,* up to now I have judged that such sensations derive from things existing outside myself. Finally, sirens, hippogriffs, and suchlike creatures are inventions of my own imagination. But perhaps I can think that all my ideas are adventitious, or all innate, or all produced by me: for I have not yet clearly discovered their true source.

About those ideas that I consider as proceeding from things existing outside myself, the key question to ask here is: What reason do I have for thinking the ideas are like the things? Well, certainly, nature itself seems to teach me to think so. Besides, experience shows me that they do not depend on my own will, and therefore do not depend on myself. For they often intrude upon me against my will. Now, for instance, I am feeling heat, whether I want to or not, and this is why I think that this sensation, or idea, of heat is coming to me

from a thing distinct from myself, in this case from the heat of the fire by which I am sitting. And by far the most obvious judgement to make is that what the thing is transmitting to me is its own likeness rather than anything else.

But I shall now see whether these reasons are sufficiently solid. When I say here that 'I am taught by nature' to think so, I mean only that I am prompted to believe this by some spontaneous inclination, not that it is shown to me to be true by some natural light.* The two things are very different: for whatever is shown to me by the natural light (for instance, that, from the fact that I am doubting, it follows that I exist, and suchlike) can in no way be doubtful, because there can be no other faculty that I could trust as much as this light, and
39 that could teach me that such things are not, after all, true. But when it comes to natural inclinations, I have before now often judged in the past that I have been led by these in the wrong direction, when it was a matter of choosing the good,* nor do I see why I should trust them more in any other domain.

Then again, although these ideas do not depend on my own will, it does not necessarily follow that they derive from things existing outside me. For just as those inclinations of which I was speaking a moment ago, although they are inside me, seem, however, to be distinct from my will, so perhaps there is some other faculty within me, as yet insufficiently known to me, that produces such ideas—just as up to now it has always seemed to me that they form themselves in me while I am asleep without any assistance from external things.*

And finally, even if they did derive from things distinct from myself, it does not follow that they have to be like those things. Indeed, in many of them I seem to have discovered major discrepancies between the idea and the object. For instance, I find within me two different ideas of the sun. One appears to be derived from the senses, and it would absolutely have to be placed in the category of ideas I class as 'adventitious'. This idea represents the sun as very small. The other, however, derives from astronomical reasoning—that is to say, it is derived from some notions innate within me, or has been produced by me in some other way. This idea represents the sun as several times larger than the earth. But certainly, both cannot be like one and the same sun existing outside me; and reason persuades me that the one that seems to have flowed directly from the sun itself* is in fact the one that is most unlike it.

All these considerations are sufficient proof that, up to now, it is as a result not of a certain judgement, but only of some blind inclin- 40
ation, that I have believed in the existence of various things distinct from myself, and conveying ideas or images of themselves to me through the sense-organs or in some other manner.

But there is yet another way that occurs to me by which I could investigate whether any of those things of which the ideas are in me exist outside me. Certainly, in so far as these ideas are only various modifications of my thinking, I acknowledge that they are all on the same footing, and they all seem to derive from me in the same way. But, in so far as one represents one thing, another another, it is plain that they differ widely among themselves. For beyond doubt those ideas that represent substances to me are something greater, and contain, if I may use the term, more 'objective reality' in themselves, than those that represent merely modes or accidents. And by the same token, the idea by which I conceive a supreme God, eternal, infinite, omniscient, all-powerful, and the creator of all things that exist beside himself, certainly has more objective reality in itself than those by which finite substances are represented.

But now it is manifest by the natural light that there must be at least as much reality in the total and efficient cause as in its effect. For, I ask, from where could the effect derive its reality, if not from the cause? And how could the cause give it reality, if it did not also possess it? Hence it follows, both that nothing can come from nothing, and that what is more perfect (that is, what contains more reality within itself) cannot derive from what is less perfect. And this 41
is not only plainly true of those effects whose reality is actual or formal, but also of ideas, in which only the objective reality is considered. For instance, a stone that did not previously exist, cannot now begin to be, unless it is produced by some thing in which everything exists, either formally or eminently,* that enters into the composition of the stone. Nor can heat be brought about in a subject that was not hot before, unless by a thing that belongs to at least the same order of perfection as heat; and the same is true elsewhere. But, by the same token, the *idea* of heat, or of the stone, cannot exist in me, unless it is produced in me by some cause in which there is at least as much reality as I conceive to be in the heat or in the stone. For although this cause transmits none of its actual or formal reality to my idea, we must not therefore think that it (the cause) must be less real; rather,

the nature of the idea itself is such that it requires no other formal reality outside itself,* except what it borrows from my thought, of which it is a mode. But the fact that this idea contains this or that objective reality, and not some other kind—this must certainly be due to some other cause, in which there is at least as much formal reality as the idea contains objective reality. For if we suppose that something is found in the idea that is not in its cause, it would have this something from nothing; and however imperfect the kind of being by which a thing exists objectively in the understanding in the form of an idea, it is certainly not nothing, and therefore cannot come from nothing.

Nor should I suppose that since the reality I am considering in my
42 ideas is purely objective, there is no need for the same reality to exist formally in the causes of these ideas, but that it is enough for it also to exist in them objectively. For just as this objective mode of being pertains to ideas from their very nature, so the formal mode of being pertains to the causes of the ideas—at least the first and dominant causes—from their nature also. And although perhaps one idea can be born from another, we cannot here have an infinite regress, but in the end we have to arrive at some first idea, the cause of which takes the form of an archetype, which formally contains all the reality that is only objectively in the idea. So that it is clear to me by the natural light that the ideas in me are of the nature of images, which can easily fall short of the perfection of the things from which they derive, but cannot, however, contain anything greater or more perfect.

And the longer and more carefully I examine all these things, the more clearly and distinctly I realize [*cognosco*] they are true. But what conclusion am I to draw from them? Certainly, if the objective reality of some one of my ideas is so great that I am certain that that reality does not exist in me either formally or eminently, and therefore that I myself cannot be the cause of this idea, it necessarily follows that I am not alone in the world, but that some other thing also exists that is the cause of this idea. But if in fact no such idea is found in me, I shall certainly have no argument that can convince me with certainty of the existence of any thing distinct from myself; for I have examined all these things very closely, and up to now I have found no other such argument.

Of these ideas I have—apart from the one that represents me to
43 myself, about which there can be no difficulty here*— one represents

God, others bodily and inanimate things, others angels, others animals, and others, finally, other human beings like myself.

As regards the ideas that represent other human beings, or animals, or angels, I can easily see that they might have been put together from the ideas I have of myself, and bodily things, and God, even if there were no other human beings, or animals, or angels in the world.

As regards ideas of bodily things, they contain nothing that is so great that it cannot apparently derive from myself: for if I inspect them more closely, and examine them one by one in the same way as I yesterday examined the idea of the wax, I realize that there is very little in them that I clearly and distinctly perceive: there is only magnitude, or extension in length, breadth, and depth; shape, which results from the limitation of this extension; place, the situation differently shaped bodies occupy relative to one another; and motion, that is, change of place. To these substance, duration, and number can be added. But the rest, such as light and colours, sounds, smells, tastes, heat and cold, and the other tactile qualities are thought by me only in very confused and obscure fashion—so much so that I do not even know whether they are true or false, that is, whether the ideas I have concerning them, are ideas of actual things or of non-things. For although I remarked not long ago that falsity in the proper ('formal') sense can be found only in judgements, there is nonetheless certainly another ('material') kind of falsity in ideas, when they represent what is nothing as if it were something. For example, the ideas I have of heat and cold are so unclear and so indistinct that 44
I cannot tell from them whether cold is nothing but a privation of heat, or heat a privation of cold, or whether both are real qualities, or neither. But there can be no ideas that do not seem to represent something to us. And therefore, if indeed it is true that cold is nothing other than the privation of heat, the idea that represents it to me as something real and positive can very properly be called false. The same applies to all other such ideas.

Certainly, I do not need to ascribe any author to these ideas apart from myself. For if indeed they are false—that is, if there is nothing they actually represent—it is known to me by the natural light that they derive from nothing: that is, they exist in me purely on account of some shortcoming in my nature, which indeed is far from perfect. But if, on the other hand, they are true, the degree of reality they

represent to me is so scanty that I cannot even distinguish between it and unreality; and therefore I cannot see why they might not derive from myself.*

But of the clear and distinct elements in my ideas of bodily things, there are some that it seems possible I borrowed from the idea of myself, namely substance, duration, number, and any other things there may be of that sort. For when I think that a stone is a substance, that is to say, a thing capable of existing by itself, and likewise that I am myself a substance, then although I conceive myself to be a thinking and not an extended thing, and the stone, on the other hand, to be an extended and not a thinking thing, so that there is a very great difference between the two concepts, they seem, however, to have this in common: they both represent a substance. Again, when I perceive that I exist now, and also remember that I existed at some time before now, and when I have various thoughts of which
45 I know the number, I acquire the ideas of duration and number, which then I can transfer to other things, of whatever kind they are. On the other hand, all the other elements from which the ideas of bodily things are put together, namely extension, shape, place, and motion, are not contained formally in myself, since I am nothing other than a thinking thing. But because they are only various modes of substance, and I moreover am a substance, it seems they could be contained in me eminently.

And so there remains only the idea of God, in which I must consider whether there is anything that could not derive from myself. By the name 'God' I understand an infinite, independent, supremely intelligent, supremely powerful substance, by which I myself and whatever else exists (if anything else does exist) was created. But certainly, all these properties are such that, the more carefully I consider them, the less it seems possible that they can be derived from me alone.* And so I must conclude that it necessarily follows from all that has been said up to now that God exists.

For indeed, even if the idea of substance is in me as a result of the very fact that I am a substance, the idea of an infinite substance would not therefore be in me, since I am finite, unless it derived from some substance that is really infinite.

Nor should I think that I perceive the infinite not by a true idea but only by negation of the finite, as I perceive rest and darkness by

the negation of motion and light; for on the contrary, I manifestly understand that there is more reality in infinite than in finite substance, and that therefore the perception of the infinite in me must be in some way prior to that of the finite: the perception of God, in other words, prior to that of myself. For how could I possibly understand that I doubt, and that I desire, that is, that there is something lacking 46
in me, and that I am not completely perfect, if there were no idea in me of a more perfect being, by comparison with which I could recognize my own shortcomings?*

Nor can it be said that perhaps this idea of God is materially false, and could therefore derive from nothing, as I remarked not long ago apropos of the ideas of heat and cold and suchlike. For on the contrary, since it is supremely clear and distinct, and contains more objective reality than any other, there is no idea that is truer in itself and in which less suspicion of falsity can be found. This idea of a supremely perfect and infinite being is, I say, supremely true; for although it perhaps might be imagined that no such being actually exists, it cannot be imagined that the idea of it represents nothing real to me, as I previously said of the idea of cold. It is also supremely clear and distinct; for whatever I clearly and distinctly perceive that is real and true and that contains some perfection is all included within it. And this remains no less true even though I do not comprehend the infinite, or even if there are innumerable other attributes in God that I can neither comprehend, nor even perhaps apprehend* in the slightest by my thought; for it is of the nature of the infinite that it should be incomprehensible to me, who am finite. Provided that I understand this and judge that everything I clearly perceive, and that I know [*scio*] to involve some perfection, as well, perhaps, as innumerable other attributes I do not know, exists in God either formally or eminently, the idea I have of him will be the truest and most clear and distinct of all my ideas.

And yet perhaps I am something greater than I understand myself to be, and all the perfections I attribute to God, are in some sense in me potentially, even if they have not yet revealed themselves, or been 47
brought into actuality.* For I am already experiencing a gradual increase in my knowledge [*cognitio*]; and I cannot see any reason why it should not be increased in this way further and further to infinity; nor why, if my knowledge were so increased, I could not by means of

it obtain all the other perfections of God; nor finally why the potentiality of these perfections, if it exists in me already, should not be enough actually to produce the idea of them.

But none of this can be true. For, first of all, even granting it to be true that my knowledge [*cognitio*] is gradually increasing and that there are many things in me in potentiality that are not yet so in actuality, nothing of this is relevant to the idea of God, in which indeed there is absolutely no potentiality: for this very fact of gradual increase is an infallible index of imperfection. Besides, even if my knowledge did continually increase, nonetheless I understand that it would still never be actually infinite, since it will never get to the point of being incapable of further increase; but I judge God to be infinite in actuality in such a way that nothing can be added to his perfection. And finally I perceive that the objective being of an idea cannot be produced from purely potential being, which properly speaking is nothing, but only from actual or formal being.

And indeed there is nothing in all this that is not manifest by the natural light to one who considers it carefully; but because, when my attention wavers, and the images of sensible things blind the eye of the mind, I do not remember so easily why the idea of a being more perfect than myself necessarily proceeds from some being that is
48 truly perfect, I wish to investigate further whether I, who have this idea, could exist if no such being existed.*

From what indeed could I derive my being? From myself, perhaps, or from my parents, or from some other beings less perfect than God: for nothing more perfect than him, or even equally perfect, can be conceived or imagined.

But if I existed of myself, I would not doubt, or wish, or lack anything at all: for I would have given myself all the perfections of which there is some idea in me, and thus I should myself be God. Nor should I suppose that what is lacking in me is perhaps more difficult to acquire than what is already in me, since on the contrary, it is plain that it was far more difficult for me, that is, a thinking thing or substance, to emerge from nothing than to acquire knowledge of the many things I do not know, since such knowledge is only an accident of this substance. But certainly, if I had this greater thing [existence] from myself, I should not have denied myself at least the things that can more easily be obtained; what is more, I should not have denied myself any of those things I perceive to be contained in the idea of

God; for indeed none of them seems to me more difficult to achieve. But if any were in fact more difficult to achieve, certainly they would appear to me to be so, if I did indeed derive my other properties from myself, since I would experience the limits of my power with respect to them.

And I cannot elude the force of these reasons by supposing that perhaps I have always been as I now am, as if it followed from that that there is no need to seek an author of my existence. For since all the time of a life can be divided into innumerable parts, of which 49
each particular one in no way depends on the rest, it does not follow from the fact that I existed not long ago that I have to exist now, unless some cause, so to speak, creates me again at this moment, or in other words, conserves me in being. For it is clear, if one considers the nature of time, that the same power and action is required to conserve any thing, whatever it may be, in being during the individual moments in which it continues to exist, as would be needed to create the same thing from the start if it did not yet exist. So clear is this in fact that we may add to the list of things manifest by the natural light that the distinction between conservation and creation exists purely in our thought.*

So therefore I need now to inquire of myself, whether I have some power, by means of which I can bring it to pass that this 'I'* that now exists shall still exist at some time in the near future. For since I am nothing other than a thinking thing, or at least, to speak precisely, since I am now dealing only with that part of myself that is a thinking thing, if any power of this sort were in me, I should beyond doubt be conscious of it. But I can find no such power, and from this I very clearly realize [*cognosco*] that I depend upon some being distinct from myself.

But perhaps this being is not God, and I was and am produced either by my parents or by some other causes less perfect than God, whatever they might be. No: for, as I have already said, it is plain that there must be at least as much in the cause as there is in the effect; and therefore, since I am a thinking thing, and one that has the idea of God in myself, it must be admitted that whatever cause is finally assigned to me must also itself be a thinking thing and one that has the idea of all the perfections I ascribe to God. And then of this thing too we can ask whether it exists of itself or by virtue of some other thing. For if it exists of itself, it is clear from the above that it must

50 itself be God, because since it has from itself the power to exist, it undoubtedly has the power to possess in reality all the perfections of which it has the idea in itself, that is, all the perfections I conceive to be in God. But if, on the other hand, it exists in virtue of some other thing, then we shall ask whether this thing too exists of itself, or in virtue of some other thing, until finally we come to an ultimate cause: and this will be God.

For it is sufficiently plain that here there is no possibility of an infinite regress,* especially because I am not dealing so much with the cause that produced me at some time in the past, as, above all, with the one that conserves me in the present time.

Nor can it be imagined that perhaps many partial causes have come together to produce me, and that from one of them I received the idea of one of the perfections I attribute to God, and from another the idea of another perfection, so that all these perfections are found, indeed, somewhere in the universe, but not all combined together in any one being that would be God. For on the contrary, the unity, simplicity, or inseparability of all those things that are in God is one of the principal perfections that I understand to inhere in him. Nor, certainly, could the idea of this unity of all his perfections have been implanted in me by any cause from which I did not also derive the ideas of the other perfections: for such a cause could not have brought it about that I should understand them as simultaneously combined and inseparable, unless it had at the same time enabled me to know what they all were.

Finally, as far as my parents are concerned, even if everything is true of them that I have ever thought to be so, certainly they do not conserve me in being, nor did they in any way produce me insofar as I am a thinking thing; they only implanted certain dispositions in the matter that I judged myself (that is, my mind, which for the moment
51 I take to be identical with my self) to inhabit. And so there can be no difficulty here about them; but we must necessarily conclude that, from the bare fact that I exist, and that in me there is an idea of a supremely perfect being, that is, God, it is proved beyond question that God also exists.

It remains for me only to examine in what manner I received this idea from God. For I did not derive it from the senses, nor did it ever thrust itself spontaneously on my attention, as do the ideas of sensible things, when the things themselves make an impression on

the external sense-organs (or appear to do so). Nor is it a fiction, a creation of my own, for I cannot subtract anything from it, or add anything at all to it. It must therefore be that the idea is innate within me, in the same way as the idea of myself is innate within me.

And certainly it is no wonder if God, when he created me, inscribed this idea within me, to serve, so to speak, as the mark by which the craftsman makes himself known in his handiwork. This mark does not have to be something distinct from the object itself. But, given this one basic fact that God created me, it is highly credible that I was in some way created in his image and likeness,* and that the likeness, in which the idea of God is contained, is perceived by me by the same faculty by which I myself am perceived by myself. That is, when I turn the eye of my mind on myself, I do not only understand myself to be an entity that is incomplete and that depends on another, and that is endowed with an indefinite aspiration to greater and greater or better things; but at the same time I understand that the being on whom I depend possesses all these greater things not only indefinitely and in potentiality but in actuality and infinitely, and is thus God. The whole force of the argument comes down to this, that I recognize that it cannot be that I should 52
exist, with the nature I possess (that is, having the idea of God within myself), unless in reality God also exists—the same God whose idea is within me, that is, the one who possesses all the perfections that I cannot comprehend but can to some extent apprehend in my thinking, and who is subject to no kind of deficiency. From this it is sufficiently clear that he cannot be a deceiver: for all cunning and deception presuppose some shortcoming, as is plain by the natural light.

But before I go more thoroughly into this, and at the same time investigate the other truths that can be deduced from it, I wish to remain here for some time in the contemplation of God himself, to ponder on his attributes, and to gaze on, wonder at, and worship the beauty of this immense light, as much as the eye of my understanding, shrouded as it is in darkness, is capable of doing. For, just as we believe by faith that the supreme happiness of the other life consists purely in the contemplation of the divine greatness, so we find also by experience that this contemplation, though far less perfect, affords us the greatest pleasure of which we are capable in this life.

FOURTH MEDITATION

OF TRUTH AND FALSITY

Over these last few days I have grown so accustomed to withdrawing
53 my mind from the senses, and have so thoroughly grasped that true perceptions of bodily things are very rare, but that more can be known [*cognosci*] about the human mind, and still more about God, that I can now direct my thought without any difficulty away from things that can be imagined and towards those that are purely intelligible, and detached from all matter. And certainly the idea I have of the human mind, in so far as it is a thinking thing, not extended in length, breadth, and depth, or having any other bodily properties, is much more distinct than the idea of any bodily thing. And when I consider that I doubt, or that I am an incomplete and dependent thing, so clear and distinct an idea of an independent and complete being (that is, God) comes to my mind, and from this single fact that such an idea is in me, or that I exist possessing this idea, I so manifestly conclude that God also exists, and that all my existence, from one moment to the next, depends on him, that I can confidently assert that nothing can be more evidently or certainly discovered [*cognosci*] by human intelligence. And now I seem to glimpse a path by which, from this contemplation of the true God, in whom indeed all the treasures of the sciences and wisdom lie hidden, we can pass to the knowledge of other things.

First of all, I recognize that it cannot happen that he should ever deceive me; for in all deceit and trickery some element of imperfection is to be found; and although to be able to deceive seems to be some indication of intelligence or power, nonetheless to wish to deceive is beyond doubt a proof of malice or feeble-mindedness, to which God cannot be liable.

Besides, I know by experience that there is within me a faculty of judging, which I certainly received from God, along with everything
54 else that is in me; and since he does not wish to deceive me, this God-given faculty must be such that I shall never go astray, as long as I use it correctly.

It would seem that there is no room left for doubt on this matter, except that it would apparently follow from what has just been said,

that I can therefore never be mistaken at all. For if whatever is in me, I have from God, and if he has not given me any faculty of making mistakes, it seems I can never be mistaken. And indeed, as long as I am thinking only of God, and directing my attention wholly to him, I cannot detect any cause of error or falsity; but when presently I turn back to myself, I find by experience that I am, on the contrary, subject to innumerable errors. When I investigate the cause of these, I observe that, besides the real and positive idea of God, or the supremely perfect being, there is also, so to speak, a certain negative idea of nothingness, or of that which is infinitely remote from all perfections, that presents itself to me; and I see also that I am so constituted as a medium term between God and nothingness, or between the supreme being and non-being, that, in so far as I was created by the supreme being, there is indeed nothing within me by which I can be deceived or led into error; but that, in so far as I have, in a way, a share of nothingness or non-being (in so far, in other words, as I am not myself the supreme being), and very many things are lacking to me, it does not seem so strange that I should be deceived. And thus I can understand, quite certainly, that error, in so far as it is error, is not something real dependent on God, but purely and simply a deficiency; and therefore that, in order to make mistakes I do not need a special mistake-making faculty given me by God for this purpose, but that it happens that I make mistakes, for the reason that the faculty of judging the truth, which he did give me, is not infinite in me.

And yet this does not satisfy me completely. For error is not a pure 55
negation but a privation,* a lack of some knowledge [*cognitio*] that ought to be in me in some way; and when I consider God's nature, it does not seem possible that he should have endowed me with some faculty that is not perfect of its kind, or that is deprived of some perfection due to it. For if, the more skilful the craftsman, the more perfect the works he produces, what can have been produced by this supreme creator of everything that is not perfect in all its components? Nor is there any doubt that God could have created me incapable of being deceived; besides, there is no doubt that he wishes always what is best—but could it be better for me to be deceived than not?

When I go into this more closely, it first occurs to me that I should not be surprised if God does some things the reasons for which I do

not understand. Nor would there be any reason to doubt his existence if perhaps I discovered other things of which I cannot understand how or why he produced them. For since I already know [*sciam*] that my nature is very weak and limited, while on the other hand God's is immense, incomprehensible, and infinite, it follows that I know [*scio*] quite clearly that he can do innumerable things of the causes of which I am ignorant; and for this reason alone, I judge that the whole category of causes that people are in the habit of seeking by considering the purposes of things* is of no use in the study of physics; for I think that it could only be rash of me to investigate God's purposes.

My next reflection is that we should not look at any one single creature in isolation, but at the whole universe of things, whenever we are inquiring whether God's works are perfect. For what would perhaps appear (and not without reason) very imperfect if it were
56 taken in isolation, is completely perfect if considered as a part of the universe; and although, since I have decided to doubt everything, I have not yet discovered [*cognovi*] for certain whether anything else exists besides God and myself, I cannot however deny, since I have become aware of the immense power of God, that many other things have been created by him, or at least could be created by him, in which case I too would exist as a part of the universe.

Finally, coming closer to myself and investigating the nature of my errors (which are sufficient proof by themselves that there is some imperfection in me), I realize that they depend on two simultaneously operative causes, namely, the faculty I possess of acquiring knowledge [*cognoscendi*] and the faculty of choosing, or free will; that is, they depend on the intellect and the will simultaneously. For through the intellect alone I only perceive ideas on which I can pass judgement, nor can any error in the strict sense be found in it when considered from this precise viewpoint. For although, perhaps, there are innumerable things in existence of which the ideas are not in me, I cannot be said, strictly speaking, to be deprived of these ideas, but only, in a negative sense, to be without them; since, certainly, I can adduce no reason to prove that God should have given me a greater faculty of acquiring knowledge [*cognoscendi*] than the one he has given me; and although I understand him to be the most skilful craftsman possible, I do not therefore think that he should have endowed each individual piece of his handiwork with all the perfections with which he may endow some. Nor indeed can I complain

that I have received from him an insufficiently wide-ranging and perfect will, or freedom of choice; for I experience it as unbounded by any limits. And it seems to me particularly important to note that there is no other property in me, apart from this one, that is so 57
perfect or so great that I cannot understand how it could be more perfect or greater. For if, for example, I consider the faculty of understanding, I immediately recognize that in me it is very small and seriously limited; and at the same time I form the idea of another faculty that is far greater, one indeed that is supremely great and infinite, and, from the very fact that I can form the idea of it, I perceive that it belongs to the nature of God. By the same token, if I examine the faculty of remembering or imagining, or any other, I realize they are all very inadequate and restricted in me, but that in God they are boundless. It is only the will, or freedom of choice, that I experience in myself as so great that I can form the idea of none greater; so much so that it is chiefly on account of the will that I understand that I bear a certain image and likeness of God. For although the will is incomparably greater in God than in me, first, in virtue of the knowledge and power that are combined with it in him, and that make it stronger and more effective, and secondly, in virtue of its object, since its range is far greater, nonetheless, when it is considered strictly as it is essentially in itself, it does not seem to be greater in him than in me. This is because it consists purely in our ability to do or not to do a given thing (that is, to affirm or deny something, pursue something or avoid it); or rather, it consists purely in this: that we are moved in relation to that which the intellect presents to us as to be affirmed or denied, pursued or avoided, in such a way that we feel we are not being determined in that direction by any external force.* For, in order to be free, I do not have to be able to be moved in either direction.* On the contrary, the more I incline to one alternative, whether because I clearly understand that 58
the good and the true are on that side, or because God so disposes my innermost thoughts,* the more freely I choose it. Certainly, neither divine grace nor natural knowledge [*cognitio*] ever diminishes freedom; on the contrary, they increase and reinforce it. On the other hand, the indifference I experience, when no reason impels me towards one alternative rather than the other, is the lowest degree of freedom, and is not a mark of perfection but only of a shortfall in my knowledge, or a certain negation;* for if I always clearly saw what is

true and good, I would never need to deliberate about a judgement to be made or a course of action to be chosen; and in that case, although I would be fully free, I could never be indifferent.

From all this, I perceive that the cause of my errors is neither the God-given power of willing, considered in itself, for it is extremely extensive and perfect of its kind; nor the power of understanding, for whatever I understand, since my understanding is a gift of God, most certainly I understand it correctly, nor is there any possibility of my being deceived in this. So what is the origin of my errors? It can only be this: that, since the range of the will is greater than that of the intellect, I do not confine it within the same limits, but extend it even to matters I do not understand;* and since it is indifferent to these, it easily falls away from the true and the good, and this is both how I come to be deceived and how I come to sin.*

For example, when I was examining, over these last few days, whether anything existed in the world, and realized that, from the very fact that I was examining this point, it clearly followed that I existed, I could not indeed refrain from judging that what I so
59 clearly understood was true. It was not that I was compelled to this by some external force, but that a great illumination of the intellect was followed by a great inclination of the will; and in this way my belief was all the freer and more spontaneous for my being less indifferent. But now, however, I not only know that I, in so far as I am a thinking thing, exist: a certain idea of bodily nature also presents itself to me, as a result of which I doubt whether the thinking nature that is within me, or rather that I myself am,* is distinct from this bodily nature, or whether they are both one and the same. (I am supposing here that no reason has yet occurred to my intellect to convince me in favour of one view or the other.) And from this fact alone, I am certainly indifferent as regards affirming or denying one view or the other, and indeed as regards making no judgement at all about the matter.

But indeed, this indifference does not extend only to those matters about which the intellect has no knowledge at all, but also to all things in general that are not sufficiently clearly known by the intellect at the time when the will is deliberating about them. For however strongly probable conjectures may draw me to one alternative, the mere fact of knowing that they are only conjectures, and not certain and indubitable reasons, is sufficient to impel me to assent to

the contrary view. This has been fully borne out in my own experience during these last few days, when, considering all the beliefs I had once very firmly held as true, I decided, simply because I had realized that it was possible to doubt them in some respect, to suppose them to be altogether false.

Now, if indeed, whenever I do not sufficiently clearly and distinctly perceive where the truth lies, I refrain from passing judgement, it is clear that I am acting rightly and not being deceived. But if I either affirm or deny, then I am not making the right use of my freedom of choice; and if I adopt the view that is false, I shall be alto- 60
gether deceived. Yet if I adopt the other view, although it happens to be the true one, I shall still be at fault, because it is manifest by the natural light that a decision on the part of the will should always be preceded by a perception on the part of the intellect. The privation in which the essence of error consists lies in this wrong use of free choice. The privation, that is, lies in the operation itself, in so far as it derives from me, but not in the faculty given to me by God, or in the operation in so far as that depends on him.*

Nor do I have any grounds for complaining that God has not given me a more powerful intellectual capacity, or a greater natural light, than he actually has, since it is of the essence of a finite intellect that it is unable to understand many things, and to be finite is of the essence of a created intellect. Rather, I should be grateful to him, who has never owed me anything, for what he has bestowed on me. But I have no cause to think that I have been deprived by him of those things he has not given me, or that he has robbed me of them.

I have no more reason to complain at his giving me a will that is more wide-ranging than my understanding; for since the will consists purely in a single property that is, so to speak, indivisible, its very nature seems to make it impossible that anything should be taken away from it. Indeed, the more extensive it is, the more grateful I should be to him who has given it to me.

And finally, I have no right to complain that God cooperates with me in the production of those acts of the will, or those judgements, in which I am deceived; for these acts are altogether true and good, in so far as they depend on God, and it is in some ways a greater perfection in me to be able to perform them than not. For the privation in which alone the essence of falsity and guilt consists requires no 61
cooperation on God's part, since it is not a thing, nor a privation

related to him as to its cause: it should be classed, purely and simply, as a negation.* For it is certainly no imperfection on God's part that he has given me the freedom to assent or not to assent to some things of which he has implanted no clear and distinct perception in my intellect; but it is undoubtedly an imperfection on my part not to use this freedom properly, and to pass judgement on things I do not rightly understand. I see, however, that God could have easily brought it about that, while remaining free and endowed only with finite knowledge, I should never err: for instance, if he had implanted in my intellect a clear and distinct perception of everything upon which I would ever have to make up my mind; or if he had simply engraved on my memory, so deeply that I could never forget it, the resolution never to pass judgement about anything I do not clearly and distinctly understand. And I can easily grasp that, in so far as I consider myself as a totality, I would have been more perfect than I am now, if I had been so created by God. But, for all that, I cannot deny that in a way the universe as a whole is more perfect as a result of the fact that some of its parts are not immune from error, while others are, than it would have been if all its parts were entirely similar. And I have no right to complain that the part God has given me to play in the world is not the most prominent and perfect of all.

Besides, even though I cannot refrain from error in the first of the ways just mentioned, which would involve my having an evident perception of everything about which I would ever need to
62 make up my mind, I can in the second way, which simply involves my remembering that, whenever the truth of a matter is not clear, I should abstain from passing judgement. For although I find by experience that there is a weakness in my nature that means that I cannot always concentrate attentively on one and the same piece of knowledge [*cognitioni*], I can nonetheless, by careful and frequently repeated meditation, ensure that I remember this maxim whenever I need to, and thus I can acquire a certain habit of not making mistakes.

And since the greatest and most distinctive perfection of a human being consists in this, I think I have derived no little profit from today's meditation, since I have tracked down the cause of error and falsity. And indeed, this cause can be no other than I have explained. For whenever in passing judgement I so keep my will under control that it confines itself to items clearly and distinctly represented to it

by the intellect, it certainly cannot come about that I should make a mistake; since every clear and distinct perception is something, and therefore cannot come from nothing, but necessarily derives from God—God, the supremely perfect being, whose nature is incompatible with deception. It is therefore undoubtedly true. And I have learned today not only what I should avoid in order not to be deceived, but at the same time what I must do in order to attain truth; for I certainly shall attain it, provided I pay sufficient attention to everything I perfectly understand, and keep it quite separate from everything else that I apprehend more confusedly and obscurely. And I shall take particular care to do this in future.

FIFTH MEDITATION 63

OF THE ESSENCE OF MATERIAL THINGS; AND AGAIN OF GOD, THAT HE EXISTS

There remain many attributes of God, and many aspects of the nature of myself, or my mind, for me to investigate. But perhaps I shall return to these another time, and for the moment nothing appears more urgent (now that I have realized what to avoid and what to do in order to attain truth) than to attempt to extricate myself from the doubts I have fallen into during these past days, and to see whether any certainty is possible with respect to material things.

And indeed, before investigating whether any such things exist outside me, I should first consider the ideas of them, in so far as these ideas exist in my thought, and see which of them are distinct, and which confused.

I can certainly distinctly imagine the quantity that philosophers commonly call 'continuous': that is, the extension of this quantity (or rather, of the thing to which the quantity is attributed) in length, breadth, and depth. I can count various parts within it. To each of these parts I ascribe various magnitudes, shapes, positions, and local motions, and to the motions I ascribe various durations.

Not only are these things, considered in these general terms, clearly known and grasped by me: I also, if I pay close attention, perceive innumerable particular facts involving shape, number, motion, and suchlike—facts so plainly true, and so much in conformity with 64

my nature, that when I first discover them I do not seem to be learning anything new, but rather to be remembering something I knew before, or to be noticing for the first time something that was in me already, although I had not previously turned the gaze of my mind in its direction.

And what I think particularly needs to be considered here is this: that I find in myself innumerable ideas of certain things, that, even if, perhaps, they do not exist anywhere outside me, cannot yet be said to be nothing. And although, in a sense, whether I think of them or not is up to me, yet they are not inventions of my own mind, but they have true and immutable natures of their own. For instance, when I imagine a triangle, even if perhaps such a figure does not exist, and has never existed, anywhere at all outside my thought, it nonetheless certainly has a determinate nature, or essence, or form, that is immutable and eternal, which was not invented by me, and does not depend on my mind. This is clear from the fact that it is possible to demonstrate various properties of the triangle (for instance, that its three angles are equal to two right angles, and that the hypotenuse subtends the greatest angle, and so forth) which, whether I like it or not, I now clearly recognize to hold good, even if up to now I have never thought of them in any way when imagining a triangle. And therefore these properties were not invented by me.

It would make no difference if I were to say that perhaps this idea of a triangle has come to me from things outside myself via the sense-organs, because, that is, I have occasionally seen bodies of a triangular shape. For I can think up innumerable other shapes that it
65 is impossible to suspect ever reached me via the senses; and yet I can demonstrate several of their properties, just as I can with the triangle. And all of these properties are certainly true, since they are clearly known [*cognoscuntur*] by me, and therefore they are something, and not a pure nothing. For it is clear that everything that is true, is something; and I have already abundantly demonstrated that everything I clearly know [*cognosco*], is true. And even if I had not demonstrated this, the nature of my mind is such that I cannot in any case help assenting to the things I clearly perceive, at least, for as long as I clearly* perceive them; and I remember that even in past times, when I was as closely attached to the objects of the senses as it is possible to be, I always considered that truths of this kind that I clearly recognized, concerning shapes, or numbers, or other matters

belonging to arithmetic or geometry or, in general, pure and abstract mathematics, were the most certain of all.

But now, if, from the fact alone that I can produce the idea of a given thing from my thought, it follows that everything I clearly and distinctly perceive to belong to the thing does in fact belong to it, cannot I also find here a further proof of the existence of God? Certainly, I find the idea of him, that is, of a supremely perfect being, in myself, just as much as I find the idea of any shape or number. And I clearly and distinctly understand that eternal existence belongs to his nature—just as clearly and distinctly as I understand that the properties I can demonstrate of some shape or number belong in fact to the nature of that shape or number. So that, even if not all the conclusions I have come to in my meditations over the past few days were true, I would still have to ascribe the same degree of certainty to the existence of God that I up to now have ascribed to mathematical 66
truths.

To be sure, this is not altogether evident at first sight: it appears to be something of a sophism. For since I am accustomed in all other things to distinguish existence from essence, I can easily convince myself that existence can be separated from the essence of God, and thus that God can be thought of as not existing. But if one considers the matter more closely, it becomes plain that existence can no more be separated from the essence of God than we can separate from the essence of a triangle that the sum of its three angles adds up to two right angles, or than we can separate the idea of a mountain from the idea of a valley.* So true is this that the thought of a God (that is, a supremely perfect being) who lacks existence (that is, who lacks a certain perfection) is no less contradictory than the thought of a mountain without a valley.

However, even if I can no more think of God without existence than I can think of a mountain without a valley, yet certainly, it does not follow from my thinking of a mountain as having a valley that any mountain exists in the world; similarly, from my thinking of God as existing, it does not seem to follow that God exists. For my thought imposes no necessity on things; and just as I am free to imagine a winged horse, even if no horse actually does have wings, so perhaps I can imagine the existence of a God, even though no God in fact exists.

No: this is where the sophism is lurking here. The point is not that, from my inability to think of a mountain except with a valley, it

follows that a mountain and a valley exist somewhere, but only that
67 the mountain and the valley, whether they exist or not, cannot be separated from each other. Whereas from the fact that I cannot think of God except as existing, it follows that existence is inseparable from God, and therefore that he exists in reality. It is not that my thought brings his existence about, or that it imposes any necessity on anything, but, on the contrary, that the necessity of the thing itself, namely the existence of God, determines me to think it. Nor am I free to think of God without existence (that is, to think of the supremely perfect being without the supreme perfection), in the way I am free to imagine a horse with or without wings.

Nor can it be maintained that, although it is necessary to admit that God exists, once I have supposed him to possess all perfections, since existence is one of these perfections, the original supposition was not itself necessary* (just as it is not necessary for me to think that all quadrilateral shapes can be inscribed in a circle, but, supposing I do think this, I must admit that a rhombus can be inscribed in a circle, which, however, is patently impossible). For although it is not necessary that I should ever find myself thinking of God, nonetheless, whenever I choose to think about the first and supreme being, and bring forth the idea of him, so to speak, from the treasury of my mind, I must necessarily credit him with all perfections, even if at the time I neither list them all nor consider them individually. And this necessity is quite sufficient for me subsequently, when I recognize that existence is a perfection, to conclude, quite rightly, that the first and supreme being exists. In the same way, it is not necessary that I should ever imagine any triangle: but whenever I want to consider a straight-sided shape having only three angles, I must
68 necessarily credit it with properties from which it can be correctly inferred that the sum of its three angles does not exceed that of two right angles, even if I do not at the time realize this. On the other hand, when I am examining what shapes can be inscribed in a circle, there is absolutely no necessity for me to think that all quadrilaterals fall into this category: indeed, I cannot even imagine this to be true, as long as I am intending to accept only what I clearly and distinctly understand. Hence there is a great difference between false suppositions, such as this one, and true ideas innate within me, the first and most important of which is the idea of God. For indeed, I understand in many ways that this idea is not something fictitious that

depends on my own thinking, but the image of a true and immutable nature: first, because no other thing can be conceived by me to the essence of which existence belongs, besides God himself; secondly, because I cannot conceive of two or more such Gods, and because, granted that one exists now, I plainly see that it is necessary both that he should have existed for all eternity up to now, and that he will continue to exist for an eternity in the future; and finally, because I perceive many other properties in God of which none can be subtracted or altered by me.

But indeed, whatever kind of proof I use, the issue always comes down to this: that nothing convinces me fully but what I clearly and distinctly perceive. It is true that, of the things I so perceive, although there are several that are obvious to anyone, there are others that can be discovered only by those who look into the matter more closely and examine it carefully. Once, however, these latter have been discovered, they are counted as no less certain than the former. Just as, if we are dealing with a right-angled triangle, it does not so readily 69
appear that that the square of the base is equal to the square of the sides as it does that the base is subtended by its greatest angle, nonetheless, once the first proposition has been grasped, it is as firmly believed as the second. But as far as God is concerned, certainly, if I were not overwhelmed by prejudices and if the images of sensible things were not pressing in on my thoughts from all directions, I should recognize nothing sooner and more readily than him. For what is more obvious in itself than that the supreme being exists, that is to say, that God, to whose essence alone existence belongs, exists?

And although careful consideration was required before I was capable of perceiving this truth, now, however, not only am I equally certain of it as I am of anything else that seems completely certain, but, moreover, I also observe that the certitude of all these other things depends on it so completely that without it nothing can ever be perfectly known [*sciri*].

For although my nature is such that, as long as I perceive something very clearly and distinctly, I cannot not believe that it is true, nonetheless, because my nature is also such that I cannot continuously fix the gaze of the mind on the same thing in order to perceive it clearly, and what often happens is that I *remember* judging something to be true, then, when I am no longer concentrating on the reasons for which I made that judgement, other reasons can be

adduced that would easily (were I ignorant of God) shake me out of my opinion. And thus I should never have true and certain knowledge [*scientia*] of anything, but only vague and shifting opinions. Thus, for example, when I am considering the nature of a triangle, it certainly appears utterly evident to me (being, as I am, well versed in the principles of geometry) that its three angles are equal to two right
70 angles; and I cannot not believe this is true, as long as I am concentrating on the proof; but, as soon as I have turned the eye of the mind in a different direction, then however well I remember that I grasped the proof very clearly, I can still easily find myself doubting its truth, if I am ignorant of God. For I can persuade myself that I was so made by nature that I am sometimes deceived in matters which I think I perceive entirely clearly, especially since I remember counting many things as true and certain that later, when guided by other reasons, I judged to be false.

But once I have perceived that God exists, then because I grasped at the same time that everything else depends on him, and that he is no deceiver, and from this deduced that everything I clearly and distinctly perceive is necessarily true, then, even if I am no longer concentrating on the reasons why I judged this to be true, provided I remember that I did see it clearly and distinctly, no contrary reason can be adduced that can induce me to doubt it; and thus I have true and certain knowledge [*scientia*] of it. And not only of it, but of all the other propositions I remember demonstrating at some stage, such as the truths of geometry and others of the same kind. For what objections can now be raised against me? That I am so constituted as often to be deceived? But I know now [*scio*] that in matters I clearly understand, I cannot be deceived. That I once counted many things as true and certain that I later realized to be false? But I had perceived none of these clearly and distinctly, but, unaware as I was of this criterion of truth, perhaps I believed them for other reasons, which I later discovered to be less sound than I had thought. So what further objection can be raised? Perhaps (an objection I put to myself not long ago) I am sleeping, or all the things I am now thinking are no more true than the thoughts that occur to one who is asleep. But this makes no
71 difference. For certainly, even if I were sleeping, if something is evident to my understanding, then it is altogether true.

And so I plainly see that the certitude and truth of all knowledge [*scientiae*] depends on the knowledge [*cognitione*] of the

true God alone: so much so, that before I had discovered this knowledge, I could have no perfect knowledge [*scire*] of anything else at all. But now innumerable truths, concerning both, on the one hand, God himself and other intellectual things and, on the other, the whole of this bodily nature which is the object of pure mathematics,* can be plainly known to me with certainty.

SIXTH MEDITATION

OF THE EXISTENCE OF MATERIAL THINGS, AND THE REAL DISTINCTION BETWEEN MIND AND BODY

It remains for me to examine whether material things exist. And indeed, I now know [*scio*] at least that, in so far as they are the object of pure mathematics, they can exist, since I perceive them clearly and distinctly. For there is no doubt that God is capable of producing everything I am capable of perceiving in this way; and I have never judged that anything was impossible for him to do, except when, in attempting to perceive it distinctly, I ran up against a contradiction. Besides, it seems to follow from the existence of the imaginative faculty, of which I experience myself as making use when dealing with these material things, that they exist. For if I consider more closely what kind of thing the imagination is, it appears to be noth- 72
ing other than a certain application of the knowing faculty to a body intimately present to that faculty, and therefore existing.

To make this plain, I shall first examine the difference that exists between imagination and pure intellection. For example, when I imagine a triangle, not only do I understand it to be a shape enclosed by three lines, but at the same time, with the eye of the mind, I contemplate the three lines as present, and this is what I call imagining. But if, on the other hand, I wish to think of a chiliogon, I do indeed understand that this is a shape consisting of a thousand sides, no less clearly than I understand that the triangle consists of three: but I do not imagine the thousand sides in the same way, that is, contemplate them as present. And although at the time, because I am accustomed always to imagine something whenever I am thinking of bodily things, I may perhaps picture some figure to myself in a confused fashion, it is quite clear that this is not a chiliogon,

because it is not at all different from the picture I would also form in my mind if I were thinking about a myriogon,* or some other many-sided figure. Nor is it of any assistance in recognizing the properties by which the chiliogon differs from other polygons. But if I am dealing with a pentagon, I can certainly understand its shape, like that of the chiliogon, without the help of the imagination: but I can also imagine it, that is, by applying the eye of the mind to its five sides, and at the same time to the area contained within them; and here I observe very plainly that I need to make a particular
73 mental effort in order to imagine, that I do not make when understanding. This further effort of the mind clearly indicates the difference between imagination and pure intellection.

At this point, I consider that this power of imagining I possess, in so far as it differs from the power of understanding, is not integral to my essence, that is, to the essence of my mind; for even if I lacked it, I should nonetheless certainly remain the same person as I now am. From this it seems to follow that the imagination depends on something distinct from me.* And I can easily understand that if some body exists to which the mind is so closely joined that it may, whenever it chooses, apply itself, so to speak, to looking into it, it could be the case that this is exactly how I imagine corporeal things. So that this mode of thinking would differ from pure intellection in the following respect alone: that the mind, while it understands, turns itself in some way towards itself, and gazes on one of the ideas that are contained within itself; but, while it imagines, it turns itself towards the body, and considers something in it that corresponds either to an idea it understands itself* or to an idea perceived by the senses. I can readily understand, I say, how the imagination may function in this way, provided, that is, the body exists. And because no other equally convenient way of explaining it occurs to me, I therefore conclude with great probability that the body exists. But this is only a probability, and although I am investigating the whole matter with great care, I do not yet see that, from this distinct idea of bodily nature that I find in my imagination, any argument can be derived that will lead necessarily to the conclusion that some body exists.

74 But I am accustomed to imagining many other things, besides this bodily nature that is the object of pure mathematics,* such as colours, sounds, pain, and suchlike: but none of these with equal distinctness.

And because I perceive these things better by the senses, from which they seem to have made their way, with the help of memory, to the imagination, in order to examine them more conveniently, I should examine sensation at the same time, and see whether, from those things that are perceived by the form of thinking I call 'sensation', I can derive some decisive argument in favour of the existence of bodily things.

And first of all, I will here go over in my memory what those things were that I previously thought were true, because they were perceived by the senses, and the reasons I had for thinking this. Then I shall weigh the reasons for which I later called these things into question. Finally, I shall consider what view I should now take.

First of all, then, I had the sensation of having a head, hands, feet, and all the other parts comprising this body I used to consider as part of myself, or perhaps even as the whole of myself. Then I had the sensation of this body as situated among many other bodies by which it could be affected—harmed or benefited: and I measured the benefits by a certain feeling of pleasure and the harm by a feeling of pain. And besides pain and pleasure, I also had the sensation of hunger, thirst, and other such appetites in myself, not to mention various bodily propensities, to joy, to sadness, to anger, and other such passions. Outside myself, besides the extension, shapes, and motions of bodies, 75
I had sensations of hardness, heat, and other tactile qualities in them; light, as well, and colours, and smells, and tastes, and sounds, the variety of which enabled me to distinguish the sky, the earth, the sea, and other bodies one from another. And surely it was not without reason that, on account of the ideas of all these qualities that presented themselves to my thought, and of which alone I had personal and immediate sensations, I believed I was sensing certain things quite distinct from my thought, that is to say, bodies from which these ideas proceeded. For I experienced these ideas as coming to me without any consent of mine: so much so, that neither could I have a sensation of any object, however much I wanted to, unless the object itself were present to a sense-organ, nor could I help having the sensation of it when it was present. And since the ideas perceived by the senses were much more vivid and emphatic,* and in their own way more distinct, than any of the ideas that I deliberately and knowingly formed* by myself in my meditations, or that I found engraved upon my memory, it seemed impossible that they should proceed from myself.* And so

it had to be the case that they derived from some other things. But since I had no knowledge of these other things except from these ideas themselves, I could only suppose that the things were like the ideas. And also because I remembered that I had made use of my senses before I made use of my reason, and saw, as well, that the ideas I formed myself were not as emphatic as those I perceived by the senses, and were mostly put together from those ideas, I readily convinced myself that I had nothing at all in the intellect, that I had not previously had in the senses.* Nor was it without reason that I judged that the par-
76 ticular body I seemed specially entitled to call my own belonged more closely to me than any other body. For I could not ever be separated from it, as I could from the other bodies; I felt all my appetites and passions in it and for it; and finally I was aware of pain and pleasure in parts of it, but not in any other body existing outside it. But why this mysterious feeling of pain is followed by a feeling of sadness in the soul, and why the awareness of pleasure is followed by joy, or why the mysterious pangs in the stomach I call hunger prompt me to take food, while a dryness in the throat prompts me to drink, and so on, I certainly could not explain except by saying that nature teaches me that it is so. For there is plainly no affinity (at least, none that I understand) between the pangs in the stomach and the will to eat, or between the sensation of a thing that is causing pain and a thought of sadness arising from this feeling. And all the other things I judged concerning the objects of the senses, I thought I had also learned from nature. For I had persuaded myself that this was the way things were before I had considered any reasons by which this could be proved.

But afterwards many experiences gradually undermined all the faith I had placed in the senses. For sometimes towers that from a distance had seemed round appeared from close up as square;* and giant statues perched on the top of those towers did not look particularly large to one gazing up from below; and by innumerable other such experiences I came to realize that in matters of the external senses our judgements are at fault. Not only the internal senses,
77 moreover; the internal ones as well. For what can be more intimate than pain? Yet I had often heard from people whose arm or leg had been amputated, that they still occasionally seemed to feel pain in the part of the body they were missing; and therefore even in myself it did not seem to be wholly certain that one of my limbs was hurting, even though I was feeling pain in it. To these points I recently added

two very general reasons for doubting. The first was that everything I have ever believed I was having a sensation of while awake, I can sometimes think I am having a sensation of while asleep; and since I do not believe that what I seem to see when asleep comes from anything existing outside me, I could not see any reason why I should believe this of the sensations I seem to have when awake. The second reason was that, since I was still ignorant of the author of my existence (or at least was pretending to be so),* I could see no reason why I could not be so constituted by nature as to be deceived, even in things that appeared to me entirely true. And as for the reasons by which I had previously convinced myself of the truth of sensible things, I could answer them without difficulty. For since I saw that I was impelled by nature to many things from which reason dissuaded me, I thought I should not place much faith in the teachings of nature. And although sense-perceptions do not depend on my will, I thought that I should not therefore conclude that they derived from things distinct from myself, because perhaps there might be some faculty within me, although yet unknown to me, that produces them.

Now, however, that I begin to know myself and the author of my existence rather better, although I do not think that all that the senses seem to teach me is to be rashly accepted, I do not think that it 78
should all be called in doubt.

First, since I know that whatever I clearly and distinctly understand can be produced by God such as I understand it to be, then if I can clearly and distinctly understand one thing without another, this is sufficient for me to be certain that the one is distinct from the other, since they can at least be produced separately by God. By what power this separation comes about makes no difference to the judgement that the things are distinct. Next, from the very fact that I know [*sciam*] I exist, and that for the moment I am aware of nothing else at all as belonging to my nature or essence, apart from the single fact that I am a thinking thing, I rightly conclude that my essence consists in this alone, that I am a thinking thing. And although perhaps (or rather certainly, as I shall shortly claim) I have a body, which is very closely conjoined to me, yet because, on the one hand, I have a clear and distinct idea of myself, in so far as I am a thinking and not an extended thing, and, on the other, a distinct idea of the body, in so far as it is only an extended and not a thinking thing, it is certain that I am really distinct from my body,* and can exist without it.

Moreover, I find in myself faculties of thinking in various specific ways—namely, the faculties of imagination and sensation—without which I can understand myself clearly and distinctly as a whole. But the converse is not true—I cannot understand them apart from an intelligent substance in which they inhere (for they contain a certain degree of intellection in their formal concept).* Hence I perceive that they are to be distinguished from me as modes are from a thing.* I also recognize various other faculties, such as those of changing place, and assuming various postures, that cannot be understood
79 (any more than those just mentioned) without some substance in which to inhere, and that therefore cannot exist without it. But it is plain that, if indeed these exist, they must inhere in a bodily or extended substance—but not, however, an intelligent one; for the clear and distinct concept of them includes some measure of extension, but does not at all include intellection. Moreover, there is in me a certain passive faculty of sensation, that is, of receiving and knowing [*cognoscendi*] ideas of sensible things. But I could make no use of it at all, if there did not exist, either in me or in another being, some active faculty of producing or generating these ideas. Now this faculty cannot, certainly, exist in myself,* because it presupposes no intellection at all, and because these ideas are produced not only without my cooperation but often even against my will.* It therefore follows that it must exist in some substance distinct from me, which substance must contain, either formally or eminently, all the reality that exists objectively in the ideas produced by the faculty (as I have already pointed out above).* This substance is either a body, or a bodily nature, that formally contains all that is contained objectively in the ideas; or else it has to be God, or some other creature nobler than a body, in which this is contained eminently. But because God is no deceiver, it is altogether plain that he does not transmit these ideas to me immediately, or by the intermediary of some creature, in whom their objective reality is contained not formally but only eminently. For since he has certainly given me no faculty by which I might realize this to be true, but has, on the contrary, endowed me
80 with a strong propensity to believe that these ideas are conveyed by bodily things, I cannot see how, if they were in fact from some other source, it would be possible to think of him except as a deceiver. And therefore bodily things exist. Perhaps, however, they do not all exist exactly as I apprehend them by the senses, since this

sensory apprehension is very obscure and confused in many respects. But at least all those properties are in them that I clearly and distinctly understand: that is, all those, generally considered, that are included in the object of pure mathematics.*

As to the remaining properties that are either purely particular (for instance, the sun's being of a certain magnitude or shape) or less clearly understood (for instance, light, sound, pain, and suchlike), although they are very doubtful and uncertain, yet this basic fact, that God is no deceiver, and that therefore it cannot be the case that any falsity should be found in my opinions, unless there is also some God-given faculty in me for correcting it, offers me a firm hope of discovering the truth with respect to them as well. And certainly, there is no doubt that everything I am taught by nature contains some element of truth: for by nature, in a general sense, I now mean nothing other than either God himself, or the system of created things established by God; and by my own nature in particular, I mean nothing other than the combination of all the properties bestowed on me by God.

Now there is nothing I am more emphatically taught by this nature of mine than that I have a body, with which there is something wrong when I feel pain, which needs food or drink, when I experience hunger or thirst, and so on and so forth. Hence I cannot doubt that there is some truth in all this.

Nature likewise teaches me, through these very feelings of pain, 81
hunger, thirst, and so forth, that I am not present in my body only as a pilot is present in a ship,* but that I am very closely conjoined to it and, so to speak, fused with it, so as to form a single entity with it. For otherwise, when the body is injured, I, who am nothing other than a thinking thing, would not feel pain as a result, but would perceive the injury purely intellectually, as the pilot perceives by sight any damage occurring to his ship; and when the body lacks food or drink, I would understand this explicitly, instead of having confused feelings of hunger and thirst. For certainly, these feelings of thirst, hunger, pain, and so forth are nothing other than certain confused modes of thinking, arising from the union and, so to speak, fusion of the mind with the body.

Besides, I am further taught by nature that various other bodies exist around mine: of these, some are to be pursued by me, others avoided. And certainly, from the fact that I perceive very different

colours, sounds, smells, tastes, degrees of heat, of hardness, and suchlike, I can validly conclude that in the bodies from which these varied sensory perceptions arise there are variations that correspond to them, even if, perhaps, they do not resemble them. And from the fact that some of these perceptions are pleasing to me, others displeasing, it is quite certain that my body, or rather myself as a whole, in so far as I am composed of a body and a mind, can be benefited or harmed by the surrounding bodies.

82 But there are many other beliefs that, although I seem to be taught them by nature, I have in fact derived not from nature itself, but from a certain habit of judging without due consideration, and so these can easily turn out to be false. For instance, that every space in which nothing at all is happening that has an impact on my senses is a vacuum;* or that in a body that is hot, say, there is something altogether similar to the idea of heat in me; that in a white or green body, there is the same whiteness or greenness of which I have the sensation, in one that is bitter or sweet the same taste, and so on and so forth;* that stars and towers and whatever other distant bodies one can think of are only of the same size and shape as they appear to be to my senses, and so on. But there is a risk I may fail to perceive this matter sufficiently clearly if I do not first define more precisely what exactly I mean when I say that I am taught something by nature. Here I am taking 'nature' in a more restricted sense than when I use the term to denote the combination of all the properties bestowed on me by God. For in this combination there are many things that belong to the mind alone, such as my perception that what has happened cannot not have happened, and all the other things that I know by the natural light. These are not my concern here. There are also many that relate to the body alone, as that it has a tendency to fall downwards,* and suchlike. But I am not here concerned with these either, only with those things bestowed by God on me, as a composite of mind and body. Now nature in this sense teaches us to avoid those things that cause a sensation of pain, and pursue those that produce a sensation of pleasure, and so forth. But it does not appear that nature teaches us anything else that would enable us to reach any conclusion, on the basis of these sensory perceptions, about things existing outside ourselves, without a prior examination by the intel-
83 lect; because it seems that a true knowledge [*scire*] of these belongs to the mind alone, but not to the composite entity. Thus, although a

star affects my eye no more than the gleam of a small torch, there is no real or positive inclination here to believe that the star is no bigger than the torch:* but I formed this belief in childhood without any reason to support it. And although when I come close to the fire I feel heat, and in fact I feel pain when I come too close to it, there is certainly no reason that should persuade me that there is something in the fire like the heat, any more than there is something in it like the pain—only that there is something in the fire, whatever in fact it is, that produces these feelings of heat or pain. Again, although in a given space there may be nothing that affects the senses, it does not therefore follow that there is no body in it. But I see that in these, and in very many other things, I have grown accustomed to perverting the order of nature, because I use sensory perceptions, which were specifically given by nature for signifying to the mind* what things are beneficial or harmful to the composite of which the mind is part—for which purpose they are sufficiently clear and distinct—as if they were reliable criteria for immediately discerning the essence of bodies existing outside us. Of this, however, they signify nothing, except in very obscure and confused fashion.

But I have already sufficiently examined how it can come to pass that, notwithstanding the goodness of God, my judgements are false. A further difficulty, however, arises here concerning these very things that are represented to me by nature as to be pursued or avoided, and concerning also the internal senses in which I seem to have discovered errors: as when someone, tricked by the pleasant taste of some food, absorbs a poison concealed in it. But in this case 84
he is prompted by nature to desire only the source of the pleasant taste, not the poison of which he knows nothing. And nothing more is to be inferred from this than that this nature is not omniscient; which is not surprising, since, man being a limited creature, the only nature he can be endowed with is one of limited perfection.

But yet we do quite frequently go astray even in things to which we are impelled by nature: as when sick people desire drink or food that will shortly do them harm. Someone might say here that they are led astray only because their nature has been corrupted:* but this does not remove the difficulty, because in truth, a sick human being is just as much a creature of God as a healthy one. And so it seems just as contrary to the goodness of God that his nature should be deceptive. Now a clock, an assembly of wheels and weights, obeys all the laws of

nature just as strictly when it has been badly manufactured and does not tell the time accurately as when it fulfils the clockmaker's wishes in every respect. And I can likewise consider the body of a human being as a kind of machine made up of bones, nerves, muscles, veins, blood, and skin so fitted together that, even if there were no mind within it, it would still have all the movements it currently has that do not result from the command of the will (and hence the mind). I can easily see that it would be natural, if, for example, the body were suffering from dropsy, for it to experience the dryness of the throat that usually communicates the sensation of thirst to the mind, so that, as a result, its nerves and other parts would be so disposed that it would have something to drink, thus making the disease worse; just as natural as it would be for a perfectly healthy body to be prompted
85 by a similar dryness in the throat to take a drink that would do it good. And although, if we take into account the intended function of the clock, we can say that, when it fails to indicate the time correctly, it has fallen away from its nature; and likewise, if we consider the machine of the human body as designed so as to enable the movements that usually take place in it, I may think that it has gone astray from its own nature if its throat is dry at a time when drink will not conduce to its preservation, yet I can see perfectly clearly that this latter meaning of 'nature' is quite different from the former. For the latter meaning is nothing more than a denomination* dependent on my thinking, when I compare a sick human being and a badly made clock with my idea of a healthy human being and a well-made clock, and it tells us nothing about the actual things in question; whereas by the former I mean something that is actually found in the things themselves, and therefore contains a degree of truth.

But certainly, even though, when considering the body suffering from dropsy, to speak of its nature being corrupted, on the grounds that its throat is dry and yet it does not need to drink, is merely an extrinsic denomination; yet if we consider the composite entity, that is, the mind as united to a body in this state (thirsty when drink would be harmful to it), this is not a pure denomination, but a genuine error of nature.* And so the question refuses to go away, how it is that the goodness of God does not prevent nature in this precise sense from being deceptive.

Now, first of all, I observe here that there is a great difference between the mind and the body, in this respect, that the body of its

nature is endlessly divisible, but the mind completely indivisible: for 86
certainly, when I consider the mind, or myself in so far as I am purely a thinking thing, I can distinguish no parts in myself but understand myself to be a thing that is entirely one and complete. And although the whole mind appears to be united with the whole body, if the foot is cut off, or the arm, or any other part of the body, I know [*cognosco*] that nothing is therefore subtracted from the mind. Nor can the faculties of willing, perceiving by the senses, understanding, and so forth be said to be parts of the mind, since it is one and the same mind that wills, that senses, and that understands. On the other hand, however, no bodily or extended thing can be thought by me that I cannot mentally divide into parts, without any difficulty; and I therefore understand it is divisible. This point alone would suffice to show me that the mind is altogether distinct from the body, if I did not yet sufficiently know [*scirem*] this for other reasons.

Next, I observe that the mind is not affected immediately by all the parts of the body, but only by the brain, or perhaps only by one very small part of the brain, namely that in which the 'common sense' is said to reside.* Whenever this part is affected in the same way, it represents the same thing to the mind, even if the other parts of the body happen to be differently affected at the same time. This is proved by innumerable observations* [*experimenta*] that there is no need to go into here.

Moreover, I observe that it is of the nature of a body that none of its parts can be moved by another part somewhat distant from it, without its being able to be moved in the same way by any of the parts that lie between them, even when the more distant part is not involved in the movement. For instance, take a piece of string, with points A, B, C, and D. If the last part, D, is pulled, the first part, A, 87
will be moved in exactly the same way as it would be moved if one of the intermediate points, B or C, were pulled, while the final point, D, remained immobile. By the same token, when I feel a pain in the foot, physics* teaches me that this sensation is produced by means of the nerves dispersed through the foot, which, since they extend upwards like strings as far as the brain, when plucked in the foot also pluck the inmost parts of the brain in which they terminate, thus stimulating a particular motion in these parts of the brain, which is so ordained by nature that it affects the mind with a feeling of pain apparently located in the foot. But because these nerves have to pass up the leg,

the thigh, the loins, the back, and the neck in order to connect the foot and the brain, it can come about that, even if the part of the nerve that is in the foot is not affected, but only one of the intermediate parts, exactly the same movement will take place in the brain as takes place when the foot is injured, so that the mind will necessarily experience the same pain. And the same must apply to all our other sensations.

Finally, I observe that, since each one of the motions that take place in the part of the brain that directly affects the mind produces only one sensation in the mind, no better explanation of this can be conceived than that the particular movement produces, of all the possible sensations it could produce, the sensation that most effectively and most frequently conduces to the preservation of the human being in good health. And experience bears witness that this applies to all the sensations with which nature has endowed us, and that therefore nothing at all can be found in them that does not bear
88 witness to God's immense power and goodness. Thus, for instance, when the nerves in the foot are violently and unusually stimulated, their movement, transmitted through the spinal cord to the inner parts of the brain, there gives a signal to the mind to experience a certain sensation, namely a pain experienced as being in the foot. By this the mind is stimulated to do its best to remove the cause of the pain, as being damaging to the foot. To be sure, the nature of man could have been so established by God that this same motion in the brain could have represented something different to the mind: it could have represented itself, in so far as it takes place in the brain, or in so far as it takes place in the foot, or in any of the places in between, or it could have represented something else altogether;* but nothing else would have been so conducive to the body's preservation. In the same way, when we need to drink, a certain dryness originates in the throat, setting in motion the nerves there, and by their means the inner parts of the brain; and this motion affects the mind with the sensation of thirst, because in this situation there is nothing more useful to us to know than that we need a drink for the sake of preserving our health. And the same applies with all our other sensations.

From all this, it is entirely plain that, notwithstanding God's immense goodness, the nature of man, as a composite of mind and body, cannot but be liable to error at times. For if some cause not in the foot, but in some one of the other parts through which the nerves

run on their way from the foot to the brain, or indeed in the brain itself, stimulates the very same motion as is usually stimulated by some injury to the foot, a pain will be felt as if in the foot, and our sense will be naturally deceived. This is because, since one and the same movement in the brain can only produce one and the same sensation in the mind, and since it is much more usually produced by some cause injuring the foot than by any other cause located somewhere else, it is in accordance with reason that it should always 89
represent to the mind a pain in the foot rather than in any other part. And if sometimes a dryness in the throat arises, not from its usual cause, which is that the body's health would be benefited by drinking, but from some other, contrary cause, as happens with those suffering from dropsy, it is better that it should deceive us in this latter case, than that, on the contrary, it should always deceive us when the body is healthy. And the same applies elsewhere.

And this consideration will assist me greatly, not only to be aware of all the errors to which my nature is liable, but also to correct or avoid them easily. For certainly, since I know [*sciam*] that all our sensations indicate the truth far more frequently than the contrary, as far as the well-being of the body is concerned, and since in examining a particular case I can almost always draw on several of them, as well as on my memory, which connects present with past, and on my understanding, which has already discovered all the causes of error, I need no longer fear that the things the senses represent to me in ordinary life are false: on the contrary, the hyperbolic doubts of these past days can be dismissed as ridiculous. Especially the ultimate doubts concerning sleeping, which I could not distinguish from waking; for now I realize that there is a massive difference between them, inasmuch as dreams are never combined by my memory with the rest of the actions of my life, as happens with my waking experiences. For certainly if, while I was awake, someone suddenly appeared before me, and then immediately disappeared, as happens in dreams, in such a way, I mean, that I could not see where he was coming
from or where he was going, I would not unreasonably judge it to 90
be an apparition or a delusion produced by my brain, rather than a real person. But when things happen to me in such a way that I am distinctly aware of whence, where, and when they have come, and I connect the perception of them to the rest of my life, without any gaps, then I am well and truly certain that they are happening not in

my sleep but when I am awake. Nor should I doubt even in the slightest degree of their truth, if after I have summoned all the senses, the memory, and the understanding to join in their examination, none of these reports anything that clashes with the report of the rest. For, from the fact that God is not a deceiver, it follows inescapably that in such cases I am not deceived. But because the necessities of action do not always allow us the opportunity for such a thorough examination, we must admit that human life is subject to frequent error in connection with particular things, and we must acknowledge the frailties of our nature.*

Correspondence between Descartes and Princess Elisabeth

René Descartes and Princess Elisabeth of Bohemia

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[Brackets] enclose editorial explanations. Small ·dots· enclose material that has been added, but can be read as though it were part of the original text. Occasional •bullets, and also indenting of passages that are not quotations, are meant as aids to grasping the structure of a sentence or a thought. Every four-point ellipsis . . . . indicates the omission of a brief passage that seems to present more difficulty than it is worth. Longer omissions are reported on, between [brackets], in normal-sized type. This version aims mainly to present the *philosophical* content of the correspondence; though after the philosophical content stops, a continuing dramatic triangle—philosopher, queen, princess—is too interesting to pass up entirely. But much material has been omitted; it can be found in Lisa Shapiro's informative edition (Chicago University Press, 2007). Titles and other honorifics are omitted; and Descartes will be made to use 'you' and 'your' where in fact he always used 'your Highness' and 'she' and 'her'. Also omitted: the signing-off flourishes—usually (from Descartes) 'your very humble and very obedient servant' and (from Elisabeth) 'Your very affectionate friend at your service'; and also, in some letters, a penultimate sentence whose only role is to lead into the closing flourish.—**Place:** Elisabeth writes from The Hague in all her letters (with one exception) through vii.1646, from Berlin through 5 xii.1647, and then from Crossen. All of Descartes' letters are written from Egmond (Holland) except for two from France in vii.1644, one from The Hague in 6.vi.1647, one from Paris vi.1648) and one last letter from Stockholm. Strictly speaking, Descartes lived and wrote at different times in two small towns called Egmond-something.

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Letters written in 1643 and 1664

Elisabeth writes on 6.v.1643:

When I heard that you had planned to visit me a few days ago, I was •elated by your kind willingness to share yourself with an ignorant and headstrong person, and •saddened by the misfortune of missing such a profitable conversation. When M. Pollot [a friend of Descartes and of the Princess] took me through the solutions you had given him for some obscurities in Regius's physics, that increased my regret at missing you, because I'd have learned them better from you directly. And direct contact would have given me something else. When Professor Regius was here in The Hague, I put to him a question that he said would be better answered by you. I am shy about my disorderly writing style, which is why I haven't before now written to you asking for this favour.

[In her next sentence, the Princess relies on a theory about soul-on-body according to which the soul's thoughts are passed on to the 'spirits'—components of the body—which then cause overt bodily movements. See also note after the end of this paragraph.] But today M. Pollot has given me such assurance of your good-will towards everyone and especially towards me that I have overcome my inhibitions and come right out with ·the question I put to the Professor, namely·:

> Given that the soul of a human being is only a *thinking* substance, how can it affect the bodily spirits, in order to bring about voluntary actions?

·The question arises· because it seems that how a thing moves depends solely on **(i)** how much it is pushed, **(ii)** the manner in which it is pushed, or **(iii)** the surface-texture and shape of the thing that pushes it. [That version of **(1)** is a guess, based on the guess that *pulsion* should have been *impulsion*.] The first two of those require *contact* between the two things, and the third requires that the causally active thing be extended. Your notion of the soul entirely excludes extension, and it appears to me that an immaterial thing can't possibly *touch* anything else. So I ask you for a definition of the soul that homes in on its nature more thoroughly than does the one you give in your *Meditations*, i.e. I want one that characterizes what it •is as distinct from what it •does (namely to think). It looks as though human souls can exist without thinking—e.g. in an unborn child or in someone who has a great fainting spell—but even if that is not so, and the soul's intrinsic nature and its thinking are as inseparable as God's attributes are, we can still get a more perfect idea of both of them by considering them separately. ·In writing to you like this· I am freely exposing to you the weaknesses of my soul's speculations; but I know that you are the best physician for *my* soul, and I hope that you will observe the Hippocratic oath and supply me with remedies without making them public. [She is referring to an oath traditionally associated with Hippocrates, a pioneer of medicine in the 4th century BCE, which includes this: 'All that may come to my knowledge in the exercise of my profession or in daily commerce with men, which ought not to be spread abroad, I will keep secret and will never reveal.']

[The French word for the bodily 'spirits' referred to in that paragraph is *esprit*. That word can also mean 'mind', and is thus translated wherever that is appropriate in this version, e.g. in Descartes's reference to the Princess's 'incomparable mind' on page 3. When he or the Princess is writing about the mind in a weightily theoretical way—e.g. discussing inter-action between mind and body—they use not *esprit* but *âme*, usually translated by 'soul'. The link between *âme* and 'soul' will be preserved throughout this version; but remember that these uses of

'soul' have little if any theological content and are, nearly always, merely high-flown ways of saying 'mind'.].

Descartes writes on 21.v.1643:

[He starts by praising the Princess's favour of *writing* to him. When they have met, he says, he has been so dazzled by her combination of intelligence and beauty that he couldn't converse well. He continues:] No doubt you have noticed this, and have kindly wanted to help me with this by leaving me the traces of your thoughts on paper. I have now read them several times and become accustomed to thinking about them, with the result that I am indeed less dazzled, but am correspondingly more admiring when I see that these thoughts seem ingenious at a first reading and appear increasingly judicious and solid the more I examine them.

In view of my published writings, the question that can most rightly be asked is the very one that you put to me. All the knowledge we can have of the human soul depend on two facts about it: **(1)** the fact that it thinks, and **(2)** the fact that being united to the body it can act and be acted on along with it.

[For 'act' French has *agir* and for 'be acted on' it has *pâtir*, for which there is no equivalent verb in English. The verb-pair

agir—*pâtir*

is linked to the English noun-pair

'agent'—'patient'

in a now-obsolete sense of 'patient', and to the noun-pair

'action'—'passion'

in a now-obsolete sense of 'passion', and to the adjective-pair

'active'—'passive'

with meanings that are still current.]

I have said almost nothing about **(2)**, focussing entirely on making **(1)** better understood. That is because my principal aim was to show that the soul is distinct from the body, and **(1)** was helpful in showing this whereas **(2)** could have been harmful ·clouding the issue, distracting the reader·. But I can't hide anything from eyesight as sharp as yours! So I'll try here to explain how I conceive of the soul's union with the body and how it has the power to move the body.

I start by focussing on the fact that we have certain *basic* notions that are like templates on the pattern of which we form all our other knowledge. There are very few of these. In addition to the most general ones—

(1) the notions of being, number, duration, etc.

—which apply to everything we can conceive, we have for the body in particular

(2) only the notion of **extension**, from which follow the notions of shape and movement;

and for the soul alone

(3) only the notion of **thought**, which includes ·the notions of· the perceptions of the understanding and the inclinations of the will;

and finally, for the soul and the body together

(4) only the notion of **their union**, on which depends the notion of the soul's power to move the body and the body's power to act on the soul in causing its sensations and passions.

I observe next that all secure, disciplined human knowledge consists only in keeping these notions well apart from one another, and applying each of them only to the things that it is right for. [Throughout this letter, phrases about a notion's being 'right for' x translate French uses of *appartenir à*, literally meaning that the notion belongs to x.] When we try to explain some difficulty by means of a notion that isn't right for it, we are bound to go wrong; just as we are when we try to explain ·or define· one of these notions in terms of another, because each of them is *basic* and thus can be understood only through itself. The use of the senses has made our notions of extension, shapes and movements much more familiar to us

than our other notions, and just because of that the principal cause of our errors lies in our commonplace attempts to use these notions to explain things that they aren't right for. For example, when we try to use the imagination to conceive the nature of the soul, or when we try to conceive how the soul moves the body in terms of how a body moves a body.

In the *Meditations*, which you were good enough to read, I tried to make conceivable **(3)** the notions that are right for the soul alone, distinguishing them from **(2)** the ones that are right for the body alone; so the first thing that I ought to explain now is how to conceive **(4)** the notions that are right for the union of the soul with the body, separately from **(2)** and **(3)**. It seems to me that what I wrote at the end of my response to the Sixth Objections can help with that; for we can't look for these simple notions anywhere except in our soul, which naturally contains them all, though it doesn't always **(i)** distinguish them from one another or **(ii)** apply them to the objects to which they ought to be applied.

Thus, I think we have until now **(i)** confused the notion of •the soul's power to act on the body with •the body's power to act on other bodies, and have **(ii)** applied them (not to the soul, for we haven't yet known the soul, but) to various qualities of bodies—weight, heat, and so on—which we have imagined to be real, i.e. to have an existence distinct from that of the body ·that has them·, and thus to be •substances though we have called them •'qualities'.

[Descartes here uses 'real'—*réelles*, which comes from the Latin *res* = 'thing'—as a way of saying that we have imagined these •qualities to be •things. He is referring scornfully to a philosophical theory that implies things like this: When cold x is placed on red-hot y, some of y's heat passes over into x. It's not just that y cools by as much as x heats up, but the very same individual instance of heat that y has is acquired by x. This theory distinguishes three items:

a concrete particular: the red-hot plate y
an abstract universal: heat
an abstract particular: the heat of y.

Descartes always rejected this theory of 'real qualities', saying that in treating an individual package (so to speak) of heat as being possessed first by y and then by x you are treating it as a thing, a substance.]

Trying to understand weight, heat and the rest, we have applied to them •sometimes notions that we have for knowing body and •sometimes ones that we have for knowing the soul, depending on whether we were attributing to them something material or something immaterial. Take for example what happens when we suppose that weight is a 'real quality' about which we know nothing except that it has the power to move the body that has it toward the centre of the earth. ·*How* do we think that **the weight of a rock moves the rock** downwards·? We don't think that this happens through a real contact of one surface against another ·as though the weight was a hand pushing the rock downwards·! But we have no difficulty in conceiving how it moves the body, nor how the weight and the rock are connected, because we find from our own inner experience that we ·*already*· *have* a notion that provides just such a connection. But I believe we are misusing this notion when we apply it to weight—which, as I hope to show in my *Physics*, is not a *thing* distinct from the body that has it. For I believe that this notion was given to us for conceiving how **the soul moves the body**.

If I make this explanation any longer I'll be doing an injustice to your incomparable mind, whereas if I let myself think that what I have written so far will be entirely satisfactory to you I'll be guilty of egotism. I'll try to steer between these by saying just this: if I can write or say something that could please you, I will always take it as a great honour to take up a pen or to go to The Hague [where Elisabeth was living at this time] for that purpose. . . . But I can't find here ·in your letter· anything that brings into play the Hippocratic oath that you put to me, because everything in the letter deserves to be seen and admired by everyone. ·Still, I will conform to the

oath·! Your letter is infinitely precious to me, and I'll treat it in the way misers do their treasures: the more they value them the more they hide them, grudging the sight of them to rest of the world and placing their supreme happiness in looking at them. . . .

Elisabeth writes on 10.vi.1643:

Your goodness shows not only in your (of course) pointing out and correcting the faults in my reasoning but also in your using false praise. . . .so as to make the faults less distressing to me. The false praise wasn't necessary: the life I live here. . . .has made me so familiar with my faults that the thought of them doesn't make me *feel* anything beyond the desire to remedy them.

So I am not ashamed to admit that I have found in myself all the causes of error the you mention in your letter, and that I can't yet banish them entirely. That's because the life that I am constrained to lead doesn't let me free up enough time to acquire a habit of meditation in accordance with your rules. The interests of my house (which I must not neglect) and conversations and social obligations (which I can't avoid), inflict so much annoyance and boredom on this weak mind ·of mine· that it is useless for anything else for a long time afterward. [By 'my house' she means the semi-royal family to which she belongs. Her father had been raised in 1620 from his semi-royal status to the title of King of Bohemia, then in a matter of months he lost his kingdom (to the Holy Roman Empire) and the other lands he had ruled (to Spain). He and some of his family took refuge in The Hague, where they were joined by Elisabeth and some of her siblings in the late 1620s. Her father died in battle (fighting on behalf of the King of Sweden) in 1632. The exiled fatherless family was in some ways politically engaged and politically prominent; it was not wealthy.] I hope that this will excuse my stupid inability to grasp ·what you want me to grasp·. I don't see how

(1) the idea that you used to have about weight

can guide us to

(2) the idea we need in order to judge how the (nonextended and immaterial) soul can move the body.

·To put some flesh on the bones of my difficulty·: I don't see why we should be persuaded that

(a) a body **can** be pushed by some immaterial thing

by

(b) the ·supposed· power to carry the body toward the centre of the earth, the 'power' that you used wrongly to attribute to weight which you ·wrongly· took to be a ·real· quality;

rather than being confirmed in the view that

(c) a body **cannot** be pushed by some immaterial thing

by the demonstration, which you promise in your physics, that

(d) the way weight operates is nothing like **(b)**.

The old idea about *weight* may be a fiction produced by ignorance of what really moves rocks toward the centre of the earth (it can't claim the special guaranteed truthfulness that the idea of God has!). ·And if we are going to try theorising about the cause of weight·, the argument might go like this:

No material cause ·of weight· presents itself to the senses, so this power must be due to the contrary of what is material, i.e. to an immaterial cause.

But I've never been able to conceive of 'what is immaterial' in any way except as ·the bare negative· 'what is not material', and *that* can't enter into causal relations with matter!

I have to say that I would find it easier to concede matter and extension to the soul than to concede that an immaterial thing could move and be moved by a body. On the one side, if the soul moves the body through *information* [French word], the spirits would have to think, and you say that nothing of

a bodily kind thinks. On the other side, you show in your *Meditations* that the body could move the soul, and yet it is hard to understand that a soul (as you have described souls), having become able and accustomed to reasoning well, can lose all that because of some vaporous condition of the body; and that a soul that can exist without the body, and that has nothing in common with the body, is so governed by it.

But now that you have undertaken to instruct me, I entertain these views only as friends whom I don't expect to keep ·as friends·, assuring myself that you will explain the nature of an immaterial substance and the manner in which it acts and is acted on in the body, making as good a job of this as of all the other things that you have undertaken to teach.

Descartes writes on 28.vi.1643:

I am very obliged to you for your patient willingness to hear me out on a subject which I presented so badly in my previous letter, giving me a chance to fill the gaps in that letter. The chief ones, it seems to me, are these two: **(1)** After distinguishing three sorts of ideas or basic notions each of which is known in its own special way and not by a comparison with the others—i.e. our notions of the soul, of the body, and of the soul's union with the body—I ought to have explained the differences among these three sorts of notions and among the operations of the soul through which we have them, and to have said how we make each of them familiar and easy to us. **(2)** After saying why I brought in the comparison with weight, I ought to have made clear that although one may wish to think of the soul as material (which strictly speaking *is* just to conceive its union with the body), that wouldn't stop one from realizing that the soul is separable from the body. I think that those cover everything that you asked me to do in your letter.

First, then, I notice this big difference amongst these three sorts of notions: •The soul is conceived only by the pure intellect; •the body—i.e. extension, shapes and motions—can also be known by the intellect alone, but the knowledge is much better when the intellect is aided by the imagination; and finally the knowledge we get of •what belongs to the soul's union with the body is a very dark affair when it comes from the intellect (whether alone or aided by the imagination), but it is very bright when the senses have a hand in it. [‘Dark’ and ‘Bright’ translate adverbs related to the adjectives *obscur* and *clair*. To translate the latter as ‘clear’ is often wrong: it makes poor sense of many things that Descartes says using *clair*, most notably of his saying that pain is always *clair*, this being his explanation of what *clair* means! His famous emphasis on ideas that are *claires et distinctes* calls for ideas that are vivid and clear (in that order).] That's why people who never come at things in a theoretical way and use only their senses have no doubt that the soul moves the body and that the body acts on the soul. They regard soul and body as a single thing, i.e. they conceive their union. ·I equate those· because conceiving the union between two things *is* conceiving them as one single thing. Metaphysical thoughts, which exercise the unaided intellect, serve to familiarize us with the notion of the soul; and the study of mathematics, which mainly employs the imagination (in thinking about shapes and motions), accustoms us to form very clear notions of body. But what teaches us how to conceive the soul's union with the body is •the ordinary course of life and conversation and •*not* meditating or studying things that exercise the imagination.

Please don't think that I am joking; I have and always will have too much respect for you to do that. It really is true that the chief rule that I keep to in my studies—the rule that I think has helped me most in my gaining a bit of

knowledge—has been this:

> I never spend more than a few hours a •day in the thoughts involving the imagination, or more than a few hours a •year on thoughts that involve the intellect alone. I give all the rest of my time to the relaxation of the senses and the repose of the mind.

[Descartes writes of giving time to the *relâche des sens* which could mean 'resting the senses' but probably means 'resting in ways that involve the senses'.] I count among imagination-involving activities all serious conversations and anything that needs to be done with attention. This is why I have retired to the country. In the busiest city in the world I could have as many hours to myself as I now employ in study, but I couldn't make such good use of them when my mind was tired by the attention I'd had to give to everyday life's bustling tangles. I take the liberty of telling you this as an admiring tribute to your ability—in the midst of all the business and cares that come to people who combine great minds with high birth—to apply your mind to the •meditations needed to appreciate the soul's distinctness from the body.

·I wrote as I did because· I judged that it was these •meditations, rather than those other intellectually less demanding thoughts, that led you to find obscurity in our notion of their union; because it seems to me that the human mind *can't* conceive

> the soul's **(a)** distinctness from the body and its **(b)** union with the body,

conceiving them very clearly and both at the same time. That is because this requires one to conceive them as **(b)** one single thing and at the same time as **(a)** two things, which is contradictory. ·When I wrote my letter· I thought you still had at the forefront of your mind the reasons which prove that **(a)** the soul is distinct from the body; and I didn't want to ask you to push them aside so as to bring to the fore the notion of **(b)** their union that everyone always experiences within himself without philosophizing—·simply· by knowing that he is a single person who has both body and thought whose natures are such that this thought can move the body and can sense what happens to the body. *That* is why in my letter I brought in a comparison with weight and the other qualities that we commonly imagine to be united to some bodies just as thought is united to our own. It was an imperfect comparison, because weight and those other qualities are not 'real' though we imagine them as being so [See note on page 3]; but I wasn't troubled by that because I thought that you were already completely convinced that the soul is a substance distinct from body.

But since you remark that it is easier to attribute matter and extension to the soul than to credit it with the capacity to move and be moved by the body without having matter, please feel free to attribute this matter and extension to the soul—because that's what it is to conceive it as united to the body. Once you have formed a proper conception of this and experienced it in yourself, you'll find it easy to realize that

- •the matter you'll have attributed to a thought is not the thought itself, and
- •the extension of this matter is of a different nature from the extension of this thought (because the former is pinned to a definite location which it occupies so as to keep out all other bodily extension, which is not the case with the latter).

So you won't find it hard to return to the knowledge of the soul's distinctness from the body in spite of having conceived their union.

[Four points about the above indented passage. •The switch from 'soul' to 'thought' is Descartes's; you might like to think about why he switched. •The passage may explain why Descartes has spoken of 'attributing matter to the soul' rather than, more naturally, 'attributing materiality

to the soul'. Could the indented passage be rewritten so as not to need the concrete noun 'matter'? •What Descartes says about 'the extension of this matter' is what he would say about the extension of *any* matter. •Is Descartes implying that thoughts do have extension, though not the *Other extended things: Keep out!* kind of extension that bodies have?]

I believe that it is very necessary to have properly understood the principles of metaphysics •once in a lifetime, because they are what give us knowledge of God and of our soul. I also think that ·someone's· •frequently focussing his intellect on them would be very harmful, because it would unfit him for handling well the functions of the imagination and the senses. The best course, I think, is to settle for keeping in one's memory and one's belief-system the conclusions that one did once drawn from metaphysical principles, and then employ the rest of one's study time to thoughts in which the intellect co-operates with the imagination and the senses.

My great devotion to your service makes me hope that my frankness won't displease you. I would have written at greater length, trying to clear up all at once the difficulties you have raised, if it weren't that... [and then he reports on the distractions of a legal problem arising from a public dispute he has had with Gisbertus Voetius, a Dutch theologian who had attacked Descartes and arranged for a formal denunciation of his philosophy at the University of Utrecht, of which he was the head].

Elisabeth writes on 1.vii.1643:

I gather that the high value I put on your teachings, and my desire to profit from them, haven't put you to as much trouble as you have had from the ingratitude of people who deprive themselves of your teachings and want to deprive the human race of them. I wasn't going to send you ·my last letter·—new evidence of my ignorance!—until I heard that you were done with those obstinate dogmatists; but M. Van Bergen kindly agreed to stay on in town here until he could have ·and take to you· a reply to your letter of 28 June—which gives me a clear view of the three kinds of notions we have, their objects, and how we should make use of them—and that obliged me to get on with it.

I find ·from your letter· that the senses show me **that** the soul moves the body, but as for **how** it does so, the senses tell me nothing about that, any more than the intellect and the imagination do. This leads me to think that the soul has properties that we don't know—which might overturn your doctrine, of which I was persuaded by your excellent arguments in the *Meditations*, that the soul is not extended. This doubt seems to be supported by the rule that you give there for handling issues of truth and falsity, ·saying· that all our errors come from our forming judgments about things that we don't perceive well enough. Although extension is not necessary to •thought, it isn't inconsistent with it either; so it may flow from •something else that the soul does that is no less essential to it ·than thought is·. [In that sentence, 'flow from' is a guess. The original has *duire à*, which isn't French. The great Descartes editors Adam and Tannery conjecture *nuire à* = 'clash with', but that reverses what seems clearly to be the main thrust of what the Princess is saying.] At least it—·the thesis that the soul is extended·—pulls down the ·self·-contradictory doctrine of the scholastics that the soul is entirely present in the whole body and entirely present in each of its parts. As for the thesis itself, I plead guilty to having confused the notion of the soul with that of the body for the same reason that the vulgar do; but this ·acknowledgment of error· still leaves me with my initial doubt, ·i.e. my thinking that perhaps after all the soul is extended·, and if you—who single-handedly kept me from being a sceptic—don't clear away this doubt

to which my first reasoning carried me, I'll lose hope of ever being certain of anything.

I *owe* you this confession. . . ., but I would think it very imprudent if I didn't already know—from my own experience and from your reputation—that your kindness and generosity are equal to the rest of your merits. You couldn't have matched up to your reputation in a more obliging way than through the clarifications and advice you have given to me, which I prize among the greatest treasures I could have.

The letters of xi.1643:

[No reply by Descartes to the foregoing letter has been found.

[He sent to the Princess a certain problem in geometry; she gave a solution to it that Descartes was told about; he wrote at length, explaining why his own first solution was less elegant than hers was said to be; she sent own solution, which Descartes heralded as 'very like the one I proposed in my *Geometry*'; and he wrote at length about the advantages of elegance and economy in mathematical proofs.

[This evidently all happened in November 1643; some of the letters involved have been lost; the three that survive—two by him, one by her—are omitted from this version of the Correspondence.

[The next letter that we have was written half a year later, by Descartes. It responds to one by Elisabeth that we do not have.]

Descartes writes on 8.vii.1644:

My voyage ·to Paris· couldn't involve any misfortune when I had the good fortune of making it while being alive in your memory. The very flattering letter ·from you· that testifies to this is the most precious thing I could have received in this country. It would have made me perfectly happy if it hadn't told me that the illness you had before I left The Hague has lingered on in the form of stomach troubles. The remedies you have chosen—involving •diet and •exercise—are in my opinion the best of all. Well, they are the best (all things considered) *after* the remedies of •the soul, which certainly has great power over the body, as is shown by the big changes that anger, fear, and the other passions arouse in it. But when the soul conducts the animal spirits to the places where they can help or harm, it does this not by directly willing the spirits to go in those ways but by willing or thinking of something else. For our body is so constructed that certain movements in it follow naturally upon certain thoughts: as we see that blushes follows from shame, tears from compassion, and laughter from joy. I know of no thought more conducive to continuing health than a strong conviction that our body is so well constructed that once we are healthy we can't easily fall ill—unless we engage in some excess or are harmed by air pollution or some other external cause. [In that sentence 'a strong •conviction' translates Descartes's double phrase '*une forte persuasion et ferme créance*; it isn't obvious what two concepts are involved in this.] Someone who is ill can restore his health solely by the power of nature, especially when he is still young. This •conviction is certainly much truer and more reasonable than the view of some people—I have *seen* this happen—who are influenced by an astrologer or a physician to think they must die in a certain amount of time, and are caused purely by this belief to become sick and even, often enough, to die. I couldn't help being extremely sad if I thought that you were still unwell; I prefer to hope that the illness is all over; but my desire to be certain about this makes me eager to return to Holland.

I plan to leave here in four or five days, to go to Poitou and Brittany where I must do the ·family· business that brought

me here. As soon as I have put my affairs in order, I'll be very anxious to return to the region where I have had the happy honour of occasionally speaking with you. There are many people here whom I honour and esteem, but I haven't yet seen anything to keep me here.

Descartes writes in Latin in vii.1644

[This is a dedicatory letter to the Princess that Descartes put at the beginning of his *Principles of Philosophy*.]

The biggest reward I have received from my published writings is that you have been so good as to read them, for that has led to my being admitted into the circle of your acquaintance, which has given me such a knowledge of your talents that I think that it would be a service to mankind to record them as an example to posterity. I wouldn't lower myself to use flattery or to assert anything that hasn't been thoroughly scrutinized, especially in a work in which I shall be trying to lay down the foundations of the truth. And I know that your generous and modest nature will prefer the simple undecorated judgment of a philosopher to the polished compliments of those with smoother tongues. So I shall write only what I know to be true either through reason or from experience, and I shall philosophize here ·in this dedicatory letter· just as I do throughout the rest of the book.

[In this paragraph and the next, 'vice' means quite generally 'morally wrong behaviour'; it doesn't have built into its meaning *any* of the further associations that the word 'vice' tends to have these days.] There's a great difference between apparent virtues and true ones. . . . What I call 'apparent virtues' are •certain relatively unusual *vices* that are ·extreme· opposites of other better known vices, with the related virtues occupying a position intermediate between the two. Because •they are further from their opposite vices than the virtues are, they are usually praised more highly ·than the related virtues are·. Here are some examples. **(1)** It more often happens that someone timidly flees from danger than that someone rashly throws himself into it; so •rashness is contrasted with the vice of timidity as if •it were a virtue, and is commonly valued more highly than true courage ·which is intermediate between timidity and rashness·. ·The same mechanism is at work when· **(2)** someone who is over-generous is more highly praised than one who gives liberally ·because his conduct is further from the vice of meanness than is the virtuous conduct of the merely liberal giver·. . . .

There is also a division within the true virtues, between ones that arise solely from knowledge of what is right and ones that come partly from some error. Examples of the latter class of virtues:

goodness that is a result of naivety,
piety that comes from fear,
courage that comes from the loss of hope.

Because such virtues differ from each other, they have different names; whereas the pure and genuine virtues that come entirely from knowledge of what is right all have the very same nature and are covered by the single term 'wisdom'. The person who is firmly and effectively resolved always to use his reasoning powers correctly, as far as he can, and to do whatever he knows to be best, is the person who is as wise as his nature allows him to be. And simply because of this ·wisdom·, he will have justice, courage, temperance, and all the other virtues—all interlinked in such a way that no one of them stands out among the others. Such virtues are far superior to the ones that owe their distinguishing marks to some admixture of vice, but they usually receive less praise because common people are less aware of them. [The shift from 'come partly from *error*' to 'have some admixture of *vice*'

is not a product of this version; it is there in the original.]

The kind of wisdom I have described has two prerequisites: •the perceptiveness of the intellect and the •disposition of the will. If something depends on the will, anybody can do it; but ·the same doesn't hold for intellectual perceptions, because· some people have much keener intellectual vision than others. Someone who is by nature a little slow in his thinking and ·therefore· ignorant on many points can nevertheless be wise in his own way and thus find great favour with God; all that is needed is for him to make a firm and steady decision to do his utmost to acquire knowledge of what is right, and always to pursue what he judges to be right. Still, he won't rise to the level of those who are firmly resolved to act rightly and have very sharp intellects combined with the utmost zeal for acquiring knowledge.

That you have that kind of zeal is clear from the fact that you haven't been prevented from studying all the worthwhile arts and sciences by the diversions of the royal household or the customary upbringing that so often condemns girls to ignorance. And the outstanding—the *incomparable*—sharpness of your intellect is obvious from your probing examination of all the secrets of these sciences, and from your getting mastery of their details in such a short time. I in particular have even greater evidence of your powers in the fact that you are the only person I have so far found who has completely everything understood I have so far published. Many other people, including ones with high intelligence and great learning, find my works very obscure. In most cases, someone who is accomplished in metaphysics hates geometry, whereas those who have mastered geometry don't grasp what I have written on First Philosophy [= 'metaphysics']. I'm right to use the word 'incomparable': yours is the *only* intellect I have encountered that finds everything equally clear. [He adds some praise of the princess's youth and beauty.] I see that everything required for perfect and sublime wisdom, both in intellect and in will, shines forth in your character. Along with your royal dignity you show an extraordinary kindness and gentleness which, though continually buffeted by the blows of fortune [see note on page 4], has never become embittered or broken. I am so overwhelmed by this that I want this statement of my philosophy to be offered and dedicated to the wisdom that I so admire in you—for philosophy is just the study of wisdom.

Elisabeth writes on 1.viii.1644:

[This was written after the Princess had received a copy of the *Principles of Philosophy* including the foregoing dedicatory letter.]

I have to thank you for the presentation copy that M. Van Bergen gave me on your behalf, and my conscience tells me sternly that I won't be able to thank you adequately! If I had received from it only the benefit it brings to our century—this century which owes you everything that earlier centuries have paid to innovators in the sciences, since you alone have demonstrated that there are any—·my debt to you would be big enough. But· what does my debt-level rise to when you have given me, along with your instruction, a share in your glory through your public declaration of your friendship and your approval? [The words 'that there are any' preserve the ambiguity of the French. The Princess may have meant 'that there are any innovations', but it seems likelier that she meant 'that there are any sciences'.] The pedants will say that you'll have to build a new morality in order to make me worthy of it! [She means '. . . to be worthy of your praise'.] But ·no new morality is needed·. My life is guided by the rule:

> Inform your intellect, and follow the good it acquaints you with.

I feel that I am only in the early stages of this process, but they win your approval there ·in your letter of dedication·. My attempt to follow this rule is what gives me my understanding of your works, which are obscure only to people who look at them very carelessly, or examine them by Aristotle's principles. For example, the intellectually ablest of our professors in this country have admitted to me that they haven't yet given any attention to your works because they are too old to start a new method, having exhausted their powers of body and the mind in the old one.

But I'm afraid that you will (rightly!) retract your high opinion of my ability to grasp things when you find out that I don't understand how quicksilver is constituted. ·My difficulty about that comes from the fact that· quicksilver is •as agitated as it is and •as heavy as it is, both at the same time. That conflicts with your definition of *weight* ·in *Principles* 4:20–23·. [She then refers to Descartes's account of quicksilver in 4:58 and challenges what she thinks is Descartes's explanation of a thing's lightness/heaviness in terms of what is below it, not of what is above it. This is a misreading of what Descartes wrote.]

The second difficulty that I encountered in trying to see how the particles that are twisted into the shape of shells can pass through the centre of the earth without being bent or disfigured by the fire that is there. . . . [This refers to Descartes's explanation of magnetism in 4:133, where he says that it depends on an unceasing 'vortex' of tiny screw-shaped particles that •pass through correspondingly shaped passages through the centre of the earth, •can't go back the way they came, and so travel halfway around the world and re-enter the passages that fit them.] The only way they could be saved from deformation would be by going very fast, but ·that explanation isn't open to you, because· you say in *Principles* 3:88. . . .that these are the least agitated parts of the first element which flow in this way through the globules of the second. I am equally surprised that they take such a long route, along the surface of the earth, to get from one pole back to the other; they could have found a shorter route [and she indicates what it is, in terms of a diagram in *Principles* 4:59].

I'm presenting here only the reasons for •my doubts about matters in your book; the reasons for •my wonder are innumerable, as are also my reasons for being obliged to you—including your kindness in telling me of your news and in giving me rules for keeping healthy. The news—of the great success of your voyage, and of your continuing to plan to return—has brought me much joy, and the rules have brought me much profit, because I have already felt the benefit of them.

Descartes writes in viii.1644:

The honour that you do me in not being displeased at my venturing to express in public how much I esteem and honour you is greater, and obliges me more, than any honour I could receive from any other source. I'm not afraid of being accused of having adjusted morality so as to make my views on this subject understood; because what I wrote about it is so true and so clear that I'm sure that every reasonable man accepts it. [The 'subject' in question is presumably morality.] But I'm afraid that what I have put in the rest of the book is more dubious and more obscure, since *you* find difficulties in it.

The difficulty about the weight of quicksilver is very considerable, and I would have tried to clear it up ·with some plausible conjecture· if I hadn't been afraid of saying something contrary to what I might learn later on when I had examined the nature of this metal more than I have up to now. All can say about it now is that I'm convinced that the little particles of air, of water, and of all the other

terrestrial bodies have many pores through which extremely finely divided matter can pass; and this follows well enough from how, according to me, these particles are formed. So I can explain why quicksilver and other metals are heavy by saying that their particles have fewer such pores. Suppose that ·for purposes of argument· we admit that particles of water have the same size and shape as those of quicksilver, and move in a similar way, all we need for an explanation of how quicksilver is bound to be much heavier than water is to suppose that •each particle of water is like a little cord that is very soft and loose while the •particles of quicksilver, having fewer pores, are like other cords that are much harder and tighter.

As for the little •particles shaped like shells, it's not surprising that they aren't destroyed by the fire at the centre of the earth. That's because this fire, which is entirely made up of extremely finely divided matter, can quite well carry •them very fast but can't make them crash up against other hard bodies; and that is what would be required to break or to divide them.

As for your other difficulty: these shell-like particles *don't* take a long way around to return from one pole to the other. In my account, most of them pass through the centre of the earth! The only particles that return through our air are ones that can't find any passage through the centre. This is how I explain why the magnetic strength of the entire mass of the earth doesn't appear to us to be as strong as that of little magnetic stones.

If everything I write here is very confusing, I beg you to forgive me. You kindly indicated which pages of the *Principles of Philosophy* you were speaking about; but I am still travelling and don't have the book with me. I hope to have the honour of paying my respects to you in The Hague in two or three months.

Descartes writes on 18.v.1645

I was extremely surprised to learn from letters of M. Pollot that you have been ill for a long time, and I curse my solitude, which led to my not knowing anything of this sooner. I really am so removed from the world that I don't learn anything about what is going on. Still, my zeal for serving you wouldn't have let me go so long without knowing the state of your health, even if I had to go to The Hague just to inquire about it, if it weren't for this:

> M. Pollot sent me a quick note about two months ago, promising to send a follow-up letter by the next regular mail. When no such letter arrived, I supposed that your health was holding steady, because Pollot never neglects to send me news of how you are doing.

But I learned from his most recent letters that you have had a low-grade fever, accompanied by a dry cough, which lasted three or four weeks, and that after five or six days of remission this illness returned. Right at the time when he sent me that letter (which took almost fifteen days to reach me) you were beginning to get better once again, ·as I learn from his even more recent letter·. I see in all this the signs of such a considerable illness (though you can certainly recover from it) that I cannot refrain from writing to tell you my view of the matter. I'm not a physician; but the honour you did me last summer of wanting to know my opinion about another illness that you then had makes me hope that you won't mind the liberty that I am now taking.

The most common cause of a low-grade fever is sadness; and fortune's stubborn *persistence* in persecuting your family gives you •sources of distress that are so public and so conspicuous that I don't have to conjecture very much or to be particularly experienced in social matters to judge that •they are the principal cause of your illness. [This refers to the

coming of civil war in England, which threatened the financial support that the English government had been giving to the shaky finances of Elisabeth's family; and also posed a threat to her uncle, Charles I of England, who did indeed lose his life over it four years later—see note on page 67.]

I would be afraid that you couldn't recover from this, if it weren't for the fact that you keep your soul content despite fortune's blows, doing this through the power of your virtue. I'm well aware that it would be unwise to try to cheer someone to whom fortune sends new occasions for grief each day. . . . I know also that you are much less affected by what concerns you personally than by what concerns the interests of your family and the persons you are care about—which I take to be the most lovable of all your virtues. What chiefly marks off the greatest souls from low-level vulgar ones, it seems to me, is that

> vulgar souls give themselves over to their passions and are happy or sad purely according to whether what happens to them is agreeable or unpleasant;

whereas

> great souls reason so powerfully that—although they too have passions, which are often more violent than those of the vulgar—their reason remains in command and brings it about that even afflictions serve them and contribute to the perfect happiness that they can enjoy ·not merely in the after-life but· already in this life.

Here is how they do it. They bear in mind •that they are immortal and capable of receiving very great contentment, and on the other hand •that they are joined to mortal and fragile bodies that are bound to perish in a few years; so they do whatever they can to make fortune favourable in this life, but they value this life so little from the perspective of eternity that they give ·worldly· events no more consideration than we give to events on the stage. Just as the sad stories that we weep to see represented on a stage often entertain us as much as happy ones, so the greatest souls get an inner satisfaction from *all* the things that happen to them, even the most distressing and unbearable. When they feel pain in their bodies they try hard to put up with it, and this show of their strength is agreeable to them. Seeing a friend in some great trouble they feel compassion at the friend's ill fortune and do all they can to rescue him from it, and they aren't afraid of risking death if that is necessary for this purpose. But the sadness that their compassion brings doesn't afflict them, because they are *happy* over the testimony of their conscience, which tells them that they are doing their duty, acting in a manner that is praiseworthy and virtuous. In short, just as the greatest prosperity of fortune never intoxicates them or makes them insolent, so also the greatest adversities can't defeat them or make them so sad that the body to which they are joined falls ill.

If I were writing to anyone but you I would be afraid that writing in this style is ridiculous; but I regard you as the noblest and most upstanding soul I know, so I think you should also be the happiest; and you really *will* be so if you cast your eyes on what is right under you and compare the value of the goods that you have—which can never be taken away from you—with the value of the goods that fortune has snatched away from you and the losses that fortune has inflicted on you through your near and dear. Then you will see all the many reasons you have to be content with the goods that you have.

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THOMAS HOBBES

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and that is, unpleasing priests; and those not only amongst Catholics, but even in that church that hath presumed most of reformation.*

CHAPTER XIII

OF THE NATURAL CONDITION OF MANKIND AS CONCERNING THEIR FELICITY, AND MISERY

Men by nature equal.

1. NATURE hath made men so equal, in the faculties of the body, and mind; as that though there be found one man sometimes manifestly stronger in body, or of quicker mind than another; yet when all is reckoned together, the difference between man, and man, is not so considerable, as that one man can thereupon claim to himself any benefit, to which another may not pretend, as well as he. For as to the strength of body, the weakest has strength enough to kill the strongest, either by secret machination, or by confederacy with others, that are in the same danger with himself.

2. And as to the faculties of the mind, (setting aside the arts grounded upon words, and especially that skill of proceeding upon general, and infallible rules, called science; which very few have, and but in few things; as being not a native faculty, born with us; nor attained (as prudence,) while we look after somewhat else,) I find yet a greater equality amongst men, than that of strength. For prudence, is but experience; which equal time, equally bestows on all [61] men, in those things they equally apply themselves unto. That which may perhaps make such equality incredible, is but a vain conceit of one's own wisdom, which almost all men think they have in a greater degree, than the vulgar; that is, than all men but themselves, and a few others, whom by fame, or for concurring with themselves, they approve. For such is the nature of men, that howsoever they may acknowledge many others to be more witty, or more eloquent, or more learned; yet they will hardly believe there be many so wise as themselves; for they see their own wit at hand, and other men's at a distance. But this proveth rather that men are in that point equal, than unequal. For there is not ordinarily a greater sign of the equal distribution of any thing, than that every man is contented with his share.

3. From this equality of ability, ariseth equality of hope in the attaining of our ends. And therefore if any two men desire the same thing, which nevertheless they cannot both enjoy, they become enemies; and in the way to their end, (which is principally their own conservation, and sometimes their delectation only,) endeavour to destroy, or subdue one another. And from hence it comes to pass, that where an invader hath no more to fear, than another man's single power; if one plant, sow, build, or possess a convenient seat, others may probably be expected to come prepared with forces united, to dispossess, and deprive him, not only of the fruit of his labour, but also of his life, or liberty. And the invader again is in the like danger of another. *From equality proceeds diffidence.*

4. And from this diffidence of one another, there is no way for any man to secure himself, so reasonable, as anticipation; that is, by force, or wiles, to master the persons of all men he can, so long, till he see no other power great enough to endanger him: and this is no more than his own conservation requireth, and is generally allowed. Also because there be some, that taking pleasure in contemplating their own power in the acts of conquest, which they pursue farther than their security requires; if others, that otherwise would be glad to be at ease within modest bounds, should not by invasion increase their power, they would not be able, long time, by standing only on their defence, to subsist. And by consequence, such augmentation of dominion over men, being necessary to a man's conservation, it ought to be allowed him. *From diffidence war.*

5. Again, men have no pleasure, (but on the contrary a great deal of grief) in keeping company, where there is no power able to over-awe them all. For every man looketh that his companion should value him, at the same rate he sets upon himself: and upon all signs of contempt, or undervaluing, naturally endeavours, as far as he dares (which amongst them that have no common power to keep them in quiet, is far enough to make them destroy each other,) to extort a greater value from his contemners, by damage; and from others, by the example.

6. So that in the nature of man, we find three principal causes of quarrel. First, competition; secondly, diffidence; thirdly, glory.

7. The first, maketh men invade for gain; the second, for safety; [62] and the third, for reputation. The first use violence, to make themselves masters of other men's persons, wives, children, and cattle; the second, to defend them; the third, for trifles, as a word, a smile,

a different opinion, and any other sign of undervalue, either direct in their persons, or by reflection in their kindred, their friends, their nation, their profession, or their name.

Out of civil states, there is always war of every one against every one.

8.* Hereby it is manifest, that during the time men live without a common power to keep them all in awe, they are in that condition which is called war; and such a war, as is of every man, against every man. For WAR, consisteth not in battle only, or the act of fighting; but in a tract of time, wherein the will to contend by battle is sufficiently known: and therefore the notion of *time*, is to be considered in the nature of war; as it is in the nature of weather. For as the nature of foul weather, lieth not in a shower or two of rain; but in an inclination thereto of many days together: so the nature of war, consisteth not in actual fighting; but in the known disposition thereto, during all the time there is no assurance to the contrary. All other time is PEACE.

The incommodities of such a war.

9. Whatsoever therefore is consequent to a time of war, where every man is enemy to every man; the same is consequent to the time, wherein men live without other security, than what their own strength, and their own invention shall furnish them withal. In such condition, there is no place for industry; because the fruit thereof is uncertain: and consequently no culture of the earth; no navigation, nor use of the commodities that may be imported by sea; no commodious building; no instruments of moving, and removing such things as require much force; no knowledge of the face of the earth; no account of time; no arts; no letters; no society; and which is worst of all, continual fear, and danger of violent death; and the life of man, solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short.

10. It may seem strange to some man, that has not well weighed these things; that nature should thus dissociate, and render men apt to invade, and destroy one another: and he may therefore, not trusting to this inference, made from the passions, desire perhaps to have the same confirmed by experience. Let him therefore consider* with himself, when taking a journey, he arms himself, and seeks to go well accompanied; when going to sleep, he locks his doors; when even in his house he locks his chests; and this when he knows there be laws, and public officers, armed, to revenge all injuries shall be done him; what opinion he has of his fellow-subjects, when he rides armed; of his fellow citizens, when he locks his doors; and of his children, and servants, when he locks his chests. Does he not there as much accuse mankind by his actions, as I do by

my words? But neither of us accuse man's nature in it. The desires, and other passions of man, are in themselves no sin. No more are the actions, that proceed from those passions, till they know a law that forbids them: which till laws be made they cannot know: nor can any law be made, till they have agreed upon the person that shall make it.

11. It may peradventure be thought, there was never such a time, [63] nor condition of war as this;* and I believe it was never generally so, over all the world: but there are many places, where they live so now. For the savage people in many places of America, except the government of small families, the concord whereof dependeth on natural lust, have no government at all; and live at this day in that brutish manner, as I said before. Howsoever, it may be perceived what manner of life there would be, where there were no common power to fear; by the manner of life, which men that have formerly lived under a peaceful government, use to degenerate into, in a civil war.

12. But though there had never been any time, wherein particular men were in a condition of war one against another; yet in all times, kings, and persons of sovereign authority, because of their independency, are in continual jealousies, and in the state and posture of gladiators; having their weapons pointing, and their eyes fixed on one another; that is, their forts, garrisons, and guns upon the frontiers of their kingdoms; and continual spies upon their neighbours; which is a posture of war. But because they uphold thereby, the industry of their subjects; there does not follow from it, that misery, which accompanies the liberty of particular men.

In such a war nothing is unjust.

13. To this war of every man against every man, this also is consequent; that nothing can be unjust. The notions of right and wrong, justice and injustice have there no place. Where there is no common power, there is no law: where no law, no injustice. Force, and fraud, are in war the two cardinal virtues. Justice, and injustice are none of the faculties neither of the body, nor mind. If they were, they might be in a man that were alone in the world, as well as his senses, and passions. They are qualities, that relate to men in society, not in solitude. It is consequent also to the same condition, that there be no propriety, no dominion, no *mine* and *thine* distinct; but only that to be every man's, that he can get; and for so long, as he can keep it. And thus much for the ill condition, which man by

mere nature is actually placed in; though with a possibility to come out of it, consisting partly in the passions, partly in his reason.

The passions that incline men to peace.

14. The passions that incline men to peace, are fear of death; desire of such things as are necessary to commodious living; and a hope by their industry to obtain them. And reason suggesteth convenient articles of peace, upon which men may be drawn to agreement. These articles, are they, which otherwise are called the Laws of Nature: whereof I shall speak more particularly, in the two following chapters.

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CHAPTER XIV

OF THE FIRST AND SECOND NATURAL LAWS, AND OF CONTRACTS

Right of nature what.

1. THE RIGHT OF NATURE, which writers commonly call *jus naturale*, is the liberty each man hath, to use his own power, as he will himself, for the preservation of his own nature; that is to say, of his own life; and consequently, of doing any thing, which in his own judgment, and reason, he shall conceive to be the aptest means thereunto.

Liberty what.

2. By LIBERTY, is understood, according to the proper signification of the word, the absence of external impediments: which impediments, may oft take away part of a man's power to do what he would; but cannot hinder him from using the power left him, according as his judgment, and reason shall dictate to him.

A law of nature what.

3. A LAW OF NATURE, (*lex naturalis*,) is a precept, or general rule, found out by reason, by which a man is forbidden to do, that, which is destructive of his life, or taketh away the means of preserving the same; and to omit, that, by which he thinketh it may be best preserved. For though they that speak of this subject, use to confound *jus*, and *lex*, *right* and *law*; yet they ought to be distinguished; because RIGHT, consisteth in liberty to do, or to forbear: whereas LAW, determineth, and bindeth to one of them: so that law, and right, differ as much, as obligation, and liberty; which in one and the same matter are inconsistent.

Difference of right and law.

Naturally every man has right to every thing.

4. And because the condition of man, (as hath been declared in the precedent chapter) is a condition of war of every one against every one; in which case every one is governed by his own reason;

and there is nothing he can make use of, that may not be a help unto him, in preserving his life against his enemies; it followeth, that in such a condition, every man has a right to every thing; even to one another's body. And therefore, as long as this natural right of every man to every thing endureth, there can be no security to any man, (how strong or wise soever he be,) of living out the time, which nature ordinarily alloweth men to live. And consequently it is a precept, or general rule of reason,* *that every man, ought to endeavour peace, as far as he has hope of obtaining it; and when he cannot obtain it, that he may seek, and use, all helps, and advantages of war.* The first branch of which rule, containeth the first, and fundamental law of nature; which is, *to seek peace, and follow it.* The second, the sum of the right of nature; which is, *by all means we can, to defend ourselves.*

The fundamental law of nature.

5. From this fundamental law of nature, by which men are commanded to endeavour peace, is derived this second law; *that a man be willing, when others are so too, as far-forth, as for peace, and defence of himself he shall think it necessary, to lay down this right to all things; and be contented with so much liberty against other men, as he would allow other men against himself.* For as long as every man holdeth this right, of doing any thing he liketh; so long are all men in the condition of war. But if other men will not lay down their right, as well as he; then there is no reason for any one, to divest himself of his: for that were to expose himself to prey, (which no man is bound to) rather than to dipose himself to peace. This is that law of the Gospel; *whatsoever you require that others should do to you, that do ye to them.* And that law of all men, *quod tibi fieri non vis, alteri ne feceris.**

The second law of nature.

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6. To *lay down* a man's *right* to any thing, is to *divest* himself of the *liberty*, of hindering another of the benefit of his own right to the same. For he that renounceth, or passeth away his right, giveth not to any other man a right which he had not before; because there is nothing to which every man had not right by nature: but only standeth out of his way, that he may enjoy his own original right, without hindrance from him; not without hindrance from another. So that the effect which redoundeth to one man, by another man's defect of right, is but so much diminution of impediments to the use of his own right original.

What it is to lay down a right.

7. Right is laid aside, either by simply renouncing it; or by transferring it to another. By *simply* RENOUNCING; when he cares not to

Renouncing a right what it is.

Transferring right what.

whom the benefit thereof redoundeth. By TRANSFERRING; when he intendeth the benefit thereof to some certain person, or persons. And when a man hath in either manner abandoned, or granted away his right; then he is said to be OBLIGED, or BOUND, not to hinder those, to whom such right is granted, or abandoned, from the benefit of it: and that he *ought*, and it is his DUTY, not to make void that voluntary act of his own: and that such hindrance is INJUSTICE, and INJURY, as being *sine jure*; the right being before renounced, or transferred. So that *injury*, or *injustice*, in the controversies of the world, is somewhat like to that, which in the disputations of scholars is called *absurdity*. For as it is there called an absurdity, to contradict what one maintained in the beginning: so in the world, it is called injustice, and injury, voluntarily to undo that, which from the beginning he had voluntarily done. The way by which a man either simply renounceth, or transferreth his right, is a declaration, or signification, by some voluntary and sufficient sign, or signs, that he doth so renounce, or transfer; or hath so renounced, or transferred the same, to him that accepteth it. And these signs are either words only, or actions only; or (as it happeneth most often) both words, and actions. And the same are the BONDS, by which men are bound, and obliged: bonds, that have their strength, not from their own nature, (for nothing is more easily broken than a man's word,) but from fear of some evil consequence upon the rupture.

Obligation

Duty.

Injustice.

8. Whensoever a man transferreth his right, or renounceth it; it is either in consideration of some right reciprocally transferred to himself; or for some other good he hopeth for thereby. For it is a voluntary act:* and of the voluntary acts of every man, the object is some *good to himself*. And therefore there be some rights, which no man can be understood by any words, or other signs, to have abandoned, or transferred. As first a man cannot lay down the right of resisting them, that assault him by force, to take away his life; because he cannot be understood to aim thereby, at any good to himself. The same may be said of wounds, and chains, and imprisonment; both because there is no benefit consequent to such patience; as there is to the patience of suffering another to be wounded, or imprisoned: as also because a man cannot tell, when he seeth men proceed against him by violence, whether they intend his death or not. And lastly the motive, and end for which this renouncing, and transferring of right is introduced, is nothing else but the security of a man's person, in his life, and in the means of so

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Not all rights are alienable.

preserving life, as not to be weary of it. And therefore if a man by words, or other signs, seem to despoil himself of the end, for which those signs were intended; he is not to be understood as if he meant it, or that it was his will; but that he was ignorant of how such words and actions were to be interpreted.

9. The mutual transferring of right, is that which men call CONTRACT. *Contract what.*

10. There is difference, between transferring of right to the thing; and transferring, or tradition, that is, delivery of the thing itself. For the thing may be delivered together with the translation of the right; as in buying and selling with ready-money; or exchange of goods, or lands: and it may be delivered some time after.

11. Again, one of the contractors, may deliver the thing contracted for on his part, and leave the other to perform his part at some determinate time after, and in the mean time be trusted; and then the contract on his part, is called PACT, or COVENANT: or both parts may contract now, to perform hereafter: in which cases, he that is to perform in time to come, being trusted, his performance is called *keeping of promise*, or faith; and the failing of performance (if it be voluntary) *violation of faith*. *Covenant what.*

12. When the transferring of right, is not mutual; but one of the parties transferreth, in hope to gain thereby friendship, or service from another, or from his friends; or in hope to gain the reputation of charity, or magnanimity; or to deliver his mind from the pain of compassion; or in hope of reward in heaven; this is not contract, but GIFT, FREE-GIFT, GRACE: which words signify one and the same thing. *Free-gift.*

13. Signs of contract, are either *express*, or *by inference*. Express, are words spoken with understanding of what they signify: and such words are either of the time *present*, or *past*; as, *I give*, *I grant*, *I have given*, *I have granted*, *I will that this be yours*: or of the future; as, *I will give*, *I will grant*: which words of the future are called PROMISE. *Signs of contract express.* *Promise.*

14. Signs by inference, are sometimes the consequence of words; sometimes the consequence of silence; sometimes the consequence of actions; sometimes the consequence of forbearing an action: and generally a sign by inference, of any contract, is whatsoever sufficiently argues the will of the contractor. [67] *Signs of contract by inference.*

15. Words alone, if they be of the time to come, and contain a bare promise, are an insufficient sign of a free-gift, and therefore not obligatory. For if they be of the time to come, as, *to-morrow I will* *Free gift passeth by words of the present or past.*

give, they are a sign I have not given yet, and consequently that my right is not transferred, but remaineth till I transfer it by some other act. But if the words be of the time present, or past, as, *I have given*, or *do give to be delivered to-morrow*, then is my morrow's right given away to-day; and that by the virtue of the words, though there were no other argument of my will. And there is a great difference in the signification of these words, *volo hoc tuum esse cras*, and *cras dabo*; that is, between *I will that this be thine to-morrow*, and, *I will give it thee to-morrow*: for the word *I will*, in the former manner of speech, signifies an act of the will present; but in the latter, it signifies a promise of an act of the will to come: and therefore the former words, being of the present, transfer a future right; the latter, that be of the future, transfer nothing. But if there be other signs of the will to transfer a right, besides words; then, though the gift be free, yet may the right be understood to pass by words of the future: as if a man propound a prize to him that comes first to the end of a race, the gift is free; and though the words be of the future, yet the right passeth: for if he would not have his words so be understood, he should not have let them run.

Signs of contract are words both of the past, present, and future.

16. In contracts, the right passeth, not only where the words are of the time present, or past; but also where they are of the future: because all contract is mutual translation, or change of right; and therefore he that promiseth only, because he hath already received the benefit for which he promiseth, is to be understood as if he intended the right should pass: for unless he had been content to have his words so understood, the other would not have performed his part first. And for that cause, in buying, and selling, and other acts of contract, a promise is equivalent to a covenant; and therefore obligatory.

Merit what.

17. He that performeth first in the case of a contract, is said to MERIT that which he is to receive by the performance of the other; and he hath it as *due*. Also when a prize is propounded to many, which is to be given to him only that winneth; or money is thrown amongst many, to be enjoyed by them that catch it; though this be a free gift; yet so to win, or so to catch, is to *merit*, and to have it as DUE. For the right is transferred in the propounding of the prize, and in throwing down the money; though it be not determined to whom, but by the event of the contention. But there is between these two sorts of merit, this difference, that in contract, I merit by virtue of my own power, and the contractor's need; but in this case of free

gift, I am enabled to merit only by the benignity of the giver: in contract, I merit at the contractor's hand that he should depart with his right; in this case of gift, I merit not that the giver should part [68] with his right; but that when he has parted with it, it should be mine, rather than another's. And this I think to be the meaning of that distinction of the Schools, between *meritum congrui*, and *meritum condigni*.* For God Almighty, having promised Paradise to those men (hoodwinked with carnal desires,) that can walk through this world according to the precepts, and limits prescribed by him; they say, he that shall so walk, shall merit Paradise *ex congruo*. But because no man can demand a right to it, by his own righteousness, or any other power in himself, but by the free grace of God only; they say, no man can merit Paradise *ex condigno*. This I say, I think is the meaning of that distinction; but because disputers do not agree upon the signification of their own terms of art, longer than it serves their turn; I will not affirm any thing of their meaning: only this I say; when a gift is given indefinitely, as a prize to be contended for, he that winneth meriteth, and may claim the prize as due.

Covenants of mutual trust, when invalid.

18. If a covenant be made, wherein neither of the parties perform presently, but trust one another; in the condition of mere nature, (which is a condition of war of every man against every man,) upon any reasonable suspicion, it is void: but if there be a common power set over them both, with right and force sufficient to compel performance, it is not void. For he that performeth first, has no assurance the other will perform after; because the bonds of words are too weak to bridle men's ambition, avarice, anger, and other passions, without the fear of some coercive power; which in the condition of mere nature, where all men are equal, and judges of the justness of their own fears, cannot possibly be supposed. And therefore he which performeth first, does but betray himself to his enemy; contrary to the right (he can never abandon) of defending his life, and means of living.

19. But in a civil estate, where there is a power set up to constrain those that would otherwise violate their faith, that fear is no more reasonable; and for that cause, he which by the covenant is to perform first, is obliged so to do.

20. The cause of fear, which maketh such a covenant invalid, must be always something arising after the covenant made; as some new fact, or other sign of the will not to perform: else it cannot make the covenant void. For that which could not hinder a man

from promising, ought not to be admitted as a hindrance of performing.

Right to the end, containeth right to the means.

21. He that transferreth any right, transferreth the means of enjoying it, as far as lieth in his power. As he that selleth land, is understood to transfer the herbage, and whatsoever grows upon it; nor can he that sells a mill turn away the stream that drives it. And they that give to a man the right of government in sovereignty, are understood to give him the right of levying money to maintain soldiers; and of appointing magistrates for the administration of justice.

No covenant with beasts.

22. To make covenants with brute beasts, is impossible; because not understanding our speech, they understand not, nor accept of [69] any translation of right; nor can translate any right to another: and without mutual acceptation, there is no covenant.

Nor with God without special revelation.

23. To make covenant with God,* is impossible, but by mediation of such as God speaketh to, either by revelation supernatural, or by his lieutenants that govern under him, and in his name: for otherwise we know not whether our covenants be accepted, or not. And therefore they that vow anything contrary to any law of nature, vow in vain; as being a thing unjust to pay such vow. And if it be a thing commanded by the law of nature, it is not the vow, but the law that binds them.

No covenant, but of possible and future.

24. The matter, or subject of a covenant, is always something that falleth under deliberation; (for to covenant, is an act of the will; that is to say an act, and the last act, of deliberation;) and is therefore always understood to be something to come; and which is judged possible for him that covenanteth, to perform.

25. And therefore, to promise that which is known to be impossible, is no covenant. But if that prove impossible afterwards, which before was thought possible, the covenant is valid, and bindeth, (though not to the thing itself,) yet to the value; or, if that also be impossible, to the unfeigned endeavour of performing as much as is possible: for to more no man can be obliged.

Covenants how made void.

26. Men are freed of their covenants two ways; by performing; or by being forgiven. For performance, is the natural end of obligation; and forgiveness, the restitution of liberty; as being a retransferring of that right, in which the obligation consisted.

Covenants extorted by fear are valid.

27. Covenants entered into by fear, in the condition of mere nature, are obligatory. For example, if I covenant to pay a ransom, or service for my life, to an enemy; I am bound by it. For it is a

contract, wherein one receiveth the benefit of life; the other is to receive money, or service for it; and consequently, where no other law (as in the condition, of mere nature) forbiddeth the performance, the covenant is valid. Therefore prisoners of war, if trusted with the payment of their ransom, are obliged to pay it: and if a weaker prince, make a disadvantageous peace with a stronger, for fear; he is bound to keep it; unless (as hath been said before) there ariseth some new, and just cause of fear, to renew the war. And even in commonwealths, if I be forced to redeem myself from a thief by promising him money, I am bound to pay it, till the civil law discharge me. For whatsoever I may lawfully do without obligation, the same I may lawfully covenant to do through fear: and what I lawfully covenant, I cannot lawfully break.

The former covenant to one, makes void the later to another.

28. A former covenant, makes void a later. For a man that hath passed away his right to one man to-day, hath it not to pass to-morrow to another: and therefore the later promise passeth no right, but is null.

A man's covenant not to defend himself, is void.

29.* A covenant not to defend myself from force, by force, is always void. For (as I have showed before) no man can transfer, or lay down his right to save himself from death, wounds, and imprisonment, (the avoiding whereof is the only end of laying down any right;) and therefore the promise of not resisting force, in no covenant transferreth any right; nor is obliging. For though a man may covenant thus, *unless I do so, or so, kill me*; he cannot covenant thus, *unless I do so, or so, I will not resist you, when you come to kill me.* For man by nature chooseth the lesser evil, which is danger of death in resisting; rather than the greater, which is certain and present death in not resisting. And this is granted to be true by all men, in that they lead criminals to execution, and prison, with armed men, notwithstanding that such criminals have consented to the law, by which they are condemned. {70}

No man obliged to accuse himself.

30. A covenant to accuse oneself, without assurance of pardon, is likewise invalid. For in the condition of nature, where every man is judge, there is no place for accusation: and in the civil state, the accusation is followed with punishment; which being force, a man is not obliged not to resist. The same is also true, of the accusation of those, by whose condemnation a man falls into misery; as of a father, wife, or benefactor. For the testimony of such an accuser, if it be not willingly given, is presumed to be corrupted by nature: and therefore not to be received: and where a man's testimony is not to

be credited, he is not bound to give it. Also accusations upon torture, are not to be reputed as testimonies. For torture is to be used but as means of conjecture, and light, in the further examination, and search of truth: and what is in that case confessed, tendeth to the ease of him that is tortured; not to the informing of the torturers: and therefore ought not to have the credit of a sufficient testimony: for whether he deliver himself by true, or false accusation, he does it by the right of preserving his own life.

The end of an oath.

31. The force of words, being (as I have formerly noted) too weak to hold men to the performance of their covenants; there are in man's nature, but two imaginable helps to strengthen it. And those are either a fear of the consequence of breaking their word; or a glory, or pride in appearing not to need to break it. This latter is a generosity too rarely found to be presumed on, especially in the pursuers of wealth, command, or sensual pleasure; which are the greatest part of mankind. The passion to be reckoned upon, is fear; whereof there be two very general objects: one, the power of spirits invisible; the other, the power of those men they shall therein offend. Of these two, though the former be the greater power, yet the fear of the latter is commonly the greater fear. The fear of the former is in every man, his own religion: which hath place in the nature of man before civil society. The latter hath not so; at least not place enough, to keep men to their promises; because in the condition of mere nature, the inequality of power is not discerned, but by the event of battle. So that before the time of civil society, or in the interruption thereof by war, there is nothing can strengthen a covenant of peace agreed on, against the temptations of avarice, ambition, lust, or other strong desire, but the fear of that invisible power, which they every one worship as God; and fear as a revenger of their perfidy. All therefore that can be done between two men not [71] subject to civil power, is to put one another to swear by the God he feareth: which *swearing*, or OATH, is a *form of speech, added to a promise; by which he that promiseth, signifieth, that unless he perform, he renounceth the mercy of his God, or calleth to him for vengeance on himself.* Such was the heathen form, *Let* Jupiter *kill me else, as I kill this beast.* So is our form, *I shall do thus, and thus, so help me God.* And this, with the rites and ceremonies, which every one useth in his own religion, that the fear of breaking faith might be the greater.

The form of an oath.

32. By this it appears, that an oath taken according to any other form, or rite, than his, that sweareth, is in vain; and no oath: and that

there is no swearing by any thing which the swearer thinks not God. For though men have sometimes used to swear by their kings, for fear, or flattery; yet they would have it thereby understood, they attributed to them divine honour. And that swearing unnecessarily by God, is but profaning of his name: and swearing by other things, as men do in common discourse, is not swearing, but an impious custom, gotten by too much vehemence of talking.

No oath but by God.

33. It appears also, that the oath adds nothing to the obligation. For a covenant, if lawful, binds in the sight of God, without the oath, as much as with it: if unlawful, bindeth not at all; though it be confirmed with an oath.

An oath adds nothing to the obligation.

CHAPTER XV

OF OTHER LAWS OF NATURE

1. FROM that law of nature, by which we are obliged to transfer to another, such rights, as being retained, hinder the peace of mankind, there followeth a third; which is this, *that men perform their covenants made*: without which, covenants are in vain, and but empty words; and the right of all men to all things remaining, we are still in the condition of war.

The third law of nature, justice.

2. And in this law of nature, consisteth the fountain and original of JUSTICE. For where no covenant hath preceded, there hath no right been transferred, and every man has right to every thing; and consequently, no action can be unjust. But when a covenant is made, then to break it is *unjust*: and the definition of INJUSTICE, is no other than *the not performance of covenant*. And whatsoever is not unjust, is *just*.

Justice and injustice what.

3. But because covenants of mutual trust, where there is a fear of not performance on either part, (as hath been said in the former chapter,) are invalid; though the original of justice be the making of covenants; yet injustice actually there can be none, till the cause of such fear be taken away; which while men are in the natural condition of war, cannot be done. Therefore before the names of just, and unjust can have place, there must be some coercive power, to compel men equally to the performance of their covenants, by the terror of some punishment, greater than the benefit they expect by

Justice and propriety begin with the constitution of commonwealth.

[72] the breach of their covenant; and to make good that propriety, which by mutual contract men acquire, in recompense of the universal right they abandon: and such power there is none before the erection of a commonwealth. And this is also to be gathered out of the ordinary definition of justice in the Schools: for they say, that *justice is the constant will of giving to every man his own.** And therefore where there is no *own*, that is, no propriety, there is no injustice; and where there is no coercive power erected, that is, where there is no commonwealth, there is no propriety; all men having right to all things: therefore where there is no commonwealth, there nothing is unjust. So that the nature of justice, consisteth in keeping of valid covenants: but the validity of covenants begins not but with the constitution of a civil power, sufficient to compel men to keep them: and then it is also that propriety begins.

Justice not contrary to reason.

4. The fool hath said in his heart, there is no such thing as justice;* and sometimes also with his tongue; seriously alleging, that every man's conservation, and contentment, being committed to his own care, there could be no reason, why every man might not do what he thought conduced thereunto: and therefore also to make, or not make; keep, or not keep covenants, was not against reason, when it conduced to one's benefit. He does not therein deny, that there be covenants; and that they are sometimes broken, sometimes kept; and that such breach of them may be called injustice, and the observance of them justice: but he questioneth, whether injustice, taking away the fear of God, (for the same fool hath said in his heart there is no God,) may not sometimes stand with that reason, which dictateth to every man his own good; and particularly then, when it conduceth to such a benefit, as shall put a man in a condition, to neglect not only the dispraise, and revilings, but also the power of other men. The kingdom of God is gotten by violence:* but what if it could be gotten by unjust violence? were it against reason so to get it, when it is impossible to receive hurt by it? and if it be not against reason, it is not against justice: or else justice is not to be approved for good. From such reasoning as this, successful wickedness hath obtained the name of virtue: and some that in all other things have disallowed the violation of faith; yet have allowed it, when it is for the getting of a kingdom. And the heathen that believed, that Saturn was deposed by his son Jupiter, believed nevertheless the same Jupiter to be the avenger of injustice: somewhat like to a piece of law in Coke's* *Commentaries on Littleton*; where he says, if the right heir of

the crown be attainted of treason; yet the crown shall descend to him, and *eo instante* the attainder be void: from which instances a man will be very prone to infer; that when the heir apparent of a kingdom, shall kill him that is in possession, though his father; you may call it injustice, or by what other name you will; yet it can never be against reason, seeing all the voluntary actions of men tend to the benefit of themselves; and those actions are most reasonable, that conduce most to their ends. This specious reasoning is nevertheless false. [73]

5. For the question is not of promises mutual, where there is no security of performance on either side; as when there is no civil power erected over the parties promising; for such promises are no covenants: but either where one of the parties has performed already; or where there is a power to make him perform; there is the question whether it be against reason, that is, against the benefit of the other to perform, or not. And I say it is not against reason. For the manifestation whereof, we are to consider; first, that when a man doth a thing, which notwithstanding any thing can be foreseen, and reckoned on, tendeth to his own destruction, howsoever some accident which he could not expect, arriving may turn it to his benefit; yet such events do not make it reasonably or wisely done. Secondly, that in a condition of war, wherein every man to every man, for want of a common power to keep them all in awe, is an enemy, there is no man can hope by his own strength, or wit, to defend himself from destruction, without the help of confederates; where every one expects the same defence by the confederation, that any one else does: and therefore he which declares he thinks it reason to deceive those that help him, can in reason expect no other means of safety, than what can be had from his own single power. He therefore that breaketh his covenant, and consequently declareth that he thinks he may with reason do so, cannot be received into any society, that unite themselves for peace and defence, but by the error of them that receive him; nor when he is received, be retained in it, without seeing the danger of their error; which errors a man cannot reasonably reckon upon as the means of his security: and therefore if he be left, or cast out of society, he perisheth; and if he live in society, it is by the errors of other men, which he could not foresee, nor reckon upon; and consequently against the reason of his preservation; and so, as all men that contribute not to his destruction, forbear him only out of ignorance of what is good for themselves.

6.* As for the instance of gaining the secure and perpetual felicity of heaven, by any way; it is frivolous: there being but one way imaginable; and that is not breaking, but keeping of covenant.

7. And for the other instance of attaining sovereignty by rebellion; it is manifest, that though the event follow, yet because it cannot reasonably be expected, but rather the contrary; and because by gaining it so, others are taught to gain the same in like manner, the attempt thereof is against reason. Justice therefore, that is to say, keeping of covenant, is a rule of reason, by which we are forbidden to do any thing destructive to our life; and consequently a law of nature.

8. There be some that proceed further; and will not have the law of nature, to be those rules which conduce to the preservation of man's life on earth; but to the attaining of an eternal felicity after death; to which they think the breach of covenant may conduce; and consequently be just and reasonable; (such are they that think it a [74] work of merit to kill, or depose, or rebel against, the sovereign power constituted over them by their own consent.) But because there is no natural knowledge of man's estate after death; much less of the reward that is then to be given to breach of faith; but only a belief grounded upon other men's saying that they know it supernaturally, or that they know those, that knew them, that knew others, that knew it supernaturally; breach of faith cannot be called a precept of reason, or nature.

Covenants not discharged by the vice of the person to whom they are made.

9. Others, that allow for a law of nature, the keeping of faith, do nevertheless make exception of certain persons; as heretics, and such as use not to perform their covenant to others: and this also is against reason. For if any fault of a man, be sufficient to discharge our covenant made; the same ought in reason to have been sufficient to have hindered the making of it.

Justice of men and justice of actions what.

10. The names of just, and unjust, when they are attributed to men, signify one thing; and when they are attributed to actions, another. When they are attributed to men, they signify conformity, or inconformity of manners, to reason. But when they are attributed to actions, they signify the conformity, or inconformity to reason, not of manners, or manner of life, but of particular actions. A just man therefore, is he that taketh all the care he can, that his actions may be all just: and an unjust man, is he that neglecteth it. And such men are more often in our language styled by the names of righteous, and unrighteous; than just, and unjust; though the

meaning be the same. Therefore a righteous man, does not lose that title, by one, or a few unjust actions, that proceed from sudden passion, or mistake of things, or persons: nor does an unrighteous man, lose his character, for such actions, as he does, or forbears to do, for fear: because his will is not framed by the justice, but by the apparent benefit of what he is to do. That which gives to human actions the relish of justice, is a certain nobleness or gallantness of courage, (rarely found,) by which a man scorns to be beholding for the contentment of his life, to fraud, or breach of promise. This justice of the manners,* is that which is meant, where justice is called a virtue; and injustice a vice.

11. But the justice of actions denominates men, not just, but *guiltless*: and the injustice of the same, (which is also called injury,) gives them but the name of *guilty*.

Justice of manners, and justice of actions.

12. Again, the injustice of manners, is the disposition, or aptitude to do injury; and is injustice before it proceed to act; and without supposing any individual person injured. But the injustice of an action, (that is to say injury,) supposeth an individual person injured; namely him, to whom the covenant was made: and therefore many times the injury is received by one man, when the damage redoundeth to another. As when the master commandeth his servant to give money to a stranger; if it be not done, the injury is done to the master, whom he had before covenanted to obey; but the damage redoundeth to the stranger, to whom he had no obligation; and therefore could not injure him. And so also in commonwealths, private men may remit to one another their debts; but not robberies [75] or other violences, whereby they are endamaged; because the detaining of debt, is an injury to themselves; but robbery and violence, are injuries to the person of the commonwealth.

Nothing done to a man by his own consent can be injury.

13. Whatsoever is done to a man, conformable to his own will signified to the doer, is no injury to him. For if he that doeth it, hath not passed away his original right to do what he please, by some antecedent covenant, there is no breach of covenant; and therefore no injury done him. And if he have; then his will to have it done being signified, is a release of that covenant: and so again there is no injury done him.

Justice commutative and distributive.

14. Justice of actions, is by writers* divided into *commutative*, and *distributive*: and the former they say consisteth in proportion arithmetical; the latter in proportion geometrical. Commutative therefore, they place in the equality of value of the things contracted

for; and distributive, in the distribution of equal benefit, to men of equal merit. As if it were injustice to sell dearer than we buy; or to give more to a man than he merits. The value of all things contracted for, is measured by the appetite of the contractors: and therefore the just value, is that which they be contented to give. And merit (besides that which is by covenant, where the performance on one part, meriteth the performance of the other part, and falls under justice commutative, not distributive,) is not due by justice; but is rewarded of grace only. And therefore this distinction, in the sense wherein it useth to be expounded, is not right. To speak properly, commutative justice, is the justice of a contractor; that is, a performance of covenant, in buying, and selling; hiring, and letting to hire; lending, and borrowing; exchanging, bartering, and other acts of contract.

15. And distributive justice, the justice of an arbitrator; that is to say, the act of defining what is just. Wherein, (being trusted by them that make him arbitrator,) if he perform his trust, he is said to distribute to every man his own: and this is indeed just distribution, and may be called (though improperly) distributive justice; but more properly equity; which also is a law of nature, as shall be shown in due place.

The fourth law of nature, gratitude.

16. As justice dependeth on antecedent covenant; so does GRATITUDE depend on antecedent grace; that is to say, antecedent free gift: and is the fourth law of nature; which may be conceived in this form, *that a man which receiveth benefit from another of mere grace, endeavour that he which giveth it, have no reasonable cause to repent him of his good will.* For no man giveth, but with intention of good to himself; because gift is voluntary; and of all voluntary acts, the object is to every man his own good; of which if men see they shall be frustrated, there will be no beginning of benevolence, or trust; nor consequently of mutual help; nor of reconciliation of one man to another; and therefore they are to remain still in the condition of *war*; which is contrary to the first and fundamental law of nature, which commandeth men to *seek peace*. The breach of this law, is [76] called *ingratitude*; and hath the same relation to grace, that injustice hath to obligation by covenant.

The fifth, mutual accommodation, or complaisance.

17. A fifth law of nature, is COMPLAISANCE; that is to say, *that every man strive to accommodate himself to the rest.* For the understanding whereof, we may consider, that there is in men's aptness to society, a diversity of nature, rising from their diversity of affec-

tions; not unlike to that we see in stones brought together for building of an edifice. For as that stone which by the asperity, and irregularity of figure, takes more room from others, than itself fills; and for the hardness, cannot be easily made plain, and thereby hindereth the building, is by the builders cast away as unprofitable, and troublesome: so also, a man that by asperity of nature, will strive to retain those things which to himself are superfluous, and to others necessary; and for the stubbornness of his passions, cannot be corrected, is to be left, or cast out of society, as cumbersome thereunto. For seeing every man, not only by right, but also by necessity of nature, is supposed to endeavour all he can, to obtain that which is necessary for his conservation; he that shall oppose himself against it, for things superfluous, is guilty of the war that thereupon is to follow; and therefore doth that, which is contrary to the fundamental law of nature, which commandeth *to seek peace*. The observers of this law, may be called SOCIABLE, (the Latins call them *commodi*;) the contrary, *stubborn, insociable, froward* [perverse], *intractable*.

The sixth, facility to pardon.

18. A sixth law of nature, is this, *that upon caution of the future time, a man ought to pardon the offences past of them that repenting, desire it*. For PARDON, is nothing but granting of peace; which though granted to them that persevere in their hostility, be not peace, but fear; yet not granted to them that give caution of the future time, is sign of an aversion to peace; and therefore contrary to the law of nature.

The seventh, that in revenges, men respect only the future good.

19. A seventh is, *that in revenges*, (that is, retribution of evil for evil,) *men look not at the greatness of the evil past, but the greatness of the good to follow*. Whereby we are forbidden to inflict punishment with any other design, than for correction of the offender, or direction of others. For this law is consequent to the next before it, that commandeth pardon, upon security of the future time. Besides, revenge without respect to the example, and profit to come, is a triumph, or glorying in the hurt of another, tending to no end; (for the end is always somewhat to come;) and glorying to no end, is vain-glory, and contrary to reason; and to hurt without reason, tendeth to the introduction of war; which is against the law of nature; and is commonly styled by the name of *cruelty*.

The eighth, against contumely.

20. And because all signs of hatred, or contempt, provoke to fight; insomuch as most men choose rather to hazard their life, than not to be revenged; we may in the eighth place, for a law of nature,

set down this precept, *that no man by deed, word, countenance, or gesture, declare hatred, or contempt of another.* The breach of which law, is commonly called *contumely.*

The ninth, against pride.

21. The question who is the better man, has no place in the condition of mere nature; where, (as has been shewn before,) all men [77] are equal. The inequality that now is, has been introduced by the laws civil. I know that Aristotle in the first book of his *Politics*, for a foundation of his doctrine, maketh men by nature, some more worthy to command, meaning the wiser sort (such as he thought himself to be for his philosophy;) others to serve, (meaning those that had strong bodies, but were not philosophers as he;) as if master and servant were not introduced by consent of men, but by difference of wit: which is not only against reason; but also against experience. For there are very few so foolish, that had not rather govern themselves, than be governed by others: nor when the wise in their own conceit, contend by force, with them who distrust their own wisdom, do they always, or often, or almost at any time, get the victory. If nature therefore have made men equal, that equality is to be acknowledged: or if nature have made men unequal; yet because men that think themselves equal, will not enter into conditions of peace, but upon equal terms, such equality must be admitted. And therefore for the ninth law of nature, I put this, *that every man acknowledge another for his equal by nature.* The breach of this precept is *pride.*

The tenth, against arrogance.

22. On this law, dependeth another, *that at the entrance into conditions of peace, no man require to reserve to himself any right, which he is not content should be reserved to every one of the rest.* As it is necessary for all men that seek peace, to lay down certain rights of nature; that is to say, not to have liberty to do all they list: so is it necessary for man's life, to retain some; as right to govern their own bodies; enjoy air, water, motion, ways to go from place to place; and all things else, without which a man cannot live, or not live well. If in this case, at the making of peace, men require for themselves, that which they would not have to be granted to others, they do contrary to the precedent law, that commandeth the acknowledgment of natural equality, and therefore also against the law of nature. The observers of this law, are those we call *modest*, and the breakers *arrogant* men. The Greeks call the violation of this law *πλεονεξία*; that is, a desire of more than their share.

23. Also if *a man be trusted to judge between man and man*, it is a precept of the law of nature, *that he deal equally between them*. For without that, the controversies of men cannot be determined but by war. He therefore that is partial in judgment, doth what in him lies, to deter men from the use of judges, and arbitrators; and consequently, (against the fundamental law of nature) is the cause of war. *The eleventh, equity.*

24. The observance of this law, from the equal distribution to each man, of that which in reason belongeth to him, is called EQUITY, and (as I have said before) distributive justice: the violation, *acception* [favouritism] *of persons*, *προσωπολημψία*.

25. And from this followeth another law, *that such things as cannot be divided, be enjoyed in common, if it can be; and if the quantity of the thing permit, without stint; otherwise proportionably to the number of them that have right*. For otherwise the distribution is unequal, and contrary to equity. *The twelfth, equal use of things common.*

26. But some things there be, that can neither be divided, nor [78] enjoyed in common. Then, the law of nature, which prescribeth equity, requireth, *that the entire right; or else, (making the use alternate,) the first possession, be determined by lot*. For equal distribution, is of the law of nature; and other means of equal distribution cannot be imagined. *The thirteenth, of lot.*

27. Of *lots* there be two sorts, *arbitrary*, and *natural*. Arbitrary, is that which is agreed on by the competitors: natural, is either *primogeniture*, (which the Greek calls *κληρονομία*, which signifies, *given by lot*;) or *first seizure*. *The fourteenth, of primogeniture, and first seizing.*

28. And therefore those things which cannot be enjoyed in common, nor divided, ought to be adjudged to the first possessor; and in some cases to the first born, as acquired by lot.*

29. It is also a law of nature, *that all men that mediate peace, be allowed safe conduct*. For the law that commandeth peace, as the *end*, commandeth intercession, as the *means*; and to intercession the means is safe conduct. *The fifteenth, of mediators.*

30. And because, though men be never so willing to observe these laws, there may nevertheless arise questions concerning a man's action; first, whether it were done, or not done; secondly (if done) whether against the law, or not against the law; the former whereof, is called a question *of fact*; the latter a question *of right*, therefore unless the parties to the question, covenant mutually to stand to the sentence of another, they are as far from peace as ever. *The sixteenth, of submission to arbitrement.*

This other, to whose sentence they submit is called an ARBITRATOR. And therefore it is of the law of nature, *that they that are at controversy, submit their right to the judgment of an arbitrator.*

The seventeenth, no man is his own judge.

31. And seeing every man is presumed to do all things in order to his own benefit, no man is a fit arbitrator in his own cause: and if he were never so fit; yet equity allowing to each party equal benefit, if one be admitted to be judge, the other is to be admitted also; and so the controversy, that is, the cause of war, remains, against the law of nature.

The eighteenth, no man to be judge, that has in him a natural cause of partiality.

32. For the same reason no man in any cause ought to be received for arbitrator, to whom greater profit, or honour, or pleasure apparently ariseth out of the victory of one party, than of the other: for he hath taken (though an unavoidable bribe, yet) a bribe; and no man can be obliged to trust him. And thus also the controversy, and the condition of war remaineth, contrary to the law of nature.

The nineteenth, of witnesses.

33. And in a controversy of *fact*, the judge being to give no more credit to one, than to the other, (if there be no other arguments) must give credit to a third; or to a third and fourth; or more: for else the question is undecided, and left to force, contrary to the law of nature.

34. These are the laws of nature, dictating peace, for a means of the conservation of men in multitudes; and which only concern the doctrine of civil society. There be other things tending to the destruction of particular men; as drunkenness, and all other parts of intemperance; which may therefore also be reckoned amongst those things which the law of nature hath forbidden; but are not necessary [79] to be mentioned, nor are pertinent enough to this place.

A rule, by which the laws of nature may easily be examined.

35. And though this may seem too subtle a deduction of the laws of nature, to be taken notice of by all men; whereof the most part are too busy in getting food, and the rest too negligent to understand; yet to leave all men inexcusable, they have been contracted into one easy sum, intelligible even to the meanest capacity; and that is, *Do not that to another, which thou wouldest not have done to thyself*; which sheweth him, that he has no more to do in learning the laws of nature, but, when weighing the actions of other men with his own, they seem too heavy, to put them into the other part of the balance, and his own into their place, that his own passions, and self-love, may add nothing to the weight; and then there is none of these laws of nature that will not appear unto him very reasonable.

36. The laws of nature oblige *in foro interno*;* that is to say, they bind to a desire they should take place: but *in foro externo*; that is, to the putting them in act, not always. For he that should be modest, and tractable, and perform all he promises, in such time, and place, where no man else should do so, should but make himself a prey to others, and procure his own certain ruin, contrary to the ground of all laws of nature, which tend to nature's preservation. And again, he that having sufficient security, that others shall observe the same laws towards him, observes them not himself, seeketh not peace, but war; and consequently the destruction of his nature by violence.

The laws of nature oblige in conscience always, but in effect then only when there is security.

37. And whatsoever laws bind *in foro interno*, may be broken, not only by a fact contrary to the law, but also by a fact according to it, in case a man think it contrary. For though his action in this case, be according to the law; yet his purpose was against the law; which where the obligation is *in foro interno*, is a breach.

38. The laws of nature are immutable and eternal; for injustice, ingratitude, arrogance, pride, iniquity, acception of persons, and the rest, can never be made lawful. For it can never be that war shall preserve life, and peace destroy it.

The laws of nature are eternal;

39. The same laws, because they oblige only to a desire, and endeavour, I mean an unfeigned and constant endeavour, are easy to be observed. For in that they require nothing but endeavour; he that endeavoureth their performance, fulfilleth them; and he that fulfilleth the law, is just.

And yet easy.

40. And the science of them, is the true and only moral philosophy. For moral philosophy is nothing else but the science of what is *good*, and *evil*, in the conversation, and society of mankind. *Good*, and *evil*, are names that signify our appetites, and aversions; which in different tempers, customs, and doctrines of men, are different: and divers men, differ not only in their judgment, on the senses of what is pleasant, and unpleasant to the taste, smell, hearing, touch, and sight; but also of what is conformable, or disagreeable to reason, in the actions of common life. Nay, the same man, in divers times, differs from himself; and one time praiseth, that is, calleth good, what another time he dispraiseth, and calleth evil: from whence arise [80] disputes, controversies, and at last war. And therefore so long as a man is in the condition of mere nature, (which is a condition of war,) as private appetite is the measure of good, and evil: and consequently all men agree on this, that peace is good, and therefore also

The science of these laws, is the true moral philosophy.

the way, or means of peace, which (as I have shewed before) are *justice*, *gratitude*, *modesty*, *equity*, *mercy*, and the rest of the laws of nature, are good; that is to say; *moral virtues*; and their contrary *vices*, evil. Now the science of virtue and vice, is moral philosophy; and therefore the true doctrine of the laws of nature, is the true moral philosophy. But the writers of moral philosophy, though they acknowledge the same virtues and vices; yet not seeing wherein consisted their goodness; nor that they come to be praised, as the means of peaceable, sociable, and comfortable living; place them in a mediocrity of passions: as if not the cause, but the degree of daring, made fortitude; or not the cause, but the quantity of a gift, made liberality.

41. These dictates of reason, men used to call by the name of laws; but improperly: for they are but conclusions, or theorems concerning what conduceth to the conservation and defence of themselves; whereas law, properly is the word of him, that by right hath command over others. But yet if we consider the same theorems, as delivered in the word of God, that by right commandeth all things; then are they properly called laws.

CHAPTER XVI

OF PERSONS, AUTHORS, AND THINGS PERSONATED*

A person what.

1. A PERSON, is he, *whose words or actions are considered, either as his own, or as representing the words or actions of another man, or of any other thing to whom they are attributed, whether truly or by fiction.*

Person natural, and artificial.

2. When they are considered as his own, then is he called a *natural person*: and when they are considered as representing the words and actions of another, then is he a *feigned* or *artificial person*.

The word person, whence.

3. The word person is Latin: instead whereof the Greeks have *πρόσωπον*, which signifies the *face*, as *persona* in Latin signifies the *disguise*, or *outward appearance* of a man, counterfeited on the stage; and sometimes more particularly that part of it, which disguiseth the face, as a mask or vizard [visor]: and from the stage, hath been translated to any representer of speech and action, as well in tribunals, as theatres. So that a *person*, is the same that an *actor* is, both on the stage and in common conversation; and to *personate*, is to *act*,

Discourse on Metaphysics

G. W. Leibniz

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[Brackets] enclose editorial explanations. Small ·dots· enclose material that has been added, but can be read as though it were part of the original text. Occasional •bullets, and also indenting of passages that are not quotations, are meant as aids to grasping the structure of a sentence or a thought.—-The division into sections is Leibniz's; the division of some sections into paragraphs is not. Leibniz wrote brief summaries of the 37 sections of this work, but did not include them in the work itself. Some editors preface each section with its summary, but that interrupts the flow. In this version the summaries are given at the end.

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Sections 1–13

1. The most widely accepted and sharpest notion of God that we have can be expressed like this:

> God is an absolutely perfect being;

but though this is widely accepted, its consequences haven't been well enough thought out. As a start on exploring them, let us note that there are various completely different ways of being perfect, and that God has them all, each in the highest degree. We also need to understand what a perfection is. Here is one pretty good indicator: a property is not a perfection unless there is a highest degree of it; so number and shape are not perfections, because there cannot possibly be a largest number or a largest thing of a given shape—·that is, a largest triangle, or square, or the like·. But there is nothing impossible about the greatest knowledge or about omnipotence [here = 'greatest possible power']. So power and knowledge are perfections, and God has them in unlimited form. It follows that the actions of God, who is supremely—indeed infinitely—wise, are completely perfect. This is not just metaphysical perfection, but also the moral kind. His moral perfection, so far as it concerns us, amounts to this: the more we come to know and understand God's works, the more inclined we shall be to find them excellent, and to give us everything we could have wished.

2. Some people—·including Descartes·—hold that there are no rules of goodness and perfection in the nature of things, or in God's ideas of them, and that in calling the things God made 'good' all we mean is that God made them. I am far from agreeing with this. If it were right, then God would not have needed after the creation to 'see that they were good', as Holy Scripture says he did, because he already knew that the things in question were his work. In saying this—·'And God saw everything that he had made·, and, behold, it was very good' (*Genesis* 1:31)—Scripture treats God as like a man; but its purpose in doing this appears to be to get across the point that a thing's excellence can be seen by looking just at the thing itself, without reference to the entirely external fact about what caused it. Reinforcing that point is this one: the works must bear the imprint of the workman, because we can learn who he was just by inspecting them. I have to say that the contrary opinion strikes me as very dangerous, and as coming close to the view of the Spinozists that the beauty of the universe, and the goodness we attribute to God's works, are merely the illusions of people who conceive God as being like themselves. Furthermore, if you say ·as Descartes did· that things are good not because •they match up to objective standards of goodness, but only because •God chose them, you will unthinkingly destroy all God's love and all his glory. For why praise him for what he has done, if he would be equally praiseworthy for doing just the opposite? Where will his justice and wisdom be,

> if there is only a kind of despotic power, if *reason*'s place is taken by *will*, and if justice is tyrannically defined as what best pleases the most powerful?

[Leibniz here relies on his view that it is through reason that we learn what things are good.] And another point: it seems that any act of the will presupposes some reason for it—a reason that naturally precedes the act—·so that God's choices must come from his reasons for them, which involve his knowledge of what would· be good; so they can't be the *sources* of the goodness of things. That is why I find it weird when Descartes says that the eternal truths of metaphysics and geometry, and therefore also the rules of goodness, justice,

and perfection, are brought about by God's will. Against this, they seem to me to be results of his •understanding, and no more to depend on his •will than his intrinsic nature does.

3. Nor could I ever accept the view of some recent philosophers who have the nerve to maintain that God's creation is not utterly perfect, and that he could have acted much better. This opinion, it seems to me, has consequences that are completely contrary to the glory of God. Just as a lesser evil contains an element of good, so a lesser good contains an element of evil. To act with fewer perfections than one could have done is to act imperfectly; showing an architect that he could have done his work better is finding fault with it. Furthermore, this opinion goes against holy scripture's assurance of the goodness of God's works. ·That goodness can't consist simply in the fact that the works could have been worse; and here is why·. Whatever God's work was like, it would always have been good in comparison with *some* possibilities, because there is no limit to how bad things could be. But being praiseworthy in *this* way is hardly being praiseworthy at all! I believe one could find countless passages in the holy scriptures and the writings of the holy fathers that support my opinion, and hardly any to support the modern view to which I have referred—a view that I think was never heard of in ancient times. It has arisen merely because we are not well enough acquainted with the general harmony of the universe and of the hidden reasons for God's conduct; and that makes us recklessly judge that many things could have been improved. Furthermore, these moderns argue—subtly but not soundly—from the false premise that however perfect a thing is, there is always something still more perfect. They also think that their view provides for God's freedom, ·through the idea that if God is free, it must be up to him whether he acts perfectly or not·; but really it is the highest freedom to act perfectly, in accordance with sovereign reason. For the view that God sometimes does something without having any reason for his choice, besides seeming to be impossible, is hardly compatible with his glory. Suppose that God, facing a choice between A and B, opts for A without having any reason for preferring it to B. I see nothing to praise in that, because all praise should be grounded in some reason, and in this case we have stipulated that there is none. By contrast, I hold that God does nothing for which he does not deserve to be glorified.

4. The love that we owe to God, above all things, is based (I think) on our grasp of the great truth that God always acts in the most perfect and desirable way possible. For a lover looks for satisfaction in the happiness or perfection of the loved one and of his actions. Friendship is wanting the same things and not-wanting the same things. And I think it will be hard to love God properly without being disposed to want what he wants, even if one had the power to get something different. Indeed, those who are not satisfied with what God does are like malcontent subjects whose mind-set is not much different from a rebel's. These principles lead me to maintain that loving God requires a certain attitude to everything that happens to us through his will: not just passively accepting it because one has no alternative, but being truly satisfied with it. I am saying this about the past; for we shouldn't be quietists about the future, stupidly waiting with folded arms for what God will do, as in the fallacy of 'the argument for idleness' (as the ancients called it). So far as we can judge what God wants, in a general way, we should act in accordance with that, doing our very best to contribute to the general good, and in particular to adorning and perfecting the things that concern us—the things that are within reach. The outcome may show that in a particular instance God didn't want our good will to have its effect, but

it doesn't follow that he didn't want us to do what we did. On the contrary, as he is the best of masters, he never asks more than the right intention, and it is up to him to know when and where good intentions should succeed.

5. So it is enough to be sure of this about God: that he does everything for the best, and that nothing can harm those who love him. But to know in detail his reasons for ordering the universe as he has, allowing sin, and granting his saving grace in one way rather than another, is beyond the power of a finite mind, especially one that has not yet attained the delight of seeing God. Still, some general remarks can be made about how God goes about governing things. Thus, we can liken someone who acts perfectly to an •expert geometer who knows how to find the best construction for a problem; to a •good architect who exploits the location and the budget for his building to the best advantage, not allowing anything nasty, or less beautiful than it could be; to a •good head of a household, who manages his property so that no ground is left uncultivated or barren; to a •clever special-effects technician in the theatre, who produces his effect by the least awkward means that can be found; or to a •learned author, who gets the largest amount of subject-matter into the smallest space he can. Now, minds are the most perfect of all things, occupying the least space and thus providing the least hindrance to one another ·because they don't take up space at all·; and their perfections are virtues. That is why we should be sure that the happiness of minds is God's principal aim, which he carries out as far as the general harmony will permit. I'll say more about this later. The simplicity of God's ways relates to the •means he adopts, while their variety, richness or abundance relate to •ends or effects. These should be in balance with one another, as the money for putting up a building has to be balanced against its desired size and beauty. Admittedly, whatever God does costs him nothing—even less than it costs a philosopher ·or scientist· to invent theories out of which to build his imaginary world—for God can bring a real world into existence merely by decreeing it. But in the exercise of wisdom ·by God or a scientist· there is something analogous to the cost of a building, namely the number of independent decrees or theories that are involved. ·For God's creative activity to be economical is for it to involve very few separate decrees; for a scientific theory to be economical in its means is for it to have very few basic principles or axioms·. Reason requires that multiplicity of hypotheses or principles be avoided, rather as the simplest system is always preferred in astronomy.

6. God's wishes or actions are usually divided into the ordinary and the extraordinary. But we should bear in mind that God does nothing that isn't orderly. When we take something to be out of the ordinary, we are thinking of some particular order that holds among created things. ·We do not, or ought not to, mean that the thing is absolutely extraordinary or disordered, in the sense of being outside every order; because· there is a universal order to which everything conforms. Indeed, not only does nothing absolutely irregular ever happen in the world, but we cannot even feign [= 'tell a consistent fictional story about'] such a thing. Suppose that someone haphazardly draws points on a page, like people who practise the ridiculous art of fortune-telling through geometrical figures. I say that it is possible to find a single formula that generates a geometrical line passing through all those points in the order in which they were drawn. And if someone drew a continuous line which was now straight, now circular, now of some other kind, it would be possible to find a notion or rule or equation that would generate it. The contours of anyone's face could be traced by a single geometrical line governed by a formula. But when a rule is very complex, what fits it is seen as irregular. So one

can say that no matter how God had created the world, it would have been regular and in some general order. But God chose the most perfect order, that is, the order that is at once simplest in general rules and richest in phenomena—as would be a geometrical line whose construction was easy yet whose properties and effects were very admirable and very far-reaching. These comparisons help me to sketch some imperfect picture of divine wisdom, and to say something that might raise our minds to some sort of conception, at least, of what cannot be adequately expressed. But I don't claim that they explain this great mystery ·of creation· on which the whole universe depends.

7. Now, because nothing can happen that isn't orderly, miracles can be said to be as orderly as natural events. The latter are called 'natural' because they conform to certain subordinate rules—·ones that are not as general and basic as God's fundamental creative decrees·—which we call the nature of things. This 'Nature' is only a way in which God customarily goes about things, and he can give it up if he has a reason for doing so—a reason that is stronger than the one that moved him to make use of these ·subordinate· maxims in the first place. General acts of the will are distinguished from particular ones. Using one version of this distinction, we can say that God does everything according to his most general will, which conforms to the most perfect order that he has chosen; but that he also has particular wills, which are exceptions (not to the most general of God's laws, which regulates the whole order of the universe, and to which there are no exceptions, but) to the subordinate maxims I have mentioned, ·the ones that constitute 'Nature'·. Any object of God's particular will is something he can be said to want. But when it comes to the objects of his general will—such as are actions of created things (especially rational ones) which God chooses to allow—we ·cannot say that God wants them all, and· must make a distinction. **(1)** If the action is intrinsically good, we can say that God wants it, and sometimes commands it, even if it doesn't happen. **(2)** But an action may be intrinsically bad, and only incidentally good because later events—especially ones involving punishment and reparations—correct its wickedness and make up for the bad with some to spare, so that eventually there is more perfection overall than if this bad thing had not been done. In a case like that we must say that God allows the action but not that he wants it, even though he goes along with it because of the laws of Nature that he has established and because he sees how to derive from it a greater good.

8. It is quite hard to distinguish God's actions from those of created things. Some believe that God does everything, and others suppose that he only conserves the •force he has given to created things, ·allowing them to decide in what •directions the force shall be exercised·. We shall see later on what truth there is in each of these. Now since actions and passions properly belong to individual substances (when there is an action there is some*thing*, some subject, that acts), I have to explain what such a substance is. This much is certain: when several predicates are attributed to the same subject, and this subject is not attributed to any other, it is called an individual substance. ·For example, we call John a substance because we can attribute to him honesty, intelligence, and so on; but we don't call his honesty a substance because, although we can attribute predicates to it ('His honesty is charming, and surprising') we can attribute it to something else, namely to John. In contrast, John cannot be attributed to anything else·. But that explanation is only nominal—·all it does is to relate our calling a thing a 'substance' to other facts concerning what we say about it·. Beyond that, we need to think about what it is for something to be truly attributed to a certain subject—·e.g.

what it is for honesty to be a property of John·. Now it is certain that all true predication is founded in the nature of things, and when a proposition is not identical, that is, when the predicate is not explicitly included in the subject ·as in 'The man who governs Somalia governs Somalia'·, it must be implicitly included in it. This is what philosophers call in-esse [being-in] when they say that the predicate *is in* the subject. So the ·notion of the· subject term must always include ·that of· the predicate, so that anyone who understood the subject notion perfectly would also judge that the predicate belongs to it. We can therefore say that the nature of •an individual substance or of a complete being is to have a notion so complete that it is sufficient to include, and to allow the deduction of, all the predicates of the subject to which that notion is attributed. •An accident, on the other hand, is a being whose notion doesn't involve everything that can be attributed to the subject to which that notion is attributed. Thus Alexander the Great's kinghood is an abstraction from the subject, ·leaving out much detail·, and so is not determinate enough to pick out an individual, and doesn't involve the other qualities of Alexander or everything that the notion of that prince includes; whereas God, who sees the individual notion or 'thisness' of Alexander, sees in it at the same time the basis and the reason for *all* the predicates that can truly be said to belong to him, such as for example that he would conquer Darius and Porus, even to the extent of knowing a priori (and not by experience) whether he died a natural death or by poison—which we can know only from history. Furthermore, if we bear in mind the interconnectedness of things, we can say that Alexander's soul contains for all time traces of everything that *did* and signs of everything that *will* happen to him—and even marks of everything that happens in the universe, although it is only God who can recognise them all.

9. Several considerable paradoxes follow from this, amongst others that it is ·never· true that two substances are entirely alike, differing only in being two rather than one. It also follows that a substance cannot begin except by creation, nor come to an end except by annihilation; and because one substance can't be destroyed by being split up, or brought into existence by the assembling of parts, in the natural course of events the number of substances remains the same, although substances are often transformed. Moreover, each substance is like a whole world, and like a mirror of God, or indeed of the whole universe, which each substance expresses in its own fashion—rather as the same town looks different according to the position from which it is viewed. In a way, then, the universe is multiplied as many times as there are substances, and in the same way the glory of God is magnified by so many quite different representations of his work. It can even be said that each substance carries within it, in a certain way, the imprint of God's infinite wisdom and omnipotence, and imitates him as far as it can. For it expresses (though confusedly) everything that happens in the universe—past, present, and future—and this is a little like infinite perception or knowledge. And as all the other substances express this one in their turn, and adapt themselves to it—·that is, they are as they are *because* it is as it is·—it can be said to have power over all the others, imitating the creator's omnipotence.

10. The ancients, as well as many able teachers of theology and philosophy a few centuries ago—men accustomed to deep thought, and admirable in their holiness—seem to have had some knowledge of the things I have been saying, and to have been led by that to introduce and defend *substantial forms*. These are much sneered at today, but they are not so far from the truth, nor so ridiculous, as the common run of our new philosophers suppose. I agree that these

forms have no work to do in explaining particular events, and thus no role in the details of physics. That is where our scholastics [= mediaeval Christian philosophers influence by Aristotle, Thomas Aquinas being the most famous example] went wrong, and the physicists of the past followed them into error: they thought they could invoke forms and qualities to explain the properties of bodies, without bothering to find out how the bodies worked—like settling for saying that a clock's form gives it a 'time-indicative quality', without considering what that consists in—·that is, without considering what mechanisms are involved·. Actually, that might be all the clock's owner needs to know, if he leaves the care of it to someone else. But this misuse and ·consequent· failure of 'forms' shouldn't make us reject them. Metaphysics needs a knowledge of them, so much so that without that knowledge—I maintain—we couldn't properly grasp the first principles ·of metaphysics·, and couldn't raise our minds to the knowledge of immaterial natures and the wonders of God. However, ·important truths need not be taken into account everywhere·. A geometer need not worry about the famous labyrinth of the composition of the continuum [that is, the puzzles that arise from the idea that a line has no smallest parts]; and the huge difficulties to be found in trying to reconcile free will with God's providence need not trouble a moral philosopher, still less a lawyer or politician; for the geometer can do all his proofs, and the politician can complete his plans, without getting into those debates, necessary and important though they are in philosophy and theology. In the same way a physicist can explain his experiments—sometimes using simpler experiments he has already made, sometimes proofs in geometry and mechanics—without needing to bring in general considerations belonging to another sphere. And if he does ·go outside his sphere, and· appeal to God's co-operation, or to some soul or 'spiritual force' or other thing of that kind, he is talking nonsense, just as much as someone who drags large-scale reflections about the nature of destiny and our freedom into an important practical deliberation. Indeed men often enough unthinkingly make this mistake, when they let the idea of what is 'fated' to happen tangle their thoughts, and sometimes are even deterred by that idea from some good decision or some important precaution.

11. I know I am putting forward a considerable paradox in claiming to rehabilitate the ancient philosophy, in a way, and to re-admit substantial forms when they have been all but banished. But perhaps you won't just brush me off if you realize that I have thought a lot about the modern philosophy, that I have spent much time on experiments in physics and proofs in geometry, and that for a long time I was sure that these entities [substantial forms] are futile. Eventually I had to take them up again—against my will, as though by force—after my own researches made me recognize that thinkers these days do less than justice to St. Thomas and to other great men of his time, and that the views of scholastic philosophers and theologians contain much more good stuff than people suppose, provided they are used relevantly. I am convinced, indeed, that if some exact and thoughtful mind took the trouble to clarify and digest their thoughts, in the way the analytic geometers do, he would find them to be a treasure-house of important and completely demonstrable truths.

12. Picking up again the thread of our reflections, I believe that anyone who thinks about the nature of substance, as I have explained it above, will find that there is more to the nature of body than extension (that is, size, shape, and motion), and that we can't avoid attributing to body something comparable with a soul, something commonly called 'substantial form'—though it has no effect on par-

ticular events, any more than do the souls of animals, if they have souls. It can be proved, indeed, that the notion of size-shape-movement is less sharp and clear than we imagine, and that it includes an element that belongs to imagination and the senses, as do—to a much greater degree—colour, heat, and other such qualities, which we can doubt are really there in the nature of external things. That is why qualities of such kinds could never constitute ·the basic nature of· any substance. Moreover, if there is nothing but size-shape-movement to make a body the thing that it is, then a body can never persist for more than a moment ·because bodies constantly gain and lose tiny bits of matter·. However, the souls and substantial forms of bodies other than ours are quite different from ·our· thinking souls. Only the latter know their own actions; and they don't naturally go out of existence, but ·last for ever and· always retain the foundation of the knowledge of what they are. This is what makes them alone liable to punishment and reward, and what makes them citizens of the republic of the universe, of which God is the monarch. It also follows that all other creatures must serve them. I shall say more about that later.

13. The foundations that I have laid down give rise to a big problem, which I must try to solve before moving on. I have said that the notion of an individual substance involves, once and for all, everything that can ever happen to it; and that by looking into that notion one can see in it everything that will ever be truly sayable of the substance, just as we can see in the nature of a circle all the properties that are deducible from it. But this seems to destroy the difference between contingent and necessary truths, to rule out human freedom, and to imply that all the events in the world—including our actions—are governed by an absolute fate. To this I reply that we have to distinguish what is certain from what is necessary. Everyone agrees that future contingents are assured, because God foresees them; but we don't infer from this that they are necessary. You may say:

> But if some conclusion can be infallibly deduced from a definition or notion, it is necessary. And you contend that everything that happens to a person is already included implicitly in his nature or notion, just as a circle's properties are contained in its circle; so you are still in trouble.

I shall now resolve this problem completely. To that end, I remark that there are two kinds of connection or following-from. One is absolutely necessary, and its contrary implies a contradiction; such deduction pertains to eternal truths, such as those of geometry. The other is necessary ·not absolutely, but· only ex hypothesi, and, so to speak, accidentally. ·It doesn't bring us to *It is necessary that P*, but only to *Given Q, it follows necessarily that P*·. Something that is necessary only ex hypothesi is contingent in itself, and its contrary doesn't imply a contradiction. This ·second· kind of connection is based not purely on ideas and on God's understanding alone, but also on his free decrees, and on the history of the universe. Let us take an example. Since Julius Caesar will become the permanent dictator and master of the Republic, and will overthrow the freedom of the Romans, these actions are comprised in his ·perfect or complete· notion; because we are assuming that it is the nature of such a perfect notion of a subject to include everything, so that the predicate can be contained in the subject. It could be put like this: it is not because of that notion or idea that Caesar will perform the action, since that notion applies to him only because God knows everything. You may object: 'But his nature or form corresponds to that notion, and since God has imposed this character ·or nature or form· on him, from then on he must necessarily act in accordance with it.' I could reply to that by bringing up the

case of future contingents: they have as yet no reality except in God's understanding and will, yet since God has given them that form in advance, they will nevertheless have to correspond to it. ·So I could counter-attack by challenging you to choose between two options, each of which you will find uncomfortable: either (1)· say that future contingents are really necessary, and not contingent, or **(2)** say that God does not know them in advance. But I prefer to •resolve difficulties rather than •excusing them by likening them to other similar ones; and what I am about to say will throw light on both of the above problems. Applying now the distinction between different kinds of connection, I say that whatever happens in accordance with its antecedents is *assured* but is not *necessary*; for someone to do the contrary ·of such an assured outcome· is not impossible in itself, although it is impossible ex hypothesi—·that is, impossible given what has gone before·. For if you were capable of carrying through the whole demonstration proving that this subject (Caesar) is connected with this predicate (his successful ·power-grabbing· enterprise), this would involve you in showing that Caesar's dictatorship had its foundation in his notion or nature, that a reason can be found there—·in that notion or nature·—why he decided to cross the Rubicon rather than stop at it, and why he won rather than lost the day ·in the battle· at Pharsalus. ·You would be discovering· that it was rational and therefore assured that this would happen, but not that it is necessary in itself, or that the contrary implies a contradiction. (In a somewhat similar way it is rational and assured that God will always do the best, although ·the idea of his doing· what is less perfect implies no contradiction.) What you discovered would not be something whose contrary implies a contradiction because, as you would find, this ·supposed· demonstration of this predicate of Caesar's is not as absolute as those of numbers or of geometry. It presupposes ·(you would find)· the course of events that God has freely chosen, and that is founded on **(1)** his primary free decision, which is always to do what is most perfect, and, on the basis of that, **(2)** his decision regarding human nature, namely that men will always (though freely) do what seems the best. Now, any truth which is founded on this sort of decision is contingent, even though it is certain, because •decisions have no effect whatsoever on the •possibility of things. And (to repeat myself) although God is sure always to choose the best, that doesn't stop something less perfect from being and remaining possible in itself, even though it won't happen—for what makes God reject it is its imperfection, not its being impossible ·which it is not·. And nothing is necessary if its opposite is possible. So we are well placed to resolve these kinds of difficulty, however great they may seem (and in fact they are equally serious for everyone else who has ever dealt with this matter). All we need is to bear in mind •that each such contingent proposition has reasons why it is so rather than otherwise—or (to put the same thing in other words), •that there is an a priori proof of its truth which makes it certain, and which shows that the connection of its subject with its predicate has its foundation in the nature of each; but •that this proof is not a demonstration of the proposition's necessity, because those reasons ·for its truth· are based only on the principle of contingency or of the existence of things, that is, on what is or what appears the best among a number of equally possible things. Necessary truths, on the other hand, are based on the principle of contradiction, and on the possibility or impossibility of essences themselves, without any regard to the free will of God or of created things.

Sections 14–23

14. Now that we have some grasp of what the nature of substances consists in, I should try to explain their dependence on one another, and the active and passive aspects of their goings-on. Well, firstly, it is very evident that created substances depend on God, who conserves them and indeed produces them continuously by a kind of emanation, just as we produce our thoughts. For God considers from every angle the general system of particular events that he has thought fit to produce in order to manifest his glory, turning it on all sides, so to speak. And as he considers all the faces of the world in all possible ways—for no aspect escapes his omniscience—each view of the universe, as though looked at from a certain viewpoint, results in a substance that expresses the universe in just that way, if God sees fit to actualize his thoughts by producing such a substance. And as God's view is always correct, so too are our perceptions; where we go wrong is in our judgments, which are our own. I said above, and it follows from what I have said here, that each substance is like a separate world, independent of every other thing except God. So all our phenomena—all the events that occur in us—are simply consequences of our being [here = 'of our nature']. These events maintain a certain order in conformity with our nature, or with the world that is in us, so to speak, and this enables us to set up rules which we can use to guide our conduct, and which are justified by their fit with future events; so that often we can judge the future by the past without falling into error. That would give us a basis for saying that these phenomena are veridical [= 'that they tell the truth'], without bothering about whether they are external to us, or whether others are aware of them too. Still, it emphatically *is* the case that the perceptions or expressions of all substances correspond with one another, in such a way that each one, by carefully following certain principles or laws that it has conformed to, finds itself in agreement with others which do the same—as when several people agree to meet together in some place on a certain day, and succeed in doing this. For them all to express the same phenomena their expressions don't have to be perfectly alike; it is enough that they are correlated—just as a number of spectators think they are seeing the same thing, and do in fact understand each other, even though each one sees and speaks according to his point of view. Now it is God alone (from whom all individuals continuously emanate, and who sees the universe not only •as they do but also •completely differently from them all) who is the cause of this correspondence in their phenomena, and brings it about that what is particular to one is public to all. Without that there would be no connection between them. This gives us a basis for saying that no particular substance ever acts on or is acted on by another particular substance. The sense in which this is true is far removed from common usage, but it is good nevertheless. Bear in mind that what happens to each substance is a consequence of its idea or complete notion and of nothing else, because that idea already involves all the substance's predicates or events, and expresses the whole universe. In reality nothing can happen to us except thoughts and perceptions, and all our future thoughts and perceptions are only the consequences—contingent ones—of our preceding thoughts and perceptions. So if I could command a clear view of everything that is happening or appearing to me right now, I would be able to see in it everything that will ever happen

or appear to me. And it would not be prevented, and would still happen to me, even if everything outside of me were destroyed except for God. But when we have perceptions of a certain kind, we think that they come from outer things acting on us; and I want to look into what this belief is based on, and what truth there is in it.

15. I needn't spend long on this. All I need just now is to reconcile what is said as a matter of metaphysics with what is said in everyday talk, which I do by saying that we rightly [or: reasonably] attribute to ourselves the phenomena that we express more perfectly, and attribute to other substances what each expresses best. So a substance that •expresses everything, ·as every substance does·, and is in that ·metaphorical· sense •infinitely extended, comes to be limited by the more or less perfect manner of its expression. This gives us a notion of how substances obstruct or limit one another; and consequently we can say that in this sense they act on one another, and are obliged to adjust themselves to one another, so to speak. ·What follows is the reason why this way of speaking, though not correct as a matter of strict and basic metaphysics, is nevertheless reasonable, or right in its own way·. It can happen that a change that raises the level of expression of one substance lowers that of another. Now, a particular substance has power in expressing well the glory of God, and in doing that it is less limited. And each thing, when it exercises its power, that is to say when it is active, changes for the better, and extends itself, in proportion to how active it is. So when a change occurs that affects several substances (and actually all changes touch them all), I believe we can ·properly· say that •one that immediately passes to a higher level of perfection or to a more perfect expression exercises its power and acts; and •one that passes to a lower level shows its weakness and is acted on. I hold also that every action of a substance that has perception signifies some pleasure, whereas every passivity [= 'every instance of being-acted-on'] involves some sadness, and vice versa. It can easily happen, though, that a present advantage is destroyed by a greater evil later on; which is why we can sin when we are active or exerting our power and enjoying doing so.

16. My remaining task is to explain how it is possible that God should sometimes have influence on men or on other substances by an out-of-the-ordinary or miraculous concourse. [Leibniz's word *concours* can mean co-operation, or (more weakly) going-along-with or permitting. He here ties it to *influence* (French), suggesting that in these cases God *acts upon* men and other substances, though that is not his considered view about what happens.] ·This question arises because· whatever happens to created substances is purely a consequence of their nature, which seems to imply that nothing extraordinary or miraculous can happen to them. Remember, though, what I said above about the place of miracles in the universe: that they always conform to the universal law of the general order, even though they over-ride subordinate rules ·and are in that sense out of the ordinary·. And since each person and each substance is like a little world that expresses the larger world, anything that happens within a substance belongs to the general order of the universe, which is indeed expressed by the essence or individual notion of that substance. Yet an extraordinary action by God on a single substance, though it does conform to the general order, can still be called miraculous. This is why if we include in our nature everything that it expresses, nothing is supernatural to it, because it extends to everything—because an effect always expresses its cause, and God is the true cause of substances. But the powers and the limits of our nature come (as I have just explained) from ·the facts about· what it expresses more perfectly; and for that reason what it expresses more perfectly belongs to it

in a particular manner. Many things are beyond the powers of our nature, indeed of all limited natures. So in order to make this easier to grasp, I say that what marks off miracles and the extraordinary concourse of God is that they cannot be foreseen by the reasoning of any created mind, however enlightened, because no such mind can rise to having a clear view of the general order. On the other hand, everything that is called 'natural' depends on less general rules that created things can understand. In order, then, to have not only meanings but words that are above reproach, it would be good if we linked certain modes of speech with certain thoughts ·in the following way·. We can use 'our essence' to stand for something including •all that we express ·however imperfectly; and in that sense·, our essence has no limits, and can rise to anything, because it expresses our union with God himself. We can use 'our nature' or 'our power' to designate what is limited in us, ·that is, to designate •the more-perfectly-expressed fragment of all we express·; and anything that surpasses the nature ·or power·—in *this* sense—of any created substance is supernatural.

17. Having several times mentioned subordinate rules, or laws of Nature, I think it would be good to give an example. Our new philosophers standardly employ the famous rule that God always conserves the same quantity of motion in the world. This is indeed most plausible, and in days gone by I thought it to be beyond doubt. But I have since realised where the mistake lies. It is that Descartes and many other able mathematicians have believed that •the quantity of motion (i.e. the speed at which a thing moves) multiplied by •its size exactly equals •the moving force ·that it exerts·; or, geometrically speaking, that forces are directly proportional to speeds and bodies. Now it is rational that the same force should always be conserved in the universe. ·Here are reasons for the two halves of that thesis. As regards the addition of force·: Looking carefully at the observable facts, we can clearly see that perpetual mechanical motion doesn't occur; because if it did the force of a machine, which is always slightly lessened by friction and so must soon come to an end, would be restored, and consequently would increase of itself without any input from outside. ·As regards the loss of force·: We also observe that a body's force is lessened only to the extent that it gives some of it to adjacent bodies, or to its own parts in so far as they have their own independent motion. ·So the new philosophers were right about the conservation of force. Where they went wrong was in this·: they thought that what can be said of •force could also be said of •quantity of motion. I am now going to show the difference between force and quantity of motion. In doing this I shall make an assumption: that a body falling from a certain height gains enough force to rise back up again, if its direction carries it that way, unless it is prevented. For example, a pendulum would return exactly to its starting position unless the resistance of the air and other little obstacles didn't slightly lessen the force it had acquired. I shall also make this assumption: that as much force is necessary to raise a one-pound body A to the height of four fathoms, as to raise a four-pound body B to the height of one fathom. All this is accepted by our new philosophers. It is clear, then, that body A, having fallen four fathoms, has acquired exactly as much force as has body B that has fallen one fathom. For body B, when it has completed its fall, has the force needed to climb back up to the start (by the first assumption), and so has the force to carry a four-pound body (its own body, that is) to the height of one fathom ; and, similarly, the body A, when it has completed its fall, has the force needed to climb back to its start, and so has the force to carry a one-pound body (its own body, that is) to the height of four fathoms. Therefore (by the second assumption) the

forces of these two bodies are equal. Let us now see whether the quantities of motion are the same on the one side as on the other. Here they will be surprised to find that there is a very great difference. For Galileo has demonstrated that the speed acquired in A's fall is double the speed acquired in B's, although the height is quadruple. So let us multiply body A (= 1) by its speed (= 2), and the resultant quantity of motion = 2. On the other hand, multiply the body B (= 4) by its speed (= 1), and the resultant quantity of motion = 4. Therefore the quantity of motion of body A at the end of its fall is half that of body B at the end of its fall, yet their forces are equal. So quantity of motion is clearly different from force, QED. This shows how force should be calculated from the size of the effect it can produce—for example by the height to which a heavy body of a particular size and type can be raised, which is very different from the speed it can reach. To double the speed you must more than double the force. Nothing is simpler than this proof. M. Descartes got this wrong through putting too much trust in his thoughts, even when they were not properly mature. But I am amazed that his followers have not since recognised this mistake. They are, I'm afraid, starting to resemble some of the Aristotelians whom they mock, getting into their habit of consulting their master's books rather than reason and Nature.

18. This point about how force differs from quantity of motion is of some importance, not only **(1)** in physics and in mechanics for discovering the true laws of Nature and rules of motion, and indeed for correcting some practical errors that have glided into the writings of certain able mathematicians, but also **(2)** in metaphysics for understanding its principles better. ·What follows illustrates point **(2)**·. Motion, if one considers only what it strictly consists in just in itself (namely, change of place), is not an entirely real thing; when several bodies change their relative positions, those changes in themselves do not settle which of the bodies should be said to have moved and which to have remained at rest. (I could show this geometrically, if I were willing to interrupt myself to do so.) But the force or immediate cause behind those changes has more reality to it; and there is an adequate basis for ascribing it to one body rather than to another, that being our only way to know to which body the motion mainly belongs. Now, this force is something different from size, shape, and motion, and this shows us that—contrary to what our moderns have talked themselves into believing—not everything that we can conceive in bodies is a matter of extension and its modifications. So here again we have to reintroduce certain beings or 'forms' that the moderns have banished. And it becomes more and more apparent that although all particular natural events can be explained mathematically or mechanically by those who understand them, the general principles of corporeal nature and even ·the somewhat less general principles· of mechanics belong to metaphysics rather than to geometry, and have to do with certain indivisible forms or natures, as the causes of appearances, rather than with corporeal or extended mass. This line of thought could reconcile the mechanical philosophy of the moderns with the caution of some intelligent and well-intentioned people who fear, with some reason, that we might be endangering piety by moving too far away from immaterial beings. ·In case that remark is too compressed, I shall now—down to the end of this section—amplify it. On the one hand, my position enables us to agree with the moderns that in scientifically explaining physical events we can proceed *as though* we were materialists, appealing to nothing but material bodies and their properties. On the other hand, we are saved from outright materialism (and thus from the risk of sliding into atheism, which materialism brings with it), by my views

about what is needed to complete the physics of bodies. (1) I hold that the laws governing the behaviour of bodies involve a concept of force that cannot be extracted from the concept of body; so it is sheerly additional to anything the materialists are comfortable with; and it points in the direction of *immaterial* beings as what might contain or exert the forces. **(2)** I hold that after we have established all the laws of matter, there remains the question 'Why are *these* the laws of matter?', and that the only tenable answer is 'Because God chose that they should be'·.

19. As I don't like to judge people harshly, I shan't make accusations against our new philosophers who claim to expel final causes from physics; but still I can't deny that the consequences of this view seem to me dangerous. [The final cause of an event is what it was for, what goal it was aimed at, what intention it was done with. Its efficient cause is what makes it happen, causing it from behind, as it were. A tidal wave might have as its efficient cause an under-sea earthquake; and if it had a final cause, it might be to punish the people in a sinful coastal city.] It is especially dangerous when it is combined with the view I refuted in section 2 of this Discourse, which seems to go as far as to eliminate purposes altogether—·from theology as well as from physics·—as if *God* acted without intending or aiming at any end or good! Against this, I hold that it is to final causes that we should look for the principle [= 'ultimate explanation'] of all existent things and of the laws of Nature, because God always aims at the best and the most perfect. I freely admit that we may go wrong in trying to work out what God's ends or purposes are; but that happens only when we want to limit them to some particular design, thinking he had only some single thing in view, whereas in fact he takes account of everything all at once. So for example it is a great mistake to think that God made the world only for us, although it is true that he did make it—all of it—for us, and that there is nothing in the universe that does not touch us [Leibniz uses the same verb here as when saying in section 15 that all changes 'touch' all substances], and which is not also adjusted to fit the concern he has for us, in accordance with the principles laid down above. So when we see some good effect or some perfection that happens or follows from the works of God, we can safely say that God intended it. We sometimes fail to act well, but not God: he doesn't do things by accident. This is why, far from risking exaggeration in this—like political observers who go to absurd lengths in attributing subtlety to the designs of princes, or like literary commentators who look for too much learning in their author—one could never over-state the complexity of thought that this infinite wisdom involves. On no subject do we run less risk of error, so long as we only make affirmations, and avoid negative propositions that limit the designs of God. Everyone who sees the admirable structure of animals is led to recognise the wisdom of the creator of things; and I advise those who have any feelings of piety, and indeed of true philosophy, to avoid saying—as do certain self-proclaimed free-thinkers—that we see because we happen to have eyes, but not that the eyes were made for seeing. If one seriously maintains these views that hand everything over to the necessity of matter or to some kind of chance (although each of these must seem ridiculous to those who understand what I have explained above), one will have trouble recognising an intelligent author of Nature. For an effect must correspond to its cause; indeed, the best way to know an effect is through its cause. If you introduce a supreme intelligence as the organiser of things, it doesn't make sense to go on to explain events purely in terms of the properties of matter, without bringing in the organizing intelligence. It would be as though, in explaining a great prince's victory in a successful siege, a historian were to say:

> It was because the small particles of gunpowder, released by the touch of a spark, shot off fast enough to impel a hard, heavy body against the walls of the place, while the particles making up the strands of copper in the cannon were so densely interwoven that they were not pulled apart by that speed;

instead of showing how the conqueror's foresight made him choose the appropriate time and means, and how his power overcame all obstacles.

20. This reminds me of a beautiful passage by Socrates in Plato's *Phaedo,* which agrees splendidly with my views on this point, and seems to have been aimed straight at our over-materialist philosophers. This agreement made me want to translate it, although it is a little long. Perhaps this sample will stimulate someone to make available to us many other beautiful and solid thoughts to be found in the writings of this famous author. [At this point there is a gap in Leibniz's manuscript, into which, he wrote, 'The passage from Plato's *Phaedo* where Socrates ridicules Anaxagoras, who introduces mind but does not make use of it, is to be inserted.' He had included an abridged version of that passage in another of his writings a few years earlier. That version constitutes the remainder of the present section.]

·Start of quotation from Phaedo·

[It is Socrates who speaks.] I once heard someone reading from a book that he said was by Anaxagoras, containing these words: 'All things were caused by an intelligent being that set them out and embellished them.' This pleased me greatly, for I believed that if the world was caused by an intelligence, everything would be made in the most perfect possible manner. That is why I believed that someone wanting to explain why things are produced, and why they perish or survive, should search for what would be most suitable to each thing's perfection. So such a person would only have to consider, in ·the thing he was studying, whether· himself or in something else, what would be the best or most perfect. For someone who knew what was most perfect would also know what would be imperfect, for the knowledge of either is knowledge of the other. Considering all this, I rejoiced at having found an authority who could teach me the reasons for things: for example, whether the earth is spherical or flat, and why it is better that it should be one way rather than the other. I expected also that in the course of saying whether or not the earth is at the centre of the universe, he would explain to me why its position is the most suitable for it to have. And that he would tell me similar things about the sun, the moon, the stars, and their movements. And finally that after having told me what would be best for each thing in particular, he would show what would be best over-all. Filled with this hope, I lost no time in acquiring Anaxagoras's books and whipping through them; but I found nothing like what I had been reckoning on: to my surprise, I found him making no use of ·the idea of· the governing intelligence that he had put forward, that he had nothing more to say about the embellishments and the perfection of things, and that he brought in an implausible ·notion of· ether. It's as though someone were to say at the outset that Socrates acts with intelligence, and then move on to explaining the particular causes of Socrates's actions thus: Socrates is seated here because he has a body composed of bone, flesh and sinews, the bones are solid but they are separated at joints, the sinews can be stretched or relaxed—all that is why the body is flexible, and, rounding out the explanation, why I am sitting here. Or as though someone, wanting to explain our present conversation, appealed to the air, and to the organs of speech and hearing and such things, forgetting the real causes, namely that the Athenians thought

it better to condemn than to acquit me, and that I thought it better to remain here than to escape. If I had not had that thought—if I had not found it more just and honourable to suffer the penalty my country chooses to impose than to live as a vagabond in exile—I swear these sinews and bones would long ago have put themselves among the Boeotians and Megarans! That is why it unreasonable to call these bones and sinews causes. Someone might say that without bones and sinews I could not do what I do, and he would be right; but the true cause is different from a mere condition without which the cause could not be a cause. Some people offer as their whole explanation of what holds the earth in its place the movements of bodies surrounding it; they forget that divine power sets everything out in the most beautiful manner, and do not understand that the right and the beautiful join forces to form and maintain the world.

·End of quotation from Phaedo·

21. Well now, since God's wisdom has always been recognised in the detail of the physical structure of certain bodies, ·especially animals and plants·, it must also be shown display itself in the general economy of the world and in the constitution of the laws of Nature. That is so true that this wisdom can be seen in the general laws of motion. Here is how. If there were nothing to a body but extended mass, and motion were only change of place, and if everything should and could be deduced with geometrical necessity from those definitions alone, it would follow (as I have shown elsewhere) that a tiny body upon bumping into an enormous stationary body would give it the same speed as it itself had, without losing any of its own. And a number of other rules which, like this one, are completely contrary to the formation of a system, would have to be admitted. But a system is provided by the decision of the divine wisdom to conserve always the same total force and direction. I even find that some natural effects can be demonstrated twice over, first through efficient causes, and then through final causes—for example by bringing in God's decision to produce his effect always in the easiest and the most determinate ways. I have shown this elsewhere, in explaining the rules of reflection and refraction of light, about which I shall say more presently.

22. It is good to point this out, in order to reconcile •those who hope to explain mechanically how the parts of an animal are initially inter-woven and what machine they compose, with •those who explain that same structure through final causes. Both are good, both can be useful, not only for admiring the great workman's ingenuity but also for making useful discoveries in physics and medicine. Authors who go these different ways ought not to heap abuse on each other ·as they sometimes do·. For I see that those who focus on explaining the beauty of divine anatomy make fun of others who think that such a beautiful variety of organs could have come from a seemingly chance motion of certain fluids; they call such people rash and profane. The latter, on the other hand, call the others simple and superstitious, and liken them to the ancients who accused of impiety the physical scientists who maintained that thunder is produced not by Jupiter but by some kind of matter in the clouds. It would be best to combine the two approaches, because—if I may use a down-to-earth example—I recognise and praise a workman's skill not only by showing what designs he had in making the parts of his machine, but also by explaining the tools he used to make each part, especially when those tools are simple and cleverly devised. God is such a skillful worker that he could produce a machine a thousand times more ingenious than those of our bodies, using only various quite simple fluids that were devised so that ordinary laws of Nature were all it took to arrange them in the right way

to produce such an admirable effect; but that doesn't alter the fact that none of this would happen if God were not the author of Nature. Explanations in terms of efficient causes are deeper and in some way more immediate and more a priori [here = 'more truly explanatory'], but for the details of events such explanations are hard to come by, and I believe that our scientists usually fall far short of achieving them. By contrast, the way of final causes is easier, despite which it often enables us to conjecture important and useful truths, truths that the other more physical route—·that is, the way of efficient causes·—would have taken ages to reach. Anatomy provides substantial examples of this. I also think that Snell, who first formulated of the rules of refraction, would have been a long time finding them if he had tried to come at them first by ·way of efficient causes, which would put him in need of· discovering how light is formed. Instead of that, he seems to have followed the method the ancients used for reflection ·of light·, which is in fact that of final causes. They looked for the easiest way to get a ray of light from one point to another by reflection in a given plane (assuming that this is the way Nature was designed), and this led them to the discovery that the angle of incidence always equals the angle of reflection. Snell, I think, more ingeniously applied this to refraction. [Leibniz here gives an extremely cryptic and unclear statement of what Snell discovered about how light is bent when it passes from one medium to another, e.g. from air to water; and he says that it implies that light always follows the easiest or anyway the most determinate route from a given point in one medium to a given point in another. He is taking it for granted that the concepts of easiest and most determinate somehow involve final causes.] (Fermat came at the matter in the same way, though without knowing of Snell's work.) Descartes tried to demonstrate this same theorem in terms of efficient causes, but his demonstration is nowhere near as good; and there is room to suspect that he would never have found the theorem by his method if he had not been told in Holland of Snell's discovery ·through final causes·.

23. I have thought it appropriate to emphasize a little the relevance to bodies of •final causes, •incorporeal natures and an •intelligent cause, so as to show that these have a role even in physical science and mathematics. I have wanted to do this because it may (on the one hand) clear contemporary physics of the charge of impiety that has been levelled at it, and (on the other) raise the minds of our philosophers from purely material considerations to thoughts of a nobler kind. Now it is appropriate to return from bodies to immaterial natures, and in particular to minds; and to say something about the means that God employs to enlighten them and to act on them. There is no doubt that here too there are certain laws of Nature, which I will be able to discuss more fully elsewhere. Just now it will be enough to say a little about ideas [sections 23–7], about whether we see all things in God [section 29], and about how God is our light [section 28]. I should point out that many errors arise from the misuse of ideas. ·For example·, some ancient and modern philosophers have based a very imperfect proof of God on the natural assumption that when we reason about something we have an idea of it. The 'proof' goes like this:

(1) I can think about God, so
(2) I have an idea of him.
(3) This idea involves his having all perfections.
(4) Existence is one of the perfections.

Therefore

(5) God exists.

·The defect in this is its move from **(1)** to **(2)**·. We often think of impossible absurdities—for example of the highest speed, or of the largest number, or of [a certain geometrical impossibility]—and the ideas involved in such thinking are in a certain sense 'false', in contrast with 'true' ideas of things

that are possible. So we can boast of having an idea—·that is, a 'true' idea·—of a thing only when we are assured of its possibility. So the above argument falls short. Still, it does at least prove that God necessarily exists *if he is possible*. ·That is a significant result, because it attributes to God something that is not true of other things·. It is indeed an excellent privilege of the divine nature to need only its possibility or essence in order actually to exist.

Sections 24–37

24. To understand the nature of ideas better, I must say a little about the different kinds of knowledge. When I can pick a thing out from among others, but cannot say what marks it out from them, my knowledge of it is confused. In this way we sometimes know vividly, without being in any way in doubt, whether a poem or a painting is good or bad, because it has a certain *je-ne-sais-quoi* that pleases or displeases us. But when I can explain the criteria I am going by, my knowledge is clear. An assayer's knowledge is ·clear· like this; he can distinguish true from false gold by means of certain tests or marks that make up the definition of gold. But the clearness of knowledge is a matter of degree, because the notions entering into the definition usually need to be defined in their turn, and are known only confusedly. But when everything that comes into a definition or an item of clear knowledge is known clearly, right down to the primary notions, I call that knowledge *adequate*. And when my mind takes in, clearly and at once, all the primary ingredients of a notion, it has *intuitive* knowledge of it. This is very rare; most human knowledge is only confused, or suppositive. [Leibniz's use of his invented word *suppositif* in section 25 shows that his thought is this: an item of knowledge to which this term applies involves a notion or idea that one *supposes* to be firmly included in one's conceptual repertoire; this contrasts with consciously bringing the idea to mind and *seeing that* one has it in one's repertoire.] It is also worthwhile to distinguish nominal definitions from real ones: I call a definition 'nominal' when we can still doubt whether the notion defined is possible. [Leibniz gives a complex geometrical example.] This shows that any reciprocal property [= 'any statement of necessary and sufficient conditions'] can serve as a nominal definition; but when the property shows the thing's possibility, it makes a *real* definition. [The source of 'nominal' is the Latin *nomen*, 'name'; the source of 'real' is the Latin *res*, 'thing'. A nominal definition, Leibniz holds, tells you only about the meaning of a word, whereas a real definition informs you about the thing.] Now as long as we have only a nominal definition, we can't be sure of the consequences that we draw from it, because if it conceals some contradiction or impossibility it could also have opposing consequences. This is why truths don't depend on names, and are not arbitrary as some new philosophers have believed. A final point: real definitions differ considerably from one another. When possibility is proved only by experience, the definition is merely •real and nothing more—as with the definition of quicksilver, which we know to be possible because we have encountered a fluid that is an extremely heavy yet fairly volatile. But when the

thing can be shown to be possible a priori—·that is, without help from experience·—as when the definition shows how the thing could be generated, then the definition is both real and •causal. And when a definition takes the analysis the whole way down to the primary notions, without assuming anything that itself requires an a priori proof of its possibility, the definition is •perfect, or •essential.

[In this section and elsewhere, 'vivid' translates the French *clair*, and 'clear' translates the French *distinct*. These are usually rendered as 'clear' and 'distinct' respectively, but the first of those is nearly always a flat mistranslation (though not in the second sentence of section 37). The French word *clair* primarily means 'vivid', 'bright', 'strongly present to consciousness', so that Descartes can say that one's awareness of an intense pain is *clair*, and bright light is *lumière claire*—even if it is dazzling and in no way clear. That is why Leibniz can say in this section, as Descartes did before him, that something's presence to the mind can be at once confused and vivid—not confused and clear! Once 'clear' has been freed from that misuse, it becomes available as a good translation for the French *distinct*.]

25. ·Let us get clear about suppositive knowledge·. When I think of a thousand, I often do so without contemplating the idea—as when I say that a thousand is ten times a hundred, without bothering to think what 10 and 100 are, because I *suppose* I know, and see no immediate need to stop to think about it. ·On those occasions, my thought that a thousand is ten times a hundred is suppositive·. In cases like that, I relate to the idea in the same way as I do in a thought in which there lurks an impossibility. Even if in a given case the relevant idea is all right, and doesn't involve an impossibility, I cannot learn that this is so by suppositive thinking. So it easily *can* and quite often *does* happen that I am mistaken about a notion that I suppose or believe I understand when in fact it is impossible, or at least incompatible with the others to which I join it; and whether I am mistaken or not, this suppositive manner of conceiving is the same.

26. To get a good grip on what ideas are, be warned of an ambiguity. Some people take an idea to be a form or differentia [= 'aspect or property'] of our thought; so that we have the idea in our mind only when we are thinking of it, and whenever we think of it again, we have different but similar ideas of the same thing. Others, however, seem to take an idea to be the immediate object of a thought, or to be some kind of permanent form, which continues to exist even when we are not contemplating it. ·I side with the latter group, and here is why·. Our soul always possesses the ability to represent to itself any nature or form when the occasion for thinking of it arises. ·This ability is permanent, even though the individual thoughts in which it is exercised come and go·. And I believe that this •ability of our soul, when it expresses some nature, form, or essence, is properly called an •idea of the thing; and it is in us—always in us—whether or not we are thinking of the thing. For our soul ·always· expresses God and the universe, and all essences as well as all existences. ·That requires our soul to have ideas of all those things at all times, which it can do only if ideas are abilities rather than individual mental or events or aspects or properties of such events·. This fits in with my principles, for nothing naturally enters our mind from outside; and it is a bad habit of ours to think of our soul as receiving messenger species, or as if it had doors and windows. We have all these forms in our mind and indeed always have had; because the mind always expresses all its future thoughts, and is already thinking confusedly of everything it will ever think clearly. We couldn't be taught something unless we already had the idea of it in our mind, the idea being like the matter out of which the thought is formed. Plato understood this very well, when he put forward his doctrine of *reminiscence*. The latter

is very sound, provided we take it in the right way—cleansing it of the error about pre-existence, and not imagining that if a soul takes in and thinks about something now it must at some earlier time have clearly known and thought about it. He also confirmed his opinion by a beautiful experiment. He introduces a small boy whom he gradually leads to ·an acceptance of· very difficult geometrical truths about incommensurables, without teaching him anything, only asking him an orderly sequence of suitable questions. This shows that our souls have virtual knowledge of all these things; that to grasp truths they need only to have their attention drawn to them; and thus that our souls at least have the ideas on which those truths depend. They might even be said to possess these truths, if we consider the truths as relations between ideas.

27. Aristotle preferred to compare our souls to as-yet blank tablets that could be written on, and he held that there is nothing in our understanding that doesn't come from the senses. This squares better with everyday notions, as Aristotle usually does (unlike Plato, who goes deeper). Ordinary usage does sanction these doctrines or rules of thumb, in the spirit in which people who follow Copernicus still say that the sun 'rises' and 'sets'. Indeed, I often find that we can give them a good sense in which they are ·not merely passable or excusable, but· entirely true; in the way in which (as I have already remarked ·in section 15·) it can truly be said that particular substances act on each other, and that we receive knowledge from outside by the agency of the senses, because some external things contain or express more particularly the reasons why our soul has certain thoughts. But when we are pursuing precise metaphysical truths, it is important to recognise how much our soul contains and how independent it is of other things. These—its 'extent' and its independence—go infinitely further than plain folk imagine, although in ordinary talk we attribute to the soul only what we are most plainly aware of, only what belongs to us in one special manner, because there is no point in going any further. Still, it would be good to choose specific terms for each way of talking, so as to avoid ambiguity. So those expressions that are in our soul whether conceived or not, can be called 'ideas'; but those that are conceived or formed ·in a consciously self-aware manner· can be called 'notions', or 'concepts'. But in whatever way we take the term 'notion', it is always false to say that all our notions come from the so-called external senses. For my notion of myself and of my thoughts, and therefore of being, substance, action, identity, and many others, come from an internal experience.

28. Now in strict metaphysical truth God is the only external cause that acts on us, and he alone affects us directly in virtue of our continual dependence. Therefore no other external object touches our soul and directly triggers our perceptions. So it is the continual action of God upon us that enables us to have in our souls ideas of all things. ·Here is how that happens·. All effects express their causes, and so the essence [= 'intrinsic nature'] of our soul is a particular expression, imitation or likeness of God's essence, thought and will, and of all the ideas contained in it. So we can say that God alone is our immediate external object, and that we see all things through him. When we see the sun and the stars, for example, it is God who gave us the relevant ideas and who conserves them in us; and who by his ordinary concurrence, following the laws he has established, brings it about that we actually think of them when our senses are suitably disposed. God is the sun and the light of souls, 'the light which lighteth every man that cometh into this world' [*John* 1:9]; and this is not a new opinion. In addition to holy scripture and the fathers, who have always been more

for Plato than for Aristotle, I remember having sometimes noticed that many people in the time of the Scholastics held that God is the light of the soul, or, as they used to say, 'the active intellect of the rational soul'. The Averroists twisted this the wrong way, but others have taken it in a manner worthy of God and capable of raising the soul to knowledge of its true good.

29. However, I don't share the opinion of some able philosophers—·most notably Malebranche·—who seem to maintain that our ideas themselves are in God and not at all in us. In my view this comes from their having ·partly grasped but· not yet thought through the points I have just been making about substances and about the whole extent and independence of our soul—points which imply that the soul contains everything that happens to it, and expresses God (and with him all possible and actual beings) as an effect expresses its cause. Anyway, it is inconceivable that I should think with someone else's ideas! Furthermore, when the soul thinks of something it must actually come to be in a certain state, and it must have contained in advance not only a completely determinate •passive power of coming to be in that state, but also an •active power in virtue of which its nature has always contained signs of the future production of this thought, and •dispositions to produce it when the time comes. And all this—·the passive power, the active power that includes the forward-looking signs, and the disposition·—has wrapped up in it the idea involved in the thought.

30. As regards God's action on the human will, there are a number of quite difficult issues that it would be tedious to pursue here. Here in outline is what we can say. In his ordinary concourse with our actions, God merely follows the laws he has established; that is to say, he continually preserves and produces our being in such a way that our thoughts occur spontaneously and freely in the order laid down by the notion of our individual substance, in which they could be foreseen from all eternity. Furthermore, he determines our will to choose what appears ·to us· the best, yet without necessitating it. He does this by decreeing that our will shall always tend towards the apparent good, thus expressing or imitating the will of God to the extent that this apparent good has (as it always does have) some real good in it. ·I comment now on 'without necessitating it'·. Absolutely speaking, our will is in a state of indifference, as opposed to necessity: it has the power to do otherwise, or to suspend its action altogether, each alternative being and remaining possible. It is therefore up to the soul to take precautions against being caught off its guard by events that come into its ken; and the way to do this is to resolve firmly to be reflective, and in certain situations not to act or judge without mature and thorough deliberation. It is true, however, and indeed it was settled from all eternity, that a particular soul will not employ this power ·to pause, reflect, deliberate· on some particular occasion. But whose fault is that? Does the soul have anyone to complain of except itself? Any complaint *after the fact* is unfair if it would have been unfair *before*. But would it have been decent for this soul, just before sinning, to complain against God as if he were determining it to sin? What God determines in these matters cannot be foreseen, so how could a soul know that it was determined to sin unless it was already doing so? It is simply a matter of not choosing to; and God couldn't have set an easier or fairer condition than that; and accordingly judges do not look for the reasons that led a man to have an evil intent, but concern themselves only with how evil it is. 'But perhaps it is certain from all eternity that I shall sin?' Answer that yourself: perhaps not! And instead of dreaming on about what you can't know and

can't learn from, act according to your duty, which you do know. 'But how does it happen that this man will certainly sin?' The reply is easy: it is that otherwise it wouldn't be this man. [Notice: He doesn't say '*he* wouldn't be this man', which is how most translations have put it.] For God sees from all time that there will be a certain Judas whose notion or idea, which God has, contains that future free action. That leaves only the question of why such a Judas, the traitor, who in God's idea is merely possible, actually exists. But no reply to that question is to be expected here on this earth, except that in general we should say: Since God found it good that Judas should exist, despite the sin that he foresaw, this evil must be repaid with interest somewhere in the universe; God will extract some greater good from it; and the bottom line is that this course of events—·the actual one· that includes the existence of this sinner—will turn out to be the most perfect out of all the possible ways things could have gone. But while we are journeying through this world we can't always •explain the admirable economy of that choice; we must settle for •knowing it without •understanding it. And at this point it is time to acknowledge the richness and unfathomable depth of the divine wisdom, and not to look for a detailed account of it—an account that would be infinitely complex. It is quite clear, though, that God is not the cause of evil. Man's soul been possessed by original sin ever since he lost his innocence, but ·that was not the start of it·. Even before that, all created things—·just because they were created·—were intrinsically limited or imperfect in a way that makes them capable of sin and of error. St. Augustine and others have held that the root of evil lies in •nothingness, and I think that this should be taken as saying what I have just said: namely, that evil comes from the •lacks and limits of created things, which God graciously remedies by the degree of perfection that he is pleased to give. This grace of God in both its ordinary and its extraordinary versions [see sections 6 and 16] varies in how deep and wide it goes. ·But· it is always enough not only to save a man from sin but also to secure his salvation, as long as he uses his own resources to combine himself with that grace. It is not always sufficient to overcome a man's inclinations; if it were, ·his inclinations would have no effect on anything, and· he would no longer be responsible for anything. That kind of sufficiency belongs only to absolutely effective grace, which is always victorious, whether through itself or through the combination of circumstances.

31. Finally, God's graces are purely gifts, and creatures have no claim on them. We can't fully explain how God chooses to distribute them by appealing to his foreknowledge (whether absolute or conditional) of how men are going to act in the future; but we mustn't think of them as absolute ·or arbitrary· decrees for which there are no rational grounds. As for God's foreknowledge of our faith or good works: it is quite true that God has chosen only those whose faith and charity he foresaw, foreseeing that he would endow them with faith. But the old question comes up again: Why will God make a gift of faith or of good works to some people and not to others? ·A difficulty about this arises from the fact that grace is effective in a man only to the extent that he brings something of himself to it·. Although to act well a man needs to be stimulated to the good, and converted, he must also then do it ·by means of his own resources·, and men vary in what their inner resources are, corresponding to how they vary in what grace is given them. So included in God's knowledge is not only his foresight of faith and of good deeds, but also his foresight of what a man himself will contribute towards them—his natural dispositions in that direction. It seems to many thinkers that we could say this: God sees what a man·'s natural dispositions will be,

and thus what he· would do without grace or extraordinary assistance, or at least what he will contribute from his own side in addition to anything that may be contributed by grace. So God could have decided to give grace to those whose natural dispositions were the best, or at any rate were the least imperfect or sinful. But if that were so, those natural dispositions, to the extent that they are good, are also the effect of grace (ordinary grace, this time), because ·in this respect too· God has favoured some people more than others. Now, since according to this doctrine, God knows perfectly well that the natural advantages he gives will be the ground for his grace or extraordinary help, doesn't everything in the end depend on his mercy? Well, we don't know how or how much God takes account of natural dispositions in his dispensing of grace. So I think that the most exact and the safest thing to say is what is dictated by my principles (and I have already said it once), namely: Among possible beings there must be the person of Peter or of John whose notion or idea contains this whole sequence of ordinary and extraordinary graces, and all the rest of these events with their circumstances; and from amongst an infinity of other equally possible people it pleased God to choose that person for actual existence. After this it seems that there is nothing more to ask, and that all the difficulties disappear. For as to this single great question why it pleased God to choose this person from among all other possible persons, it would be very unreasonable not to be satisfied with the general reasons I have given, the details being beyond us. So, instead of having recourse to •an absolute ·and arbitrary· decree that is unreasonable because there are no reasons for it, or to •reasons that fail to resolve the difficulty because they need reasons in their turn, it would be best to say in agreement with St. Paul that there are •certain great reasons for God's choices, reasons of wisdom or of fitness that are unknown to mortals; God has conformed to these reasons, which are founded on the general order whose aim is the greatest perfection of the universe. The themes of this Discourse—the glory of God and the manifestation of his justice, his mercy and his perfections generally, and finally the immense profundity of riches that enraptured the soul of St. Paul—all come down to that in the end.

32. I have to add only that the thoughts I have just been explaining—and in particular the great principle of

- •the perfection of God's operations, and that of
- •the notion of a substance containing all its events with all their circumstances

—so far from harming religion, serve to reinforce it. They blow away some very serious difficulties, inspire souls with love of God, and elevate minds to the understanding of incorporeal substances—doing all this far better than did any previous theories. For it is quite clear that all other substances depend on God, as thoughts emanate from our substance ·and in that way depend on it·; that God is all in all, and is intimately united to all created things in proportion to how perfect they are; that he alone by his influence determines them from outside. ·Elaborating this last point·: If to act on something is to affect it immediately ·i.e. directly·—which is correct in the ·strict· language of metaphysics—it can be said that in this sense *only God* acts on me and can do me good or harm. Other substances ·cannot, strictly speaking, help or harm me, because they· contribute only to ·God's· reason for ·making· those changes. ·The other substances do *come into* those reasons·, because God takes account of all substances when he shares out his blessings and makes them adjust to one another. So it is he alone who produces the connection or communication [= something like 'interplay'] among substances: he brings it about that the states of one coincide or agree with those of another, and

as a result that one substance can correctly perceive what state another is in. But we needn't always mention the universal cause in particular cases; and in common parlance the items that we say 'act on' a given substance ·putting it into a certain state· are the ones that enter into God's reasons ·for putting it into that state·, in the sense that I explained above. We can also see that every substance has a perfect spontaneity, that everything that happens to it is a consequence of its •idea or of its •nature. and that nothing affects it from outside except God alone. (In substances with intellect, this spontaneity becomes freedom.) This is why a certain person of very lofty mind and revered holiness used to say that the soul should often think as though there were only God and it in the world. [Garber says that this probably refers to St. Theresa.] Nothing can make us understand immortality better than this independence and extent of the soul, which absolutely shelters it from everything external, since it alone constitutes its whole world, and together with God is sufficient for itself. It is possible for the soul to come to an end through absolute annihilation; but its coming to end in any *other* way—·being destroyed by dissolution, through damage, like a machine·—is just as impossible as it is that the world should destroy itself unaided. Changes in the extended mass we call our body could not have any effect on the soul, nor could the dissolution of that body destroy what is indivisible, ·namely, the soul·.

33. We also see how to clear up that great mystery of the union of the soul and the body: how does it come about that the passive and active states [or: the undergoings and doings] of the one are accompanied by active and passive states—or anyway by corresponding states—in the other? ·This is a mystery because· it is utterly inconceivable that the one should influence the other, and it is not reasonable to fall back on the extraordinary operation of the universal cause—·God·—to explain normal everyday events. Here, however, is the true explanation ·of those events·. I have said that whatever takes place in the soul or in any substance is a consequence of its notion, so that the mere idea or essence of the soul carries with it ·the requirement· that all the soul's states or perceptions must arise spontaneously from its own nature. And they must do this in just such a way that they correspond, unaided, to whatever happens in the whole universe,

> but more particularly and more perfectly to what happens in the body that is assigned to the soul in question. That is because, in a way and for a time, the soul expresses the state of the universe through the relation of other bodies to its own.

This also tells us how our body *belongs to* us without being *attached to our essence*. And I believe that people who know how to think long and hard will favour my principles for just that reason: that they will be able easily to see what the connection between soul and body consists in, a connection that seems otherwise to be inexplicable. We can also see that the perceptions of our senses, even when they are vivid, must necessarily contain some confused feeling. For since all the bodies in the universe are in sympathy [= 'harmony', 'correspondence'], our body receives the impressions of all the others, and although our senses •are related to everything, our soul cannot possibly •attend to each particular thing. Thus our confused feelings result from a downright infinite jumble of perceptions. In somewhat the same way the confused murmur that people hear when nearing the sea shore comes from the putting together of the reverberations of countless waves. For if several perceptions don't fit together so as to make one, and no one of them stands out above the rest, and the impressions they make are all just about equally strong and equally capable of catching the soul's attention,

it can perceive them only confusedly.

34. ·In this section I use the notion of *unum per se*, a Latin phrase meaning 'a unity through itself'. This applies to anything whose intrinsic nature makes it one, single, an individual, as distinct from something that is not inherently *one* though it may suit us to treat it as *one*. Each organism is a *unum per se*; a pile of leaves or a gallon of water is not·. If we suppose that bodies that compose a *unum per se*, such as ·the body of· a man, are substances and that they have substantial forms, and that lower animals have souls, we must acknowledge that these souls and substantial forms cannot completely come to an end, any more than, in the view of other philosophers, atoms or the ultimate parts of matter can come to an end. For no substance ever comes to an end, though a substance may greatly alter. These ·souls or substantial forms of lower animals· also express the whole universe, although more imperfectly than minds do. But the principal difference ·between them and minds· is that they don't know what they are or what they do, and so—not being able to look into themselves reflectively—they can't discover necessary and universal truths. ·That is because the way to discover necessary truths is to look into oneself and see how one's ideas are inter-related·. For lack of such self-reflection, they have no moral quality; which means that as they pass through hundreds of transformations (as when a caterpillar changes into a butterfly), it would make no moral or practical difference if we said that they cease to exist. We can even say that they really do cease to exist, as when we say that bodies perish through dissolution. But the thinking soul, which knows what it is and can say that pregnant word 'I', not only (as a matter of metaphysics) is much more enduring than the others, but also (as a matter of morals) endures and constitutes the same person. For it is memory, or the knowledge of this I, which makes the thinking soul capable of punishment and reward. Similarly, the immortality required by morality and religion doesn't consist merely in the lasting-for-ever that all substances have, for that would not be something to hope for if it didn't involve the memory of what one has been. Suppose that someone could suddenly become the King of China, but only on condition of forgetting what he had been, as if he had just been born all over again. Would it not in practice, or in terms of perceivable effects, be the same as if he had been annihilated and a King of China created then and there? And that is something that that individual could have no reason to want.

35. ·In those remarks I have been separating morality from metaphysics; but in some contexts we must run the two in a single harness·. To show by natural reasons that God will preserve for ever not only our substance, but also our person (that is, the memory and the knowledge of what we are—although clear knowledge of this is sometimes suspended in sleep or in fainting spells), we must unite morality with metaphysics. That is, we must think of God not only as the •root cause of all substances and of all beings, but also as the •leader of all persons or thinking substances, or as the absolute monarch of the most perfect city or republic—which is what the universe composed of the assembled totality of minds is. For God himself is the most accomplished of all minds, as he is also the greatest of all beings. For minds certainly are the most perfect of beings, and express God best. If bodies are only true phenomena—·that is, reliable appearances to minds·—then minds are the only substances there are; and if they are not that, they are at any rate the most perfect. And since—as I have sufficiently explained—the expressing of God and the universe is the whole nature, goal, virtue or function of substances, there is no room to doubt that substances that do this knowing

what they are doing, and able to understand great truths about God and the universe, express them incomparably better than the natures that belong to lower animals and are incapable of knowing any truths, or—·lower down still·—to things that lack feeling and knowledge altogether. The difference between substances that think and ones that don't is as great as that between a mirror and someone who sees. God can have conversations (so to speak) with minds, and can even enter into society with them by telling them what he thinks and wants—doing this in a special way that lets them know and love their benefactor. Since he himself is the greatest and wisest of minds, it is natural to think that minds—thinking substances—must concern God infinitely more than all other things, which can serve only as the tools of minds. Similarly, we see that wise folk always value a man infinitely more than any other thing, however precious it may be; and it seems that the greatest satisfaction an otherwise contented soul can have is to see itself loved by others. Between our love for one another and our love for God, however, there is a difference. His glory and our worship could not add to his satisfaction, because his sovereign and perfect happiness *leads to* the knowledge that created things have, and so cannot be partly *caused by* that knowledge. However, whatever is good and rational in finite spirits is also possessed by God in a suitably higher form; and just as we would praise a king who preferred to save the life of a man rather than of the most precious and rarest of his animals, so we should not doubt that the most enlightened and just of all monarchs would think the same.

36. Minds are actually the most perfectible of substances, and their perfections have the special feature that they obstruct one another the least, or rather that they help one another—for only the most virtuous could be the most perfect friends. From which it plainly follows that God, who always aims at the greatest perfection in general, will have the greatest care for minds, and will give to them (not only in general, but also to each particular mind) the highest level of perfection that the universal harmony will allow. It can be said indeed that God's being a mind is what qualifies him as the reason why things exist. If he couldn't voluntarily choose the best, there would be no reason why one possible thing should exist rather than some other. So of all the features of created things that God takes into account, he attends first and foremost to the quality ·that he shares with them, namely that· of being a Mind. [In this section, mind/Mind tracks Leibniz's *esprit/Esprit*.] Only minds are made in his image, are of his race (so to speak), are like children of his house, for only they can serve him freely, and act in imitation of the divine nature, knowing what they are doing. A single mind is worth a whole world, since it not only expresses the world, but also knows it, and governs itself there after the fashion of God. Thus, it seems that although each substance expresses the entire universe, Minds express God rather than the world, whereas other substances express the world rather than God. And this nobility in the nature of Minds—bringing them as near to divinity as is possible for mere created things—leads to God's deriving infinitely more glory from them than from any other beings. That is why this moral quality of God's, which makes him the lord or King of Minds, is one in which he takes a quite special interest—an interest that might be called personal. It is in this that he humanizes himself, willingly lays himself open to being thought of in anthropomorphic ways, and enters into society with us as a prince does with his subjects. This concern is so dear to him that the happy and flourishing state of his empire, which consists in the greatest possible happiness of the inhabitants, becomes the highest of his laws. For happiness is to people what perfection is to beings ·in general·. And if

the ultimate explanation of the existence of the real world is the decree that it should have the greatest perfection that it can, then the ultimate aim for the moral world—the city of God, the noblest part of the universe—should be to infuse it with the greatest possible happiness. So we mustn't doubt that God—in order that his city should never lose any person, as the world never loses any substance—has arranged everything so that Minds not only (of course) can live for ever, but also retain for ever their moral quality. Consequently they will always know what they are; otherwise they wouldn't be liable for reward or punishment, which are essential to any republic, and especially to the most perfect one, where nothing could be neglected. In fact since God is at once the most fair and mild of kings, and since he demands of his subjects only a good will, provided it is sincere and serious, they couldn't wish for a better condition. To make them perfectly happy, God asks only that they love him.

37. Ancient philosophers knew very little of these important truths. Only Jesus Christ expressed them divinely well, and in such a clear and down-to-earth way that even the dullest minds could understand them. Thus his gospel has entirely changed the face of human affairs. He has told us about the kingdom of heaven, that perfect republic of Minds meriting the title 'City of God', whose admirable laws he has revealed to us. He alone has shown how much God loves us, and how exactly he has provided for everything that affects us: •that, caring for sparrows, he will not neglect the rational creatures who are infinitely dearer to him; •that all the hairs of our heads are counted; •that the sky and the earth will perish before any change in the word of God or in any of the conditions for our salvation; •that God cares more about the least of thinking souls than about the whole machine of the world; •that we need not fear those who can destroy bodies but could not harm souls, because God alone can make souls happy or unhappy; •that the souls of the just are, in his hands, safe from all the revolutions of the universe, since nothing can act on them except God alone; •that none of our actions is forgotten; •that everything is taken into account, even an idle remark or a well used spoonful of water; and, finally, •that all must result in the greatest well-being for good people, that the righteous shall be like suns, and that we have never experienced or conceived anything giving us a fore-taste of the happiness that God prepares for those who love him.

Leibniz's summaries

1. God is perfect, and does everything in the most desirable way.

2. Against those who maintain that there is no goodness in God's works, and that the rules of goodness and beauty are arbitrary.

3. Against those who think that God could have done better.

4. The love of God requires complete contentment and acceptance with regard to what he has done, but we don't have to be quietists.

5. What the rules of perfection of God's conduct consist in; the simplicity of means is balanced against the richness of ends.

6. God does nothing disorderly, and it isn't possible even to *feign* events that are not regular.

7. Miracles conform to the general order, although they run counter to subordinate rules. What God wants and what he allows; general and particular will.

8. In order to distinguish between God's actions and those of created things, it is explained what the notion of an individual substance consists in.

9. Each substance expresses the whole universe in its own way; and everything that happens to it is included in its notion, with all the circumstances and ·because it expresses everything else· the whole series of external things.

10. The doctrine of substantial forms has some value, but such forms make no difference to observable events, and shouldn't be used to explain particular effects.

11. The reflections of the so-called Scholastic theologians and philosophers should not be completely despised.

12. The notions that make up extension involve something imaginary, and can't constitute the substance of body.

13. Since the individual notion of each person involves once and for all everything that will ever happen to him, we can see in that notion the a priori proofs or reasons for the occurrence of every event—seeing why one thing happens rather than another. But although these truths are certain, they are still contingent, for they are based on the free will of God and of created things. It is true that there are always reasons for their choices, but those reasons incline without necessitating.

14. God produces a variety of substances according to his different views of the universe; and he intervenes so as to bring it about that the particular nature of each substance makes what happens to it correspond to what happens to all the others, without their directly acting on one another.

15. When one finite substance 'acts on' another, all that happens is that the first undergoes an increase in the degree of its expression while the other undergoes a decrease, which happens because God formed them in advance so that they would fit together.

16. Our essence expresses everything, so it expresses God's extraordinary concourse. But our nature or clear expression is finite, and follows certain subordinate rules; it doesn't extend far enough to take in God's extraordinary concourse.

17. An example of a subordinate rule of natural law, which shows that God always systematically conserves the same *force*, but not (contrary to the Cartesians and others) the same quantity of *motion*.

18. The distinction between force and quantity of motion is important. For one thing, it shows that to explain how bodies behave we must bring in metaphysical considerations apart from extension.

19. The usefulness of final causes in physical science.

20. A memorable passage by Socrates in Plato's *Phaedo* against over-materialist philosophers.

21. If mechanical rules depended only on geometry and not on metaphysics, the observed facts would be quite different.

22. Reconciliation of two methods, one working through final causes and the other through efficient ones, in order to satisfy both sides: those who explain Nature mechanically, and those who appeal to immaterial natures.

23. Returning to immaterial substances, I explain how God acts on the mind's understanding, and discuss whether we always have an idea of what we are thinking about.

24. What vivid and dark, clear and confused, adequate and inadequate, intuitive and suppositive knowledge are; nominal, real, causal and essential definition.

25. In what cases our knowledge is combined with the contemplation of an idea.

26. That we have within us all ideas; Plato's doctrine of reminiscence.

27. How our soul can be compared with a blank tablet, and in what way our notions come from the senses.

28. God alone is the immediate object of our perceptions, who exists outside of us, and he alone is our light.

29. However, we think directly through our own ideas and not through God's.

2

30. How God inclines our soul without necessitating it; that we have no right to complain; we should not ask why Judas sinned, since that free act is included in his notion; we should only ask why Judas the sinner was admitted into existence in preference to some other possible people. Original imperfection or limitation, prior to sin; the different levels of grace.

31. The reasons for election, foreseen faith, absolute decrees. Everything comes down to God's reason for deciding to admit into existence a certain possible person, whose notion contains a certain series of graces and free actions. Which removes the difficulties at a stroke.

32. The usefulness of these principles in matters of piety and religion.

33. Explaining the communication between the soul and the body, which has been taken to be inexplicable or miraculous. The origin of confused perceptions.

34. How minds differ from other substances, souls or substantial forms. The immortality that we require implies memory.

35. The excellence of minds; God attends to them ahead of other creatures; minds express God rather than the world, and other simple substances express the world rather than God.

36. God is the monarch of the most perfect republic, composed of all minds, and the happiness of this city of God is his main aim.

37. Jesus Christ revealed to men the wonderful mystery and laws of the Kingdom of Heaven, and the splendour of the supreme happiness that God prepares for those who love him.

An Enquiry into the Sources of Morals

David Hume

1751

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[Brackets] enclose editorial explanations. Small ·dots· enclose material that has been added, but can be read as though it were part of the original text. Occasional •bullets, and also indenting of passages that are not quotations, are meant as aids to grasping the structure of a sentence or a thought. Every four-point ellipsis . . . . indicates the omission of a brief passage that seems to present more difficulty than it is worth. Larger omissions are reported within square brackets, in normal-sized type.—Hume's title for this work is *An Enquiry Concerning the Principles of Morals*. In his day a 'principle' was often not a kind of •proposition but rather a •'source of activity' or •'activator' or the like. On page 3 he calls morality an 'active principle', and on page 29 he writes that a certain 'principle still exerts its active energy'—he isn't talking about the active energy of a *proposition*! This sense of 'principle' is what is meant in the title of this work, which on pages 4, 56 and 65 Hume describes as an enquiry into 'the origin of morals'.

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Most of the principles and reasonings contained in this volume were published in a work in three volumes, called *A Treatise of Human Nature*, a work which the author had projected before he left college, and which he wrote and published soon after. It wasn't a success, and he came to realize that he had gone to the press too early; so he re-worked the whole thing in the following pieces, in which he hopes to have corrected some faults in his earlier reasoning and more in his writing. [The *Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding*, the *Dissertation on the Passions*, and the present work were published in one volume.] Yet several writers who have honoured the author's philosophy with answers have taken care to aim all their guns at that juvenile work which the author has never acknowledged, and have gloated over victories that they imagined they had won against it. That is dishonest and unfair, and a striking example of the polemical tricks that a bigoted zeal thinks it is entitled to employ. From now on, the author wants the following pieces to be regarded as the only source for his philosophical sentiments and principles. [In Hume's day a 'sentiment' could be •a view/opinion/belief, or a •feeling. Why not replace each occurrence of 'sentiment' by 'belief' or by 'feeling', as is appropriate in the given context? For two reasons. •Hume sometimes seems to make 'sentiment' sprawl across both its meanings. •Some things that many people regard as beliefs are, in Hume's view, really feelings; and with a given occurrence of 'sentiment' it's not always clear how far he means to be showing his hand just there. So in this version 'sentiment' is never replaced. In cases where—as on page 2—it is both sure and important that it means 'feeling', that is indicated by the addition of '•or feeling•'.]

Section 1: The general sources of morals

The disputes that one has with •men who are stubbornly obstinate in their principles are the most tiresome of all; except perhaps for the disputes with •perfectly insincere people who don't really believe the opinions they defend, but engage in the controversy because they enjoy it or because they want to show how much cleverer and more ingenious they are than the rest of mankind. Both kinds of disputant show the same blind adherence to their own arguments, the same contempt for their opponents, and the same emotional intensity in pushing their bad arguments and false doctrines. Neither kind gets through reasoning the views he is defending, so it's no use expecting to be able to move them from falsehood to truth by reasoning; the only 'logic' they'll be moved by is the 'logic' that speaks to the feelings!

Those who have denied the reality of moral distinctions can be classified among the insincere disputants. It simply isn't conceivable that any human being could ever *seriously believe* that all kinds of people and all kinds of behaviour are equally entitled to everyone's affection and regard. Nature will make one man so different from another, and this difference is made so much greater still by upbringing, example and habit, that when we compare the two men we *have to* be aware of how unalike they are. That they are somewhat different couldn't be questioned by the most thorough sceptic or denied by the most confident dogmatist. However numb

a person is with regard to his fellow men, he must often be visited by thoughts of right and wrong; and however firmly wedded he is to his prejudices, he must be aware that the other people are also given to such thoughts. So the only way to •convert an antagonist of this kind—·i.e. one who denies that there are moral differences between man and man·—is to •leave him to himself! When he finds that nobody is willing to argue with him, he will probably end up—out of sheer boredom—coming over to the side of common sense and reason.

A *serious* controversy has started up recently—one that is worth engaging in—about the general foundation of morals:

- •Are morals derived from reason or from sentiment (·or feeling·)?
- •Do we get our knowledge of them by a chain of argument and induction, or by an immediate feeling and finer internal sense?
- •Should moral opinions (like all sound judgments of truth and falsehood) be the same for every rational intelligent being; or are they (like the perception of beauty and ugliness) based entirely on the particular make-up of the human species?

The ancient philosophers often *assert* that virtue is nothing but •conformity to reason; but their writings generally suggest that they *think* that morals derive their existence from •taste and sentiment. And on the other side, our modern enquirers talk a great deal about the 'beauty' of virtue and 'ugliness' of vice, ·seeming to imply that their basis is •sentiment or feeling·; but they have commonly tried to account for the virtue/vice distinction by metaphysical •reasonings and by deductions from the most abstract principles of the understanding. There has been so much confusion in these subjects that a really important opposition between two systems. . . .could pass unnoticed—until recently, that is. The elegant Lord Shaftesbury, who first called this distinction to our attention, and who in general accepted the principles of the ancients, is himself not entirely free from the same confusion.

Admittedly there are plausible arguments on both sides of the question. On the side of the view that moral distinctions are discernible by pure reason there is this line of thought:

> Consider the many disputes—in everyday life as well as in philosophy—regarding morals; the long chains of proofs that are often produced on both sides; the examples cited, the authorities appealed to, the analogies employed, the fallacies detected, the inferences drawn, and the various conclusions tailored to fit the principles they are supposed to go with. Where does all this come from if morals aren't in the domain of reason? Truth is disputable; taste isn't.
>
> > **(1)** What exists in the nature of things is the standard of our •judgment.
> >
> > **(2)** What each man feels within himself is the standard of •sentiment ·or feeling·.
>
> [A note on the two sides of the contrast Hume is drawing here. **(1)** In his time 'judgment' could stand for thinking that P, coming to the conclusion that P, believing that P. There was nothing specially moral about the word's meaning, as there is for us when, for example, we describe someone as 'judgmental'. **(2)** This is a place where 'sentiment' clearly means 'feeling' and not 'belief' (see note on page 1). These two points together help to explain why this work could not have been entitled 'An Enquiry into the Sources of Moral Judgments'.] Propositions in geometry can be proved, systems in physics can be controverted; but the harmony of verse, the tenderness of passion, the brilliancy of wit, must give immediate pleasure. No man *reasons* about someone else's *beauty*, but we often reason concerning the justice or injustice of

someone's actions. In every criminal trial the prisoner aims **(1)** to disprove the accusations about what he has actually done, and **(2)** to show that even if these actions were real they could be justified as innocent and lawful. Everyone knows that **(1)** is settled by deductions of the understanding; how can we suppose that in settling **(2)** a different faculty of the mind is employed?

On the other side, those who hold that all moral views are matters of sentiment may say things like this:

It is impossible for reason ever to draw moral conclusions. The essence of virtue is that it is *amiable* [here = 'lovable'], the essence of vice is that it is *odious*. Could reason or argumentation tell us which items are to be labelled 'amiable' and which 'odious'—settling in advance that *this* must produce love, and *that* must produce hatred? What reason can we ever give for the facts about what we love and what we hate except the basic structure of the human mind?

The purpose of all moral theorizing is to teach us our duty, and by presenting the ugliness of •vice and the beauty of •virtue to get us into the habit of avoiding •one and embracing •the other. Could we ever expect to achieve *that* through inferences and conclusions of the understanding, which don't in themselves have any hold on our affections and don't set in motion our active powers? Inferences etc. reveal truths; but they can't influence our behaviour because the truths they reveal are indifferent, and don't create either desire or aversion. [Here and in the next paragraph, 'indifferent' means 'not involving any kind of *for* or *against*'.] If •something is honourable, fair, appropriate, noble or generous, it **takes possession of the heart**, and stirs us to embrace and maintain •it. On the other hand, if something is intelligible, evident, probable or true, that **procures only the cool assent of our understanding**. . . .

If you extinguish all the warm feelings and attitudes in favour of virtue, and all disgust or aversion to vice, thus making people totally indifferent towards these distinctions, the result will be that morality is no longer a *practical* study, having no tendency to regulate our lives and actions.

These arguments (and many more that might be produced) are so plausible that I'm inclined to suspect that the arguments on *both* sides are solid and satisfactory, and that •reason and •sentiment work together in almost all moral judgments and conclusions. ·But, if I am right, they enter the picture in different ways·. There is the final judgment, which

- •pronounces people and actions amiable or odious, praiseworthy or blameable,
- •stamps on them the mark of honour or infamy, approval or censure,
- •renders morality an active principle, and
- •makes virtue our happiness, and vice our misery.

This final moral conclusion depends on some internal sense or feeling that nature has made universal in the whole species; for only a feeling could have an influence such as I have described. But we often find that in order to reach this sentiment ·or feeling·, and to pick out accurately the thing the feeling is *about*, we have to •go through much reasoning, •make fine distinctions, •draw sound conclusions, •compare things that are not greatly alike, •examine complicated relations, and •settle various factual matters. Some sorts of beauty, especially natural beauty, command our affection and approval when we first see them; and if something doesn't have this effect, there's no way for

reasoning to remedy the situation and make the item in question more in tune with our taste and sentiment. But there are many kinds of beauty, especially in the finer arts, where one has to use much reasoning if one is to have the right feeling; and a wrong liking ·for a work of art· can often be corrected by argument and reflection. There are good reasons to think that moral beauty is of the latter kind, and can't get a suitable influence on the human mind unless it gets help from our intellectual faculties.

But although this question about which of our faculties is at work in morals is challenging and important, I don't need to go into it any further here. What I *do* want to do in this enquiry is to discover the true origin of morals. If I have the good fortune to succeed in that, it won't be hard to see how far either sentiment or reason enters into all our moral judgment. (I'll return to that in Appendix 1.) To achieve my purpose, I'll try to follow a very simple method: I shall analyse the complex of mental qualities that we commonly call 'personal merit'. I shall consider every attribute of mind that makes a man an object either of •respect and affection or of •hatred and contempt, every habit or sentiment or ability which, if ascribed to any person, implies either •praise or •blame. . . . Everyone is alert to this difference, so I am pretty sure that I won't ever go seriously wrong in drawing up my lists, putting any item that I am thinking about into the wrong list. All I need do is to look into myself for a moment, and consider whether I would want to have this or that quality ascribed to me, and whether, if it were ascribed to me, that would come from a friend or from an enemy. The very nature of language guides us almost infallibly in forming a judgment of this kind; every language contains one set of words that are understood as approving, and another set that are understood as disapproving, and a quite casual acquaintance with the idiom enables us to collect and arrange the ·lists of· estimable and of blameable qualities of men, without having to *reason* about what we are doing. The only role of reasoning in this matter is to discover what is in common to the attributes that bring approval, and what is common to all that bring disapproval, and on that basis to reach the foundation of ethics, and find the universal sources from which all blame or approval is ultimately derived. As this is a question of fact, not of abstract theory, the only way we can expect to succeed is by following the experimental method, deriving •general maxims from a comparison of •particular instances. The other scientific method, in which a general abstract principle is first established and then a variety of inferences and conclusions are drawn from it, may be intrinsically better, but it isn't as well suited to the imperfection of human nature, and is a common source of illusion and error in morals as well as in other subjects. Men are now cured of their passion for *hypotheses* and *systems* in natural philosophy [= 'natural science'], and won't listen to any arguments that aren't derived from experience. It's high time they tried a similar reformation in all moral proceedings, and rejected every system of ethics, however subtle or ingenious, that isn't based on fact and observation. I shall begin my enquiry by considering the social virtues, *benevolence* and *justice*. Getting clear about them will probably give us an opening through which the other virtues can be accounted for.

Section 2: Benevolence

Part 1

·How benevolence is valued·

You may well think that there is no need to *show* that the benevolent or softer affections are estimable, and always attract the approval and good-will of mankind. All languages have equivalents of the words 'sociable', 'good-natured', 'humane', 'merciful', 'grateful', 'friendly', 'generous' and 'beneficent', and such words always express the highest merit that human nature can attain. When these amiable qualities are accompanied by ·noble· birth and power and distinguished abilities, and display themselves in the good government or useful instruction of mankind, they seem even to raise the possessors of them above the rank of *human* nature, making them somewhat approach the status of *divine*. Great ability, undaunted courage, tremendous success—these may expose a hero or politician to the public's envy and ill-will; but as soon as 'humane' and 'beneficent' are added to the praises—when instances are displayed of mercy, gentleness, or friendship—envy itself is silent, or joins in with the general voice of approval and applause.

When Pericles, the great Athenian statesman and general, was on his death-bed, his surrounding friends—thinking he was unconscious—began to express their sorrow by listing their dying patron's great qualities and successes, his conquests and victories, his unusually long time in power, and his nine trophies erected ·to celebrate victories· over the enemies of the republic. In fact the dying hero was conscious, heard all of this, and joined in: 'You are forgetting the highest of my praises. While dwelling on those common advantages, in which luck had a principal share, you haven't observed that no citizen ever wore mourning because of me.'

In men of more ordinary talents and abilities, the social virtues become, if possible, still more essentially needed if a person is to be regarded with approval, because in that case there is no high distinction to compensate for any lack of social virtues, or to preserve the person from our severest hatred as well as contempt. Cicero has written that high ambition and great courage are apt in less perfect characters to degenerate into a turbulent ferocity. What such less perfect people mainly need are the softer and more social virtues, which are good and amiable in anyone who has them.

According to ·the Latin writer· Venal, what is chiefly *good* about someone's having great •powers and abilities is that this makes his •benevolence more extensive, giving him greater opportunities to spread his kindly influence than lesser men have. Let us face it: the only way a man can truly enjoy the advantages of being distinguished in other ways is by doing good. His high position in itself merely exposes him to danger and tempest. His only real privilege is his ability to provide shelter to inferiors who entrust themselves to his cover and protection. But I'm forgetting that it's not my present business to recommend generosity and benevolence, or to paint in their true colours all the genuine charms of the social virtues. These virtues sufficiently engage every heart when they are first understood, and it's hard not to break out in praise of them whenever they crop up in discourse or reasoning. But my object here is the theoretical rather than the practical part of morals, so I'll just say this, expecting everyone to agree: No qualities are more entitled to the general good-will and approval of mankind than beneficence and humanity, friendship and gratitude, natural affection

and public spirit, or anything that comes from a tender sympathy with others and a generous concern for mankind in general. Whenever these appear, they seem to inject themselves, so to speak, into each beholder, causing *him* to have some of these the same favourable and affectionate sentiments. [Throughout this work, Hume uses 'sympathy' in its basic original sense of 'fellow-feeling'. In this sense of the word, I can have sympathy with you in your happiness, or—see 'contagion and sympathy' on page 49—be irritable in sympathy with your bad temper.]

Part 2

·Benevolence and utility·

When we are praising a humane and beneficent man, we always emphasize the happiness and satisfaction that society gets from his good works. We are apt to say that he is dear to his parents not only because of the tie of blood but also, and more, because of his pious attachment to them and his dutiful care for them. His children never feel his authority except when it is exerted for their benefit. With him, the ties of love are consolidated by beneficence and friendship. The ties of friendship approach those of love and inclination, because of the spirit in which he does good things for his friends. For his servants and dependents he is a sure resource; and they no longer dread the power of fortune except insofar as it concerns his welfare. From him the hungry receive food, the naked receive clothing, the ignorant or lazy receive skill and work. He is like the sun in being an inferior minister [= 'subordinate agent'] of providence; he cheers, invigorates and sustains the world around him.

If he is confined to private life, his sphere of activity is smaller but his influence is all benign and gentle. If he is exalted into a higher position, mankind and posterity reap the fruit of his labours. These modes of praise are *always* employed, and with success, when we want to inspire esteem for someone. Can't we infer from this that the utility resulting from the social virtues—·the good that is done under their influence·— is at least a part of their merit, and is one source of the approval and respect that everyone gives to them? When we recommend even an animal or a plant as useful and beneficial, we applaud and praise it in a manner suited to its nature. Just as, on the other hand, when we think about the harmful influence of any kind of plant or animal, this always creates in us a sentiment ·or feeling· of aversion. The eye is pleased with the view of corn-fields and loaded vine-yards, horses grazing and flocks pasturing; but it avoids the view of briars and brambles that provide shelter for wolves and snakes.

If a machine or piece of furniture or article of clothing or house is well designed for use and convenience, to that extent it is beautiful, and is contemplated with pleasure and approval. With this kind of thing, an experienced eye will detect many excellences that ignorant and uninstructed people would miss. Can anything stronger be said in praise of an occupation—such as merchandising or manufacturing—than to point out the good it does for society? And won't a monk or an inquisitor be enraged if we treat his religious organisation as useless or harmful to mankind?

The historian rejoices in displaying the benefits arising from his labours. The writer of romances does what he can to lessen or deny the bad consequences that are ascribed to the kind of thing he writes.

In general, what praise is implied in the simple epithet 'useful'! What reproach in the contrary!

Cicero in opposition to the Epicureans said: 'Your Gods are not entitled to any worship or adoration, whatever imaginary perfections you endow them with. They are totally useless and inactive. Even the Egyptians, whom you so

much ridicule, never treated any animal as sacred except on account of its utility.'

The sceptics assert that the all religious worship originated from the utility of inanimate objects, such as the sun and moon, to the support and well-being of mankind. (This is an absurd theory of the origin of religion, ·but its sheer existence supports my thesis about the central place of utility, doing-good, bringing-benefit, to our approval and admiration·.) This is also the reason that historians commonly give for the deification of eminent heroes and legislators.

To plant a tree, to cultivate a field, to beget children—these are all meritorious acts, according to the religion of Zoroaster.

·Empirical evidence of failures of benevolence·

In moral judgments, this matter of public utility is always centrally in view; and whenever every-day or philosophical disputes arise concerning the limits of duty, by far the most certain way of settling the disputed question is to ascertain how each side of it relates to the true interests of mankind. If we find that a misreading of the evidence has led us to accept a false opinion ·about human interests·, as soon as further experience and sounder reasoning have given us a more correct view of the facts, we retract our first sentiment and re-adjust the line between moral good and evil. ·Here are four examples of this kind of shift in moral opinion·. **(1)** Giving alms to common beggars is naturally praised, because it seems to bring relief to those who are poor and distressed; but when we see that alms-giving encourages idleness and debauchery, we regard that kind of charity as a weakness rather than a virtue. **(2)** Tyrannicide, i.e. the assassination of usurpers and oppressive rulers, was highly praised in ancient times, because it •freed mankind from many of these monsters, and •seemed to keep in awe other rulers who couldn't be reached by the sword or the dagger. But history and experience have since convinced us that this practice makes rulers more suspicious and cruel; so that a Tiberius and a Brutes [two high-minded killers of their rulers], though treated with indulgence because of the prejudices of their times, are now regarded as *not* people to imitate. **(3)** Generosity in rulers is regarded as a sign of beneficence; but when it has the result that the homely bread of honest and hard-working people is often converted into luxury-foods for wasteful idlers, we soon retract our thoughtless praises. The regrets of a monarch for having lost a day were noble and generous; but if he had intended to spend the day in acts of generosity to his greedy courtiers, it was better lost than misused in that way. **(4)** Luxury, or a refinement on the pleasures and conveniences of life, has for a long time been regarded as the source of every corruption in government, and the ultimate cause of faction, sedition, civil wars, and the total loss of liberty. [Hume wrote 'the immediate cause' etc.; presumably a slip.] So it was seen by everyone as a vice, and was attacked by all satirists and severe moralists. Those who show (or try to show) that such refinements tend to increase industry, civility and arts are offering new rules for our •moral as well as our •political sentiments, representing as praise-worthy, or ·at least· as innocent, behaviour that had formerly been regarded as harmful and blameable. [This refers to Mandeville's *Fable of the Bees: Private Vices Public Benefits*.]

Taking all of this together, it seems undeniable that •nothing can bestow more merit on any person that his having a very high degree of the sentiment of benevolence; and that at least •a *part* of the merit of this sentiment comes from its probable consequences for the interests of our species and the happiness of human society. When we think about a benevolent person, we carry our view of •his character and disposition forward to •their good

consequences; and we look with satisfaction and pleasure at anything that has such a benign influence and contributes to such a desirable end. The social virtues are *never* viewed as barren and unfruitful; we *always* think of them along with their beneficial tendencies, seeing their gentle reign over the hearts of men as a cause of the happiness of mankind, the order of society, the harmony of families, the mutual support of friends.

How much of their merit ought we to ascribe to their utility? I'll be better placed to answer that when some other things have been dealt with (Sections 3 and 4). Why do the good consequences of the social virtues have such a command over our esteem and approval? I shall address that in Section 5.

Section 3: Justice

Part 1

The proposition that

- Justice is useful to society, and thus at least *part* of its merit must come from that fact

doesn't need to be argued for ·because it is so obviously true·. Not so the proposition that

- Public utility is the *sole* origin of justice, and thoughts about its beneficial consequences are the *sole* basis for its merit.

This proposition is more challenging and important, so it better deserves to be looked into with care.

·Justice and abundance·

Let's suppose that nature has given the human race such a profuse abundance of all external conveniences that all of us, without any care or industry on our part, can be confident that we are fully supplied with whatever our hungriest appetites can want or our most luxurious imagination can wish or desire. Let us suppose that man is so situated that:

- His natural beauty surpasses all acquired ornaments.
- The perpetual mildness of the seasons makes clothes unnecessary.
- Raw fruit and vegetables provide delicious food.
- The clear fountain provides the richest beverage.
- No hard work is needed—no ploughing, no navigation.
- Music, poetry and meditating are his only business.
- Conversation, fun and friendship are his sole amusement.

It seems clear that in such a happy state every other social virtue would flourish and be increased tenfold; but the cautious, jealous virtue of *justice* would never once have been dreamed of. What point would there be in dividing up goods, when everyone already has more than enough? Why institute *property* when there can't possibly be any harm ·in not doing so·? Why call this object 'mine' when just by stretching out my hand I could get another one that is like it and equally valuable? In this state of affairs, justice would be totally useless; it would be an idle ceremonial, having no place in the list of virtues.

Even in the present needy condition of mankind, we see that wherever any benefit is bestowed by nature in an unlimited abundance, we leave it in common among the whole human race, not dividing it up in terms of right and property. •Water and •air, though more needed than anything else, are not claimed as the property of individuals; and no-one can commit an injustice by the most lavish use and enjoyment of •these blessings. In large fertile countries with few inhabitants, land is seen in the same way. And those who defend the liberty of the seas have as their principal theme the unexhausted use of them in navigation—·i.e. the fact that however many ships there are, the world's oceans don't get used up·. If the benefits of navigation (·such as trade and treasure-finding·) were equally inexhaustible, those defenders of the liberty of the seas would never had any opponents, and no nation would ever have claimed a separate, exclusive dominion over ·some part of· the ocean.

It can happen in some countries at some times that there is ownership of water but not of land (see *Genesis* 12 and 21). That happens if there is more land than the inhabitants can use, and water is scarce and hard to find.

·Justice and benevolence·

Here is a second supposition. Let us suppose that the human race, while having the same needs and shortages that it actually has, had a mind that was so enlarged, so full of friendship and generosity, that each man had the utmost concern for every man, feeling no more concern for his own interest than for the interests of his fellows. It seems obvious that this extensive benevolence would cancel the use of justice, and the divisions and barriers of property and obligation would never been thought of. Why should I want a contract or a promise to bind someone else to do me some good, when I know that he already has the strongest inclination to seek my happiness, and would *unprompted* perform the desired service. ('What if his performing it would cause a greater loss to him than the benefit he would be bringing to you?' In that case he knows that my innate humanity and friendship will cause me to be the first to oppose this imprudent generosity.) Why place boundary-markers between my neighbour's field and mine, when my heart has made no division between my interests and his, and shares all his joys and sorrows with the same force and vivacity as if they were originally my own? [That is, if they had *begun* as my own, rather than *becoming* mine because my neighbour has them and I have a tender heart.] In this supposed state of affairs, every man is a second self to another [Hume presumably meant: 'to *every* other'], and would trust all his interests to the discretion of every man without jealousy, without partition, and without distinguishing one person from another. The whole human race would constitute a single family in which everything would be held in common, and be used freely, without regard to property; but cautiously too, with as much concern for the needs of each individual as if our own interests were intimately concerned.

Given what the human heart is actually like, it might be hard to find complete examples of such enlarged affections; but we may see approximations to it in *families*; and ·in any group· the stronger the mutual benevolence is among the individuals, the nearer the group comes ·to the no-need-for-justice condition·, until all distinctions of property are in a great measure lost and mixed up among them. The laws presume that the cement of friendship between a married couple is so strong as to abolish all division of possessions; and in many cases it actually *is* as strong as that. And it's a matter of empirical fact that during the ardour of new enthusiasms when every principle [see note on title page] is heated up into its most extreme form, reformers have frequently tried to ·abolish property, i.e.·

have community of goods; and what has led the imprudent fanatics to change course and restore the ideas of justice and of separate property—the only thing that *could* get them to do this—is their experience of the drawbacks that the no-property system has, because of the selfishness of men (who hid their selfishness during the revolution, or returned to being selfish after the revolutionary fuss had died down). That's a measure of how true it is that the virtue of justice derives its existence entirely from the needed things that it *does* for human interactions and the social state of mankind.

·JUSTICE AND SCARCITY·

To make this truth more obvious, let us reverse the suppositions we have been making, taking everything to the opposite extreme, and seeing what effect that would have in each case. Suppose a society suffers such a lack of all common necessities that even with the utmost frugality and industry most of them will die ·prematurely·, and everyone lives in extreme misery. I think you will readily agree that in such a pressing emergency the strict laws of justice will be suspended, being dislodged by the stronger motives of necessity and self-preservation. When a sailor whose ship is going down is in the water, is it a crime for him to seize whatever he can to keep him afloat, without regard to whose property it is—or *was*? If a besieged city is starving to death, can we imagine that any citizen will see a means of preservation within his reach ·and not take it·, losing his life because of his scrupulous regard for what in *other* situations would be the rules of property and justice? What that virtue is for, and what it tends to produce, is happiness and security through the preservation of order in society; but when a society is on the brink of perishing from extreme necessity, there is no greater evil to be feared from violence and injustice; and every man may now provide for himself by any means that prudence dictates and humanity permits. Even in cases of need that are less drastic than the one we have been supposing, the government opens granaries without the consent of their owners, on the correct assumption that the authority of the law can stretch that far as long as it does so in a fair way. Well, if any number of men came together without the tie of laws or civil jurisdiction, and suffered a famine, would it be regarded as criminal or injurious to divide up the available food *equally*, if this were done through power and even violence?

·JUSTICE AND MALEVOLENCE·

[A few lines down, Hume is probably using 'contempt' in a less active sense than we give the word today. In this milder sense, to have contempt for something is to regard it as negligible, to treat as of no account—thus many people's 'contempt for order', a soldier's 'contempt' for pain. Most occurrences of 'contempt' in this work do use it in our stronger or more active sense.] Now suppose that a virtuous man has the bad luck to fall into the society of ruffians, far removed from the protection of laws and government; how is he to behave in that miserable situation? He sees

- such ruthless and violent greed prevailing,
- such a disregard for fairness,
- such contempt for ·social· order,
- such stupid blindness to future consequences,

that it is bound to have the most tragic conclusion—death for the majority and total dissolution of this society for the rest. ·The question was: what should he do?· All he can do is to arm himself, no matter *whose* sword or shield it is that he snatches up, so as to provide himself with all possible means of ·self·-defence and security. His personal concern for justice is no longer any use for his own safety or anyone else's, so he must consult the dictates of self-preservation alone, without concern for those who no longer deserve his care and attention.

·The rules of justice can also be rightly suspended· in a

politically organized society. When any man commits crimes that make him obnoxious to the public, he is punished by the laws in his goods (·fines·) and in his person (·imprisonment or physical punishment·). This means that the ordinary rules of justice are briefly suspended with regard to him, and it becomes fair to inflict on him, for the benefit of society, things it would be wrong or injurious to inflict on him otherwise. If it weren't for this suspension, punishment would always be wrong.

Think about the rage and violence of a public war—·e.g. a war between two countries·. What is it but a suspension of justice among the warring parties, who see that this virtue is now no longer of any *use* or advantage to them? The laws of war, which then take over from the laws of equity and justice, are rules calculated to do good and be useful for men who are in that particular state they are now placed in, ·namely the state of war·. If a •civilized nation is at war with •barbarians who don't even respect any rules of war, the former must also suspend *their* observance of any such rules, because they no longer serve any purpose; and they must make every battle or skirmish as bloody and destructive as possible to ·the barbarians·, whom we may suppose to have been· the first aggressors.

Thus, the rules of equity or justice depend entirely on the particular state and condition in which men are placed; what starts them and keeps them in existence is ·their usefulness·, the utility that comes to the public from their strict and regular observance. If you reverse in any significant way the condition of men—produce extreme abundance or extreme need, endow humans with perfect moderation and humanity or perfect rapacity and malice—you make justice entirely useless, totally destroying its essence and suspending its obligation on mankind. The usual state of human affairs is a medium amidst all these extremes. We are naturally partial to ourselves and our friends, but are capable of learning the advantage resulting from a more equitable conduct. Few enjoyments are given us ·directly· from the open and liberal hand of nature; but by skill and hard work we can extract them in great abundance. That is why the ideas of property become necessary in all civil society; it is why justice is useful to the public; and that is the sole source of its merit and moral obligation.

·The 'golden age'·

These conclusions are so natural and obvious that even the poets have noticed them, in their descriptions of the happiness of 'the golden age' celebrated by ancient Greek poets. According to those pleasant fictions,

- •The seasons in that first period of nature were so temperate that men didn't need clothes or houses to guard against the violence of heat and cold.
- •The rivers flowed with wine and milk.
- •The oaks yielded honey.
- •Nature *spontaneously* produced her greatest delicacies.

And that wasn't the best of it. In that happy age, not only were tempests removed from nature, but the more violent ·inner· tempests that now cause such uproar and create such confusion were unknown to human breasts. Avarice, ambition, cruelty, selfishness, were never heard of. The only states of mind that anyone had were cordial affection, compassion and sympathy. Even the carefully correct distinction of 'mine' and 'thine' was banished from the human scene, and took with it the very notions of property and obligation, justice and injustice.

·THE 'STATE OF NATURE'·

This •poetic fiction of the golden age is in some ways comparable with the •philosophical fiction of the state of nature; except that the former is represented as the most charming and peaceable condition that can possibly be imagined, whereas the latter is depicted as a state of mutual war and violence accompanied by extreme need. At the outset, we are told, mankind's ignorance and savage nature were so prevalent that they couldn't trust one another; each had to depend on himself, and his own force or cunning, for protection and security. No law was heard of; no rule of justice known; no rights of ownership respected; the only measure of right was *power*, and a perpetual war of all against all was the result of men's untamed selfishness and barbarity.[1]

Whether such a condition of human nature could exist, and whether if it did it could for long deserve to be called a *state*, is doubtful. Men are necessarily born into a family-society, at least, and are brought up by their parents to observe some rules of conduct and behaviour. But it can't be denied that if such a state of mutual war and violence *were* ever real, it would inevitably involve the suspension of all laws of justice because they couldn't do any possible good.

The more we look into human life from different angles, and the newer and more unusual the lights are in which we survey it, the more we'll be convinced that this account of the virtue of justice is realistic and satisfactory.

·JUSTICE AND THE LESSER BREEDS·

·Here is a supposition of a quite different kind from the earlier ones·. Suppose this to be the case:

> Mixed in among mankind are creatures of a different species, which, though rational, are so much weaker in body and mind than human beings are that they can't stand up to us and can never, however greatly provoked, make us feel the effects of their resentment.

If this came true, I think that •we would be bound by the laws of humanity to treat these creatures gently, but •we wouldn't strictly speaking lie under any restraint of justice with regard to them, and •they couldn't have any property or other rights in relation to us ·though they might have them in relation to one another·. Our relationships with them couldn't be called 'society', a label that implies some degree of equality; what there would be instead is absolute command on one side and servile obedience on the other. If we want something, they must immediately hand it over. The only basis there is for them to own anything is our permitting them to. The

[1] This fiction of a state of nature as a state of war wasn't first invented by Hobbes, as is commonly imagined. Plato tries to refute an hypothesis very like it in *Republic*, Books 2-4, whereas Cicero treats it as common knowledge and certainly correct: 'You can't *not* know that in the natural course of events, before there was any natural or civil law fully laid down, men wandered in disorderly rabbles over the countryside, and owned only what they could seize and keep, through wounds and bloodshed, by their own personal strength. This led the best and wisest men, having considered what men are naturally like and how far they can be taught anything, to •bring together in one place those who had previously been scattered abroad, and to •lead them out of their savage way of life into one in which there was justice and gentleness. The next step was to form the constitutions, devised for human use, that we call "commonwealths". Then there were ·larger· collections of men that came to be called "states". And then men built walls around sets of houses that we now call "cities", and divine and human laws began to be recognised. The biggest single difference between **(1)** this manner of life, polished by civilization, and **(2)** the savage one ·that came first· is the fact that **(1)** law is the ruling principle of the one whereas **(2)** violence dominates the other. If we don't want to be guided by law, we must settle for violence. And if we want to put an end to violence, we'll have to allow law to prevail—i.e. to allow courts of justice to prevail, because they contain within themselves all law and justice. If we turn against courts of justice, or they are destroyed or suspended, violence will take over. *Everyone* sees this.' Cicero, *Pro Sestio* 42. [This was a small episode in a very long defence speech to the Roman Senate, which was sitting as a court of law. Cicero's client was acquitted.]

only barrier they have to our lawless will—·lawless, that is, in relation to *them*·—is our compassion and kindness. We'll never suffer any inconvenience from the exercise of our power ·over them·, a power that is so firmly established in nature; so the restraints of justice and property would be totally useless for us and would therefore never have a place in this unequal relationship.

This is clearly how men are situated in relation to animals. (Are they *rational*? I'll leave that for others to determine!) The great superiority of civilized Europeans over barbarous Indians •tempted us to think we related to them as we do to the animals, and •led us to throw off all restraints of justice, and even of humanity, in our treatment of them. In many nations, females are reduced to a similar slavery, and are denied any rights of property in relation to their lordly masters. But although the males when they combine forces have, in all countries, enough bodily force to maintain this severe tyranny, their fair companions have so much subtlety, skill and charm that they are commonly able to break up the confederacy among the males and then share with them all the rights and privileges of society.

·Now look at another sequence of suppositions·. **(1)** Suppose the human species were so built by nature that each individual had *within himself* everything needed for his own preservation and for the propagation of his kind, and that all society and all interactions between man and man were cut off by the primary intention of the supreme creator. It seems obvious that such a solitary being would be no more capable of justice ·or injustice· than he would be of social discourse and conversation. If mutual respect and forbearance didn't *achieve* anything, they would never guide the behaviour of any reasonable man. The headlong rush of the emotions wouldn't be checked by any reflection on future consequences. And, as each man would love himself alone and depend only on himself and his own activity for safety and happiness, he would always do his very best to claim preference over every other being, because he wouldn't be linked to any of them by any ties of nature or of self-interest. **(2)** Now vary this last supposition ·of the solitariness of every human being· by supposing that the conjunction of the sexes is established in nature. That immediately gives rise to *families*; particular rules will be found to be necessary if it is to survive, so these will be immediately accepted as applying *within* each family though not as between any family and people outside it. **(3)** Now suppose that a number of families unite to form a single society that has no links with any others: in that case, the rules preserving peace and order will extend themselves right out to the boundaries of society; at any distance beyond those boundaries they will have no force because they won't do any good. **(4)** But then (finally) suppose that many distinct societies interact with one another for mutual convenience and advantage; then the boundaries of justice still extend still wider, in proportion to the breadth of men's views and the strength of their inter-connections. History, experience and reason sufficiently instruct us in this natural development of human sentiments, and in the gradual broadening of our views about the scope of justice, in proportion as we come to know more about the *utility* of that virtue.

Part 2

If we examine the particular laws by which justice is directed and property determined, we'll still reach the same conclusion. The only object of all these laws and regulations is the good of mankind. It's not just that the peace and interest of society requires that there be •an institution of individual ownership; •the actual rules by which we sort out the details

of what is mine and what is yours are themselves devised to serve, as well as possible, the further interests of society.

Let us suppose that a creature who has reason but no experience of human nature is mulling over the question of what rules of justice or property would best promote public interest, and establish peace and security among mankind. His most obvious thought would be this:

> Give the largest possessions to those with the most virtue; and give everyone a power of doing good that is proportional to his wanting to do good.

This rule might be appropriate—might lead to the best results—in a perfect theocracy in which everything happens through the particular volitions of an infinitely intelligent being. But if ·mere· mankind adopted such a law, it couldn't be cleanly applied because merit is so uncertain; the immediate result would be the total dissolution of society. (Why is merit uncertain? Because it is naturally obscure, and also because each individual over-rates his own merit.) Fanatics may think ·they are entitled to help themselves to others' property because· *dominion is based on grace* and *saints alone inherit the earth*; but the law of the land rightly treats these high-flying theorists as being on a par with common robbers, and teaches them by the severest discipline that a rule that seems in theory to be advantageous to society may be found in practice to be totally harmful and destructive.

History tells us that there were **religious fanatics** of this kind in England during the civil wars, though the obvious tendency ·towards chaos· of these principles probably created so much horror in people that these dangerous would-be reformers felt compelled to renounce or at least conceal their views. Perhaps the *levellers*, who wanted all property to be distributed equally, were a kind of **political fanatics**, an off-shoot of the religious ones. They were more open about their views ·than the saints-alone-inherit-the-earth people·, because their views seemed more capable of being put into practice, as well as being more useful to human society.

·There are indeed several sound things to be said in defence of the levellers·. **(1)** Nature is so generous towards mankind that if all her gifts were evenly divided among our species, and improved by skill and work, every individual would enjoy all the •necessities and most of the •comforts of life, and wouldn't be liable to any misfortunes except ones deriving from physical illness. **(2)** Whenever we depart from this equality, we rob the poor of more satisfaction than we add to the rich; the slight gratification of a frivolous vanity in one individual often costs more than bread to many •families and even •provinces. **(3)** The rule of equality, as well as being ·potentially· very useful, isn't altogether impracticable. It has actually been followed, at least partially, in some republics; especially that of Sparta, where it is said to have been accompanied by the most beneficial consequences. And then there were the Agrarian laws, so often pushed for in Rome and actually carried out in many Greek cities; those laws all came from a general idea of the good consequences [the utility] of the levelling principle.

But historians tell us—and common sense agrees—that however attractive these ideas of perfect equality may be, they are basically *not* practicable; and if they could be and were put into practice, their consequences would be extremely harmful to human society. However equally possessions are divided up, men's different degrees of skill, care and industry will immediately break the equality. And if you try to avoid this by putting constraints on skill, care and industry, you'll reduce society to extreme poverty; instead of •preventing want and beggary in a few people, you'll be •making it unavoidable for the whole community! Also, to •spot any inequality the moment it shows up there would have to be a rigorous monitoring system, and to •punish

and correct it there would have to be a very severe penal system. That much authority would be sure to degenerate into tyranny, and to be exercised in unfair ways. But—more to the point—nobody could possibly *have* such authority in a society such as the levellers want. Perfect equality of possessions would destroy all subordination, thereby greatly weakening the authority of officers of the law; as well as levelling out property, it would pretty well level out power.

What we can conclude from all this is that in order to establish laws for the regulation of property we must

- •be acquainted with the nature and situation of man;
- •not be taken in by misleading facts about what *seems* to be the case; and
- •search for the rules that are over-all the most useful and beneficial.

To get this right one doesn't need to look very deeply ·into the human condition· or to have a very broad experience ·of it·; but one does need to avoid being too selfish on the one hand or too uncritically egalitarian on the other.

As an example ·of how basically easy it is to get the right answers·: *Anyone* can see •that something produced or improved by a man's skill or labour ought to be permanently *his* (social benefit: encouraging such useful habits and accomplishments). •That his property ought to be inherited by his children and relations (social purpose: the same). •That he can consent to make it the property of someone else (social purpose: creating the commerce and other interactions that are so beneficial to human society). And •that all contracts and promises ought to be carefully fulfilled (social purpose: to secure the mutual trust and confidence that does so much to promote the general interest of mankind). ·In each case, I am talking about the social purpose of •having that rule about property, not of •acting in that way in an individual case·.

Study the writers on the 'laws of nature' and you'll find that, whatever principles they set out with, they are sure to end up with the one I have been defending. They all give as the ultimate reason for every rule that they lay down the convenience and necessities of mankind. That is the most convincing kind of support to have—the support of someone who is trying to *oppose* one's views.

Indeed, what other reason *could* writers ever give for holding that *this* is *mine* and *that* is *yours*; since nature, left to itself, surely never made any such distinction? The things labelled 'mine' and 'yours' are in themselves quite *other* than us; they are totally separated from us; and nothing but the general interests of society can form the connection.

It can happen that the interests of society •require that there be *some* rule of justice in a particular ·kind of· case, but •don't pick any particular rule out of several that are all equally beneficial. When that happens, the slightest analogies are laid hold of ·as a basis for selecting one rule over the others·, because there would be perpetual conflicts if no selection were made and several rules were regarded as being in force. That's why your sheerly possessing—being the *first* to possess—something is supposed to make it yours, if no-one else has any prior claim to it. Many of the reasonings of lawyers are of this analogical nature, and depend on very slight connections of the imagination. [What 'analogy' is at work in the first-possession rule? In Hume's time 'analogy' often meant merely 'similarity'; and his thought here seems to be that •having x physically under your control is superficially *like* •legitimately owning x.]

Does anyone hesitate, in extraordinary cases, to •violate all respect for the private property of individuals and •sacrifice to public interest a distinction that was established in the first place for the sake of that interest? *The safety of the people* is the supreme law: All other more special laws are subordinate to it, and dependent on it. And if in

the *common* course of things those laws are followed and respected, that is only because the public safety and interest *commonly* demand that society be governed in a way that is even-handed and fair.

Sometimes both •utility and •analogy fail, and leave the laws of justice in total uncertainty. We need to have a rule according to which your having been in possession of something for a long time makes you the rightful owner of it, ·and we get that far through reasoning about •utility and •analogy·; but sheer reasoning won't ·take us any further, i.e. it· won't determine how many days, months or years constitute a 'long time' is for purposes of this rule. In this case, *civil laws* have to do what is not done by *the natural code*; they assign different values of 'long time' for different kinds of things that can be owned, depending on the different utilities that the legislator is concerned about. [Hume's actual words here are 'according to the different utilities proposed by the legislator'. This has been announced as a case where 'utility and analogy fail'; perhaps he means that here the rules are settled on the basis not of *facts* about utility but rather of *what a legislator thinks* about utility.]. . . .

All questions of property fall under the authority of civil laws, which extend, restrain, modify and alter the rules of natural justice, according to the *convenience* of each community in particular. The laws do or should constantly reflect the constitution of government, the manners, the climate, the religion, the commerce and the situation of each society. A recent learned and able author has pursued this subject at great length, and has grown from these seeds a complete philosophy of politics, with many ingenious and brilliant thoughts and some substance.[2]

[2] I am referring to ·Montesquieu·, the author of *L'esprit des loix* (·which appeared in 1748, three years before the present work·). This illustrious writer starts off from a different theory ·from mine·, taking all *right* to be based on certain relations (*rapports*). [He means that according to Montesquieu all moral truths can be deduced from objective facts about how things relate to one another.] In my opinion this is a system that will never be reconciled with true philosophy. Malebranche seems to have been the first proponent of this abstract theory of morals, which was afterwards adopted by Cudworth, Clarke and others. Because it leaves out all sentiment ·or •feeling·, and claims to base everything on •reason, it has had plenty of followers in this philosophic age. (See my Section 1 and Appendix 1.) With regard to justice—our present topic—the case against this theory seems short and conclusive:

•Property depends on civil laws.
•The sole purpose of civil laws is to secure the interests of society. Therefore
•The interests of society is the sole foundation of property and justice.

[Hume says that each premise 'is allowed' and that the conclusion 'must be allowed'; presumably he means in each case 'allowed by Montesquieu'.] Not to mention the fact that the interests of society provide the whole basis for our being obliged to obey the civil law. ·Two further considerations·: **(1)** It sometimes happens that the way the civil law handles something clashes with our ideas of justice. Cases where this happens are not •objections to my theory; they are •confirmations of it. When a •civil law is so perverse that it goes against all the interests of society, it loses all its authority, and then men judge by the ideas of •natural justice, which are in line with those interests. **(2)** Sometimes the civil laws (for good reasons) require that a certain kind of performance involve a ceremony or a special form; when that is lacking, ·the civil law says that from a legal point of view the performance hasn't happened·. This decree of the law runs contrary to our usual ideas of justice, ·and those ideas remain at work in a case like this·: someone who takes advantage of such legal technicalities is usually regarded as dishonest. Thus, the interests of society require that contracts be fulfilled, and this is as basic as you can get in both natural and civil justice; but the omission of a trivial detail—·e.g. the contract's being dated as well as signed·—will often invalidate a contract as a matter of public law; but it won't invalidate it in the 'court' of conscience. In a case of this sort we take it that the judge is •withdrawing his power of enforcing the right ·that was meant to arise from the contract·, not •declaring that there isn't such a right. . . .

What is a man's property? Anything that it is lawful for him and only him to use. *What rule do we have for picking out these objects?* Here we must have resort to statutes, customs, precedents, analogies, and a hundred other things—some of them constant and inflexible, others variable and arbitrary [= 'matters of choice']. But what they are all rooted in is the interests and happiness of human society. If we leave that out of account, nothing could appear more whimsical, unnatural and even superstitious than most of the laws of justice and of property.

·JUSTICE AND SUPERSTITION·

It is a very easy task to ridicule simple-minded superstitions, and expose the folly of special attitudes to foods, days, places, postures, clothing. All you need do is to consider all the qualities and relations of the objects in question, and discover no adequate cause for the affection or antipathy, veneration or horror, that have such a great influence over a large part of mankind. A Syrian would starve rather than taste pigeon; an Egyptian won't come near bacon; but when these foods are examined by the senses of sight, smell or taste, or studied through the sciences of chemistry, medicine or physics, no difference is ever found between them and any other kind of meat; no factual basis is ever found for the religious passion. A fowl on Thursday is lawful food; on Friday it's abominable. Eggs in this house and in this diocese are permitted during Lent; just down the road eating them is a damnable sin. Yesterday there was nothing religious about this plot of land or this building; today the mumbling of certain words has made it holy and sacred. When a philosopher points these things out, it's safe to say that he won't make any difference to anyone. The facts are so obvious that everyone must have noticed them at first sight. When they *don't* prevail, that isn't because people don't know the facts or have misunderstood them somehow; it's because of people's upbringing, prejudice and passion.

Someone who doesn't look carefully enough, or who is thinking at too a high a level of generality, might come to think that a similar superstition is involved in all the sentiments [see note on page 1] of justice; and that if we take the focus of justice—namely, what we call *property*—and subject it to the same scrutiny of sense and science, we won't find, however hard we look, any foundation for the distinctions drawn by moral sentiment. It is lawful for me to eat fruit from this tree, but it would be a crime for me to take fruit of the same kind from a tree a few yards away. If I had been dressed like this an hour ago, I would have deserved the severest punishment; but a man has pronounced a few magical syllables and thereby made it proper for me to be clothed in this way. If this house were in the neighbouring territory, it would have been immoral for me to live in it; but because it is built on this side of the river it is subject to a different municipal law, and I incur no blame or censure by coming to own it. It may be thought, then, •that the kind of reasoning that so successfully exposes superstition can also be applied to justice, and •that it's no more possible with justice than with superstition to pick out the precise features of the object that are the basis for the sentiment.

But there's this solid difference: •superstition is frivolous, useless and burdensome, whereas •justice is absolutely necessary for the well-being of mankind and the existence of society. When we set this fact aside (we couldn't *overlook* it—it's too obvious for that), it has to be agreed that all respects for right and property seem to be entirely without foundation, as much so as the grossest and most vulgar superstition.

> •Why does that man's making certain sounds implying consent change the nature of my actions with regard to this object?

•Why does the reciting of a liturgy by a priest, dressed in a certain way and holding his body in a certain way, make a heap of brick and timber forever sacred?

If the interests of society weren't involved in any way, the former question would be an unanswerable as the latter.[3]

These reflections don't weaken the obligations of justice, or take anything away from the most sacred attention to *property*. On the contrary, such sentiments get new force from my reasoning. What stronger foundation can be desired—or even *conceived*—for any duty than to observe that •if it isn't established human society or even human nature will collapse, and that •our nature and society will arrive at still greater degrees of happiness and perfection to the extent that the duty in question is regarded as inviolable?

·Justice as an instinct·

The dilemma seems obvious: Justice obviously tends to promote public utility and to support civil society. The

[3] Obviously, the will or consent alone never transfers property or creates the obligation of a promise. . . . For the will to impose an obligation on any man, it must be expressed by words or signs. The words initially come in as subservient to the will, but before long they become the principal part of the promise; and a man who secretly •intends not to keep his promise and •withholds the assent of his mind, isn't any less bound by the promise. But though in most cases the expression is the whole promise, it isn't always so. **(1)** Someone who uttered the words without knowing their meaning wouldn't have made a binding promise. **(2)** Someone who knows what the words mean and utters them only as a joke, giving clear signs that he has no serious intention of binding himself, wouldn't be obliged to keep the promise. **(3)** But for this to hold good, the 'clear signs' mustn't be ones that we cleverly detect while the man is trying to deceive us. For him not to be bound by a verbal promise he must give signs *different from signs of deceit* that he doesn't intend to keep the promise. All these contradictions are easily accounted for if justice arises entirely from its public utility [= 'its usefulness to society']; they'll never be explained on any other basis.

[In the next sentence: a 'casuist' is someone who applies general moral and religious doctrines to particular cases; a 'relaxed' casuist is one who cuts corners and stretches points in doing this.] It is remarkable that the moral decisions of the Jesuits and other relaxed casuists were usually made in the course of dealing with subtleties of reasoning such as I have been pointing out. . . . Why has the indignation of mankind risen so high against these casuists? It can only be because everyone sees that if the practices the casuists were trying to rule out were authorized, *human society couldn't survive*; and that morals should always be handled with a view to •public interest rather than to •the demands of high-level fine-grained philosophical theories of morals. Any sensible person can have the thought: *If the secret direction of the intention can invalidate a contract, where is our security?* But someone coming at this from an abstract metaphysical point of view might think that where an intention was supposed to be requisite, if it really wasn't there then no consequence ought to follow—no obligation would be imposed. The •casuistical subtleties may not be greater than the •subtleties of lawyers that I have hinted at above; but they meet with very different receptions from the world because the •former are pernicious while the •latter are innocent and even necessary. The Roman Catholic church teaches that

(1) Any sacrament can be invalidated by the frame of mind of the officiating priest.

This position comes from rigorously following through the ·seeming· consequences of the obvious truth that empty words alone, without any meaning or intention in the speaker, can never have any effect. The analogous position in civil laws would be that

(2) Any civil contract can be nullified by the frame of mind of one of the parties to it.

What is at stake in **(1)** is the eternal salvation of thousands of people, ·whereas what's at stake in **(2)** is merely the upsetting of civil society·. So why do we *not* follow the church's lead in **(1)** by accepting **(2)** regarding civil contracts? Our rejection of **(2)** comes entirely from our sense of the danger and inconvenience that would ensue from accepting it! This gives us a clear example of the fact that however positive, arrogant and dogmatic any superstition may appear to be, it can never *thoroughly* convince anyone that •its threats are real, or get anyone to give •them any weight at all when balanced against the common incidents of life that we learn from daily observation and empirical thinking.

sentiment of justice could be **(1)** derived from our reflecting on that tendency. The only alternative is that the sentiment of justice—like

- •hunger, thirst, and other appetites, and like
- •resentment, love of life, attachment to offspring, and other passions,

—**(2)** arises from a simple basic instinct in the human constitution, implanted there by nature for similar salutary purposes. If **(2)** is the case, it follows that *property*—which is what *justice* is about—is marked off by a simple basic instinct, and is not ascertained by any argument or reflection. But who ever heard of such an instinct? 'Perhaps we have it but it hasn't yet been discovered.' That is obviously wrong; this is *not* a subject in which new discoveries can be made. We would have as much chance of discovering in the human body a new *sense* that no-one had noticed before!

And there's another point. It looks like a very simple proposition to say that *nature distinguishes property through an instinctive sentiment*; but in reality we'll find that there would have to be ten thousand different instincts, many of them concerned with objects having great fine-grained intricacy. For when a definition of *property* is required, the *ownership* relation is found to break down into possession acquired by occupation, by industry, by prescription, by inheritance, by contract, and so on. Is it believable that nature, through a basic instinct, instructs us in all these methods of acquisition?

Also, the words 'inheritance' and 'contract' stand for ideas that are infinitely complicated; a hundred volumes of laws and a thousand volumes of commentators haven't been found sufficient to define them exactly. Does nature, whose instincts in men are all simple, embrace such complicated and artificial objects? And (·this being a different point·) does nature create a rational creature without trusting anything to the operation of his reason?

Even if all those difficulties were overcome, the 'basic instinct' theory of justice still wouldn't be satisfactory. Man-made laws can certainly transfer property. Must we say that it is by *another* basic instinct that we acknowledge the authority of kings and senates, and mark all the boundaries of their jurisdiction? Judges, too, even when their sentence is wrong and illegal, must be allowed for the sake of peace and order to have decisive authority, and ultimately to determine who owns what. Do we have basic innate ideas of magistrates and chancellors and juries? Isn't it *obvious* that all these institutions arise merely from the necessities of human society?

All birds of the same species build their •nests alike at every time and in every country; that's the force of instinct at work. Men build their •houses differently at different times and in different places; that shows the influence of reason and custom. A similar inference can be drawn from a comparison of •the sexual instinct with •the institution of property. ·That is, the contrast between •the sameness of the nests of any one species of birds and •the variety among human houses is comparable with the contrast between •the sameness of ·human· sexual feelings and conduct around the world and across the ages and •the variety among systems of civil laws·.·

Now, it has to be admitted that systems of civil law, despite their variety, are pretty much the same in their general outlines—because what they are meant to achieve and mainly *do* achieve is pretty much the same. Similarly, all houses have a roof and walls, windows and chimneys, though they are varied in their shape, lay-out and materials. But the common features of houses clearly point to the conveniences of human life, and equally clearly so do the common features of systems of civil law. It's really clear with

both that the source of all this is reason and reflection ·on human needs, rather than a basic instinct·.

I needn't mention the variations that all the rules of property receive from the finer turns and connections of the imagination, and from the subtleties and abstractions of law-topics and reasonings. This can't possibly be reconciled with the notion of basic instincts.

·Snap judgments about injustice·

Here is something that will create a doubt about the theory of justice that I have been defending. Our upbringing and acquired habits have the effect that when we blame something as an injustice we aren't always conscious of any immediate reflection on its bad consequences. When something is very familiar to us, its familiarity makes us apt to overlook it; and what we have very frequently done for certain reasons we are apt to go on doing, mechanically, without recalling every time the thoughts that first led us to this. The considerations of human convenience—or rather necessity—that lead to ·our having the notion of· justice are so universal, and everywhere point so much to the same rules ·of justice·, that the habit ·of condemning unjust acts and institutions· takes place in all societies, and we have to think about it a little to ascertain its true origin. Not that the origin is notably obscure: even in ordinary everyday life we often resort to the principle of public utility, saying ·to ourselves or others·—'What would become of the world if *that* kind of behaviour were rampant? How could society survive under such disorders?'. . . .

From all this we seem to have learned something about the force that I have been highlighting—the force of thoughts about public interest and utility—namely how strongly it affects our levels of admiration or moral approval. The sole basis for the virtue of justice is that justice is necessary for the support of society; and since no moral excellence is more highly esteemed ·than justice is·, we can conclude that this matter of *usefulness* has, generally, the strongest energy and most complete command over our sentiments. So it must be the source of a considerable part of the merit ascribed to humanity, benevolence, friendship, public spirit, and other social virtues of that sort, just as it is the sole source of our moral approval of fidelity, justice, veracity, integrity and those other estimable and useful qualities and forces. In saying this I am relying on the principle:

> When any force has been found to have a great strength and energy in one instance, credit it with having a similar energy in all similar instances.

This is entirely agreeable to the rules of philosophy [here = 'empirical science'], and even of common sense; and it is indeed Newton's chief rule of scientific method.

Section 4. Political society

If everyone were •intelligent and wise enough to perceive at all times how strongly his interests are served by the observance [meaning *his* observance] of justice and equity, and were •strong-minded enough to keep steadily focussed on his over-all *long-term* interests rather than being diverted by the enticements of *present* pleasure and advantage, there would never have been any such thing as government or political society. In the situation as I have described it, each man would have lived in entire peace and harmony with everyone else—doing this in the exercise of his natural liberty, ·with no constraints from governmental laws·. What need is there for man-made laws, when unaided natural justice is a sufficient restraint? If nothing ever goes wrong, why have judges? Why curtail our natural freedom when *all* our uses of it are found to be innocent and beneficial? Obviously, if there no way for government to be in the least useful, it wouldn't exist; the whole basis for the duty of allegiance ·to the government of one's country· is the good that government does for society by preserving peace and order among mankind.

·Laws of nations·

When a number of political societies are formed, and they maintain a thick web of interactions amongst themselves, it is immediately found that a new set of rules would be useful in that situation; so such rules come into existence, under the title 'laws of nations'. Examples include

- •Ambassadors are not to be harmed in any way.
- •Poisoned weapons are not to be used.
- •A soldier in battle is not to be immediately killed if he surrenders.

These rules and others of that kind are plainly calculated for the advantage of states and kingdoms in their inter-relations.

The rules of justice that apply among •individuals are not entirely suspended among •political societies. All rulers claim to respect the rights of other rulers, and no doubt *some* of them can say this without hypocrisy. Alliances and treaties are constantly being made between independent states, and this would be a mere waste of parchment if it hadn't been found that treaties etc. have *some* influence and authority. But here is the difference between kingdoms and individuals. •Human nature can't possibly survive without the association of individuals; and that association can exist only if some respect is paid to the laws of equity and justice. Disorder, confusion, the war of all against all, are the inevitable upshot of such licentious conduct ·as would occur if equity and justice had no place·. •Nations, on the other hand, can survive without having relations with one another. They can even survive, to some extent, under a general war. Though respect for justice is useful among states, it isn't as necessary ·or useful· there as it is among individuals; and corresponding to that lessened usefulness is a lessened degree of moral obligation. All politicians and most philosophers will allow that in particular emergencies 'reasons of state' may justify dispensing with the rules of justice, ·unilaterally· invalidating some treaty or alliance the strict observance of which would be very harmful to either of the contracting parties. But it is generally agreed that nothing less than the most extreme necessity can justify individuals in a breach of promise or an invasion of the properties of others.

In a confederated commonwealth, such as the ancient Achaean republic ·in Greece·, or today's Swiss Cantons and United Provinces [= the Netherlands], the league has a

special utility, and so the conditions of union have a special sacredness and authority, and a violation of them would be regarded as being *at least* as criminal as any private injury or injustice.

·CHASTITY·

The long and helpless infancy of a human being requires that the parents work together for the care of their young, and this collaboration requires the virtue of chastity, i.e. fidelity to the marriage bed. You'll agree that if chastity weren't useful in that way it would never have been thought of as a virtue.[4]

Sexual infidelity in marriage is much more harmful in women than in men. That's why the laws of chastity are much stricter over the female sex than over the male.

These rules are all connected with procreation; yet they are supposed to apply to women who are past child-bearing as much as to those in the flower of their youth and beauty. General rules are often extended beyond their original source, and this is true in all matters of taste and sentiment. [The *starred passage* expands what Hume wrote in ways that the ·small dots· convention can't easily indicate.] *It is agreed that our ideas about personal beauty arise very much from ideas of utility. An example might be this: we see a hump-back as ugly, basically because we think of such a hump as an obstacle to activity, to doing well in life—the opposite of useful. Now consider this story that has come out of France: during a stock-market surge in Paris, a hump-backed fellow went every day to the street where the stock-brokers gather, and was well paid for letting them use his hump as a desk on which to sign their contracts. So *his* hump was thoroughly useful. But would the money that he made in this way turn him into a handsome fellow? No. The imagination is influenced by associations of ideas; and even if a given association initially arose from the judgment—such as the association of *hump-backed* with *ugly*, mediated by the judgment that humped backs are not useful—it isn't easily altered by particular exceptions that we come across. That could explain our hostility to sexual infidelity in women who are past child-bearing age.* There is also something else we can add: if older women were free to be unchaste, their example would be harmful to the younger ones; if women could always look forward to a time when they would be at liberty to indulge themselves in this way, it would be natural for them to bring that time closer, i.e. not to wait, and to think more lightly of this whole duty that is in fact so much needed by society.

·INCEST·

Members of a single family living together have such frequent opportunities for licence of this kind [Hume's exact phrase] that nothing could preserve purity of manners if marriage or any sexual relationship were allowed between people who are closely related to one another. Incest, therefore, being especially harmful in its effects, is regarded as especially wicked and morally ugly. ·And some of the details of the anti-incest morality can also be explained in terms of consequences, as I shall now show·.

Why did the laws of Athens allow a man to marry a half-sister **(1)** who had the same father as he did, but not

[4] Plato's only answer to objections raised against the community of women that is established in his imaginary commonwealth is this: 'It was a good saying, and still is, that what is useful is fair, what is useless is ugly' (*Republic* 5 457). There can't be any doubt about this where *public* usefulness is concerned—and that was Plato's topic. Indeed, what other point is there to all the ideas of chastity and modesty? Phaedrus writes: 'Unless what we do is useful, the glory of it is nil'. Plutarch writes: 'Nothing that is harmful is beautiful.' The Stoics thought the same. [Hume quotes Sextus Empiricus as reporting this about the Stoics. He quotes Phaedrus in Latin, Sextus in Greek, and Plato and Plutarch in both.]

a half-sister **(2)** who had the same mother? Plainly for this reason: The manners of the Athenians were so reserved that a man was never allowed to approach the women's part of any house, even the house of a close relative, except when he was paying a visit to his own mother. His step-mother and her children—·including the half-sister **(1)**·—were as much shut up from him as the women of any other family, so that there was as little danger of any unlawful sexual relations between him and them as between him and any other women; ·whereas a half-sister **(2)** with whom he shared a mother would be someone he had grown up with and seen countless times·. For a similar reason, uncles and nieces were allowed to marry at Athens. But the permitted-in-Athens marriages that I have mentioned were not permitted in Rome, where relations between the sexes were more open. Public utility is the cause of all these variations.

·Other kinds of immoral conduct·

If something that doesn't do a man credit escapes his lips in private conversation, or if he says it in a private letter, it is highly blameworthy to repeat it to anyone else. The free and social interactions of minds would be seriously inhibited if such rules of trustworthiness were not established.

Even in passing on gossip from which we can't foresee any harm resulting, it is regarded as a piece of indiscretion, if not of immorality, to tell whom we got the story from. As these stories are passed from hand to hand they are altered in various ways; and they often reach the persons concerned—·the persons they are *about*·—and produce animosities and quarrels among people whose intentions were entirely innocent and inoffensive.

To pry into secrets, to open or even read the letters of others, to spy on their words and looks and actions—what practices are more trouble-making in society? What habits, therefore, are more blameable?

This principle [see note on title page] ·of the well-being of society· is also the basis for most of the laws of good *manners*—a kind of lesser morality that aims at the ease of company and conversation. Too much ceremony is blamed; so is too little; and anything that promotes ease, without an indecent familiarity, is useful and praiseworthy.

It is commendable to be constant in one's friendships, attachments and familiarities, and this is needed to support trust and good relations in society. But in places where people come together casually in some pursuit of health and pleasure, public convenience doesn't require such constancy; it is customary to encourage unreserved conversation in such contexts by granting the privilege of then dropping one's casual acquaintance, without this being a breach of civility or good manners.

·The morality of lesser 'societies'·

Even in societies with utterly immoral foundations, ones that are the most destructive to the interests of the general society, there have to be certain rules that the members are constrained to observe by a sort of false honour as well as by private self-interest. Robbers and pirates, it has often been remarked, couldn't maintain their harmful confederacy if they didn't establish a new distributive justice among themselves, calling into force among themselves the laws of equity they have violated with the rest of mankind.

I hate a drinking companion, says the Greek proverb, *who never forgets*. The follies of the last drinking spree should be buried in eternal oblivion, so as to give full scope to the follies of the next one!. . . .

In any society ·or club· that exists for the purpose of playing some game, there have to be laws governing how the game is played; and these laws are different for different games. The basis for such societies is admittedly frivolous, and the laws are to a great extent (though not entirely)

capricious and arbitrary. That creates an important difference between these laws and the rules of justice, fidelity and loyalty; because the latter are required for there to be general societies of men, which are absolutely requisite for the survival of the species. . . . So there is only a very limited likeness between the rules of games and the moral rules of society at large; all we can learn from it, probably, is that rules are necessary whenever men have *any* kind of relations with each other.

They can't even pass each other on the road without rules. Waggoners, coachmen and mounted couriers have principles governing who gives way to whom, and these are mainly based on mutual ease and convenience. But some of them are arbitrary, or at least dependent on a kind of capricious analogy like many of the reasonings of lawyers.[5]. . . .

And it goes even further than that: men can't even *murder* each other without rules and maxims and an idea of justice and honour. War has its laws as well as peace; and even the kind of war-for-amusement that is carried on among wrestlers, boxers and gladiators is regulated by fixed principles. The people concerned have some interests in common, and thus a shared notion of what is useful; and from this there inevitably arises a standard of right and wrong among them.

Section 5. Why utility pleases

Part 1

We praise the social virtues because of their utility'—that's such a natural thought that one would expect to meet with it everywhere in moral writers, as the main basis for their reasoning and enquiry. In ordinary everyday life the utility of conduct is always appealed to, and we can't think of any greater eulogy to give to any man than •to display his usefulness to the public, and •list the services he has done for mankind and society. Even our praise for the regularity and elegance of an inanimate form is conditional on those features' not destroying the thing's fitness for any useful purpose. And what a satisfactory apology we can make for any disproportion or seeming ugliness, if we can show that the feature in question was needed for the intended use! A ship appears more beautiful to an artist, or to anyone moderately skilled in navigation, if its prow is wider

[5] One such rule is:

•The lighter machine must yield to the heavier, and •in machines of the same kind the empty one must yield to the one that is loaded.

This rule is based on *convenience*. Then there is this rule:

•Those who are going *to* the capital city have precedence over those who are coming *from* it.

This seems to be based on some idea of dignity of the great city, and of the preference for the future over the past (·which, if it is correct, brings this rule under the heading of 'arbitrary and capricious'·)

than its stern than it would if it were built with precise geometrical regularity. . . . If a building's doors and windows were exact squares, it would hurt the eye just because of that squareness, which is ill-adapted to the shape of a human being, for whose use the building was intended.

So it's not surprising that a man whose habits and conduct are harmful to society, and dangerous or harmful to everyone who has any connection with him, should for that reason be an object of disapproval, communicating to every spectator the strongest sentiment or ·feeling· of disgust and hatred.[6]

And yet these effects of usefulness or its contrary have not loomed large in philosophers' systems of ethics, and they have looked elsewhere for explanations of the origin of moral good and evil. Why? Perhaps it's because they found it hard to *account for* our attitude to usefulness. But if we have had experience that confirms the existence of a principle [see note on title page], we shouldn't reject it just because we can't give a satisfactory account of its origin, or show it to be a special case of some more general principle. As for our present topic, if we would just think about it for a little while we would find it easy enough to account for the influence that utility has ·on our feelings·, and to deduce it from ·more general· principles that are the best known, the most thoroughly recognized, in human nature.

·MORALITY'S BASIS IS NATURE, NOT INDOCTRINATION·

Ancient and modern sceptics have inferred from •the apparent usefulness of the social virtues that •all moral distinctions arise from cultural influence, and that •they were first invented and then encouraged by the skill of politicians, so as to make men manageable and to subdue the natural ferocity and selfishness which had made them unfit for society. It's true that this principle of instruction and upbringing has a powerful influence, so that it can often **(1)** make the sentiments of approval or dislike greater or smaller than they would have been if left to nature; and sometimes it can even **(2)** create a new sentiment of approval or dislike, one that owes nothing to any natural principle—which is what happens in all superstitious practices and observances. But surely no thoughtful enquirer would think that *all* moral affection or dislike arises from this origin. If nature hadn't made *any* such distinction, based on the original constitution of the mind, language would not have contained the words 'honourable' and 'shameful', 'lovely' and 'odious', 'noble' and 'despicable'; and if politicians had invented these terms they could never have made them intelligible to anyone. So this paradox of •the sceptics is just very superficial. It isn't hard to fend off the nit-picking of •that sect in the context of politics and morals; it would be good if we deal with them as well in the context of the theoretical and less intelligible sciences of logic and metaphysics! So we have to acknowledge that the social virtues have a *natural* beauty and amiableness, which right from the outset—before any instruction or cultural input—attracts the respect and

[6] We oughtn't to think that because an inanimate object (·a chair, say·) can be useful as well as a man, it ought to qualify for the label 'virtuous' as a man can. The sentiments aroused by utility are very different in the two cases. In the case of the man, the feelings are mixed with affection, respect, approval and so on, but not in the case of the chair. Similarly, the chair may have good colour and proportions, just as a human figure can. But can we ever be in love with the chair? There are many passions and sentiments of which thinking rational beings are the only proper objects, this being settled by the basic constitution of human nature; and if qualities that would arouse love and affection in a human being were transferred to an inanimate object, they wouldn't arouse the same sentiments. . . . A very small variation in the object, even when the same qualities are preserved, will destroy a sentiment. Thus, the beauty for which a man loves a woman, if transferred to a man, would not arouse an amorous passion except in cases where nature is extremely perverted.

affection of mankind. And because the chief source of the merit of these virtues is their public utility, it follows that the end that they tend to promote must be in some way agreeable to us, taking hold of some natural affection. Public utility must please—either for self-interested reasons or from more generous motives.

·THE SELF-INTEREST THEORY OF MORALITY·

It has often been maintained that because •every man has a strong connection with society, and sees that he can't possibly survive in isolation, he •favours all the habits or principles that promote order in society and give him the quiet possession of this priceless blessing, However much we value our own happiness and welfare, we must to that extent applaud the practice of justice and humanity, which is our only way of maintaining the social confederacy and getting for every man the advantages of mutual protection and assistance. This derivation of morals from a concern for one's own interests is an obvious thought, and it hasn't arisen wholly from the irresponsible teasing attacks of the sceptics. To mention no others, Polybius—one of the gravest and most judicious writers of antiquity, as well as one of the most moral—has traced all our sentiments of virtue to this selfish origin. (This is in Book 6, chapter 6, of his *Histories*.)[7] But though the solid practical sense of that author, and his dislike of vain subtleties, give him considerable authority on the present subject, this isn't something to be settled by •authority, and the voice of •nature and •experience seems plainly to oppose the selfish theory.

We often praise virtuous actions that were performed long ago and far away, where the utmost subtlety of imagination couldn't discover any appearance of self-interest, or find any way of connecting our present happiness and security with events so widely separated from us.

When an adversary does something generous, brave, noble, we approve his action even if we know that its consequences will go *against* our particular interests.

In any case where •private advantage goes along with our general •affection for virtue, we easily see and acknowledge the mixture of these distinct sentiments, which feel different and have different influences on the mind. We are perhaps quicker to praise generous humane actions that further our own interests; but those interests come nowhere near to explaining the •topics of praise that we insist on [probably meaning 'the •general principles that govern our most intensely felt praise']. And we can try to bring other people over to our sentiments without trying to convince them that *they* get any advantage from the actions that we are presenting for their approval and applause.

If you •describe the model of a praiseworthy character, consisting of all the most lovable moral virtues; and •give examples in which these virtues display themselves in an extraordinary manner; you will easily elicit esteem and approval from all your audience, without their even *asking* when and where this noble person lived. Yet 'when and where' are absolutely crucial to self-love, i.e. the concern for one's own individual happiness. ·Here's an example of what

[7] Undutifulness to parents is disapproved of by every person 'who reflects on what he sees and, comparing the future with the past, expresses his indignation at this ill-treatment to which he foresees that he also may some day be exposed'. Ingratitude is disapproved of for a similar reason (though Polybius seems here to mix in something more generous): 'Each person is bound to be shocked by ingratitude; through sympathy with the resentment of his neighbour, and from the thought that he may at some time suffer in the same way. And from that arises in the mind of every man a certain sense of the nature and force of duty.' Perhaps he meant only that our sympathy or humanity is more enlivened by our considering the similarity of our case with that of the person suffering; which is a good point.

I mean·:

> There was a statesman who, in the shock and contest of party-political conflict, managed through his eloquence to get an able adversary banished. He secretly followed the adversary, offering him •money for his support during his exile and •consolation in his misfortunes. 'Alas!' cried the banished statesman, 'how I regret leaving my •friends in this city, where even •enemies are so generous!'. . . .

We give this conduct the praise and approval that it deserves; and we don't retract these sentiments when we learn that all this happened in Athens about two thousand years ago, and that the men involved were Eschines and Demosthenes. . . . When pressed by these facts and arguments, a defender of the self-interest theory of morality might say:

> We transport ourselves by the force of imagination into distant times and places, and think about the advantage that we *would* have reaped from these characters if we *had been* contemporaries and had been involved in the situation.

This is a dodge, and a weak one at that. It is not conceivable how a *real* sentiment or passion could arise in us from what we know to be an *imaginary* interest; especially when our real interest is still kept in view, and is often acknowledged to be entirely distinct from the imaginary one and sometimes even opposite to it.

A man who is brought to the brink of a precipice can't look down without trembling; and the sentiment of imaginary danger drives him, in opposition to his belief that he is really safe. ·This may look like a real example of something I have said to be 'inconceivable', but it isn't really, because **(1)** it has a special feature·:

> In this case the imagination is helped by the presence of a striking object—·the cliff-face and the sheer drop·;

and also because **(2)** ·it is really a different phenomenon·:

> Even the 'striking object' won't have this effect unless it is, for this man, somewhat unusual and unfamiliar. Custom soon reconciles us to heights and precipices, and wears off these false and delusive terrors.

In our estimates of characters and conduct, the reverse is the case: the oftener we engage in careful scrutiny of morals, the *more* delicate is the feeling we acquire of the most minute differences between vice and virtue. Indeed, in everyday life we so *often* express all kinds of moral determinations that nothing of this kind could be new or unusual to us. And no false views or prejudices could hold their ground against experience that is so common and familiar. What mainly forms associations of ideas is experience, so that no association could possibly be established and survive in direct opposition to experience.

Usefulness is agreeable, and elicits our approval. This is a matter of fact, confirmed by daily observation. But, *useful*? For what? For somebody's interest, surely. Whose interest then? Not only our own; for our approval frequently extends beyond our own interests. So it must be the interests of those who benefit from the character or action we approve of; from which we can conclude that the welfare of those people, however far away they are in time or space, is not a matter of total indifference to us. By opening up this principle [see note on title page] we shall discover one great source of moral distinctions.

Part 2

Self-love is such a busily energetic drive in human nature, and the interest of each individual is usually so closely connected with that of the community, that there was an excuse for the philosophers who thought that all our concern

for the public might ultimately come down to a concern for our own happiness and preservation. ·Here's how they arrived at that thought·. They •saw every moment instances of approval or blame, satisfaction or displeasure, towards characters and actions. They •called the objects of these sentiments 'virtues' or 'vices'. They •saw that virtues tended to increase the happiness of mankind, and that vices tended to increase mankind's misery. They •asked themselves 'Could it be that we have any *general* concern for society, or any *disinterested* [= 'not *self*-interested'] resentment of the harm that comes to others?' And they •found it simpler to regard all these sentiments as special cases of self-love, and •discovered an excuse (at least) for this unifying move in the fact that the interests of any individual are so often closely linked to the interests of the public.

Despite this frequent mixing of interests, however, it is easy to perform what natural scientists—following Bacon—call a 'crucial experiment', one that points out the right way in any doubt or ambiguity. We have found cases where someone's private interest was different from—even contrary to—the public interest, and where nevertheless the *moral* sentiment stayed steady, despite this divergence of interests. And whenever these distinct interests are seen to coincide, we always find a noticeable increase in the sentiment, a warmer affection for virtue, a more intense detestation of vice—feelings that are properly called 'gratitude' and 'revenge'. Under pressure from these examples we have to reject the theory that accounts for every moral sentiment in terms of self-love. We must make room for a more publicaffection, and allow that we have some concern for the interests of society, considered just in itself. Usefulness is only a tendency to lead to a certain result; and it is a contradiction in terms to say 'I am pleased with x as a means to y, though y itself is something I am not concerned with'. Thus, if usefulness is a source of moral sentiment, and if this usefulness is not always thought of in terms of 'useful to *me*', it follows that anything that contributes to the happiness of society recommends itself *directly* to our approval and good-will. Here is a drive within us that accounts in great part for the origin of morality. Why should we look for abstruse and remote systems when such an obvious and natural one lies ready to hand?[8]

·SYMPATHY· [see note on page 6]

Is it hard for us to •understand the force of humanity and benevolence? Or to •take in that the very look of happiness, joy and prosperity gives pleasure; the very look of pain, suffering and sorrow communicates uneasiness? ·The Latin poet· Horace said that the human countenance borrows smiles or tears from the human countenance—'Human faces laugh with those who laugh, and weep with those who weep'. If you reduce a person to solitude, he will lose almost all enjoyment, because his emotions aren't helped along by corresponding emotions in his fellow-creatures. (·I said '*almost* all' because· he might still have intellectual pleasures, ·e.g. from solving a mathematical problem·, and sensual

[8] We needn't push our researches so far as to ask '*Why* do we have humanity, i.e. a fellow-feeling with others?' It's enough that we experience this as a force in human nature. Our examination of causes must stop somewhere; and in every science there are some general principles [= 'drives'] that we can't hope to show to be special cases of something even more general. No man is absolutely indifferent to the happiness and misery of others. The first has a natural tendency to give pleasure; the second, pain. You can find this in yourself—so can anyone. It's not likely that these principles can be resolved into simpler and more universal ones, whatever attempts may have been made to do that. And even if it were possible, that wouldn't be part of my present topic. For present purposes we can safely treat these principles as basic, and be well satisfied if we can make all their consequences sufficiently plain and clear! ·That is, we can ignore any questions about what led *to* them and focus on what comes *from* them·.

pleasures, ·e.g. feeling warm and well fed·.) Even when the signs of sorrow and mourning are arbitrary [= 'conventional, or at any rate •not natural'], they still make us sad; and the •natural symptoms, tears and cries and groans, never fail to create compassion and uneasiness in other people's minds. And if the *effects* of misery affect us in such a lively manner, can we be supposed to be entirely unfeeling or indifferent towards its *causes* when a malicious or treacherous character and conduct are presented to us?

Suppose we enter a convenient, warm, well-designed apartment. We have to get pleasure just from seeing it, because it presents us with the pleasing ideas of ease, satisfaction and enjoyment. The hospitable, good-humoured, humane landlord appears, and this event must surely make the whole even more attractive; and we can't easily forbear reflecting with pleasure on the satisfaction that everyone gets from their dealings with him.

His whole family show their happiness by the freedom, ease, confidence and calm enjoyment expressed in their faces. I have a pleasing sympathy in the prospect of so much joy, and can't think of the source of it without having the most agreeable emotions.

He tells me that an oppressive and powerful neighbour tried to dispossess him of his inheritance, and for years disturbed all his innocent and social pleasures. I feel an immediate indignation arise in me against such violence and injury.

He adds that it isn't surprising that a private wrong should come from a man who has enslaved provinces, depopulated cities, and made the battle-field and the scaffold stream with human blood. I am struck with horror at the prospect of so much misery, and am driven by the strongest hostility towards its author.

Wherever we go, whatever we think or talk about, just about everything presents us with a view of human happiness or misery, and arouses in us a sympathetic surge of pleasure or uneasiness. In our serious occupations, and in our careless amusements, this principle still exerts its active energy.

·Sympathy and the arts·

A man who enters a theatre is immediately impressed by the view of so many people sharing in one common pastime; and he experiences, just from the look of them, a heightening of his disposition to have every sentiment ·or feeling· that his fellow-creatures have.

He notices that the actors are energised by the appearance of a full house, and raised to a level of enthusiasm that they can't command when they are calm and alone.

If the play is skillfully written, every emotion ·represented· on the stage is communicated to the spectators, as though by magic. The spectators weep, tremble, resent, rejoice, and are inflamed with all the variety of passions that drive the characters in the drama.

When an event in the play goes against our wishes and interrupts the happiness of our favourite characters, we are conscious of feeling anxiety and concern. If their sufferings come from the treachery, cruelty or tyranny of an enemy, we experience intense resentment against the enemy. It is regarded as *contrary to the rules of art* to represent a calamity in a cool and indifferent manner. A distant friend or a confidant who has nothing immediately at stake in the catastrophe ought, if possible, to be avoided by the playwright, because such a character might communicate a similar indifference to the audience. . . .

Few species of poetry are more entertaining than the *pastoral*, and we are all aware that the chief source of its

pleasure arises from the images of a gentle and tender tranquillity that it represents in its characters, communicating a similar sentiment to the reader. ·The Italian poet· Sannazaro ·in his *Piscatory Eclogues*· shifted the scene ·from gentle pleasant meadows· to the sea-shore; this let him present ·the ocean·, the most magnificent object in nature, but it is agreed that it was a wrong choice. The idea of the toil, labour and danger suffered by the fishermen is painful ·to the reader· because of the unavoidable sympathy that accompanies every conception of human happiness or misery.

. . . .No passion, when well represented, can be entirely indifferent to us; because every man has within him at least the seeds and first principles [see note on title page] of every passion. It's poetry's business to bring every affection near to us by lively imagery and representation, making it look like truth and reality; which is a certain proof that wherever reality itself is found. our minds are disposed to be strongly affected by it.

Any recent event that affects the fate of states, provinces or many individuals is extremely interesting even to those whose welfare is not directly involved. News of such an event is quickly spread, eagerly heard, and enquired into with attention and concern. On such an occasion the interest of society appears to be to some extent the interest of each individual. The imagination is sure to be affected, though the passions that are aroused may not always be strong and steady enough to have much influence on behaviour.

Reading a history book seems like a calm entertainment; but it wouldn't entertain at all if the reader didn't have feelings corresponding to those that the historian describes.

It's hard to read Thucydides or Guicciardin attentively while one describes trivial clashes between small cities of Greece, and the other describes the harmless wars between Pisa and Florence. Not many people are involved, and the interest is small, so these passages don't fill our imagination or bring our feelings into play. But the deep distress of the large Athenian army that attacked Syracuse, and the danger that constituted such a strong threat to Venice—*these* arouse compassion; *these* move terror and anxiety.

We can become convinced of the cruel depravity of ·the Roman emperors· Nero and Tiberius by the cool uninvolving style of Suetonius as well as by the masterly writings of Tacitus. But what a difference in our feelings! Suetonius coldly relates the facts; whereas Tacitus sets before our eyes the venerable figures of Soranus and Thrasea—·two of Nero's innocent victims·—who faced their fate bravely, and were moved only by the melting sorrows of their friends and families. What sympathy then touches every human heart! What indignation against the tyrant whose ungrounded fear or unprovoked malice gave rise to such detestable barbarity!

If we shift from plays and history-books, and look at real-life events that we observe for ourselves, powerful concern is aroused, and how much stronger it often is than the narrow attachments of self-love and self-interest! •Popular uprisings, •party zeal, •devoted obedience to leaders of groups—these are some of the most visible effects (though not the most commendable!) of this social sympathy in human nature.

Our feelings are somewhat engaged by anything that carries an image of human sentiment and affection, even when the subject is fairly trivial.

When a person stutters, we sympathize with this trivial uneasiness and suffer for him. And it is a rule in criticism that every combination of syllables or letters that is hard to pronounce sounds harsh and disagreeable to the ear, apparently because of a sort of sympathy. Indeed, when we skim a book with our eye, we notice such unharmonious composition because we still imagine that someone is reading it aloud to us and having a hard time pronouncing these

jarring sounds. So delicate is our sympathy!

·Beauty, utility, sympathy·

Relaxed and unconstrained postures and motions are always beautiful. An air of health and vigour is agreeable. •Clothes that warm us without burdening the body—that cover us without imprisoning the limbs—are well-designed. The feelings of the affected person have a role in all our judgments of beauty, communicate to the spectator similar touches of pain or pleasure.[9] So it's not surprising that we can't make judgments about the characters and conduct of men without considering the likely consequences of their actions, and the happiness or misery they bring to society. What association of ideas could operate if the sympathy principle were totally inactive?[10]

·Sympathy and morality·

If a man isn't affected by images of human •happiness or •misery—because he is emotionally cold or narrowly selfish—he must be equally indifferent to the images of •virtue and •vice. And on the other hand we always find that a warm concern for the interests of our species is accompanied by a delicate feeling for all moral distinctions—a strong •resentment of harm done to men, a lively •approval of their faring well. People can be seen to differ a great deal in this respect; but no-one is so entirely indifferent to the interests of his fellow-creatures that he doesn't have *any* sense of actions as being morally good or bad because of the results they tend to produce. If someone is confronted by two candidates for his moral judgment, •one that is beneficial and •another that is harmful to his species or community, it's not *possible* that he won't prefer the beneficial one (however coolly) and ascribe to it some measure of merit (however small). It is not possible if he *wears a human heart* [Hume's exact phrase]. Let us suppose someone who is ever so selfish, with his own private interests occupying ever so much of his attention; even this man, in cases where his own interests are not affected, must inevitably feel *some* leaning towards the good of mankind as the goal to choose other things being equal. . . . We surely •take into consideration the happiness and misery of others when we are weighing the various motives for action, and •incline to the happiness side when no private concerns draw us to seek our own advantage by harming our fellow-creatures. And if the principles of humanity are capable in many instances of influencing our actions, they must always have some authority over our sentiments [see note on page 1], and give us a general approval

[9] 'The horse whose flanks are slim is handsomer—and faster. The athlete whose muscles have been well developed by exercise is better to look at—and more likely to win. Outward appearance is never separated from usefulness. Everyone with any sense knows this.' Quintilian, *Institutes* Book 8 ch. 3.

[10] How much good we expect to flow from someone's conduct depends in part on how high his social rank is, and on the quality of the relationships—·in private life, in business, in politics etc.·—into which he has entered. If he falls short of our expectations, we blame him for not being more useful; and we blame him much more severely if anything positively bad has arisen from his behaviour. When there's a clash of interests between two countries, we judge the merits of a statesman by how much good or bad has resulted *for his own country* from his actions and advice, without regard to their adverse effect on its enemies and rivals. His fellow-citizens are central to our thoughts when we are determining his ·moral· character. Nature has implanted in everyone a greater affection for his own country ·than for any other·, so we never expect any regard to distant nations when a competition arises. ·Another quite different reason for attending primarily to what the statesman achieves for his own country depends not on its being *his own* but on its being *just one country*·. We're aware that the interests of *mankind in general* are better promoted when every man attends to the good of •his own community than they would be if everyone acted on the basis of a loose indeterminate view about the good of •the species. The latter motivation doesn't provide one with a suitably limited object on which to exert oneself; so no good can be expected to come from it.

of what is useful to society, and disapproval of what is dangerous or harmful. The strength of these sentiments ·in this or that kind of case· may be the subject of controversy; but there can't be a ·viable· theory or system that denies their existence.

A creature who is absolutely malicious and spiteful (if there is such a thing in nature) must be worse than merely *indifferent* to the images of vice and virtue. All his sentiments must be inverted, and be directly opposite to the sentiments that prevail in the human species. Anything that contributes to the good of mankind will run contrary to the constant direction of his wishes and desires, and must therefore produce uneasiness and disapproval ·in him·; and on the other hand anything that is a source of disorder and misery in society must for the same reason be regarded ·by him· with pleasure and satisfaction. Timon ·of Athens· was called 'the manhater', probably more because of his depression than because of inveterate malice. One day he embraced Alcibiades with great fondness, saying 'Go on, my boy! Acquire the confidence of the people, then one day I foresee that you'll be the cause of great calamities to them.' (This story is from Plutarch.) If the Manicheans were right in their view that the universe is a battlefield between two principles ·or gods·, one good one and the other evil, these two gods would have to have totally opposite sentiments concerning human actions as well as concerning everything else. Every case of justice and humanity that pleased one of the gods, because of its tendency to do good, would displease the other. All mankind so far resemble the good principle that our natural philanthropy inclines us always to give the happiness of society preference over its misery, and consequently to prefer virtue to its opposite—except at times when self-interest or revenge or envy has perverted our disposition. It may be that absolute, unprovoked, disinterested malice never finds a place in any human breast; but if it does, it must there pervert all the sentiments of morals as well as the feelings of humanity. If Nero's cruelty had been entirely voluntary, rather than being an effect of constant fear and resentment, it's obvious that his steady and uniform approval would have gone to ·the cruel, treacherous, self-serving· Tigellinus rather than to ·his two noble advisors· Seneca and Burrhus.

A statesman or patriot who serves our own country in our own time will always have a more passionate respect paid to him than one whose beneficial influence operated long ago or in distant countries. That's because the good resulting from the generous humanity of the latter person, being less ·closely· connected with us, is less brightly lit for us and affects us with a less lively sympathy. We may agree that their merit is equally great, although our sentiments are not raised to the same height by both. In a case like this, •our judgment corrects the inequalities of our internal emotions and perceptions; just as •it preserves us from being misled by the various images presented to our external senses. When the distance from us of an object is doubled, it then throws on the eye a picture half the size of the previous one; but we imagine that it looks the same size in both situations, because we know that its image would expand if we walked towards it, and that this expansion would come not from the object itself but from our position in relation to it. Indeed, without such a correction of appearances—both in internal and external sentiment—we could never think or talk steadily about anything, while our fluctuating situations continually

[11] For a similar reason, our moral determinations or general judgments are based on the •tendencies ·or expectable consequences· of actions and characters, not on the •actual consequences that they happen to have. Though in our real feeling or sentiment we can't help taking a more favourable view of

varied the things we were talking about, throwing them into such different and contrary lights and positions.[11]

The more we converse with other people and the larger the set of social inter-relations that we maintain, the more familiar we'll become with these general preferences and distinctions, without which we could hardly speak intelligibly to each other. Every man's self-interest is special to himself, and the aversions and desires arising from it can't be supposed to mean as much to anyone else. So general language, which is formed for •general use, has to be moulded on some more •general views; its way of using words expressive of praise or blame have to be made to fit sentiments arising from the •general interests of the community. Granted that in most men these sentiments aren't as strong as the ones concerning private good, still, everyone's feelings—even those of the most depraved and selfish people—must make *some* distinction ·between what is generally beneficial and what isn't·, attaching the notion of *good* to ·generally· beneficent conduct and the notion of *evil* to the contrary. Let's admit that

•sympathy is much fainter than our concern for ourselves, and that

•sympathy with persons far away is much fainter than sympathy with persons nearby.

But for precisely this reason we must, in our calm thinking and speaking about the characters of men, neglect all those differences—·setting aside self/other, near/far, and then/now·—and make our sentiments more public and social. And it's not just that we ourselves often change our situation in one of these respects; in addition to that, we're constantly meeting up with people whose situation is different from ours, people we could never talk with if we remained constantly in the position and point of view that is special to ourselves. So the interplay of sentiments in society and conversation makes us form some general unchanging standard by which we may approve or disapprove of characters and conduct. The heart doesn't entirely adopt those general notions, or regulate all its love and hatred by the universal abstract ·moral· differences of vice and virtue, without regard to whether something affects oneself or one's near and dear. Still, these ·abstract· moral differences have a lot of influence, and serve well enough for discourse at least,

•someone whose position joined to his virtue makes him really useful to society

than of

•someone who exercises the social virtues only in good intentions and benevolent affections, ·because his social position doesn't enable him to do any actual good for society·.

It isn't hard—and it is necessary—for us to separate each person's •character from •how things happen to work out for him; and having made this separation we judge these two persons to be morally on a par and give them the same general praise. Our judgment corrects the appearance, or tries to; but it can't entirely prevail over sentiment. Why is this peach-tree said to be better than that one, if not because it produces more or better fruit? And wouldn't we give the same praise to it even if snails or vermin had destroyed the peaches before they were ripe? In morals too, isn't *the tree known by the fruit*? And can't we easily distinguish nature from accident with the man as well as with the tree?

[12] Nature has wisely ordained that private connections should commonly prevail over universal views and considerations; otherwise our affections and actions would be dissipated and lost, for lack of a proper *limited* object. Thus, a small benefit done to ourselves or our near friends arouses more lively sentiments of love and approval than a great benefit done to a distant commonwealth. But still we •know to correct these inequalities by

which means that they serve all our purposes in company, in the pulpit, on the stage, and in the schools.[12]

Thus, in whatever light we take this subject, the merit ascribed to the social virtues still appears to be uniform, and arises chiefly from the concern that the natural sentiment of benevolence gets us to have for the interests of mankind and society. If we consider these drives that are built into the human make-up, as we encounter them in daily experience and observation, we must *a priori* conclude that a creature such as man *can't* be totally indifferent to the well-being or ill-being of his fellow-creatures, and *must* be disposed to pronounce straight off—in a case where nothing gives him any particular bias—that what promotes their happiness is good and what tends to their misery is bad, saying this without any qualifications or ifs or buts. [Strictly, an *a priori* belief owes nothing to experience, whereas this one, Hume says, rests on 'daily experience and observation'. But when on this page he speaks of looking at the matter *a posteriori* (the standard opposite of *a priori*), it seems that the distinction he is making is between **(1)** views about morality that are based on the **prior** facts about human nature from **(2)** views about morality that are based on facts about the consequences of morality, the facts that are **posterior** to it.] Here then are the faint rudiments or outlines, at least, of a *general* distinction between actions; and to the extent that any individual person's humanity intensifies •his connection with those who are injured or benefited and •the liveliness of his conception of their misery or happiness, his consequent censure or approval will become correspondingly more vigorous. A generous action barely mentioned in an old history book or a minor magazine needn't communicate any strong feelings of applause and admiration. When virtue is placed at such a distance, it's like a star: to the eye of reason it appears as luminous as the sun at noon [i.e. as a matter of theory we think it is that bright], but it's so far away that it doesn't affect the senses with either light or heat. Bring this virtue nearer, by our acquaintance or connection with the people involved or even just by an eloquent description of the case, and then our hearts are immediately caught, our sympathy enlivened, and our cool approval converted into the warmest sentiments of friendship and respect. These seem to be necessary and certain consequences of the general principles of [= 'drives in'] human nature as revealed in common life and practice.

Now let us run all this in the opposite direction. Consider the matter *a posteriori*, thinking about consequences. Doesn't the merit of social virtue come in large measure from the feelings of humanity that such virtue produces in the spectators? It seems to be a plain matter of *fact* •that the utility of something—of *anything*—is a source of praise and approval; that utility is

- •constantly appealed to in all moral decisions about the merit or demerit of actions;
- •the only source of the high respect paid to justice, fidelity, honour, allegiance, chastity;
- •inseparable from all the other social virtues—humanity, generosity, charity, friendliness, mildness, affability, gentleness, mercy and moderation; and, in short,
- •a foundation for the chief part of morals, the part concerning mankind as a whole.

It appears also that in our general approval of characters and conduct, the useful tendency of the social virtues doesn't move us through self-interest, but has a much more universal and extensive influence. It appears that a tendency to public good and to the promoting of peace, harmony and

thinking about them, and •retain a general standard of vice and virtue based chiefly on general usefulness. These corrections are like the ones we perform in processing what comes to us through our senses.

order in society always engages us on the side of the social virtues by working on the benevolent forces in the human make-up. And it appears, as an additional confirmation, that these drives of humanity and sympathy enter so deeply into all our sentiments, and have such a powerful influence, that they can arouse the strongest censure and applause. My present theory is the simple result of all these inferences, each of which seems to be based on uniform experience and observation.

If you aren't sure whether there's anything in our nature giving us •humanity or •a concern for others, think about this:

> •We see in countless cases that anything tending to promote the interests of society is very highly approved of ·by people in general·.

That should teach you that we have a drive to benevolence, and that it is strong; because nothing could possibly please us as a means to an end if we didn't care in the least about the end. On the other hand, if you aren't sure whether there is implanted in our nature anything making us engage in moral blame and approval, think about this:

> •We see in countless cases the influence of humaneness.

From that you should infer that everything that promotes the interests of society must communicate pleasure, and what is harmful must give uneasiness. But when these different lines of thought come together in establishing the same conclusion, don't they put that conclusion beyond the reach of any doubt or denial?

But I hope to provide further confirmation for this theory when I present other sentiments of admiration and respect that come from the same source or from ones like it.

Section 6: Qualities useful to ourselves

Part 1

It seems clear that when we examine a quality or habit that someone has, if it shows up as being in any respect bad for the person in question, or if it incapacitates him for business and action, we immediately blame it, and count it among his faults and imperfections. Laziness, negligence, lack of order and method, obstinacy, fickleness, rashness, credulity—no-one ever regarded any of these qualities as neutral features of someone's character, let alone praised them as accomplishments or virtues! Their downside immediately strikes our eye, and gives us the sentiment of pain and disapproval.

It's generally agreed that no quality is absolutely either blameable or praiseworthy; ·i.e. there's no quality that is blameable whenever it occurs, and none that is praiseworthy whenever it occurs·. The moral status of a given instance of a quality depends on the *degree* to which the quality is present in it. The Aristotelians say that what makes something virtuous is its being appropriately between two extremes; ·but that isn't seriously in conflict with my view, because· this *between* position is chiefly determined by usefulness.

Groundwork for the Metaphysic of Morals

Immanuel Kant

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[Brackets] enclose editorial explanations. Small ·dots· enclose material that has been added, but can be read as though it were part of the original text. Occasional •bullets, and also indenting of passages that are not quotations, are meant as aids to grasping the structure of a sentence or a thought. Every four-point ellipsis . . . . indicates the omission of a brief passage that seems to present more difficulty than it is worth. Longer omissions are rerported between square brackets in normal-sized type.] In the title, 'Groundwork' refers not to the foundation that is laid but to the work of laying it.

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Preface

Ancient Greek philosophy was divided into three branches of knowledge: •natural science, •ethics, and •logic. This classification perfectly fits what it is meant to fit; the only improvement it needs is the supplying of the *principle* on which it is based; that will let us be sure that the classification does cover all the ground, and will enable us to define the necessary subdivisions ·of the three broad kinds of knowledge·. [Kant, following the Greek, calls the trio *Physik*, *Ethik* and *Logik*. Our word 'physics' is much too narrow for *Physik*, which is why 'natural science' is preferred here. What is lost is the surface *neatness* of the Greek and German trio, and of the contrast between natural science and metaphysics, *Physik* and *Metaphysik*]

There are two kinds of rational knowledge:

- •material knowledge, which concerns some object, and
- •formal knowledge, which pays no attention to differences between objects, and is concerned only with the *form* of understanding and of reason, and with the universal rules of thinking.

Formal philosophy is called •'logic'. Material philosophy—having to do with definite objects and the laws that govern them—is divided into two parts, depending on whether the laws in question are laws of •nature or laws of •freedom. Knowledge of laws of the former kind is called •'natural science', knowledge of laws of the latter kind is called •'ethics'. The two are also called 'theory of nature' and 'theory of morals' respectively.

•Logic can't have anything empirical about it—it can't have a part in which universal and necessary laws of thinking are derived from *experience*. If it did, it wouldn't be *logic*—i.e. a set of rules for the understanding or for reason, rules that are valid for *all* thinking and that must be rigorously proved. The •natural and •moral branches of knowledge, on the other hand, *can* each have an empirical part; indeed, they must do so because each must discover the laws ·for its domain·. For •the former, these are the laws of nature considered as something known through experience; and for •the latter, they are the laws of the human will so far as it is affected by nature. ·The two sets of laws are nevertheless very different from one another·. The laws of *nature* are laws according to which everything *does* happen; the laws of morality are laws according to which everything *ought to* happen; they allow for conditions under which what ought to happen doesn't happen.

•*Empirical* philosophy is philosophy that is based on experience. •*Pure* philosophy is philosophy that presents its doctrines solely on the basis of *a priori* principles. Pure philosophy ·can in turn be divided into two·: when it is entirely *formal* it is •logic; when it is confined to definite objects of the understanding, it is •metaphysics.

In this way there arises the idea of a two-fold metaphysic—a *metaphysic of nature* and a *metaphysic of morals*. Physics, therefore, will have an empirical part and also a rational part, and ethics likewise, though here the empirical part may be called more specifically 'practical anthropology' and the rational part 'morals' in the strict sense.

All crafts, trades and arts have profited from the division of labour; for when •each worker sticks to one particular kind of work that needs to be handled differently from all the others, he can do it better and more easily than when •one person does everything. Where work is not thus differentiated and divided, where everyone is a jack-of-all-trades, the crafts remain at an utterly primitive level. Now, here is a question worth asking: Doesn't pure philosophy in each of its parts require a man who is particularly devoted to that part? Some people regularly mix up the empirical with the rational, suiting their mixture to the taste of the public

without actually knowing what its proportions are; they call themselves *independent thinkers* and write off those who apply themselves exclusively to the rational part of philosophy as mere *ponderers*. Wouldn't things be improved for the learned profession as a whole if those 'independent thinkers' were *warned* that they shouldn't carry on two employments at once—employments that need to be handled quite differently, perhaps requiring different special talents for each—because all you get when one person does several of them is bungling? But all I am asking is this: Doesn't the nature of the science ·of philosophy· require that we carefully separate its empirical from its rational part? That would involve putting

- •a metaphysic of nature before real (empirical) natural science, and
- •a metaphysic of morals before practical anthropology.

Each of these two branches of metaphysics must be carefully cleansed of everything empirical, so that we can know how much pure reason can achieve in each branch, and from what sources it creates its *a priori* teaching. ·The metaphysic of morals must be cleansed in this way, no matter who the metaphysicians of morals are going to be·—whether they will include all the moralists (there are plenty of them!) or only a few who feel a calling to this task.

Since my purpose here is directed to moral philosophy, I narrow the question I am asking down to this:

- •Isn't it utterly necessary to construct a pure moral philosophy that is completely freed from everything that may be only empirical and thus belong to anthropology?

That there must be such a philosophy is self-evident from the common idea of *duty* and *moral laws*. Everyone must admit •that if a law is to hold *morally* (i.e. as a basis for someone's being *obliged* to do something), it must imply absolute necessity; •that the command: *You are not to lie* doesn't apply only to human beings, as though it had no force for other rational beings (and similarly with all other moral laws properly so called); •that the basis for obligation here mustn't be looked for in people's natures or their circumstances, but ·must be found· *a priori* solely in the concepts of pure reason; and •that any precept resting on principles of mere experience may be called a practical rule but never a moral law. This last point holds even if there is something universal about the precept in question, and even if its empirical content is very small (perhaps bringing in only the motive involved).

Thus not only are moral laws together with their principles essentially different from all practical knowledge involving anything empirical, but all moral philosophy rests solely on its pure ·or non-empirical· part. Its application to human beings doesn't depend on knowledge of any facts about them (anthropology); it gives them, as rational beings, *a priori* laws—·ones that are valid *whatever* the empirical circumstances may be·. (Admittedly ·experience comes into the story in a certain way, because· these laws require a power of judgment that has been sharpened by experience—•partly in order to pick out the cases where the laws apply and •partly to let the laws get into the person's will and to stress that they are to be acted on. For a human being has so many preferences working on him that, though he is quite capable of having the *idea* of a practical pure reason, he can't so easily bring it to bear on the details of how he lives his life.)

A metaphysic of morals is therefore indispensable, ·for two reasons, one •theoretical and one •practical·. One reason comes from •our wish, as theoreticians, to explore the source of the *a priori* practical principles that lie in our reason. The other reason is that •until we have the guide and supreme

norm for making correct moral judgments, morality itself will be subject to all kinds of corruption. ·Here is the reason for that·. For something to be morally good, it isn't enough that it conforms to the ·moral· law; it must be done *because* it conforms to the law. An action that isn't performed with that motive *may* happen to fit the moral law, but its conformity to the law will be chancy and unstable, and more often than not the action won't be lawful at all. So we need to find the moral law in its purity and genuineness, this being what matters most in questions about conduct; and the only place to find it is in a philosophy that is *pure* ·in the sense I have introduced—see page 1·. So metaphysics must lead the way; without it there can't *be* any moral philosophy. Philosophy ·that isn't pure, i.e.· that mixes pure principles with empirical ones, doesn't deserve the name of 'philosophy' (for what distinguishes •philosophy from •intelligent common sense is precisely that •the former treats as separate kinds of knowledge what •the latter jumbles up together). Much less can it count as 'moral philosophy', since by this mixing ·of pure with empirical· it deprives morality of its purity and works against morality's own purposes.

I am pointing to the need for an entirely new field of investigation to be opened up. You might think that ·there is nothing new about it because· it is already present in the famous Wolff's 'introduction' to his moral philosophy (i.e. in what he called 'universal practical philosophy'); but it isn't. Precisely because his work aimed to be *universal* practical philosophy, it didn't deal with any particular *kind* of will, and attended only to *will in general* and with such actions and conditions as that brings in; and so it had no room for the notion of •a will that is determined by *a priori* principles with no empirical motives, which means that it had no place for anything that could be called •a *pure* will. Thus Wolff's 'introduction'. . . .concerns the actions and conditions of the **human will** as such, which for the most part are drawn from ·empirical· psychology, whereas the metaphysic of morals aims ·at a non-empirical investigation, namely· investigating the idea and principles of a **possible pure will**. Without having the least right to do so, Wolff's 'universal practical philosophy' does have things to say about *laws* and *duty*; but this doesn't conflict with what I have been saying. For the authors of this intellectual project remain true to *their* idea of it ·in this part of its territory also: they· don't distinguish

- •motives that are presented completely *a priori* by reason alone and are thus *moral* in the proper sense of the word,

from

- •motives that involve empirical concepts—ones that the understanding turns into universal concepts by comparing experiences.

In the absence of that distinction, they consider motives without regard to how their sources differ; they treat them as all being of the same kind, and merely *count* them; and on that basis they formulate their concept of *obligation*, ·so-called·. This is as far from *moral* obligation as it could be; but in a philosophy that doesn't decide whether the origin of all possible practical concepts is *a priori* or *a posteriori*, what more could you expect?

Intending some day to publish a •metaphysic of morals, I now present this •groundwork, ·this exercise of foundation-laying·, for it. There is, to be sure, no other basis for such a metaphysic than a critical examination of *pure practical reason*, just as there is no other basis for metaphysic than the critical examination of *pure speculative reason* that I have already published. [The unavoidable word 'speculative' (like its cognate'speculation') is half of the dichotomy between practical and speculative. A speculative endeavour is one aimed at establishing truths about what *is* the case, implying nothing about what *ought* to be the

case; with no suggestion that it involves guesswork or anything like that. Two of Kant's most famous titles—*Critique of Pure Reason* and *Critique of Practical Reason* —are really short-hand for *Critique of Pure Speculative Reason* and *Critique of Pure Practical Reason.* respectively. That involves the speculative/practical contrast; there is no pure/practical contrast. The second of those two works, incidentally, still lay in the future when Kant wrote the present work.] However, ·I have three reasons for not plunging straight into a critical examination of pure practical reason·. **(1)** It is nowhere near as important to have a critical examination of pure •practical reason as it is to have one of ·pure· •speculative reason. That is because even in the commonest mind, human reason can easily be brought to a high level of correctness and completeness in moral matters, whereas reason in its theoretical but pure use is wholly dialectical [= 'runs into unavoidable self-contradictions']. **(2)** When we are conducting a critical examination of pure practical reason, I insist that the job is not finished until •practical reason and •speculative reason are brought together and unified under a common concept of *reason*, because ultimately they have to be merely different applications of one and the same *reason*. But I couldn't achieve this kind of completeness ·here· without confusing the reader by bringing in considerations of an altogether different kind ·from the matter in hand·. That is why I have used the title *Groundwork for the Metaphysic of Morals* rather than *Critique of Pure Practical Reason*. **(3)** A metaphysic of morals, in spite of its forbidding title, can be done in a popular way so that people of ordinary intelligence can easily take it in; so I find it useful to separate this preliminary work on the foundation, dealing with certain subtleties *here* so that I can keep them out of the more comprehensible work that will come later. [Here and throughout, 'popular' means 'pertaining to or suitable for ordinary not very educated people'. The notion of being widely *liked* is not prominent in its meaning.]

In laying a foundation, however, all I am doing is seeking and establishing the *supreme principle of morality*—a self-contained and entirely completable task that should be kept separate from every other moral inquiry. Until now there hasn't been *nearly* enough attention to this important question ·of the nature of and basis for the supreme principle of morality·. My conclusions about it could be •clarified by bringing the ·supreme· principle to bear on the whole system of morality, and •confirmed by how well it would serve all through. But I must forgo this advantage: basically it would gratify me rather than helping anyone else, because a principle's being easy to use and its seeming to serve well don't prove for sure that it is right. They are more likely merely to create a *bias* in its favour, which will get in the way of its being ruthlessly probed and evaluated in its own right and without regard to consequences.

[Kant has, and uses in the present work, a well-known distinction between •'analytic' propositions (known to be true just by analysing their constituent concepts) and •'synthetic' propositions (can't be known without bringing in something that the concepts don't contain). In this next sentence he uses those terms in a different way—one that goes back to Descartes—in which they mark off not two •kinds of proposition but two •ways of proceeding. In the analytic procedure, you start with what's familiar and on that basis work out what the relevant general principles are; synthetic procedure goes the other way—you start with general principles and derive familiar facts from them.]

In the present work I have adopted the method that is, I think, the most suitable if one wants to proceed •analytically from common knowledge to settling what its supreme principle is, and then •synthetically from examining this principle and its sources back to common knowledge to which it applies. So the work is divided up thus:

Chapter 1 Moving from common-sense knowledge to philosophical knowledge about morality.
Chapter 2 Moving from popular moral philosophy to the metaphysic of morals.
Chapter 3 Final step from the metaphysic of morals to the critical examination of pure practical reason.

Chapter 1:

Moving from common-sense knowledge to philosophical knowledge about morality

Nothing in the world—*or out of it*!—can possibly be conceived that could be called 'good' without qualification except a GOOD WILL. Mental *talents* such as intelligence, wit, and judgment, and *temperaments* such as courage, resoluteness, and perseverance are doubtless in many ways good and desirable; but they can become extremely bad and harmful if the person's *character* isn't good—i.e. if the *will* that is to make use of these •gifts of nature isn't good. Similarly with •gifts of fortune. Power, riches, honour, even health, and the over-all well-being and contentment with one's condition that we call 'happiness', create pride, often leading to arrogance, if there isn't a good will to correct their influence on the mind. . . . Not to mention the fact that the sight of someone who shows no sign of a pure and good will and yet enjoys uninterrupted prosperity will never give pleasure to an impartial rational observer. So it seems that without a good will one can't even be worthy of being happy.

Even qualities that are conducive to this good will and can make its work easier have no intrinsic unconditional worth. We rightly hold them in high esteem, but only because we assume them to be accompanied by a good will; so we can't take them to be absolutely ·or unconditionally· good. •Moderation in emotions and passions, self-control, and calm deliberation not only are good in many ways but seem even to constitute part of the person's *inner* worth, and they were indeed unconditionally valued by the ancients. Yet they are very far from being good without qualification—·good in themselves, good in any circumstances·—for without the principles of a good will they can become extremely bad: ·for example·, a villain's •coolness makes him far more dangerous and more straightforwardly abominable to us than he would otherwise have seemed.

What makes a good will *good*? It isn't what it brings about, its usefulness in achieving some intended end. Rather, good will is good because of *how it wills*—i.e. it is *good in itself*. Taken just in itself it is to be valued incomparably more highly than anything that could be brought about by it in the satisfaction of some preference—or, if you like, the sum total of all preferences! Consider this case:

> Through bad luck or a miserly endowment from stepmotherly nature, this person's will has no power at all to accomplish its purpose; not even the greatest effort on his part would enable it to achieve anything it aims at. But he does still have a good will—not as a

> mere wish but as the summoning of all the means in his power.

The good will of this person would sparkle like a jewel all by itself, as something that had its full worth in itself. Its value wouldn't go up or down depending on how useful or fruitless it was. If it was useful, that would only be the *setting* ·of the jewel·, so to speak, enabling us to handle it more conveniently in commerce (·a diamond ring is easier to manage than a diamond·) or to get those who don't know much ·about jewels· to look at it. But the setting doesn't affect the value ·of the jewel· and doesn't recommend it the experts.

But there is something extremely strange in this •idea of the absolute worth of the will—the mere *will*—with no account taken of any use to which it is put. It is indeed *so* strange that, despite the agreement even of common sense (·an agreement I have exhibited in the preceding three paragraphs·), you're bound to suspect that there may be nothing to it but high-flown fancy, and that I have misunderstood what nature was up to in appointing reason as the ruler of our will. So let us critically examine the •idea from the point of view of this suspicion.

We take it as an axiom that in the natural constitution of an organized being (i.e. one suitably adapted to life) no organ will be found that isn't perfectly adapted to its purpose, whatever that is. Now suppose that nature's real purpose for you, a being with reason and will, were that you should survive, thrive, and be happy—in that case nature would have hit upon a *very* poor arrangement in appointing your *reason* to carry out this purpose! For all the actions that you need to perform in order to carry out *this* intention of nature - and indeed the entire regulation of your conduct—would be marked out for you much more exactly and reliably by *instinct* than it ever could be by *reason*. And if nature had favoured you by giving you reason as well as instinct, the role of reason would have been to let you •contemplate the happy constitution of your nature, to admire it, to rejoice in it, and to be grateful for it to its beneficent cause; *not* to let you •subject your faculty of desire to that weak and delusive guidance and to interfere with nature's purpose. In short, nature would have taken care that reason didn't intrude into *practical morality* and have the presumption, with its weak insight, to think out for itself the plan of happiness and how to get it. Nature would have taken over the choice not only of ends but also of the means to them, and with wise foresight she would have entrusted both to instinct alone. [Kant presents this paragraph in terms not of 'you' but of 'a being'.]

What we find in fact is that the more a cultivated reason devotes itself to the enjoyment of life and happiness, the more the person falls short of true contentment; which is why many people—especially those who have made the greatest use of reason—have a certain hostility towards reason, though they may not be candid enough to admit it. They have drawn many advantages from reason; never mind about its role in the inventions that lead to •ordinary luxuries; my interest is in the advantages of intellectual pursuits, which eventually seem to these people to be also a •luxury of the understanding. But after looking over all this they find that they have actually brought more trouble on themselves than they have gained in happiness; and eventually they come not to *despise* but to *envy* the common run of people who stay closer to merely natural instinct and don't give reason much influence on their doings. ·So much for the drawbacks of well-being and happiness as one's dominant aim in life·. As for those who play down or outright deny the boastful eulogies that are given of the happiness and contentment that reason can supposedly bring us: the judgment they are making doesn't involve gloom, or

ingratitude for how well the world is governed. Rather, it's based on the idea of another and far nobler purpose for their existence. It is for achieving *this* purpose, not happiness, that reason is properly intended; and this purpose is the supreme condition, so that the private purposes of men must for the most part take second place to it. ·Its being the supreme or highest condition means that it isn't itself conditional on anything else; it is to be aimed at *no matter what* else is the case; which is why our private plans must stand out of its way·.

So reason isn't competent to act as a guide that will lead the will reliably to its objectives and will satisfy all our needs (indeed it *adds* to our needs!); an implanted instinct would do this job much more reliably. Nevertheless, reason is given to us as a *practical* faculty, that is, one that is meant to have an influence on the *will*. Its proper function must be to produce a will that is good *in itself* and not good *as a means*. Why? Because

- •nature has everywhere distributed capacities suitable to the functions they are to perform,
- •the *means* ·to good· are, as I have pointed out, better provided for by instinct, and
- •reason and it alone can produce a will that is good *in itself*.

This ·good· will needn't be the sole and complete good, but it must be the condition of all others, even of the desire for happiness. So we have to consider two purposes: **(1)** the unconditional purpose of producing a good will, and **(2)** the conditional purpose of being happy. Of these, **(1)** requires the cultivation of reason, which - at least in this life—in many ways *limits* and can indeed almost *eliminate* **(2)** the goal of happiness. This state of affairs is entirely compatible with the wisdom of nature; it doesn't have nature pursuing its goal clumsily; because reason, recognizing that its highest practical calling is to establish a good will, can by achieving that goal get a contentment of its own kind (the kind that comes from attaining a goal set by reason), even though this gets in the way of things that the person merely *prefers*.

So we have to develop •the concept of a will that is to be esteemed as good in itself without regard to anything else, •the concept that always takes first place in judging the total worth of our actions, with everything else depending on it, •a concept that is already lodged in any natural and sound understanding, and doesn't need to be *taught* so much as to be *brought to light*. In order to develop and unfold it, I'll dig into the concept of duty, which *contains* it. The concept of a good will is present in the concept of duty, ·not shining out in all its objective and unconditional glory, but rather· in a manner that brings it under certain subjective •restrictions and •hindrances; but •these are far from concealing it or disguising it, for they rather bring it out by contrast and make it shine forth all the more brightly. ·I shall now look at that contrast·.

·My topic is the difference between doing something from duty and doing it for other reasons. In tackling this, I shall set aside without discussion two kinds of case—one for which my question doesn't arise, and a second for which the question arises but is too easy to answer for the case to be interesting or instructive. Following those two, I shall introduce two further kinds of case·. **(1)** I shan't discuss actions which—even if they are useful in some way or other—are clearly *opposed to* duty, because with them the question of doing them *from duty* doesn't even arise. **(2)** I shall also ignore cases where someone does A, which really is in accord with duty, but where what he directly *wants* isn't to perform A but to perform B which somehow leads to or involves A. ·For example: he (B) unbolts the door so as to escape from the fire, and in so doing he (A) enables

others to escape also. There is no need to spend time on such cases·, because *in them* it is easy to tell whether an action that is in accord with duty is done •from duty or rather •for some selfish purpose. **(3)** It is far harder to detect that difference when the action the person performs—one that is in accord with duty—is what he directly wanted to do, ·rather than being something he did only because it was involved in something *else* that he directly wanted to do·. Take the example of a shop-keeper who charges the same prices for selling his goods to inexperienced customers as for selling them to anyone else. This is in accord with duty. But there is also a prudential and not-duty-based motive that the shop-keeper might have for this course of conduct: when there is a buyers' market, he may sell as cheaply to children as to others so as not to lose customers. Thus the customer is honestly served, but we can't infer from this that the shop-keeper has behaved in this way from duty and principles of honesty. His own advantage requires this behaviour, and we can't assume that in addition he directly wants something for his customers and out of love for them he charges them all the same price. His conduct of his policy on pricing comes neither from *duty* nor from *directly wanting* it, but from a selfish purpose. [Kant's German really does say first that the shop-keeper *isn't* led by a direct want and then that he *is*. His point seems to be this: The shop-keeper *does* want to treat all his customers equitably; his intention is aimed at precisely that fact about his conduct (unlike the case in **(2)** where the agent enables other people to escape but isn't aiming at that *at all*). But the shop-keeper's intention doesn't *stop there*, so to speak; he wants to treat his customers equitably not because of what he wants for *them*, but because of how he wants them to behave later in *his* interests. This involves a kind of indirectness, which doesn't assimilate this case to **(2)** but does distinguish it from a fourth kind of conduct that still isn't morally worthy but not because it involves the 'indirectness' of **(2)** or that of **(3)**.]

(4) It is a duty to preserve one's life, and moreover everyone directly wants to do so. But because of ·the power of· that want, the often anxious care that most men have for their survival has no intrinsic worth, and the maxim *Preserve yourself* has no moral content. Men preserve their lives *according to* duty, but not *from* duty. But now consider this case:

> Adversities and hopeless sorrow have completely taken away this unfortunate man's relish for life. But his fate has not made him ·passively· •despondent or dejected. He is strong in soul, and is •exasperated at how things have gone for him, ·and would like actively to do something about it. Specifically·, he *wishes for death*. But he preserves his life without loving it, not led by any want or fear, but acting from duty.

For this person the maxim *Preserve yourself* has moral content.

We have a duty to be charitably helpful where we can, and many people are so sympathetically constituted that without any motive of vanity or selfishness they •find an inner satisfaction in spreading joy and •take delight in the contentment of others if they have made it possible. But I maintain that such behaviour, done in that spirit, has no true moral worth, however amiable it may be and however much it accords with duty. It should be classed with ·actions done from· other wants, such as the desire for honour. With luck, someone's desire for honour may lead to conduct that in fact accords with duty and does good to many people; in that case it deserves •praise and •encouragement; but it doesn't deserve •high esteem, because the maxim ·on which the person is acting· doesn't have the moral content of an action done not because the person *likes* acting in that way but from duty. [In this context, 'want' and 'liking' and 'desire' are used

to translate *Neigung*, elsewhere in this version translated as 'preference'; other translations mostly use 'inclination'.]

Now consider a special case:

> This person has been a friend to mankind, but his mind has become clouded by a sorrow of his own that has extinguished all feeling for how others are faring. He still has the power to benefit others in distress, but their need leaves him untouched because he is too preoccupied with his own. But now he tears himself out of his dead insensibility and acts charitably purely from duty, without feeling any want or liking so to behave.

Now, for the first time, his conduct has genuine moral worth. Having been deprived by nature of a warm-hearted temperament, this man could find in himself a source from which to give himself a far higher worth than he could have got through such a temperament. It is just here that the worth of character is brought out, which is morally the incomparably highest of all: he is beneficent not from preference but from duty.

To secure one's own happiness is a duty (at least indirectly), because discontent with one's condition—bundled along by many cares and unmet needs—could easily become a great *temptation to transgress against duties*. But quite apart from duty, all men have the strongest and deepest desire [*Neigung*] for happiness, because in the idea of happiness all our desires are brought together in a single sum-total. But the injunction 'Be happy!' often takes a form in which it *thwarts* some desires, so that a person can't get a clear and secure concept of •the sum-total of satisfactions that goes under the name 'happiness'. So it isn't surprising that the prospect of •a single satisfaction, definite as to what it is and when it can be had, can outweigh a fluctuating idea ·such as that of happiness·. For example, a man with the gout [a painful ailment made worse by alcohol and rich food] can choose to enjoy what he likes and put up with the consequences, because according to his calculations (this time, anyway) he hasn't sacrificed present pleasure to a possibly groundless expectation of the 'happiness' that health is supposed to bring. But even for this man, whose will is not settled by the general desire for happiness and for whom health plays no part in his calculations, there still remains—as there does for everyone—the law that *he ought to promote his happiness, not from wanting or liking but from duty*. Only by following this could his conduct have true moral worth.

No doubt this is how we should understand the scriptural passages that command us to love our neighbour and even our enemy. We can't be commanded to *feel* love for someone, or to simply *prefer* that he thrive. There are two sorts of love: •practical love that lies in the will and in principles of action, and •pathological love that lies in the direction the person's feelings and tender sympathies take. [Kant uses 'pathological' simply to mean that this is a *state* that the person is in; from Greek *pathos* = 'that which happens to a person'; no suggestion of abnormality. His point is that being a *loving* person is no more morally significant than being a *stupid* person or a *right-handed* person.] The latter of these cannot be commanded, but the former can be—and that is a command to do good to others from duty, even when you don't want to do it or like doing it, and indeed even when you naturally and unconquerably *hate* doing it.

·So much for the **first proposition** of morality:

> •For an action to have genuine moral worth it must be done from duty.·

The **second proposition** is:

> •An action that is done from duty doesn't get its moral value from the purpose that's to be achieved through it but from the maxim that it involves, ·giving the *reason* why the person acts thus·.

So the action's moral value doesn't depend on whether what is aimed at in it is actually achieved, but solely on the principle *of the will* from which the action is done, irrespective of anything the faculty of *desire* may be aiming at. From what I have said it is clear that the purposes we may have in acting, and their effects as drivers of the will towards desired ends, can't give our actions any unconditional value, any *moral* value. Well, then, if the action's moral value isn't to be found in

•the will in its relation to its hoped-for effect,

where *can* it be found? The only possible source for it is

•the principle on which the will acts—and never mind the ends that may be achieved by the action.

For the will stands at the crossroads, so to speak, at the intersection between •its *a priori* principle, which is formal, and •its *a posteriori* driver—·the contingent desire that acts on it·—which is material. In that position it must be determined by something; and if it is done from duty it must be determined by the formal principle of the will, since every material principle—·every contingent driver of the will·—has been withdrawn from it.

The **third proposition**—a consequence of the first two—I would express as follows:

•To have a duty is to be required to act in a certain way out of respect for law.

(1) As for what will result from my action, I can certainly *prefer* or *be drawn to* it, but I can't have *respect* for it; to earn my respect it would have to be something the will *does*, not merely something that its doings *lead to*. **(2)** Similarly, I can't •respect any want or preference: if the preference is mine, the most I can do is to •endorse it; if it is someone else's I can even •love it—i.e. see it as favourable to my interests. What can get respect and can thus serve as a command is •something that isn't **(1)** a consequence of my volition but only a source for it, and isn't **(2)** in the service of my preferences but rather overpowers them or at least prevents them from being considered in the choice I make; •this something is, in a word, *law* itself. Suppose now that someone acts from duty: the influence of his *preferences* can't have anything to do with this, and so facts about what he might achieve by his action don't come into it either; so what is there left that can lead him to act as he does? If the question means 'What is there objectively, i.e. distinct from himself, that determines his will in this case?' the only possible answer is *law*. And if the question concerns what there is *in the person* that influences his will—i.e. what subjectively influences it—the answer has to be *his respect for this practical law*, and thus his acceptance of the maxim *I am to follow this law even if it thwarts all my desires*. (A maxim is a subjective principle of volition. The objective principle is the practical law itself; it would also be the subjective principle for all rational beings if reason fully controlled the formation of preferences.)

So an action's moral value doesn't lie in •the effect that is expected from it, or in •any principle of action that motivates it because of this expected effect. All the expected effects—something agreeable for me, or even happiness for others—could be brought about through other causes and don't *need* •the will of a rational being, whereas the highest good—what is unconditionally good—can be found only in •such a will. So this wonderful good, which we call *moral* goodness, can't consist in anything but *the thought of law* in itself *that only a rational being can have*—with the will being moved to act by this thought and not by the hoped-for effect of the action. When the person acts according to this conception, this moral goodness is already present •in him; we don't have to look for it •in the upshot of

his action.[1] [In passages like this, 'thought' translates *Vorstellung* = 'mental representation'.]

So we have a law the thought of which can settle the will without reference to any expected result, and *must* do so if the will is to be called absolutely good without qualification; what kind of law can this be? Since I have robbed the will of any *impulses* that could come to it from obeying any law, nothing remains to serve as a ·guiding· principle of the will except *conduct's universally conforming to law as such*. That is, **I ought never to act in such a way that I couldn't also will that the maxim on which I act should be a universal law**. In this context the ·guiding· principle of the will is conformity to law as such, not bringing in any particular law governing some class of actions; and it *must* serve as the will's principle if *duty* is not to be a vain delusion and chimerical concept. Common sense in its practical judgments is in perfect agreement with this, and constantly has this principle in view.

Consider the question: May I when in difficulties make a promise that I intend not to keep? The question obviously has two meanings: is it •prudent to make a false promise? does it conform to •duty to make a false promise? No doubt it often *is* •prudent, ·but not as often as you might think·. Obviously the false promise isn't made prudent by its merely extricating me from my present difficulties; I have to think about whether it will in the long run cause more trouble than it saves in the present. Even with all my supposed cunning, the consequences can't be so easily foreseen. People's loss of trust in me might be far more disadvantageous than the trouble I am now trying to avoid, and it is hard to tell whether it mightn't be more *prudent* to act according to a universal maxim *not ever to make a promise that I don't intend to keep*. But I quickly come to see that such a maxim is based only on fear of consequences. Being truthful from •duty is an entirely different thing from being truthful out of •fear of bad consequences; for in •the former case a law is included in the concept of the action itself (·so that the right answer to '*What* are you doing?' will include a mention of that law·); whereas in •the latter I must first look outward to see what results my action may have. [In the preceding sentence, Kant speaks of a 'law for me' and of results 'for me'.] To deviate from the principle of duty is certainly bad; whereas to be unfaithful to my maxim

[1] It might be objected that I tried to take refuge in an obscure feeling behind the word 'respect', instead of clearing things up through a concept of reason. Although respect is indeed a feeling, it doesn't come from outer influence; rather, it is a •feeling that a rational concept creates unaided; so it is different in kind from all the •feelings caused from outside, the ones that can come from desire or fear. When I directly recognize something as a law for myself I recognize it *with respect*, which merely means that I am conscious of submitting my will to a law without interference from any other influences on my mind. The will's being directly settled by law, and the consciousness of this happening, is called 'respect'; so *respect* should be seen as an *effect* of the law's operation on the person's will, not as a *cause* of it. Really, respect is the thought of a value that breaks down my self-love. Thus it is not something to be either desired or feared, though it has something analogous to both ·desire and fear·. The only thing that can be respected is law, and it has to be the law that we •impose on ourselves yet •recognize as necessary in itself.

•As a law it makes us subject to it, without consulting our self-love; which gives it some analogy to fear.
•As imposed on us by ourselves, it is a consequence of our will; which gives it some analogy to preference.

·This is really the only *basic* sense of the term 'respect'·. Any •respect for a *person* is only •respect for the law (of righteousness, etc.) of which the person provides an example. Our respect for a person's talents, for instance, is our recognition that we ought to practice until we are as talented as he is; we see him as a kind of example of a •law, because we regard it as our •duty to improve our talents. ·So respect for persons is a disguised form of respect for law·. All moral *concern* (as it is called) consists solely in respect for the law.

of prudence may be very advantageous to me, though it is certainly safer to abide by it. How can I know whether a deceitful promise is consistent with duty? The shortest way to go about finding out is also the surest. It is to ask myself:

- •Would I be content for my maxim (of getting out of a difficulty through a false promise) to hold as a *universal* law, for myself as well as for others?

·That is tantamount to asking·:

- •Could I say to myself that anyone may make a false promise when he is in a difficulty that he can't get out of in any other way?

Immediately I realize that I could will •the lie but not •a universal law to lie; for such a law would result in there being no promises at all, because it would be futile to offer stories about my future conduct to people who wouldn't believe me; or if they carelessly did believe me and were taken in ·by my promise·, would pay me back in my own coin. Thus my maxim would necessarily destroy itself as soon as it was made a universal law.

So I don't need to be a very penetrating thinker to bring it about that my will is morally good. Inexperienced in how the world goes, unable to prepare for all its contingencies, I need only to ask myself: *Can you will that your maxim become a universal law?* If not, it must be rejected, not because of any harm it might bring to anyone, but because there couldn't be a system of •universal legislation that included it as one of its principles, and •that is the kind of legislation that reason forces me to respect. I don't yet *see* what it is based on (a question that a philosopher may investigate), but I at least understand these two:

- •It is something whose value far outweighs all the value of everything aimed at by *desire*,
- •My duty consists in my having to act from pure respect for the practical law.

Every other motive must yield to duty, because it is the condition of a •will that is good in itself, and the value of •*that* surpasses everything.

And so in the common-sense understanding of morality we have worked our way through to its *principle*. Admittedly, common sense doesn't have the abstract thought of this principle as something universal, but it always has the principle in view and uses it as the standard for its judgments.

It would be easy to show how common sense, with this compass in its hand, knows very well how to distinguish •good from •bad, •consistent with duty from •inconsistent with duty. To do this it doesn't have to be taught anything new; it merely needs (Socrates-fashion) to have its attention drawn to the principle that it already has; and thus ·we can see· that neither science nor philosophy is needed in order to know what one must do to be honest and good, and even to be wise and virtuous. That's something we might well have assumed in advance: that the knowledge of what every person is obliged to do (and thus also what everyone is obliged to know) is *everyone's* business, even the most common person's. We can't help admiring the way common sense's ability to make •practical judgment outstrips its ability to make •theoretical ones. In •theoretical judgments, if common sense ventures to go beyond the laws of experience and perceptions of the senses, it falls into sheer inconceivabilities and self-contradictions, or at least into a chaos of uncertainty, obscurity, and instability. On the other hand, it is just when common sense *excludes* ·everything empirical—that is·, all action-drivers that bring in the senses—that its ability to make •practical judgments first shows itself to advantage. It may then start splitting hairs, quibbling with its own conscience or with other claims concerning what should be called right, or wanting to satisfy itself about the exact worth of certain actions; and the great

thing about these activities of common sense is that in them it has as good a chance of getting it right as any philosopher has—perhaps even a better chance, because the philosopher doesn't have any *principle* that common sense lacks and his judgment is easily confused by a mass of irrelevant considerations so that it easily goes astray. ·Here are two ways in which we could inter-relate common-sense morality and philosophy·: **(1)** We could go along with common-sense moral judgments, and bring in philosophy—if at all—only so as to make the system of morals more complete and comprehensible and its rules more convenient for use, especially in disputation. **(2)** We could steer common sense away from its fortunate simplicity in practical matters, and lead it *through* philosophy into a new path of inquiry and instruction. From what I have said, isn't it clear that **(1)** is the wiser option to take?

Innocence is indeed a glorious thing, but it is very sad that it doesn't take care of itself, and is easily led astray. For this reason, even wisdom—which consists in •doing and allowing more than in •knowing—needs science [*Wissenschaft*], not as something to learn from but as something that will ensure that wisdom's precepts get into the mind and stay there. ['Knowing' translates *Wissen*, which is half the word translated as 'science', an overlap that Kant surely intended. The 'science' in question here is presumably metaphysics.] ·Without that help, they are not likely to 'stay there', and here is why·. Against all commands of duty that a man's reason presents to him as deserving of so much respect, he feels in himself a powerful •counter-weight—namely, his needs and preferences, the complete satisfaction of which he lumps together as 'happiness'. Reason issues inexorable commands without promising the preferences anything ·by way of recompense·. It ignores and has no respect for the claims ·that desire makes·—claims that are so impetuous and yet so plausible, and which refuse to give way to any command. This gives rise to a natural dialectic—·an intellectual conflict or contradiction·—in the form of a propensity to argue against the stern laws of duty and their validity, or at least to cast doubt on their purity and strictness, and, where possible, to make them more accordant with our wishes and desires. This undermines the very foundations of duty's laws and destroys their dignity—which is something that even *ordinary* practical reason can't, when it gets right down to it, call good.

In this way common sense is driven to go outside its own territory and to take a step into the field of practical *philosophy*. It doesn't do this because of any speculative (= 'theory-building') need, which is something that never occurs to it so long as it is satisfied to remain merely healthy reason. [Kant's phrase translated here as 'common sense' is *gemeine Menschvernunft*, which contains *Vernunft* = 'reason'. Putting its bits together it could be taken to mean 'general human reason', but 'common sense' is about right.] Rather, it is driven to philosophy in order to become •informed and clearly •directed regarding the source of its principle and how exactly it differs from the maxims based on needs and preferences. It does this so as to escape from the embarrassment of opposing claims, and to avoid risking the loss of all genuine moral principles through the ambiguity in which common sense is easily involved—·the ambiguity between the moral and prudential readings of questions about what one ought to do·. Thus when common-sense moral thought develops itself, a dialectic surreptitiously occurs that forces it to look to philosophy for help, and the very same thing happens in common-sense theoretical thinking. It is true of each kind of ordinary or common-sense thought: each can come to rest only in a complete critical examination of our reason.

Chapter 2:

Moving from popular moral philosophy to the metaphysic of morals

Although I have derived our existing concept of duty from the ordinary ·commonsensical· use of our practical reason, that doesn't at all imply that I have treated it as an empirical concept. On the contrary, if we attend to our experience of men's doings, we meet frequent and—I admit—*justified* complaints that we can't cite a single sure example of someone's being disposed to act from pure duty—not one!— so that although much is done that accords with what duty commands, it always remains doubtful whether it is done *from* duty and thus whether it has moral worth. That is why there have always been philosophers who absolutely denied the reality of this ·dutiful· disposition in human actions, attributing everything ·that people do· to more or less refined self-interest. This hasn't led them to question the credentials of the concept of morality. Rather, they ·have left that standing, and· have spoken with sincere regret of the frailty and corruption of human nature, which •is high-minded enough to accept the idea ·of duty·—an idea so worthy of respect—as a source of commands, •is too weak to follow this idea ·by obeying the commands·, and •employs reason, which *ought* to be its source of laws, only to cater to the interests that its preferences create—either singly or, at best, in their greatest possible harmony with one another.

It is indeed absolutely impossible by means of experience to identify with complete certainty a single case in which the maxim of an action—however much it might *conform to* duty—rested solely on moral grounds and on the person's thought of his duty. It sometimes happens that we make a considerable sacrifice in performing some good action, and can't find within ourselves, search as we may, anything that could have the power to motivate this except the moral ground of duty. But this shouldn't make us confident that the true determining cause of the will was actually our •sense of duty rather than a secret impulse of •self-love masquerading as the idea of duty. For we like to give ourselves credit for having a more high-minded motive than we actually have; and even the strictest examination can never lead us entirely behind the secret action-drivers—·or, rather, behind the •pretended action-driver to where the •real one secretly lurks·—because when moral worth is in question it is not a matter of visible actions but of their invisible inner sources.

·The claim that the concept of duty is an empirical one is not only false but dangerous·. Consider the people who ridicule all morality as a mere phantom of human imagination overreaching itself through self-conceit: one couldn't give *them* anything they would like better than the concession that the concepts of duty have to come wholly from experience (for their laziness makes them apt to believe that the same is true of all other concepts too). This concession would give them a sure triumph. I am willing to admit—out of sheer generosity!—that most of our actions are in accord with duty; but if we look more closely at our thoughts and aspirations we keep encountering •the beloved *self* as what our plans rely on, rather than •the stern command of duty with its frequent calls for *self*-denial. One needn't be an enemy of virtue, merely a cool observer who can distinguish •even the most intense wish for the good from •actual good, to wonder sometimes whether true virtue is to be met with *anywhere* in the world; especially as one gets older and one's

power of judgment is made wiser by experience and more acute in observation. [Kant was 60 years old when he wrote this work.] What, then, can stop us from completely abandoning our ideas of duty, and preserve in us a well-founded respect for its law? Only the conviction that

> •Even if there never *were* any actions springing from such pure sources, *that*'s not the topic. Our concern is not •with whether this or that *was done*, but •with reason's commanding—on its own initiative and independently of all appearances—what *ought to be done*.

So our concern is •with ·a kind of· actions of which perhaps the world has never had an example; if you go purely by experience you might well wonder whether there *could* be such actions; and yet they are sternly commanded by reason. Take the example of *pure sincerity in friendship*: this can be demanded of every man as a duty; the demand comes independently of all experience from the idea of reason that acts on the will on *a priori* grounds; so it isn't weakened in the slightest by the fact—if it is a fact—that there has never actually been a sincere friend.

When this is added:

> •If we don't want to deny all truth to the concept of morality and to give up applying it to any possible object, we have to admit that morality's law applies so widely that it holds •not merely for men but for all rational beings as such, •not merely under certain contingent conditions and with exceptions but with absolute necessity ·and therefore unconditionally and without exceptions·,

—when *this* becomes clear to us, we see that no experience can point us towards even the *possibility* of such apodictic laws. [This word, like the German *apodiktisch*, comes from Greek meaning, roughly, 'clearly demonstrated'. Kant uses it to mean something like 'utterly unbreakable, unconditional, permitting no excuses or exceptions'.] For what could entitle us to accord *unlimited* respect to something that perhaps is valid only under contingent human conditions? And how could laws for •our will be held to be laws for •the will of any rational being (and valid for us only because we are such beings), if they were merely empirical and didn't arise *a priori* from pure though practical reason?

One couldn't do worse by morality than drawing it from examples. We can't get our concept of morality initially from examples, for we can't judge whether something is fit to *be* an example or model of morality unless it has *already* been judged according principles of morality. ·This applies even to •the model that is most frequently appealed to·. Even •Jesus Christ must be compared with our ideal of moral perfection before he is recognized as being perfect; indeed, he says of himself 'Why callest thou me (whom you see) *good*? There is none good (the archetype ·or model· of good) but one, i.e. God (whom you don't see)' [*Matthew* 19:17; the bits added in parentheses are Kant's]. But ·don't think that with God the father we have at last found the example or model from which we can derive our concept of morality·. Where do we get the concept of *God as the highest good* from? Solely from the idea of moral perfection that reason lays out for us *a priori* and which it ties, unbreakably, to the concept of a free will. ·Some have said that the moral life consists in 'imitating Christ', but· imitation has no place in moral matters; and the only use of examples there is •for encouragement—i.e. showing beyond question that what the law commands *can* be done—and •for making visible ·in particular cases· what the practical rule expresses more generally. But they can never entitle us to steer purely by examples, setting aside their true model which lies in reason.

Well, then, there are moral concepts that are established *a priori*, along with the principles of morality. *Would it be a good idea to set these out in abstract form?* Given that

- •there is no genuine supreme principle of morality that *doesn't* rest on pure reason alone independently of all possible experience,

·and thus given that

- •the *a priori* concepts and principles I have mentioned are the whole foundation for morality·,

I don't think there should be any question about whether they should be presented abstractly. At any rate, there should be no question about that if we want our knowledge of them to be distinguished from ordinary knowledge and to merit the label 'philosophical'. But these days the question may arise after all. For if we conducted a poll on the question:

> Which would you prefer—•pure rational knowledge of morality, separated from all experience and bringing with it a metaphysic of morals, or •popular practical philosophy?

it is easy to guess on which side the majority would stand!

Catering to the notions of the man in the street is all very well *after* we have made a fully satisfactory job of ascending to the principles of pure reason—*first* providing a metaphysical basis for the doctrine of morals and *then* getting it listened to by popularizing it. But it's utterly absurd to aim at popularity [here = 'being accessible by the common man'] at the outset, where everything depends on the correctness of the fundamental principles. There is a real virtue—a rare one!—in genuine popularization of philosophy; but the procedure I have been describing, ·in which popularity is sought at the outset·, involves no such virtue. It is not hard to be generally comprehensible if one does it by dropping all basic insight and replacing it with a disgusting jumble of patched-up observations and half-reasoned principles. Shallow-minded people lap this up, for it is very useful in coffee-house chatter, while people with better sense feel confused and dissatisfied, and helplessly turn away. Philosophers who see right through this hocus-pocus call people away from sham 'popularity' and towards the genuine popularity that can be achieved on the basis of hard-won insights; but they don't get much of a hearing.

When we look at essays on morality written in this beloved style, what do we find? Sometimes •human nature in particular is mentioned (occasionally with the idea of a rational nature in general); now •perfection shows up, and now •happiness; •moral feeling here, •fear of God there; a •little of this and a •little of that—all in a marvellous mixture. It never occurs to the authors to ask: *Can* the principles of morality be found in knowledge of human nature (knowledge that we can get only from experience)? If they can't—if the principles are *a priori*, free from everything empirical, and to be found in pure rational concepts with not a trace of them anywhere else—shouldn't we tackle the investigation of them as a separate inquiry, as *pure* practical philosophy or (to use the dread word) as a *metaphysic* of morals,[2] dealing with it on its own so as to bring it to completion and make the popularity-demanding public wait until we have finished?

·The answer to that last question is 'Yes, we should', because· a completely self-contained metaphysic of morals, with no admixture of anthropology or theology or physics or. . . .occult qualities. . . ., is not only an essential basis for all theoretically sound and definite •knowledge of duties,

[2] We can if we wish divide the philosophy of morals into 'pure' (metaphysics) and 'applied' (meaning 'applied to human nature'), like the divisions of mathematics and logic into pure and applied. This terminology immediately reminds us that moral principles are not based on what is special in human nature but must stand on their own feet *a priori*, and that they must yield practical rules for every rational nature, and accordingly for man.

but also a tremendously important help towards actually •carrying out its precepts. For the *pure* thought of duty and of the moral law generally, unmixed with empirical inducements, has a •stronger influence on the human heart purely through reason—this being what first shows reason that it *can* be practical—than all other action-drivers that may be derived from the empirical field; so much •stronger that reason, aware of its dignity, despises the empirical inputs and comes to dominate them. In contrast with this, a mixed theory of morals—assembled from action-drivers involving feelings and preferences and from rational concepts—is bound to make the mind vacillate between motives that •can't be brought together under any principle and that •can lead to the good only by great good luck and will frequently lead to the bad.[3]

What I have said makes ·five things· clear: that •all moral concepts have their origin entirely *a priori* in reason, and this holds as much for the most ordinary common-sense moral concepts as for ·the ones used in· high-level theorizing; that •moral concepts can't be formed by abstraction from any empirical knowledge or, therefore, from anything contingent; that •this purity ·or non-empiricalness· of origin is what gives them the dignity of serving as supreme practical principles; that •any addition of something empirical takes away just that much of their influence and of the unqualified worth of actions ·performed in accordance with them·; and that •not only is it necessary in developing a moral *theory* but also important in our *practical* lives that we derive the concepts and laws of morals from pure reason and present them pure and unmixed, determining the scope of this entire practical but pure rational knowledge (the entire faculty of pure practical reason). [What follows is meant to flow on from that fifth point; Kant wrote this paragraph as one sentence.] This ·determination of *scope*· is to be done *not* on the basis of principles of *human* reason that non-moral philosophy might allow or require, *but rather* (because moral laws are to hold for every rational being just because it is rational) by being derived from the universal concept of *rational being*. To apply morals to men one needs anthropology; but *first* morals must be completely developed as pure philosophy, i.e. metaphysics, independently of anthropology; this is easy to do, given how separate the two are from one another. For we know—·and here I repeat the fifth of the points with which I opened this paragraph·—that if we don't have such a metaphysic, it is not merely •pointless to ·try to· settle accurately, as a matter of theory, what moral content there is in this or that action that is in accord with duty, but •impossible to base morals on legitimate principles even for ordinary practical use, especially in moral instruction; and that's what is needed for pure moral dispositions to be produced and worked into men's characters for the purpose of the highest good in the world.

[3] I have been asked. . . .why teachings about virtue containing so much that is convincing to reason nevertheless achieve so little. . . . The answer is just this: the teachers themselves haven't brought their concepts right out into the clear; and when they wish to make up for this by hunting all over the place for motives for being morally good so as to make their medicine have the right strength, they spoil it. Entertain the thought of

> an act of honesty performed with a steadfast soul, with no view towards any advantage in this world or the next, under the greatest temptations of need or allurement.

You don't have to look very hard to see that conduct like *this* far surpasses and eclipses any similar action that was affected—even if only slightly—by any external action-driver. It elevates the soul and makes one want to be able to act in this way. Even youngish children feel this, and one should never represent duties to them in any other way.

In this study I have already moved

•from common moral judgment to philosophical moral judgment,

and am now advancing by natural stages ·*within* the realm of philosophical moral judgment, specifically·:

•from popular philosophy to metaphysics.

Popular philosophy goes only as far as it can grope its way by means of examples; metaphysics is not held back by anything empirical, and, because it has to stake out the whole essence of rational knowledge of this kind, it will if necessary stretch out as far as ideas ·of reason·, of which there can't be any examples. In making this advance we must track and clearly present the practical faculty of reason, right from •the universal rules that set it up through to •the point where the concept of duty arises from it.

Everything in nature works according to laws. Only a rational being has a *will*—which is the ability to act according to *the thought of* laws, i.e. to act on principle. To derive actions from laws you need reason, so that's what *will* is—practical reason. When •reason is irresistible in its influence on the will, the actions that a rational being recognizes as objectively necessary are also subjectively necessary; i.e. the will is an ability to choose *only* what reason recognizes, independently of preferences, as practically necessary, i.e. as good. But when •unaided reason isn't enough to settle the will, the will comes under the influence of subjective conditions (certain action-drivers) that don't always agree with the objective conditions—in short, the will is not in complete accord with reason. In this case (which is the actual case with men) the actions that are recognized as •objectively necessary are •subjectively contingent, and if such a will is determined according to objective laws that is because it is *constrained*. . . .i.e. is following principles of reason to which it isn't by its nature necessarily obedient.

When the thought of an objective principle constrains a will, it is called a 'command' (of reason), and its verbal expression is called an 'imperative'.

All imperatives are expressed with an 'ought', which indicates how an objective law of reason relates to a will that it *constrains*. An imperative says that it would be *good* to do or to refrain from doing something, but it addresses this to a will that doesn't always do x just because x is represented to it as *good* to do. Practical good is what determines the will by means of the thoughts that reason produces—and thus not by subjective causes but objectively, on grounds that are valid for every rational being just because it is rational. This contrasts with the thought that it would be *nice* to act in a certain way; the latter influences the will only by means of a feeling that has purely subjective causes, which hold for the senses of this or that person but not as a principle of reason that holds for everyone.[4]

[4] When the faculty of desire is affected by feelings, we speak of what the person •*prefers*, which always also indicates a •*need*. When a contingently determinable will is affected by principles of reason, we say that it has an •*interest*. Interests are to be found only in a dependent will, one that isn't of itself always in accord with reason; we can't make sense of the idea of God's will's having interests. But even the human will can *have* an interest without *acting on* it. The interest that one merely *has* is a practical interest in the •action; the interest on which one *acts* is a pathological interest in the •upshot of the action. [See the note on 'pathological' on page 9.] Whereas the former indicates only the effect on the will of principles of reason •in themselves, the latter indicates the effect on it of the principles of reason •in the service of the person's *preferences*, since ·in these cases· all reason does is to provide the practical rule through which the person's preferences are to be satisfied. In the former case, my focus is on the action; in the latter, it is on whatever is pleasant in the result of the action. We saw in chapter 1 that when an action is done from duty, attention should be paid not to any interest in its upshot but only to the action itself and the law which is its principle in reason.

Objective laws of the good would *apply to* a perfectly good will just as much to as to any other; but we shouldn't think of them as *constraining* such a will, because it is so constituted that it can't be determined to act by anything except the thought of the good. Thus no imperatives hold for God's will or for any holy will. The 'ought' is out of place here, for the volition is of itself *necessarily* at one with the law. Thus, what imperatives do is just to express the relation of •objective laws of volition •in general to the •subjective imperfection of the will of this or that •particular rational being—the will of any human, for example.

All imperatives command either •hypothetically or categorically. The •former expresses the practical necessity of some possible action as a means to achieving something else that one does or might want. An imperative would be categorical if it represented an action as being objectively necessary in itself without regard to any other end.

Since every practical law represents some possible action as •good, and thus as •necessary for anyone whose conduct is governed by reason, what every imperative does is to specify some action that is

- •necessary according to the principle of a will that has something good about it.

If the action would be good only as a means to something else, the imperative is **hypothetical**; but if the action is thought of as *good in itself* and hence as

- •necessary in a will that conforms to reason, which it has as its principle,

the imperative is **categorical**.

The imperative thus says of some action I could perform that it would be good, and puts the practical rule into a relationship with my will; ·and it is no less an imperative if· I don't immediately perform the ·commanded· action simply because it is good (I don't know that it is good, or I do know this but ·I don't care, because· my conduct is guided by other maxims that are opposed to the objective principles of practical reason).

A **hypothetical** imperative merely says that the action is good for some purpose that one *could* have or that one actually *does* have. In the •former case it is a problematic practical principle, in the •latter it is an assertoric one. The **categorical** imperative, which declares the action to be objectively necessary without referring to any end in view. . . .holds as an apodictic practical principle.

Anything that could come about through the powers of some rational being *could* be an end ·or goal or purpose· for some will or other. So ·there are countless possible ends, and therefore· countless hypothetical imperatives, i.e. principles of action thought of as necessary to attain a possible end in view. Every science has a practical segment in which

- •some purpose is set forth as a problem, and
- •imperatives are offered saying how that purpose can be achieved.

So we can give these imperatives the general label 'imperatives of skill'. The practical part of a science is concerned only with •what must be done to achieve a certain purpose; it doesn't address the question of •whether the purpose is reasonable and good. The instructions to a physician for how to make his patient thoroughly healthy, and to a poisoner for how to bring certain death to his victim, are of equal value in that each serves perfectly to achieve the intended purpose. Since in early youth we don't know what purposes we may come to have in the course of our life, parents •try above all to enable their children to learn *many kinds* of things, and •provide for *skill* in the use of means to *any chosen* end. For any given end, the parents can't tell whether it will actually come to be a purpose that their child actually has, but ·they have to allow that· some day it *may* do so. They are

so focused on this that they commonly neglect to form and correct their children's judgment about the worthwhileness of the things that they may make their ends.

But there is one end that can be supposed as actual in all rational beings to which imperatives apply, i.e. all rational beings that are *dependent* [see footnote 4 above]; and thus one purpose that they not only *can* have but that we can assume they all *do* have as a matter of natural necessity. This purpose is *happiness*. The hypothetical imperative that declares some action to be practically necessary for the promotion of happiness is an *assertoric* imperative. We should describe it not as

- necessary to a problematic purpose, one that is merely possible,

but as

- necessary to a purpose that we can *a priori* and with assurance assume for each person, because it belongs to his essence.

Skill in the choice of means to one's own greatest welfare can be called 'prudence' in the narrowest sense.[5] Thus the imperative that refers to the choice of means to one's own happiness (i.e. the precept of prudence) is still only *hypothetical*; it commands the action not *outright* but only *as a means to another end*.

·After those two kinds of hypothetical imperative· we come at last to one imperative that commands certain conduct •immediately, and not •through the condition that some purpose can be achieved through it. This imperative is *categorical*. It isn't concerned with what is to result *from* the conduct, or even with what will happen *in* the conduct (its •matter), but only with the •form and the principle from which the conduct follows. What is essentially good in the conduct consists in the frame of mind—·the willingness to obey the imperative·—no matter what the upshot is. This may be called 'the imperative of *morality*'.

Volition according to these three principles is plainly distinguished by the dissimilarity in the pressure they put on the will. As an aid to getting this dissimilarity clear, I believe we shall do well to call them, respectively,

rules of skill,
advice of prudence,
commands (laws) of morality.

For it is only *law* that carries with it the concept of a *necessity* (·'This action *must* be performed'·) that is unconditional and objective and hence universally valid; and commands are laws that must be obeyed even when one would prefer not to. *Advice* also involves necessity, but it's a necessity that can hold only under a subjectively contingent condition (i.e. whether this or that man counts this or that as part of his happiness). Whereas the categorical imperative isn't restricted by ·or made dependent on· any condition. As absolutely (though practically) necessary, it can be called a 'command' in the strict sense. We could also call the first imperatives 'technical' (relevant to arts and skills), the second 'pragmatic' (relevant to well-being), and the third 'moral' (relevant to any free conduct whatsoever, i.e. to morals).[6]

[5] The word 'prudence' may be taken in two senses, that of **(1)** 'worldly prudence' and that of **2** 'private prudence'. **(1)** refers to a man's skill in influencing others so as to get them serve his purposes. **(2)** is the insight to bring all these purposes together to his own long-term advantage. Any value that **(1)** has ultimately comes from **(2)**; and of someone who is 'prudent' in sense **(1)** but not in sense **(2)** we might better say that he is over-all *not* prudent but only clever and cunning.

[6] This seems to me to be the right meaning for the word 'pragmatic'. For constraints are called 'pragmatic' when they don't strictly flow from the law of states as necessary statutes but rather from provision for the general welfare. A history is composed 'pragmatically' when it teaches *prudence*—i.e. instructs the world how it could look after its advantage better (or not worse) than it has in the past.

The question now arises:

•How are all these imperatives possible?

This question doesn't ask, for any kind of imperative,

•How can the action that the imperative commands be performed?

Rather, it asks,

•How are we to understand the constraint that the imperative puts upon the will in setting it its task?

·We shall see that there is not much of a problem about this for the first of the three kinds of imperative, and the same is true—though with slight complications—of the second·.

(1) How an imperative of **skill** is possible requires no particular discussion. If someone wills an end, and if reason has decisive influence on his actions, then he also wills any steps he can take that are indispensably necessary for achieving that end. What this proposition implies about the will is *analytic*, and here is why:

> When I will x as to-be-brought-about-by-me, I already have—·as a *part* of that act of will·—the thought of the means to x, i.e. the thought of my causality in the production of x. And the imperative extracts from the concept of *willing x* the concept of *actions necessary for the achievement of x*.

(Of course, truths about *what* means are necessary for achieving x are synthetic propositions; but those are only about how to achieve x and not about the act of the will.) ·Here's an example of this interplay between analytic and synthetic propositions·. Mathematics teaches that

•to bisect a line according to an infallible principle, I must make two intersecting arcs from each of its extremities;

and this is certainly a *synthetic* proposition. But if I know that that's the only sure way to bisect the line, the proposition

•if I fully will the effect, I must also will the action necessary to produce it

is *analytic*. For •conceiving of something as an effect that I can somehow bring about is just the same as •conceiving of myself as acting in this way.

(2) If only it were as easy to give a definite concept of happiness, the imperatives of **prudence** would perfectly correspond to those of **skill** and would likewise be analytic. For then we could say that, with prudence as with skill, whoever wills the end wills also (necessarily according to reason) the only means to it that are in his power. Unfortunately, however, the concept of happiness is so indefinite that, although each person wishes to attain it, he can never give a definite and self-consistent account of *what* it is that he wishes and wills ·under the heading of 'wanting happiness'·. The reason for this is that

> all the •elements of the concept of happiness are empirical (i.e. must be drawn from experience),

whereas

> the •·completed· idea of happiness requires ·the thought of· an absolute whole—the thought of a maximum of well-being in my present and in every future condition.

Now it is impossible for a finite being—even one who is extremely clear-sighted and capable—to form a definite ·and detailed· concept of what he really wants here ·on this earth·. ·Consider some of the things people say they aim for·! •Wealth: but in willing to be wealthy a person may bring down on himself much anxiety, envy, and intrigues. •Great knowledge and insight: but that may merely sharpen his eye for the dreadfulness of evils that he can't avoid though he doesn't now see them; or it may show him needs ·that he doesn't know he has, and· that add to the burden his desires already place on him. •Long life: but who can guarantee

him that it wouldn't be a long misery? •Health: but often enough *ill*-health has kept him from dissolute excesses that he would have gone in for if he had been perfectly healthy! In short, he can't come up with any principle that could with complete certainty lay down what would make him truly happy; for that he would need to be omniscient. So in his pursuit of happiness he can't be guided by detailed principles but only by bits of empirical advice (e.g. concerning diet, frugality, courtesy, restraint, etc.) which experience shows to be usually conducive to well-being. It follows from this •that imperatives of prudence can't strictly speaking *command* (i.e. present actions objectively as practically *necessary*); •that they should be understood as advice rather than as commands of reason; •that the problem:

> Settle, for sure and universally, what conduct will promote the happiness of a rational being

is completely unsolvable. There couldn't be an imperative that in the strict sense *commanded* us to do what makes for happiness, because happiness is an ideal not of reason but of imagination, depending only on empirical grounds. ·This means that whether a person will achieve happiness depends on countlessly many particular facts about his future states·; and there is absolutely no chance of picking out the actions that will produce the right infinite totality of consequences that will constitute happiness. If the means to happiness *could* be stated with certainty, this imperative of **prudence** would be an analytic practical proposition, for it would then differ from the imperative of **skill** only in ·the way described in paragraph **(1)** above, namely·: the imperative of skill is addressed merely to a purpose that a person *may* have, while the purpose of the imperative of prudence—·namely happiness·—is *given* for every person. That leaves them the same in this respect: each commands the means to something that the person is assumed to have as a *willed* purpose, so each commands the *willing of the means* to someone who *wills the end*; and so each is analytic. So there is no difficulty about how such an imperative is possible. [Both here, and at the start **(2)** of the discussion of imperatives of prudence, Kant makes it pretty clear that such imperatives are *not* actually analytic because of the indeterminateness about what happiness amounts to, though they *would be* analytic otherwise. He evidently thinks that if there is only *this* barrier to their being analytic, their status as nearly analytic (so to speak) makes them unproblematic.]

(3) On the other hand, the question of how the imperative of **morality** is possible *does* call for an answer, for this imperative is not hypothetical, and so what it presents as objectively necessary can't be based on any presupposed purpose as in the case of hypothetical imperatives. But don't lose sight of the fact that it can't be shown empirically—can't be shown by *producing an example*—that there *are* any imperatives of morality; perhaps every imperative that seems to be categorical is tacitly hypothetical. For example,

> Someone says 'You oughtn't to promise anything deceitfully' and we ·take this to be categorical; we· assume •that an action of this kind must be regarded as in itself bad and thus that the imperative prohibiting it is categorical. (The alternative is to think •that the necessity involved in this prohibition is mere advice about how to avoid something else that is bad, along the lines of 'You oughtn't to promise falsely, in case people find out about it and your credit rating is wrecked'.)

But we can't point with certainty to any example in which the will is directed by the law alone without any other action-drivers, ·i.e. in which the will obeys a categorical imperative·. In a given case this may *appear* to be so, but it's always *possible* that a fear of disgrace and perhaps also a dim sense of other dangers may have had a secret influence

on the will. ·We can't rule this out on empirical grounds·: who can prove by experience that something *doesn't have* a cause ·of a certain sort· when experience can only show us that *we don't perceive* such a cause? In such a case—·i.e. when other incentives are secretly affecting the will·—the so-called 'moral imperative', which appears to be categorical and unconditional, is in fact only a pragmatic injunction that calls on us to attend to our own advantage.

With each of the other two kinds of imperative, experience shows us that imperatives of the kind in question do exist, and the inquiry into their possibility is the search only for •an explanation of them, not for •evidence that they exist. It is not so with categorical imperatives. Our investigation of *their* possibility will have to proceed purely *a priori*—starting with no empirical presuppositions, and in particular without the advantage of the premise that such imperatives actually exist. ·That they *do* exist is one of the things we may hope to establish through our inquiry into their possibility·. (In the meantime—·though this is an aside·—this much at least may be seen: the categorical imperative is the only one that can be taken as a practical *law*, while all other imperatives may be called *principles* of the will [here = 'movers of the will'] but not *laws*. This is because what is merely necessary-for-attaining-some-chosen-end can be regarded as itself *contingent*, ·as can be seen from the fact that· when we give up the end in question we get rid of the instruction stated in the imperative. In contrast with this, an unconditional command leaves the will no freedom to choose the opposite, so that it (and only it) involves the *necessity* that we require of a law.)

·I have spoken of one thing we are *up against* when trying to show the possibility of categorical imperatives, namely that we must do this *a priori*, without being able to appeal to any empirical evidence that such imperatives do actually exist·. Now for a second point about getting insight into the possibility of a categorical imperative or law of morality, namely: there's a very solid reason why it will be hard to do this, because this imperative is an *a priori* synthetic •practical proposition.[7]

·We know already that· it is hard to see that •theoretical propositions of this sort—·i.e. ones that are synthetic and known *a priori*·—are possible, so we must be prepared for at least as much difficulty when it comes to •practical ones.

In approaching this task, let us first ask:

> Doesn't the mere *concept* of a *categorical imperative* provide us with the form of words expressing the proposition—the only ·kind of· proposition—that can be a categorical imperative?

·Don't think that answering Yes to this ends our task·. For even when we know •how the imperative *sounds*—·i.e. how it is worded·—the question of •how such an absolute command *is possible* will require difficult and special labours to answer; I shall get into these in the final chapter.

When I have the general thought of *a hypothetical imperative*, I can't tell just from this thought what such an imperative will contain. To know *that*, I have to know what the condition is. But when I have the thought *categorical*

[7] ·When I affirm a categorical imperative·, I connect the action with the will *a priori*, and hence necessarily, without making this conditional on the person's preferring to achieve this or that end. (Though I do this *objectively*, i.e. under the idea of a reason that has complete control over all its subjective motivators.) So this is a practical proposition that *doesn't* analytically derive the willing of an action from some other volition already presupposed (for we don't have the perfect will that would be needed for there always to be such a volition, ·namely a volition to obey the moral law·) Rather, the proposition connects the action *directly* with the concept of the will of a rational being as something that •isn't contained in it ·so that the connection •isn't analytic·.

imperative, I know right away what it will contain. For all the imperative contains is

the law, and
the necessity that the maxim conform to the law;

and the law doesn't contain any condition limiting it (·comparable with the condition that is always part of a hypothetical imperative·). So there is nothing left for the maxim to conform to except the universality of a law as such, and what the imperative represents as necessary is just precisely that conformity of maxim to law.[8]

So there is only one categorical imperative, and this is it: ·Act only on that maxim through which you can at the same time will that it should become a universal law·.

Now if all imperatives of duty can be derived from this one imperative as a principle, we'll at least be able to show what we understand by the concept of duty, what the concept means, even if we haven't yet settled whether so-called 'duty' is an empty concept or not.

The universality of law according to which effects occur constitutes what is properly called *nature* in the most general sense,. . . .i.e. the existence of things considered as determined by universal laws. So the universal imperative of duty can be expressed as follows: **Act as though the maxim of your action were to become, through your will, a universal law of nature**.

I want now to list some duties, adopting the usual division of them into •duties to ourselves and •duties to others, and into •perfect duties and •imperfect duties.[9]

(1) A man who has been brought by a series of troubles to the point of despair and of weariness with life still has his reason sufficiently to ask himself: 'Wouldn't it be contrary to my duty to myself to take my own life?' Now he asks: 'Could the maxim of my action ·in killing myself· become a universal law of nature?' Well, here is his maxim:

> For love of myself, I make it my principle to cut my life short when prolonging it threatens to bring more troubles than satisfactions.

So the question is whether *this* principle of self-love could become a universal law of nature. If it did, that would be a nature that had a law according to which a single feeling •created a life-affirming push and also •led to the destruction of life itself; and we can see at a glance that such a 'nature' would contradict itself, and so couldn't *be* a nature. So the maxim we are discussing *couldn't* be a law of nature, and therefore would be utterly in conflict with the supreme principle of duty.

(2) Another man sees himself being driven by need to borrow money. He realizes that no-one will lend to him unless he firmly promises to repay it at a certain time, and he is well aware that he wouldn't be able to keep such a promise. He is disposed to make such a promise, but he has enough conscience to ask himself: 'Isn't it improper and opposed to duty to relieve one's needs in that way?' If he does decide to make the promise, the maxim of his action will run like this:

[8] A *maxim* is a subjective principle of acting, and must be distinguished from the *objective* principle, which is the practical *law*. The maxim contains the practical rule that reason comes up with in conformity with the state the person (the subject) is in, including his preferences, his ignorances, and so on; so it is the principle according to which the subject *acts*. The law, on the other hand, is the objective principle valid for every rational being, and the principle by which the subject *ought to act*; that is, it is an imperative.

[9] Please note that I reserve the ·serious, considered· division of duties for a future *metaphysic of morals*, and that the present division is merely one I chose as an aid to arranging my examples. . .

> When I think I need money, I will borrow money and promise to repay it, although I know that the repayment won't ever happen.

·Here he is—for the rest of this paragraph—reflecting on this·: 'It may be that this principle of self-love or of personal advantage would fit nicely into my whole future welfare, ·so that there is no *prudential* case against it·. But the question remains: would it be right? ·To answer this·, I change the demand of self-love into a universal law, and then put the question like this: If my maxim became a universal law, *then* how would things stand? I can see straight off that it could never hold as a universal law of nature, and must contradict itself. For if you take a law saying that anyone who thinks he is in need can make any promises he likes without intending to keep them, and make it *universal* ·so that everyone in need *does* behave in this way·, that would make the promise and the intended purpose of it *impossible*—no-one would believe what was promised to him but would only laugh at any such performance as a vain pretence.'

(3) A third finds in himself a talent that could be developed so as to make him in many respects a useful person. But he finds himself in comfortable circumstances, and would rather indulge in pleasure than take the trouble to broaden and improve his fortunate natural gifts. But now he asks whether his maxim of neglecting his gifts, agreeing as it does with his liking for idle amusement, also agrees with what is called 'duty'. He sees that a system of nature conforming with this law could indeed *exist*, with everyone behaving like the Islanders of the south Pacific, letting their talents rust and devoting their lives merely to idleness, indulgence, and baby-making—in short, to *pleasure*. But he can't possibly **will** that this should become a universal law of nature or that it should be implanted in us by a natural instinct. For, as a rational being, he necessarily wills that all his abilities should be developed, because they serve him and are given to him for all sorts of possible purposes.

(4) A fourth man, for whom things are going well, sees that others (whom he could help) have to struggle with great hardships, and he thinks to himself:

> What concern of mine is it? Let each one be as happy as heaven wills, or as he can make himself; I won't take anything from him or even envy him; but I have no desire to contribute to his welfare or help him in time of need.

If such a way of thinking were a universal law of nature, the human race could certainly survive—and no doubt *that* state of humanity would be better than one where everyone chatters about sympathy and benevolence and exerts himself occasionally to practice them, while also taking every chance he can to cheat, and to betray or otherwise violate people's rights. But although it is possible that that maxim should *be* a universal law of nature, it is impossible to **will** that it do so. For a will that brought *that* about would conflict with itself, since instances can often arise in which the person in question would need the love and sympathy of others, and he would have no hope of getting the help he desires, being robbed of it by this law of nature springing from his own will.

Those are a few of the many duties that we have (or at least think we have) that can clearly be derived from the single principle that I have stated on the preceding page. We must *be able to will* that a maxim of our action become a universal law; this is the general formula for the moral evaluation of our action. •Some actions are so constituted that their maxim can't even be *thought* as a universal law of nature without contradiction, let alone being *willed* to be such. It's easy to see that an action of that kind conflicts with stricter or narrower (absolutely obligatory) duty. •With

other actions, the maxim-made-universal-law is not in that way internally impossible (·self-contradictory·), but it is still something that no-one could possibly *will* to be a universal law of nature, because such a will would contradict itself. It's easy to see that an action of *that* kind conflicts with broader (meritorious) duty. Thinking of duties in terms not of the *object* of their action but rather of the *kind of obligation* they involve, what I have given is a complete display of all the kinds of duty, in terms of their dependence on a single principle.

If we attend to what happens in us when we act against duty, we find that we don't (because we *can't*) actually will that our maxim should become a universal law. Rather, we are willing that the opposite of the maxim on which we are acting should remain as a law generally, but we take the liberty of catering to our preferences by making an exception—'just for me, just this once!'. So if we weighed everything from a single standpoint, namely that of *reason*, we would find a contradiction in our own will: willing that a certain principle •be objectively necessary as a universal law and yet •subjectively not hold universally but rather admit of exceptions. However, ·we *don't* consider our actions in this unitary way; rather·, we regard our action ·at one time· from the point of view of a will wholly conformable to reason and then ·at another time· from the point of view of a will affected by preferences; so there is actually no contradiction, but rather the preference's *resisting* the command of reason. In this the •universality of the principle is changed into mere •generality—·i.e. the move is made from *all* to *ever so many* or *almost all*·—so that the practical principle of reason meets the maxim half-way. This procedure, whether or not it can be justified in our own impartial judgment, shows that we really do acknowledge the validity of the categorical imperative and allow ourselves (while keeping a wary eye on it) only a few exceptions—ones that strike us as unimportant and as forced on us.

I have thus at least shown that if *duty* is a concept that is to have significance and actual law-giving authority for our actions, it has to be expressed in categorical imperatives, never in hypothetical ones. And along with that I have made clear—and ready for any use—the *content* that the categorical imperative must have if it is to contain the principle of all duty (if there is such a thing as duty). This is a substantial result; but I haven't yet reached the point where I can prove *a priori* that •this kind of imperative really exists, that •there is a practical law that of itself commands absolutely and without any action-drivers, and that •obedience to this law is duty.

If we want to reach that point, it is extremely important that we pay heed to this warning:

> Don't slip into thinking that the reality of this principle can be derived from the *special constitution of human nature*!

For duty has to be practical-and-unconditional necessity of action; so it has to hold for all rational beings (the only beings to which an imperative has anything to say), and is a law for all human wills *only because they are rational beings*. In contrast with that, anything that is derived from

> •the temperament of human beings in particular, from
> •certain feelings and propensities ·of human beings·,

or even from (if this is possible)

> •a particular tendency of the human *reason* that might not hold for the will of every rational being,

—such a thing can yield a •*maxim* that is valid for us, but not a •*law*. That is, it can yield •a subjective principle on which we might act if our desires and dispositions take us that way, but not •an objective principle telling us how to act even if all our dispositions, preferences, and natural tendencies

were pulling us in the opposite direction. Indeed, the •fewer subjective causes there are *for* acting in a certain way and •the more there are *against*, the more clearly we can see the sublimity and intrinsic dignity of duty's command to act in that way. The pulls in the other direction don't weaken the constraint of the law or lessen its validity.

Here we see philosophy put into a precarious position, which has to be made firm even though there is nothing in heaven or on earth to hang it from or stand it on! Here philosophy has to show its purity as the •sustainer of its own laws, and not as the •herald of laws that are whispered to it by an implanted 'sense' or by who knows what guardian 'nature'! 'Laws' of the latter kind may always be better than nothing, but they can't yield fundamental principles. Such principles can only be dictated by *reason*: they must have an entirely *a priori* origin, getting none of their commanding authority from the preferences of mankind and all of it from the supremacy of the law and due respect for it. Otherwise—·that is, if human nature were the only basis for morality·—mankind would be condemned to self-contempt and inner disgust.

Thus if anything empirical were brought in as an ingredient in the principle of morality, it would not only •be utterly useless in this role but would also •do terrific harm to the purity of morality ·in practice·—for in morals the proper, priceless value of an absolutely good will consists precisely in action's being driven by something that is *free from* all influences from contingent grounds that only experience can make available. We can't too strongly or too often warn against this slack—indeed this *low*— cast of mind, that looks for its principles [here = 'the sources of moral energy'] among empirical motives and laws. ·The warning is constantly and urgently needed·, because reason in its weariness is glad to rest on this pillow and dreamily. . . .substitute for •morality a botched-up •bastard assembled from limbs of very different species—it looks like anything you want to see in it, but not like virtue to anyone who has ever beheld her in her true form.[10]

So this is our question:

> Is it a necessary law *for all rational beings* that they should always judge their actions by maxims that they themselves could will to hold good as universal laws?

If there is a such a law, it must already be connected—wholly *a priori*—with the concept of *the will of a rational being*. But in order to discover this connection, we must, however reluctantly, take a step into metaphysics; but it will be into the metaphysic of morals, not the region of metaphysics involved in •speculative philosophy. [The 'speculative'/'practical' contrast is explained on pages 3–4.] A •practical philosophy doesn't commit itself to explanations of *what happens* but to laws about what *ought to happen* even if it never does—i.e. objective-practical laws. [Kant means that they are 'objective' at least in the sense that they are not 'subjective', i.e. don't have anything to say about what the person, the *subject*, wants or hopes or prefers or fears or aims at. For another example of this contrast at work, see pages 7–8.] In practical philosophy, therefore, we needn't inquire into

- •why something pleases or displeases,
- •how merely sensory pleasure differs from taste,
- •whether taste is different from a general satisfaction of reason,
- •what the feelings of pleasure and unpleasure depend on,

[10] To behold virtue in its proper form is simply to present morality with •nothing sensuous stirred into the mixture and •every spurious adornment of reward or self-love stripped off. Viewed in that way, it outshines everything that appears charming to the senses, as can easily be seen by anyone whose reason hasn't been spoiled for all abstraction.

- how such feelings give rise to desires and inclinations.
- how desires and preferences, with the co-operation of reason, give rise to maxims.

All of that belongs ·not to practical philosophy but· to empirical psychology. (If we think of *natural science* as *the philosophy of nature based on empirical laws*, then empirical psychology is the second part of it, ·empirical physics being the first·.) In contrast with that, our present concern is with objectively-practical laws and thus with how a will relates to itself when it determines itself only by reason, and ·in that inquiry· every empirical consideration automatically falls away. Why? Because if *unaided reason* determines conduct, it must necessarily do so *a priori*, ·and thus without bringing in anything empirical·. *Can* reason determine conduct in this way? That is what we are now to investigate.

The will is thought of as someone's capacity ·or ability· to control how he behaves *in conformity with the representation of certain laws*. [Slightly correcting what Kant wrote, which literally means: 'The will is thought of as a capacity to control itself. . . '.] Such a capacity can be found only in rational beings. Now, what serves the will as the objective ground for its action upon itself is an *end*, and if it is given by reason alone it must be an end for all rational beings. On the other hand, what contains the ground of the possibility of the action that leads to the end is called the *means*. The subjective ground of desire is the *action-driver*, while the objective ground of volition is the *motive*. And so we have a distinction between

- subjective ends resting on action-drivers, and
- objective ends depending on motives that are valid for every rational being.

Practical principles are *formal* when they abstract from all subjective ends; they are *material* when they are based on subjective ends and thus on certain action-drivers. All of the ends—*material* ends—that a rational being voluntarily sets before himself as things to be achieved through his conduct are merely •relative, for their value comes solely from how they •relate to the particular way in which the subject's faculty of desire is constituted; and from this we can't get any practical *laws*, i.e. any universal and necessary principles that hold for all rational beings and for every act of the will. So the only imperatives that these relative ends support are hypothetical ones.

But suppose there were something *whose existence in itself* had absolute value, something which *as an end in itself* could support determinate laws. *That* would be a basis—indeed the *only* basis—for a possible categorical imperative, i.e. of a practical law.

·*There is* such a thing! It is a human being!· I maintain that man—and in general every rational being—exists as an end in himself and *not merely as a means* to be used by this or that will at its discretion. Whenever he acts in ways directed towards himself or towards other rational beings, ·a person serves as a *means* to whatever end his action aims at; but· he must always be regarded as *also an end*. Things that are preferred have only *conditional* value, for if the preferences (and the needs arising from them) didn't exist, their object would be worthless. ·That wouldn't count against the 'objects' in question if the desires on which they depend did themselves have unconditional value, but they don't·! If the preferences themselves, as the sources of needs, did have absolute value, one would want to have them; but that is so far from the case that every rational being must wish he were altogether free of them. So the value of any objects *to be obtained* through our actions is always conditional. Beings whose existence depends not on our will but on nature, if they are not rational beings, have only relative value as means, and are therefore called 'things' [*Sachen*]; whereas rational beings are called '*persons*', because their nature

already marks them out as ends in themselves (i.e. as not to be used merely as means)—which makes such a being •an object of respect, and •something that sets limits to what anyone can choose to do. Such beings are not merely subjective ends whose existence as a result of our action has value *for us*, but are objective ends, i.e. things [*Dinge*] whose existence is an end in itself. It is indeed an *irreplaceable* end: you can't substitute for it something else to which it would be merely a means. If there were no such ends in themselves, nothing of absolute value could be found, and if all value were conditional and thus contingent, no supreme practical principle for reason could be found anywhere.

So if there is to be a supreme practical principle, and a categorical imperative for the human will, it must be an objective principle of the will that can serve as a universal law. Why must it? Because it has to be drawn from the conception of something that is an end in itself and therefore an end for everyone. The basis for this principle is: *rational nature exists as an end in itself*. Human beings necessarily think of their own existence in this way, which means that the principle holds as a subjective principle of human actions. But every other rational being also thinks of his existence on the same rational ground that holds also for myself;[11] and so it is at the same time an *objective* principle—·one that doesn't depend on contingent facts about this or that *subject*·—a supreme practical ground from which it must be possible to derive all the laws of the will. So here is the practical imperative: **Act in such a way as to treat humanity, whether in your own person or in that of anyone else, always as an end and never merely as a means**. Let us now see whether this can be carried out.

To return to our previous examples: **(1)** Someone thinking of committing suicide will, if he is guided by the concept of necessary duty to oneself, ask himself

> •Could my suicide be reconciled with the idea of humanity as *an end in itself*?

·And his answer to this should be No·. If he escapes from his burdensome situation by destroying himself, he is using a person merely as *a means* to keeping himself in a tolerable condition up to the end of his life. But a man is not a *thing* [*Sache*], so he isn't something to be used *merely* as a means, and must always be regarded in all his actions as an end in himself. So I can't dispose of a man by maiming, damaging or killing him—and that includes the case where the man is myself. (This basic principle needs to be refined so as to deal properly with questions such as 'May I have one of my limbs amputated to save my life?' and 'May I expose my life to danger in order to save it?' I shan't go into these matters here; they belong to *morals* and not to the metaphysic of morals.)

(2) [Three times in this next paragraph, and nowhere else in this work, Kant writes of someone's 'containing' the end of an action by someone else. Presumably for B to 'contain' the end of A's action is for B to have A's end as *his* end also, to seek what A seeks.] As concerns necessary. . . .duties to others, when someone A has it in mind to make someone else B a deceitful promise, he sees immediately that he intends to use B merely as a means, without B's containing in himself the *end* of the action. For B can't possibly assent to A's acting against him in this way, so he can't contain in himself the end of this action. This conflict with the principle about treating others as ends is even easier to see in examples of attacks on people's freedom

[11] Here I put this proposition forward as a postulate. The reasons for it will be given in the last chapter.

and property; for in those cases it's obvious that someone who violates the rights of men intends to make use of the person of others merely as means, without considering that as rational beings they should always be valued at the same time as ends, i.e. as beings who can contain in themselves the end of the very same action.[12]

(3) With regard to contingent (meritorious) duty to oneself [for 'meritorious' see page 26], it isn't sufficient that the action *not conflict* with humanity in our person as an end in itself; it must also *harmonize* with it. In human nature there are predispositions to greater perfection that are part of nature's purpose for humanity. . . .; to neglect these might perhaps be consistent with the *preservation* of humanity as an end in itself but not with the *furtherance* of that end.

(4) With regard to meritorious duty to others: Humanity might survive even if

- •no-one contributed to the happiness of others, but also
- •no-one intentionally took anything away from the happiness of others;

·and this is a likely enough state of affairs, because· the end or purpose that all men *naturally* have is *their own* happiness. This would put human conduct into harmony with humanity as an end in itself, but only in a *negative* manner. For a *positive* harmony with humanity as an end in itself, what is required is that everyone ·positively· tries to further the ends of others as far as he can. For the ends of any person, who is an end in himself, must as far as possible be also *my* ends, if that thought ·of him as an end in himself· is to have its *full* effect on me.

This principle concerning the status of each human being—and more generally of each rational creature—as an end in himself is the supreme limiting condition on the freedom of action of each man. (·*Supreme* in the sense that it trumps everything else, e.g. prudential considerations·.) It isn't drawn from experience; ·there are two reasons why it *can't* be·. •One reason is the principle's universality: it applies to *absolutely all rational beings*, and experience doesn't stretch out that far. •The other is the fact that the principle isn't about humanity considered subjectively, as something that men *do* take to be an end, i.e. do choose to aim at, but rather about humanity considered as the objective end that *ought to* constitute the supreme limiting condition of all subjective ends, whatever they may be. ·Experience can inform us about what subjective ends men *do* set before themselves, but not about what non-subjective end *ought to* trump every subjective end·. So this principle ·can't arise from experience, and· must arise from pure reason.

According to the first principle, the •objective basis for all practical legislation lies in •the rule and the form of universality, which makes it capable of being a natural law [bold type on page 24]. Its •subjective basis is •the end; and according to the second principle the subject of all ends is every rational being as an end in itself. From this we now derive the third practical principle of the will, as the supreme condition of its harmony with universal practical reason, namely, **the idea of the will of every rational being as a will laying down universal law**.

[12] Don't think that the banal 'Don't do to anyone else what you wouldn't want done to you' could serve here as a guide or principle. It is only a consequence of the real principle, and a restricted and limited consequence at that. It can't ·as it stands· be a universal law, because it doesn't provide a basis for •duties to oneself, or •benevolent duties to others (for many a man would gladly consent to not receiving benefits from others if that would let him off from showing benevolence to them!), or •duties to mete out just punishments to others (for the criminal would argue on this ground against the judge who sentences him). And so on.

By this ·third· principle, any maxim is rejected if it isn't consistent with the will's role as a giver of universal law. Hence the will is not merely subject to the law, but subject to it in such a way that it must be viewed as

•prescribing the law to itself,

and for just that reason as

•being subject to the law,

the law of which it sees itself as the author.

I have presented two kinds of ·categorical· imperative: one kind tells us to act in a manner that is lawful, like the lawfulness of the natural order; the other lays down that rational beings are in themselves supreme *ends*; and just because both of these are categorical, their commanding authority owes nothing to any action-driver involving one's *interests*. But so far I have been *assuming* them to be categorical—an assumption I had to make if I was to explain the concept of duty. But *are there* any such imperatives, practical propositions that command categorically? Back there I couldn't prove independently that there are, any more than I can prove it in this present chapter. But there's something that I *could* have done—namely to point out an inherent feature of an imperative that specifically marks it off as categorical rather than hypothetical. The feature I have in mind is the renunciation of all one's *interests* when one wills from duty. And now we have an example of this in the formulation of the principle ·of morality· that is now before us, the third, which involves the idea of the will of every rational being as a *will that gives ·or legislates· universal law*.

A will that is *subject to* laws can be bound to them by some interest that it has; but a will that *is itself the supreme law-giver* can't depend upon any interest for this role. Why can't it? Because if it did, it would need *another* law saying that its interests could be satisfied only if the first law were universally valid; ·in which case the first law wouldn't be supreme, after all·.

Thus the principle of every human will as *a will giving universal law in all its maxims*,[13] provided it is otherwise correct, is very well suited to being a categorical imperative because of this feature: it involves the idea of giving universal law, so it isn't based on any interest, and thus it is the only possible imperative that can be unconditional. . . .

Look back on all the previous attempts to discover the principle of morality—no wonder they all failed! The searchers saw that

•man is bound by his duty to laws;

but it didn't occur to them that

•all man is subject to are laws—universal laws—legislated by himself,

and that

•all he bound to is to act in accordance with his own will,

a will designed by nature to be a giver of universal law. The thought of him only as *subject to some law or other* brings with it the need for some *interest* that will pull or push him to obey the law—his will has to be constrained to act thus and so by *something else*—because the law hasn't arisen from *his* will. This strictly valid inference means that all the work of looking for a supreme ground for duty was wasted labour; it never brought them to *duty* but only to the necessity for acting from a certain *interest*. It might be the person's own interest or someone else's; either way, the imperative always had to be conditional, and couldn't serve as a moral command. I shall call this principle— ·the third of

[13] I needn't clarify this principle with fresh examples, because the ones I have already used to illustrate the categorical imperative and its formulation can here serve the same purpose.

my three·—the principle of **autonomy** of the will in contrast with every others, which I accordingly count as **heteronomy**. [From Greek: *auto/hetero* = self/other, and *nomos* = law. So Kant's terminology distinguishes *self-governed* from *other-governed*.]

The concept of •every rational being as one who must regard himself as giving universal law through all the maxims of its will, so as to judge himself and his actions from this standpoint, leads to thje fruitful concept of •a realm of ends. [The German *Reich* mainly means 'kingdom' or 'empire', but the less highly charged 'realm' seems to fit well enough here.]

By 'realm' I understand the systematic union of different rational beings through shared laws. (The next sentence presents a thought-experiment; in conducting it, we have to abstract from personal differences of rational beings, and thus from all content of their private ends or purposes.) Because laws determine which ends have universal validity, we can think of a ·unified· *whole* of all ends in systematic connection—a whole composed of •rational beings who *are* ends in themselves and of •ends that they may individually set for themselves. This is a realm of ends, which is possible on the principles stated above.

That is because all rational beings stand under the law that each of them should treat himself and all others *never merely as a means* but always *also as an end in himself*. This gives rise to a systematic union of rational beings through shared objective laws, i.e. a *realm*; and it may be called a realm of ends because what these laws have as their purpose is just the relation of these beings to each other as ends and means. (Admittedly this realm of ends is only an ideal.)

A rational being is a *member* of the realm of ends if he *gives* universal laws in it while also being *subject to* those laws. He is *sovereign* in the realm of ends if, as law-giving, he isn't subject to anyone else's will. A rational being must always regard himself as law-giving in a realm of ends that is possible only through the freedom of the will, and this holds whether he belongs to the realm as a member or as sovereign. Being sovereign in the realm of ends isn't a matter of *choice*; to be sovereign a rational being must •be completely independent ·of everything else·, •have no needs, and •have unlimited power adequate to his will.

So the morality of any action is constituted by how the action relates to the law-giving that is indispensable if there is to be a realm of ends. But this law-giving must be found in every rational being, being able to arise from his will. So the principle that drives his will is:

•never to act on a maxim that couldn't consistently be a universal law,

and thus

•to **act only so that the will could regard itself as giving universal law through its maxim**.

In the case of a rational being whose maxims don't by their nature already necessarily conform to this objective principle, the necessity of acting according to that principle is called practical compulsion ·or constraint·, i.e. *duty*. The *sovereign* in the realm of ends doesn't have duties; all the mere *members* have duties, and are indeed burdened by duty to the same extent.

[Of the two versions of the end of this next sentence, the first fits Kant's thought better: the only things he has called ends in themselves are rational beings. The second doctrinally drops out of the blue. But it is what Kant wrote; to get the first reading we must replace Kant's *sie* by *sich*.] The •practical necessity of acting in accordance with this principle, i.e. •duty, doesn't rest at all on feelings, impulses, and preferences; its sole basis is the way rational beings relate to one another—a relationship in which the will of a rational being must always be regarded as law-giving,

plausible reading: otherwise it couldn't think of **itself** as an end in itself.
literal reading: otherwise it couldn't think of **duty** as an end in itself.

Reason accordingly checks out every maxim of your will, ·in its role· as giver of laws, to see how it relates to everyone else's will and also to every action towards yourself. It doesn't do this from any external practical motive or future advantage, but rather from the idea of the *dignity* of a rational being who obeys no law except one that he himself gives while obeying it.

In the realm of ends everything has either a *price* or an *intrinsic value*. Anything with a price can be replaced by something else as its equivalent, whereas anything that is above all price and therefore admits of no equivalent has intrinsic value. [In this paragraph, 'intrinsic value' translates *Würde*, which is usually translated—here and in the Kantian literature generally—by 'dignity'. At the end of the next paragraph Kant explicitly equates those two meanings.]

Something that involves general human desires and needs has a *market price*. Something that doesn't involve anyone's *needing* anything but accords with a certain taste (i.e. with pleasure in the purposeless play of our feelings) has a *luxury price* [*Affektionspreis* = 'price related to the feelings']. But if something makes it possible—and is the *only* thing that makes it possible—for something to be an end in itself, then it doesn't have mere relative value (a *price*) but has intrinsic value (i.e. dignity). [Kant wrote: *hat... einen innern Wert, d. i. Würde.*]

Now, it is only through morality that

- •a rational being can be a law-giving member in the realm of ends;

so it is only through morality that

- •a rational being can be an end in himself.

So morality, and humanity so far as it is capable of morality, are the only things that have dignity. Skill and diligence in work have a •market price; wit, lively imagination, and humour have a •luxury price; but fidelity in promises and benevolence on principle (not benevolence from instinct) have •intrinsic value ·which I have called *dignity*·. If you don't have these, neither nature nor art can supply anything that would make up for that lack in you; for their value doesn't lie in the effects that flow from them—their usefulness, the advantages they bring—but only in the attitudes, i.e. the maxims of the will, that are ready to express themselves in this manner through actions, even if the actions don't meet with success. For us to look on these actions with immediate favour and pleasure, we don't have to bring in any of our subjective states, any immediate *liking* for or attraction to such actions. The actions exhibit the will that generates them as the object of an immediate respect, since nothing but reason is required to get the will to act like that. (Note that reason *imposes* these actions on the will; it doesn't *coax* it into performing them, for that would flatly contradict the notion of duty.) This esteem lets the value of such a turn of mind be recognized as *dignity* ·or *intrinsic value*·, and puts it infinitely above any *price*; to compare it with, or weigh it against, things that have price would be to violate its holiness, as it were.

And what is it, then, that justifies virtue, or a morally good frame of mind, in making such lofty claims ·for itself·? It is its enabling the rational being to have a *share* in the giving of universal laws and thus to become fit to be a member in a possible realm of ends. (His nature has already marked him out for this role, as an end in himself and therefore as a law-giver in the realm of ends.).... For a rational being has no value except what the law confers on it. The law-giving that confers all value must therefore have *dignity* (i.e. an

unconditional and incomparable value); and the •esteem that a rational being must have for this is best described as 'respect' [*Achtung*; some of Kant's uses of this suggest that 'reverence' would be a better translation]. Autonomy is thus the basis for the dignity of human nature and of every rational nature.

·I remind you that I have presented the principle of morality in three ways:

- •Act as though the maxim of your action were to become, through your will, a universal law of nature. [page 24]
- •Act in such a way as to treat humanity, whether in your own person or in that of anyone else, always as an end and never merely as a means. [page 29]
- •Act only so that your will could regard itself as giving universal law through its maxim. [page 32]

· The above three ways of presenting the principle of morality are basically only so many different formulations of the very same law, and any two of them come together in the third. They *do* differ in a certain way, but the difference is subjective rather than objective—·i.e. the three formulations don't express different moral principles, but they offer different ways for our minds to come at morality·. This difference is intended to introduce a certain analogy that will bring an idea of reason closer to intuition and thus nearer to feeling. All maxims have:

(1) **A form**; specifically, they are all universal. That leads to this formulation of the moral imperative: maxims must be chosen as if they were to hold as universal laws of nature.

(2) **A matter ·or content·**, i.e. an end. That leads to this formulation: all merely relative ends, ones that people *choose*, must be restricted by ·and subordinated to· the status of rational beings, which are ·not *chosen* as ends but are· ends by their very nature, and are therefore ends in themselves.

(3) **A complete fixing** of all maxims through this formulation: all the maxims that come from your own law-giving should harmonize with a possible realm of ends as with a realm of nature.[14]

Moving through these three items is like moving through the Categories ·of Quantity, as set forth in my *Critique of Pure Reason*·:

the •Unity of the form of the will (its universality),
the •Plurality of the matter (the objects, ends), and
the •Totality of the system of ends.

In arriving at moral judgments one does better ·to go by just one of the three formulations, specifically· to follow the strict method and base one's thinking on the universal formulation of the categorical imperative: *Act in accordance with a maxim that can at the same time make itself a universal law*. But if one wants to enable the moral law to have *access* to a mind, it is very useful to bring one and the same action under the three concepts I have listed, and thus, so far as possible, to bring it nearer to intuition.

We can now end where we started, with the concept of an unconditionally good will. A will is absolutely good if it *can't* be bad, and thus never adopts maxims that conflict with themselves when they are generalized into universal laws. So this principle is also its supreme law: Always act on maxims whose universality as laws you can at the same time will. That's the only way a will can avoid ever coming into conflict with itself, and such an imperative is categorical.

[14] •Teleology considers nature as a realm of ends; •morals regards a possible realm of ends as a realm of nature. In the •former the realm of ends is a *theoretical* idea for explaining what exists. In the •latter it is a *practical* idea for bringing about something that doesn't yet exist but will become real through our conduct, in conformity with this very idea.

Because the •validity of the will as a universal law for possible actions has an analogy with the •way existing things are inter-connected under universal laws, this being the formal aspect of nature in general, the categorical imperative can be put like this: ·Act on maxims that can at the same time have themselves as universal laws of nature as their object·. That gives us the formula for an absolutely good will.

Rational nature is distinguished from the rest of nature in that it sets for itself an end. This end would be the material of every good will, but ·its relation to the *absolutely* good will involves a little wrinkle which I shall now explain·. The idea of an absolutely good will doesn't have anything to do with this or that end that the will seeks to •bring about; the ends that a will aims to •bring about can only make it relatively good, not absolutely good; so we must understand the end of an absolutely good will

> not as *an end to be •brought about* but as *an independently existing end*

which connects with the absolutely good will *negatively*—it is

> an end which must never be acted against,

which implies that

> it must never, in any act of the will, be valued merely as a means but always also as an end.

. . . .The principle: ·Act in relation to every •rational being (whether yourself or another) so that in your maxim •he is an end in himself· is thus basically identical with the principle: *Act on a maxim that involves its own universal validity for every rational being*. That's because the statement 'In my use of means to any end I should restrict my maxim to the condition of its universal validity as a law for every subject' is equivalent to the statement 'The subject of ends (i.e. the rational being itself) must be made the basis of every maxim of action and thus be treated never as a mere means but as the supreme limiting condition in the use of all means—i.e. also as an end.

It •follows from this—no-one could question that it follows—that every rational being, as an end in himself, must be able to regard himself as a *giver* of universal laws that include any laws to which he may be *subject*. For what marks him off as an end in himself is just this fitness of his maxims for universal law-giving. It also •follows that this dignity that he has, his prerogative over all merely natural beings, involves his having to take his maxims from the point of view of himself and every other rational being as law-givers—which is why they are called 'persons'. In this way, a world of rational beings. . . .is possible as a realm of ends, through the law-giving activities of all the persons who are its members. Consequently every rational being must act as if his maxims made him at all times a law-giving member of the universal realm of ends. The formal principle of these maxims is: Act as though your maxims were also to serve as universal law for all rational beings. A realm of ends is thus possible only by analogy with a realm of nature. The realm of ends is possible only through

> •maxims, i.e. rules imposed on *oneself*,

while the realm of nature is possible only through

> •laws governing how things are acted on by *other things*.

Despite this difference, nature as a whole, though looked on as a machine, is given the name '*realm* of nature'—to the extent that, and because, it has reference to rational beings as its ends. [This is one of the places where 'kingdom' might be better than 'realm'.] Such a realm of ends would actually come into existence through maxims whose rule is prescribed to all rational beings by the categorical imperative, *if every rational being followed them all the time*. A rational being who scrupulously follows this maxim can't expect every other

rational being to follow suit; nor can he expect the realm of nature. . . .to favour his expectation of happiness. Despite that, the law:

> Act in accordance with the maxims of a universal-law-giving member of a merely possible realm of ends

remains in full force because it commands categorically. And just here lies the ·two-part· paradox: **(1)** the will is subject to an inflexible rule ·concerning the place of *humanity* in its deliberations·, simply because of the *dignity* of humanity as rational nature without any end or advantage to be gained by being human, and thus out of respect for a mere idea; and **(2)** what makes some maxims sublime, and makes every rational subject worthy to be a law-giver in the realm of ends, is just precisely this independence of his maxims from all such action-drivers ·as chosen ends and possible advantages·. If it weren't for this independence, the rational being would have to be seen as subject only to the natural law of his needs. Even if the realm of nature and the realm of ends were thought of as united under one sovereign, so that the realm of ends •moved from being a mere •idea to becoming a reality and •gained reinforcement from a strong action-driver, still there would be no increase in its intrinsic value. For when we think about this possibility ·of a world in which a unique sovereign brings it about that principled actions do always lead to good consequences·, we have to think of the sole absolute law-giver as judging the value of rational beings only on the strength of the disinterested conduct that they prescribe to themselves merely from the •idea. The essence of things isn't changed by their external relations, and the absolute [= 'non-relational'] value of a man doesn't involve his relations to other things either; so whoever is estimating a man's absolute worth must set aside his external-relational properties—and this holds for *anyone* doing such an estimation, even the supreme being. Morality is thus the relation of actions ·not to anything external to the person, but· to the autonomy of the will. . . . ·Now here are definitions, in terms of the autonomy of the will, of five key terms in morality·. •An action that can co-exist with the autonomy of the will is *permitted*. •One that clashes with autonomy of the will is *forbidden*. •A will whose maxims are necessarily in harmony with the laws of autonomy is a *holy* or *absolutely good* will. •If a will is not absolutely good, it is morally constrained by the principle of autonomy and its relation to that principle is *obligation* (so a holy will can't have obligations). •The objective necessity of an action from obligation is called *duty*.

From what I have been saying, it is easy to understand how this happens: although in thinking of duty we think of *subjection* to law, we nevertheless also ascribe a certain *sublimity* and *dignity* to the person who fulfils all his duties. There is nothing sublime about being *subject to* the moral law, but this person is also a *giver of* the law—that's why he is subject to it, and only to that extent is he sublime. Also, I have shown above how the only action-driver that can give an action moral value is *respect for the law*, not any kind of fear or desire. The proper object of •respect is our own will to the extent that it tries to act only on maxims that could contribute to a system of universal legislation (such a will is ideally possible for us), and the •dignity of humanity consists just in its capacity to *give* universal laws to which it is also *subject*.

The autonomy of the will as the supreme principle of morality

A will's autonomy is that property of it by which it is a law to itself, independently of any property of the objects of its volition. So the principle of autonomy is:

> Always choose in such a way that the maxims of your choice are incorporated as universal law in the same volition.

That this practical rule is an imperative, i.e. that the will of every rational being is necessarily bound to it as a constraint, can't be proved by a mere analysis of the concepts occurring in it, because it is a synthetic proposition. This synthetic proposition presents a command, and presents it *as necessary*; so it must be able to be known *a priori*. To prove it, then, we would have to go beyond knowledge of •objects to a critical examination of the •subject (i.e. to a critique of pure practical reason). But that is not the business of the present chapter. But mere analysis of moral concepts *can* show something to our present purpose, namely that the principle of autonomy that we are discussing *is* the sole principle of morals. This is easy to show, because conceptual analysis shows us •that morality's principle must be a categorical imperative and •that the imperative ·in question· commands neither more nor less than this very autonomy. [See note on page 32 for 'autonomy' and 'heteronomy'.]

The heteronomy of the will as the source of all spurious principles of morality

A will is looking for a law that will tell it what to do: if it looks anywhere except in the fitness of its maxims to be given as universal law, going outside itself and looking for the law in the property of any of its objects, *heteronomy* always results. For in that case the law is not something the will gives to itself, but rather something that the ·external· object gives to the will through its relation to it. This relation, whether it rests on preference or on conceptions of reason, admits of only *hypothetical* imperatives: •I should do x because I want y. The moral or categorical imperative, on the other hand, says that •I should do x whether or not I want anything else. For example, the hypothetical says that •I shouldn't lie if I want to keep my reputation. The categorical says that •I shouldn't lie even if lying wouldn't bring the slightest harm to me. So the categorical imperative must abstract from every object thoroughly enough so that no object has any *influence* on the will; so that practical reason (the will), rather than catering to interests that are not its own, shows its commanding authority as supreme law-giving. Thus, for instance, I ought to try to further the happiness of others, but not in the spirit of 'it matters to me that these people should be happier, because. . . ' with the blank filled by a reference to some *preference* of mine, whether directly for the happiness of the people in question or indirectly via some satisfaction that is related to their happiness through reason. Rather, I should to try to further the happiness of others solely because a maxim that excludes this can't be included as a universal law in one and the same volition.

Classification of all possible principles of morality that you'll get if you take heteronomy as the basic concept

·Why the interest in *all possible* principles that come from this underlying mistake? Because· in the absence of a critical examination of the pure use of reason, human reason always—including here—tries *every possible* wrong way before it succeeds in finding the one true way!

If you start with the idea of heteronomy—i.e. of how the will can be directed *from outside itself*—you will be led to principles of one of two kinds: empirical and rational. **(1)** The empirical ones have to do with *happiness*, and are based on ·the thought of the will as being influenced by· either **(1a)** physical feelings ·concerning one's own happiness· or **(1b)** moral feelings. **(2)** The rational ones have to do with

perfection and are based on the thought of the will as being influenced by either **(2a)** the rational concept of perfection as a possible result ·of our activities· or **(2b)** the concept of an independently existing perfection (the will of God). ·You can see that all four of these have the will being influenced from outside itself. Let us now look into them in detail·.

(1) Empirical principles are not at all fit to serve as the basis of moral laws. For moral laws should be *universal*, valid for all rational beings without distinction, that being what makes them *unconditionally* practically necessary; but this universality is lost if moral laws are derived from the specific constitution of human beings—·a constitution that may not be shared by other rational beings·—or the particular circumstance in which human beings happen to live. **(1a)** But the principle of *one's own happiness* is the most objectionable of the empirical bases for morality. ·There are at least three reasons for this, of which the third is the weightiest·. •This basis for morality is just false: experience contradicts the allegation that well-being is always proportional to good conduct. •The principle contributes nothing to the establishment of morality, because making a man happy is very different from making him good, and making him prudent and sharp in seeing what is to his own advantage is far from making him virtuous. •Above all: this principle supports morality with action-drivers that undermine it and destroy all its sublimity, for it puts the motives to virtue and those to vice in the same class, obliterating the difference of *kind* between them, and teaching us merely to make a better job of calculating ·what will make us happy·. **(1b)** Now for the supposed special sense, moral feeling.[15] There are endless differences in degree between different kinds of feeling, so that feelings can't give us a uniform standard of good and bad; and anyway one can't validly judge for *others* by means of *one's own* feeling. So the appeal to moral feelings is superficial. Those who believe that feelings can help them to grasp universal laws are people who can't *think*! Despite all this, the moral-feeling approach is nearer to morality and the *dignity* of morality, because it honours virtue by ascribing *immediately to her* the satisfaction and esteem we have for her, and does not, as it were, **(1a)** tell her to her face that what attaches us to her is not her beauty but only our advantage! [The use of 'her' to refer to virtue is based not on Kant's using a personal pronoun (German doesn't have them) but just on the content of the metaphor that he uses.]

(2) Among the rational principles of morality—the ones based on reason—there is **(2a)** the ontological concept of perfection. It is empty, indefinite, and consequently useless for finding in the immeasurable field of possible reality the greatest possible sum ·of perfections· that is suitable to us. Also, when we try to say what marks off *this* reality—·perfection·—from all other realities, we inevitably tend to move in a circle and can't avoid tacitly •presupposing the morality that we are trying to •explain. Nevertheless, this is better than **(2b)** the theological concept, which derives morality from a most perfect divine will. ·There are two reasons for the inferiority of the theological concept; or, more accurately, they are two halves of a single reason which constitutes a *dilemma* confronting the theological approach to morality·. The perfection of the divine will is not something that is *given* to us in intuition ·analogous to how items are given to us through the senses·; so we have to derive it from our own concepts. •Foremost among these is our concept

[15] I bring *moral feeling* under the heading of *happiness* because every empirical interest promises to contribute to our well-being by the agreeableness that a thing affords, either **(1a)** indirectly, through the thing's contributing to our happiness, or **(1b)** directly, through our finding the thing itself agreeable without any thought of our own future advantage. . . .

of morality; if we let this generate our concept of God's perfection, and then use the latter as a basis for morality, we are guilty of a flagrantly circular explanation. •And if we don't get at God's perfection in that way, our only remaining concept of it is made up of

the attributes of desire for glory and dominion,

combined with

the awe-inspiring conceptions of power and vengefulness;

and any system of ethics based on these would be directly opposed to morality.

The **(1b)** concept of the moral sense and **(2a)** that of perfection in general have this to be said for them, that they don't weaken morality; but neither is capable of serving as its foundation. Still, if I had to choose between them, I would opt for **(2a)** perfection in general, because it takes the decision ·about the basis for morality· away from the realm of sensibility and submits it to the court of pure reason. It doesn't get a *decision* there, but at least it preserves the indefinite idea of a will that is good in itself, without falsifying it—·saving a place for it· until it can be more narrowly defined.

You won't mind if I don't grind through a long refutation of all these doctrines. There's no need for me to do that, because it is so easy to do and so well understood—even by those whose official positions require them to declare for one of these theories because their hearers wouldn't tolerate suspension of judgment. What matters more to us here is to know this: All these principles try to base morality purely on heteronomy of the will, so they are bound to fail.

[An addition to this paragraph is marked by * rather than ·, because of its length.] Whenever an *object* of the will has to be laid down as prescribing the rule that is to tell the will what to do, the rule is none other than heteronomy. In such a case the imperative is conditional—

If or *because* you want such and such an object, you ought to act thus and so

—so it can't command morally, i.e. categorically. The object's influence on what my will does may go through my *preference* (as in the principle of my own happiness) or through my *reason* directed to objects of my possible volitions (as in the principle of perfection); but the will in these cases never determines itself *directly* by the conception of the action itself. It is always directed ·by an object *through something other than the will*, namely· through the action-driver that is stirred up in the will by the prospect of getting a certain result:

I ought to do x because I will y;

and then another law must be planted in me, a law saying that *I must will y*; and this law in its turn would require an imperative to restrict this maxim—*i.e. an imperative of the form

I ought to will y *if I want* z.

Why? Because if instead we had simply

I ought to will y,

that involves no appeal to anything outside the will; it is a categorical imperative, and doesn't involve heteronomy of the will. But that puts it outside the scope of the present discussion, which is of the consequences of trying to base morality on heteronomy, i.e. on the influence on the will of factors outside it. Relying on heteronomy has one bad consequence that I haven't yet mentioned*. With a hypothetical imperative such as we get with heteronomy of the will, the aim is for •the thought of a result to be obtained by one's own powers to stir up in the will •an impulse of a certain kind (·the thought of achieving y is to stir up an impulse to do x·); but whether and how that thought generates that impulse depends on the natural constitution of the person

concerned—i.e. depends either on his sensibility (preference and taste) or on his understanding and reason. Now, what the person's sensibility or intellect makes of any intended upshot—e.g. whether it takes pleasure in it—depends on the details of what kind of sensibility or intellect nature has endowed the person with; which implies that strictly speaking the source of this law is *nature*. As a law of nature, this would have to be known and proved by experience, which means that it would be contingent and therefore unfit to be a necessary practical rule such as the moral rule must be. This is still *heteronomy* of the will: the law is given to the will not by •the will itself but by •an impulse from outside it, an impulse that influences the will because the person's nature makes him susceptible to it.

So an absolutely good will, the principle of which must be a categorical imperative, doesn't specify any object, and contains only *the form of volition as such*, and this form is *autonomy*. That is,

- •the sole law that the will of every rational being imposes on itself

is just

- •the fitness of the maxims of every good will to turn themselves into universal laws;

and there is no need for *this* to be supported by any action-driver associated with an interest.

How can there be such a synthetic practical a priori proposition, and why it is necessary? The solution of that problem doesn't lie within the boundaries of the metaphysic of morals; and I haven't here affirmed its truth, let alone claimed to have a proof of it in my power. All I have done is to show, by spelling out the generally accepted concept of morality, that an autonomy of the will is unavoidably connected with morality—is indeed its foundation. So anyone who holds that morality is *something* and not *a chimerical idea without truth* must accept, along with morality, the principle that I have derived here. Consequently, this chapter like the first was merely analytic; ·it reached its conclusions by analysing, spelling out the content of, the generally accepted concept of morality·. If the categorical imperative, and with it the autonomy of the will, is true and absolutely necessary as an *a priori* principle, it follows that morality isn't a phantom; but to *prove* that it isn't we must be able to make **a synthetic use of pure practical reason**. But we mustn't venture on this use without first making a *critique* of this faculty of reason. In this next chapter—the last—I shall give the chief features of such a critique, in enough detail for our purpose.

Chapter 3:

Moving from the metaphysic of morals to the critique of pure practical reason

The concept of freedom is the key to explaining the autonomy of the will

Will is a kind of causality that living beings exert if they are rational, and when the will can be effective independent of outside causes acting on it, that would involve this causality's property of *freedom*; just as *natural necessity* is the property of the causality of all non-rational beings, through which they are caused to act in specific ways by the influence of outside causes.

The account of freedom I have just given is *negative* (·it says there is freedom when the active will does *not* have external causes acting on it·), and so it isn't fruitful for insight into what freedom *is*; but there flows from it a concept of freedom that is *positive*, and accordingly richer and more fruitful. Although freedom is not a property of the will according to •laws of nature, it doesn't follow that freedom is lawless! It must in fact be a causality according to immutable •laws *of a special kind*. The 'concept' of lawless free-will would be an absurdity, because the concept of causality brings with it the concept of laws according to which if something we call a cause is given then something else, the effect, must occur. ·And since

freedom conceptually involves *causality*, and
causality conceptually involves *law*,

it follows that

freedom conceptually involves *law*

. We saw that· natural necessity is a •**hetero**nomy of effective causes, because each effect can come about only through a law according to which •**something else** gets the cause to exercise its causality. What can the freedom of the will be, then, but •**auto**nomy, i.e. the will's property of •**itself** being a law? However, the proposition:

•The will itself is a law in all its actions

only expresses the principle:

•Act only on a maxim that can also have *itself as a universal law* for its object.

And this is just the formula of the categorical imperative and is the principle of morality. Therefore a •free will and a •will under moral laws are identical. [Earlier in this paragraph Kant said that all causality involves an *effect*'s being caused by something else. What he is now treating as the mark not of causality as such but of heteronomous causality in particular is *the cause*'s being stirred into action by something else. In the next paragraph, 'something else' occurs again in a manner that does *seem* to conflict with what Kant first said about causality in general.]

So if we start with freedom of the will, we get morality (together with its principle) from it merely by •analysing its concept. But the principle of morality:

An absolutely good will is one whose maxim can always include itself regarded as a universal law,

is a •synthetic proposition, because that property of the maxim can't be found by analysis of the concept of an absolutely good will. What makes such a synthetic proposition possible is there being two cognitions [= 'items of knowledge'] that are connected with each other through their both being contained in some third cognition. In the case of physical causes, the 'third cognition' that ties the cause to the effect is the •nature of the sensible world; but the concept of *that* conjoins the two concepts of something as cause in relation

to *something else* as effect; so it doesn't meet our present needs. In our present context, the 'third cognition' that does the job is the •*positive* concept of freedom. Two tasks present themselves: **(1)** To show what this third cognition *is* to which freedom directs us and of which we have an *a priori* idea, and **(2)** To make comprehensible the deduction of the concept of freedom from pure practical reason, and along with that the possibility of a categorical imperative. But I can't do either of these right here and now; first, some further preparation is needed.

Freedom must be presupposed as a property of the will of all rational beings

It isn't enough to ascribe freedom to •our will, on whatever grounds, if we don't also have sufficient grounds for attributing it to •all rational beings. For morality serves as a law for us only because we are rational beings, so it must hold for all rational beings; and morality must be derived solely from the property of freedom; so freedom must be shown to be a property of the will of all rational beings. And it doesn't suffice to do this on the basis of certain supposed empirical facts concerning human nature: we need an *a priori* proof (·which empirical facts can't provide·), and we need a result concerning absolutely all rational beings endowed with a will (·and not merely concerning human beings·). Now I say this:

> Any being who can't act otherwise than *under the idea of freedom* is, just for that reason, really free in his conduct—i.e. all laws that are inseparably bound up with freedom hold for him just as if his will were validly pronounced free in itself as a matter of theoretical philosophy.[16]

Now I maintain this:

> We must necessarily equip every rational being who has a will with the idea of freedom, this being an idea under which he must act.

For the thought of such a being includes the thought of a reason that is practical, i.e. has causality with respect to its object. Now we can't conceive of a reason that would consciously take direction (about how to judge) from outside itself, for then the person ·whose reason it was· would think that what settled how he judged was not his reason but some ·external· impulse. Reason must regard itself as the author of its principles, owing nothing to external influences; so it must—as practical reason, or as the will of a rational being—regard itself as free. That is to say, the will of a rational being can be *his* will only under the idea of freedom, so that from a practical point of view such a will must be ascribed to all rational beings.

Why should I be moral?

We have finally traced the determinate concept of morality back to the idea of freedom, but we couldn't prove freedom to be actual in ourselves and in human nature. We saw only that we must *presuppose* it if we want to think of a being as rational and as conscious of himself as the cause of his own actions, i.e. as endowed with a will; and so we find that on just those same grounds we must ascribe to each being

[16] I start in a way that is sufficient for my purposes, with freedom as something posited by all rational beings merely *in idea* as the basis for their actions. I go about things in this way so as to avoid having to prove freedom also in its theoretical respect. Even if the latter—·actual, factual, theoretical freedom·—is left unproved, ·it makes no difference, because· the laws that would hold for a being who was really free hold also for a being who cannot act except under the idea of his own freedom. Thus we escape the burden ·of proof· that the theoretical assertion of freedom would impose upon us.

endowed with reason and will this property of settling for himself how he will act, doing this under the idea of freedom.

From the presupposition of this idea ·of freedom· there flowed also the consciousness of a law of action:

> The subjective principles of actions (i.e. maxims) must always be adopted in such a way that they can hold also as objective, i.e. hold as universal principles, thereby serving as universal laws that we give to ourselves.

But why ought I, just because I am a rational being, subject myself to this law? And why should all other beings endowed with reason do so? Admittedly no interest *impels* me to do this, for that wouldn't yield a categorical imperative; but I must still *take* an interest in it, and have insight into how it comes about. For this 'ought' is really a 'shall' that holds for every rational being whose reason isn't hindered in its generating of actions. For beings like ourselves, that necessity of action is expressed only as 'ought', and the subjective necessity is thus distinguished from the objective. By 'beings like ourselves' I mean ones who are affected not only by reason but also by action-drivers that come from the senses—beings who don't always do what reason would have done if left to itself.

So it seems that all we have done with respect to the moral law (i.e. the principle of the autonomy of the will) is to *presuppose* it in the idea of freedom, as though we couldn't independently prove its reality and objective necessity. Even that would bring some gain, because in doing it we would at least have defined the genuine principle more accurately than had been done before; but we wouldn't have made any progress regarding the validity of the moral law or the practical necessity of subjecting ourselves to it. If anyone asked:

- Why do our actions have to be based on maxims that could be universally valid as laws?
- What is the basis for the value that we ascribe to this way of acting—a value so great that no interest, anywhere, can outweigh it?
- How does it come about that a man believes that it is only through *this* that he feels his own personal value, in contrast to which that of a pleasant or unpleasant state is to be regarded as nothing?

we couldn't give him any satisfactory answer.

We do indeed find that we can take an interest in a personal quality that makes us fit to enjoy some condition if reason were to allot that condition to us, even though the personal quality doesn't automatically bring the condition with it. ·An example might be: taking an interest in *being the sort of person who would be a good spouse*, this being distinct from taking an interest in being married·. That is, we can take an interest in *being worthy of happiness* without having *being happy* as a motive. But this judgment ·about value—this taking of an interest·—is in fact only the effect of the importance we have already ascribed to the moral law (when through the idea of freedom we detach ourselves from every empirical interest). But ·we are confronted by the proposition that·

> We *ought* to detach ourselves from every empirical interest, to regard ourselves as free in acting and yet as subject to certain laws, in order to find right there within ourselves a value that would compensate for the loss of everything that could make our situation desirable.

How *this* is possible, and hence *on what grounds the moral law is binding*, can't be grasped through my procedure up to here.

It has to be admitted that there is a kind of circle here from which there seems to be no escape. We take ourselves to be free in the order of effective causes so that we can think of ourselves as subject to moral laws in the order of ends; and then we think of ourselves as subject to these laws because we have ascribed to ourselves freedom of the will. This is circular because •freedom and •self-legislation by the will are both •autonomy; so they are equivalent concepts, which is why neither of them can be used to explain or support the other. At most they can be used for the logical purpose of bringing apparently different representations of the same object under a single concept (like reducing the both of the fractions $\frac{51}{68}$ and $\frac{69}{92}$ to $\frac{3}{4}$).

There remains open to us, however, one way out ·of the circle·, namely, to pursue an inquiry into these:

- •thinking of ourselves as causes that are effective *a priori* through freedom, and
- •thinking of ourselves in terms of our actions considered as empirically observable effects.

·For example: •thinking of myself as voluntarily raising my arm, and •thinking of myself as seeing my arm go up·. The question is: Don't these involve different standpoints?

[In this next paragraph and later on, Kant refers to a certain 'world' that he calls *Verstandeswelt* = 'world of understanding'. Evidently this 'world' has at least as much to do with •reason as with •understanding, and we shall see on the next page that Kant distinguishes these from one another. So 'world of understanding' would be a misleading label, and 'intelligible world' is used instead. In some places where *Verstandeswelt* would be especially misleading, Kant instead uses *intelligibel Welt*.] What I am about to say requires no subtle reflection, and presumably even the most ordinary intellect could arrive at it (doing so in its own way, through an obscure exercise of judgment that it calls 'feeling'!). All mental representations that come to us involuntarily (as do those of the senses) enable us to know objects only •as they affect us, which leaves us still ignorant of what they are •in themselves; and therefore representations of this kind, however closely and sharply we attend to them, can give us only knowledge of *appearances*, never knowledge of *things in themselves*. This distinction may be made just by noticing the difference between •representations that we passively receive from somewhere else and •ones that we actively produce out of ourselves. Once the distinction has been made ·somehow·, it automatically follows that we must admit and assume behind the appearances something else that is not appearance, namely things in themselves. But we have to accept that we can't get any closer to them, and can't ever know what they are in themselves, because all we can know of them is how they affect us. This must yield a distinction, though a rough one, between

- •a *sensible world*, which can be very different to various observers, because of differences in their sensibilities, and
- •an *intelligible world*, which underlies the sensible world, and remains always the same.

A man shouldn't claim to know even *himself* as he really is by knowing himself through inner sensation—·i.e. by introspection·. For since he doesn't produce himself (so to speak) or get his concept of himself *a priori* but only empirically, it is natural that he gets his knowledge of himself through *inner sense* and consequently only through how his nature *appears* and how his consciousness is *affected*. But beyond the character of his own subject, which is made up out of these mere appearances, he necessarily assumes something else underlying it, namely his *I* as it is in itself. Thus in respect to mere perception and receptivity to sensations he must count himself as belonging to the sensible world;

but in respect to whatever pure activity there may be in himself (which reaches his consciousness •directly and not •by affecting the ·inner or outer· senses) he must count himself as belonging to the intellectual world—though he doesn't know anything more about it.

A thoughtful person must come to some such conclusion as this about all the things that present themselves to him. Even someone with a very ordinary mind is likely to have this thought, because we know that such people are strongly inclined to expect something invisibly active at work behind the objects of the senses; but they don't learn anything from this because they soon spoil it by trying to make the 'invisible something' perceptible, i.e. to make it an object of intuition. ·They do this by wondering 'What is it *like*, this unknown something that lurks behind the appearances of things?', when their only concept of what a thing can be *like* is made from the concept of how things *appear* to them·.

Now a human being really finds within himself a capacity by which he distinguishes

> •himself from •all other things,

and that includes distinguishing

> •himself ·as something active· from •himself considered as affected by objects.

This capacity or faculty is *reason*. Its pure, spontaneously active nature puts reason on a higher level even than understanding, ·and here is why·. Understanding ·is like reason in this: it· is spontaneously active, and does not—like the faculty of *sense*—merely contain representations that come from our being passively affected by things. But ·it is unlike reason in that· the only concepts it can produce through its activity are ones whose only role is to *bring the representations of sense* under rules. . . . ·The intellectual management of the data of the senses is the understanding's *only* task·. Without this use of sensibility the understanding wouldn't have any thoughts at all. In contrast with this, reason shows in its ideas, as we call them (·ideas relating to reason as concepts do to the understanding·), a spontaneity so pure that it goes far beyond anything that sensibility can come up with. The highest occupation of reason is to distinguish the sensible world from the intellectual world, thereby marking out limits for the understanding itself.

Because of this, a rational being must regard himself—in his role *as an intelligence*, setting aside his lower faculties—as belonging not to the sensible world but to the intelligible world. So he has two standpoints from which he can •consider himself and •recognize the laws for the use of his powers and hence for all his actions. **(1)** As belonging to the sensible world, ·he falls· under the laws of nature (heteronomy). **(2)** As belonging to the intelligible world, ·he is· under ·the moral authority of· laws that are independent of nature, and so are not empirical but based entirely on reason.

As a rational being and thus as belonging to the intelligible world, a human being can never think of the causality of his own will except under the idea of freedom; because reason must always take itself to be independent of the determining causes of the sensible world, and that independence is what freedom *is*. Now we have the idea of freedom inseparably connected with the concept of autonomy, which is bound up with the universal principle of morality, which is ideally the ground of all actions of rational beings, just as the law of nature is the ground of all appearances.

That allays the suspicion (the one that I stirred up earlier) that there might be a hidden circle in our reasoning from •freedom to •autonomy and from •that to •the moral law—that we might have laid down the idea of freedom for the sake of the moral law so that we could later derive the law from freedom! That would have made us unable to give

any basis for the law. . . . But now we see that when we think of ourselves as free, we carry ourselves into the intelligible world as members of it and recognize •the autonomy of the will and •the morality that autonomy brings with it; whereas when we think of ourselves as under an obligation, we regard ourselves as belonging to the sensible world and at the same time also to the intelligible world.

How is a categorical imperative possible?

A rational being counts himself, as an intelligence, as belonging to the intelligible world, and only as an effective cause belonging to *this* world does he call his causality a 'will'. On the other side, though, he is conscious of himself as a bit of the sensible world in which his actions are encountered as mere *appearances of* that causality ·of his will·. But we aren't acquainted with that causality ·of his will·, so there's no way we can grasp how these actions can arise from it; and so they must instead be regarded as caused by other appearances, namely, desires and preferences belonging to the sensible world. Considered only as a member of the intelligible world, my behaviour would completely accord with the principle of the autonomy of the pure will; considered as a bit of the sensible world, my behaviour would have to be assumed to conform wholly to the natural law of desires and preferences and thus to the heteronomy of nature. (The former behaviour would rest on the supreme principle of morality, and the latter on that of happiness.) But *the intelligible world contains the ground or basis of the sensible world and therefore of its laws*, and so the intelligible world is (and must be conceived as) directly law-giving for my will, which belongs wholly to the intelligible world. Therefore I see myself, in my status as an intelligence, •as subject to the law of the intelligible world, i.e. the law of reason which is contained in the idea of freedom, and •as subject to the autonomy of the will. Therefore the laws of the intelligible world must be regarded as imperatives for me, and actions that conform to them must be regarded as duties. All this holds, despite the fact that on the other side I am a being that belongs to the sensible world.

So this is how categorical imperatives are possible: The idea of freedom makes me a member of an intelligible world; if I were a member *only* of that world, all my actions *would* always conform to the autonomy of the will; but since I confront myself also as a member of the world of sense, my actions *ought to* conform to it. This categorical 'ought' presents *a priori* a synthetic proposition. ·It is synthetic· because ·in it· **(1)** my will affected by my sensuous desires has *added to it* the idea of **(2)** something that reason says contains its supreme condition, namely •that very same will considered as pure, self-sufficiently practical, and belonging to the intelligible world. ·It is a genuine addition; there's no way you could extract **(2)** from **(1)** by sheer analysis·. [Kant adds a not very helpful comparison of this with his doctrine, expounded in his *Critique of Pure Reason*, about *a priori* synthetic propositions that are essential to our knowledge of any system of nature.]

The practical application of common-sense confirms the correctness of this deduction. When we present examples of honesty of purpose, of steadfastness in following good maxims, and of sympathy and general benevolence (even with great sacrifices of advantage and comfort), there is no man, not even the most malicious villain (provided he is otherwise accustomed to using his reason), who doesn't wish that he also might have these qualities. It's merely because of his preferences and impulses that he can't make himself be like this; but he would like to be free of the burden of such preferences. He thus shows himself as having a thought in which he, with a will free from all impulses of sensibility,

transfers himself into an order of things altogether different from that of his desires in the field of sensibility. In this thought he doesn't look for any gratification of desires or any state of affairs that would satisfy any desire that he has or can imagine having; for if *that* were his aim, the very idea that elicits this wish from him would lose its pre-eminence. All he can be looking for is a greater intrinsic value as a person. He believes himself to be this better person when he shifts himself to the standpoint of a member of the intelligible world, to which he is automatically taken by the idea of freedom (i.e. of not being acted on by causes in the sensible world). And in this standpoint he is conscious of a •good will which on his own confession constitutes the law for his •bad will as a member of the sensible world. He recognizes the status of the law even while he breaks it. The moral 'ought' is therefore his own necessary will as a member of the intelligible world, and it is conceived by him as an 'ought' only because he regards himself at the same time as a member of the sensible world.

Concerning the outermost boundary of all practical philosophy

All human beings think of themselves as having free will. That is the source of all judgments that acts that *weren't* performed *ought to have been* performed. But this freedom isn't ·something of which we have· an experiential concept; it *can't* be, because even when

> experience shows the opposite of things that are represented as •necessary on the supposition of freedom,

freedom still remains, ·which shows that it can't be defeated by facts of experience because it isn't in the same arena, so to speak, as they are·. On the other hand it is equally •necessary that everything that happens should be inexorably caused in accordance with natural laws; and this *natural necessity* [a single word in German] is also not ·something of which we have· an experiential concept, because it brings with it the concept of necessity and thus of *something that can be known a priori*, ·i.e. without consulting experience·. But this concept of a ·system of· nature is confirmed by experience, and it has to be presupposed if experience is to be possible—experience being knowledge of the objects of the senses interconnected by universal laws. So •freedom is only an *idea of reason*, whose objective reality in itself is doubtful, whereas •nature is a *concept of the understanding*, which does and necessarily must exhibit its reality in examples drawn from experience.

From this there arises a dialectic of reason—·a seeming conflict of reason with itself·—because the freedom ascribed to the will seems to contradict natural necessity, ·and reason finds itself drawn to each side of the apparent conflict· at this parting of the ways. •For speculative purposes ·such as the pursuit of scientific theories·, reason finds the road of •natural necessity more well-trodden and usable than that of freedom. •But for practical purposes—thinking about *what to do and what not to do*—the only way of bringing reason to bear is along the path of •freedom; which is why even the subtlest philosophy can't argue freedom away, any more than the most ordinary common-sense can. So philosophy has to assume that no real contradiction will be found between freedom and natural necessity as applied to the very same human actions, for it can't give up the concept of nature any more than it can that of freedom.

We'll never be able to grasp *how* freedom is possible, but in the meantime we should at least eradicate in a convincing way this apparent contradiction. For if the very thought of freedom contradicted itself or contradicted nature (which is

equally necessary), freedom would have to be surrendered in favour of natural necessity.

But this contradiction couldn't be escaped if the subject who seems to himself to be free were thinking of himself *in the same sense* or *in the same relationship* when he •calls himself free as when he •takes himself to be subject to natural law with respect to the very same action. So speculative philosophy can't be excused from its task of showing at least this much: •that ·the ways of talking that produce· the illusion of contradiction come from our thinking of the person in a different sense and relationship when we call him free from that in which we consider him as a part of nature and subject to its laws; and •that these two ·standpoints· not only *can* very well coexist but *must* be thought of as necessarily united in one and the same subject. If this much is not shown, we are left with no basis for burdening reason with an idea ·as troublesome as that of freedom·—an idea which, though it can *without contradiction* be united with the well-established concept ·of natural necessity·, nevertheless entangles us in troubles that sorely embarrass reason in its theoretical use. It is only theoretical philosophy that has this duty; its purpose is to clear the way for practical philosophy. So it isn't up to the philosopher to *decide* whether to remove the apparent contradiction or rather to leave it untouched; for if he doesn't remove it, the theory about it would be a no-man's-land which the fatalist would be entitled to take over, as a squatter, driving all morality out.

But we still haven't reached the boundary of •practical philosophy. For the settling of the controversy ·over freedom· doesn't belong to •it. The situation is just that practical philosophy demands that theoretical reason put an end to the discord in which •it entangles itself in theoretical questions, so that practical reason may have peace and security from outward attacks that could put into dispute the land on which it wants to build.

The common-sense claim to have freedom of the will is based on the person's consciousness of something that has also been conceded as a presupposition, namely that

> •reason is independent of causes that determine a person's psychological state—causes that are all of the sort that sensation can inform us about, and that can be brought under the general name 'sensibility'.

A human being, who in this way regards himself as an intelligence,

> •when he thinks of himself as an intelligence with a will, and consequently with causality,

puts himself in a different order of things and in a relationship to determining grounds of an altogether different kind from what comes into play

> •when he perceives himself as a phenomenon in the world of sense (as he really is also), and subjects *his* causality to external causal factors according to natural laws.

Now he soon realizes that both can exist together—indeed, that they *must*. For there is not the slightest contradiction between **(1)** *a thing in appearance* (belonging to the sensible world) being subject to certain laws from which as **(2)** *a thing in itself* it is independent. That he must think of himself in this twofold way rests on **(1)** his consciousness of himself as an object affected through the senses, and **(2)** his consciousness of himself as an intelligence (i.e. as independent of sensible impressions in the use of reason), and thus as belonging to the intelligible world.

[The indented portion of this paragraph is a first-person rendition of something that Kant writes using 'he' rather than 'I'.] That's how it comes about that a human being •claims to have a will that doesn't make him accountable for what belongs only to his desires and preferences, but •thinks of this same

will as making possible—indeed necessary—actions that he can perform only by disregarding all his desires and sensuous attractions. The causality of these actions lies in •him as an intelligence and in •an intelligible world's principles concerning effects and actions. All he knows about this intelligible world is this:

> In this sensible world the law is given only by reason, and indeed pure reason independent of sensibility. Moreover, since it is only as an •intelligence that I am a *genuine self* (as a •human being I am only an *appearance of myself*), those laws apply to me immediately and categorically; so that nothing that I am pushed into doing by preferences or impulses—thus, nothing caused by the sensible world—can count against the laws of my volition as an intelligence.

Indeed, he doesn't hold himself responsible for those ·preferences and impulses· or attribute them to his *genuine self* (i.e. to his will); though when he •allows them to influence his maxims in ways that go against the rational laws of his will, he holds his will to account for •*that*.

By *thinking itself* into an intelligible world, practical reason doesn't at all step across that world's boundaries, but it would do so if it tried to *see* or *feel* its way into it. The ·thought of the· intelligible world is only a negative thought with respect to the sensible world; it doesn't give reason any laws for determining the will. The only positive thing about it is this:

> Freedom as a negative determination—·i.e. as something that involves **not** being interfered with by sensible causes·—is also connected with a **positive** power and even a causality of reason, a causality that we call a 'will'.

. . . .But if practical reason were to borrow an *object of the will* (i.e. a motive) from the intelligible world, it would be overstepping its boundaries and pretending to be acquainted with something of which it knows nothing. So the concept of an intelligible world is only a *standpoint* that reason sees itself as having to take, outside appearances, *in order to think of itself as practical*. Reason *couldn't* be practical if the influences of sensibility settled how the human being behaved, but it *must* be practical unless his consciousness of himself as an intelligence, and thus as a rational and rationally active cause (i.e. a cause acting in freedom), is to be contradicted. This thought certainly brings with it the idea of an order and a law-giving different from that of the mechanism of nature, which has to do with the sensible world; and it necessitates the concept of an intelligible world, i.e. the totality of rational beings as things in themselves; but without the slightest pretence to have any thoughts about it that go beyond its formal condition—i.e. the universality of the maxim of the will as law, and thus the will's autonomy which is required for its freedom. All laws that are fixed on an *object* make for heteronomy, which belongs only to natural laws and can apply only to the sensible world.

We can explain things only by bringing them under laws governing things that *could* be confronted in experience. But freedom is only an idea ·of reason·; there is no way its objective reality could be shown through natural laws or, therefore, through any experience. Because it can't be illustrated even in an analogical way with examples, we can't ever *grasp* it or even *see into it* a little. It holds only as a necessary presupposition of reason in a being who believes himself conscious of having

> a will, i.e. a faculty or capacity different from that of mere *desire*—a capacity to get himself to act as an intelligence, and thus to act according to laws of reason and independently of natural instincts.

But when we come to an end of causation according to

natural laws, we are at an end of all *explanation*, and all that is left for us to do is to *defend*—i.e. to refute objections from those who purport to have seen more deeply into the essence of things and who boldly declare freedom to be impossible. We can only show them that the supposed contradiction they have discovered in the idea of freedom lies simply in this:

> They have to regard a human being as •appearance in order to bring natural laws to bear on his actions; and now when we require them to think of him-as-intelligence as a •thing in itself, they still persist regarding considering him as appearance.

Separating his causality (his will) from all natural laws of the sensible world *does* indeed involve a contradiction if this is the very same subject that we previously brought under natural laws; but the contradiction will disappear if they will think again, and admit that behind appearances things in themselves must stand as their hidden ground, and that we can't insist that the laws of operation of these grounds must be the same as those that govern their appearances.

The subjective impossibility of *explaining* the freedom of the will is the same as the impossibility of discovering and making graspable an interest which a human being can take in moral laws.[17] Yet he *does* actually take an interest in them, and our name for the foundation of this is 'moral feeling'. Some have wrongly offered this moral feeling as our standard for moral judgment, whereas really it should be seen as the *subjective* effect that the law has on the will; the *objective* grounds ·for moral judgment· come ·not from feeling but· from reason.

If a sensuously affected rational being is to will an action that reason alone prescribes as what he ought to do, reason must of course be able to instil a feeling of pleasure or satisfaction in the fulfilment of duty, and hence must have a causal power to affect sensibility in accordance with its own principles. But it is wholly impossible to conceive *a priori* how a mere thought with nothing sensuous in it produces a sensation of pleasure or unpleasure. For that is one particular kind of causality which, like every kind of causality, we can learn about only by consulting experience, not *a priori* . But ·we can't understand *this* causality through experience either, because· we can do that only for cause-effect pairs where *both* items are objects of experience, whereas here the effect •does lie within experience but the cause—namely, reason acting through mere ideas, which furnish no object for experience—•does not. So it is completely impossible for us human beings to explain how and why we have an interest in *the universality of the maxim as law* and thus an interest in morality. Only this much is certain: **(1)** It *is not* the case that the law holds for us because we have an interest in it (for that would be heteronomy, making practical reason depend on sensibility in the form of an underlying *feeling*, which could never yield a moral law); and **(2)** It *is* the case that we have an interest in the moral law because it holds for us as human beings, because it has arisen from our will as intelligence, and hence from our genuine self. That source for the moral law is what gives it its authority, what

[17] It is by *interest* that reason becomes practical, i.e. becomes a cause acting on the will. That is why it is only of a being with reason that we say 'He takes an interest in' something; non-rational creatures don't have interests—only sensuous impulses. Reason takes an •immediate interest in actions only in cases where what has moved the will in that direction is the universal validity of the action's maxim. That's the only kind of interest that is pure [= 'non-empirical']. In contrast with that, reason takes an indirect or •mediated interest in an action if it acts on the will only through the intervention or •mediation of another object of desire or under the supposition of some particular feeling that the subject has; and since such objects of desire and particular feelings can't be found out by reason itself, unaided by experience, this mediated kind of interest is only *empirical* and not a *pure* interest of reason. . . .

makes it hold for us, because **reason necessarily makes what belongs to mere •appearance subordinate to the character of the •thing in itself**.

So the question *How is a categorical imperative possible?* can be answered to this extent: We can •cite the only presupposition under which it is possible, namely the idea of freedom; and we can •have insight into the necessity of this presupposition. That is all we need for the *practical use* of reason (i.e. to be convinced of the categorical imperative's validity and hence also of the moral law). But how this presupposition itself is possible can never be grasped by any human reason. However,. . . .the presupposition of the freedom of the will is quite •possible, as speculative philosophy can prove, for it doesn't involve itself in a contradiction with the principle that natural necessity interconnects all the appearances in the sensible world. More than that, it is unconditionally •necessary for any rational being. I mean that it is *practically* necessary for him, meaning that he needs it for his consciousness of his causality through reason,. . . .needs the idea of it as the fundamental condition of all his voluntary acts. But the question still stands:

> *How* can pure reason, all by itself without any outside help from other action-drivers, be practical? *How* can the mere principle of the universal validity of its maxims as laws. . . .create, unaided, an action-driver and produce an interest that would be called 'purely moral'? In short: **How can pure reason be practical**?

All human reason is wholly incompetent to explain this, and it is a waste of trouble and labour to try.

It is just the same as if I tried to find out how freedom itself as the causality of a will is possible, for in making that attempt I would be leaving the philosophical basis of explanation behind, and I have no other. I *would* still have the intelligible world, the world of intelligences, and I could drift around in that; but ·it couldn't supply the desired explanation, because· although I have a well-founded *idea* of that world I don't have the least *knowledge* of it—and I can't have such knowledge, however hard I exercise my natural faculty of reason. This intelligible world signifies only a *something*—·a whatever-it-is·—that is left after I have excluded from the factors acting on my will everything belonging to the sensible world, which I did merely so as to shut the principle of motives out of field of sensibility. I did this by limiting this field and showing that it doesn't contain absolutely everything, and that outside it there is still more; but that's all I know about this 'more', ·namely that it lies outside the sensible world·. It is pure reason that has this ·idea, that is· the thought of this ideal entity, ·the intelligible world·; it has been deprived of all *matter* (i.e. all knowledge of objects); so all that I am left with ·in trying to make sense of pure reason· is

- •the *form*, namely the practical law of the universal validity of maxims, and
- •the possible role of pure reason as an effective cause acting on the will in accordance with that form.

There is no room here for any ·external· action-driver. If we insist on there being one, then the action-driver—i.e. that in which reason directly takes an interest—would have to be this idea of an intelligible world. But to understand how *this* could drive action is precisely the problem we can't solve.

Here, then, is the outermost boundary of all moral inquiry [assuming that Kant wrote *oberste* = 'highest' when he meant to write *äußerste* = 'outermost', as in the heading on page 47]. It's very important to locate it accurately, because if we don't, ·either of two disasters may occur·. On the one hand, •reason may search for the supreme ·moral· motive in the sensible world, in a way harmful to morals. . . . On the other hand, •reason may impotently flap its wings in the space—so far as reason

is concerned it's an *empty* space!—of. . . .the intelligible world, without being able to move from its starting point and so losing itself among phantoms. For the rest, the *idea* of a pure intelligible world, as a whole of all intelligences to which we ourselves belong as rational beings (though on the other side we also belong to the sensible world), is always a useful and permissible idea for the purpose of a rational •belief, even though all •knowledge terminates at that world's boundary. Its service is that of awakening in us a lively interest in the moral law through the noble ideal of a universal realm of *ends in themselves* (rational beings) to which we can belong as members only when we scrupulously conduct ourselves by maxims of freedom as if they were laws of nature.

Concluding remark

The speculative use of reason *with respect to nature* leads to the absolute necessity of some supreme cause of *the world*. The practical use of reason *with regard to freedom* leads also to an absolute necessity, but only of *the laws of actions* of a rational being as such. Now, it is an essential principle of all use of our reason to push its knowledge to an awareness of its necessity, for otherwise it wouldn't be rational knowledge. But it is also an equally essential *limitation* of this very same reason that it can't see that

necessarily x exists or y happens, or
necessarily z ought to happen,

except on the basis of some *condition* that applies to x or y or z. ·But the obtaining of a condition won't make something necessary unless the condition itself is necessary; and so· if reason keeps searching for conditions it only pushes its satisfaction further and further into the future. So reason, restlessly seeking the unconditionally necessary, sees itself as *having to assume it*, though it has no way of making it comprehensible to itself; it is happy enough if it can merely discover the concept that is *compatible* with this presupposition. According to my account of the supreme principles of morality, reason can't render comprehensible the absolute necessity of an unconditional practical law (such as the categorical imperative must be). If you want to complain about this, don't blame my account—blame reason! ·Not that *blame* is appropriate·: reason can't be blamed for being unwilling to explain the moral law through a condition—i.e. by making some interest its basis—for a law explained in that way would no longer be if it did, the law would cease to be moral and would no longer be the supreme law of freedom. So we truly don't comprehend the unconditional practical necessity of the moral imperative; but we do comprehend its *incomprehensibility*, which is all that can fairly be demanded of a philosophy that in its principles forces its way out to the boundaries of human reason.

1863

UTILITARIANISM

John Stuart Mill

Mill, John Stuart (1806-1873) - English philosopher and economist who was a leading proponent of Utilitarianism and a supporter of women's suffrage.

Mill's best-known works were influenced by his wife, Harriet Taylor, to whom he attributed his understanding of the human side of his reforms. Utilitarianism (1863) - Utilitarianism was the term coined by Mill to state his doctrine that a right action is one that makes for "the greatest happiness of the greatest number." This essay explicitly states his theory.

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Chapter 1

General Remarks

THERE ARE few circumstances among those which make up the present condition of human knowledge, more unlike what might have been expected, or more significant of the backward state in which speculation on the most important subjects still lingers, than the little progress which has been made in the decision of the controversy respecting the criterion of right and wrong. From the dawn of philosophy, the question concerning the summum bonum, or, what is the same thing, concerning the foundation of morality, has been accounted the main problem in speculative thought, has occupied the most gifted intellects, and divided them into sects and schools, carrying on a vigorous warfare against one another. And after more than two thousand years the same discussions continue, philosophers are still ranged under the same contending banners, and neither thinkers nor mankind at large seem nearer to being unanimous on the subject, than when the youth Socrates listened to the old Protagoras, and asserted (if Plato's dialogue be grounded on a real conversation) the theory of utilitarianism against the popular morality of the so-called sophist.
It is true that similar confusion and uncertainty, and in some cases similar discordance, exist respecting the first principles of all the sciences, not excepting that which is deemed the most certain of them, mathematics; without much impairing, generally indeed without impairing at all, the trustworthiness of the conclusions of those sciences. An apparent anomaly, the explanation of which is, that the detailed doctrines of a science are not usually deduced from, nor depend for their evidence upon, what are called its first principles. Were it not so, there would be no science more precarious, or whose conclusions were more insufficiently made out, than algebra; which derives none of its certainty from what are commonly taught to learners as its elements, since these, as laid down by some of its most eminent teachers, are as full of fictions as English law, and of mysteries as theology. The truths which are ultimately accepted as the first principles of a science, are really the last results of metaphysical analysis, practised on the elementary notions with which the science is conversant; and their relation to the science is not that of foundations to an edifice, but of roots to a tree, which may perform their office equally well though they be never dug down to and exposed to light. But though in science the particular truths precede the general theory, the contrary might be expected to be the case with a practical art, such as morals or legislation. All action is for the sake of some end, and rules of action, it seems natural to suppose, must take their whole character and colour from the end to which they are subservient. When we engage in a pursuit, a clear and precise conception of what we are pursuing would seem to be the first thing we need, instead of the last we are to look forward to. A test of right and wrong must be the means, one would think, of ascertaining what is right or wrong, and not a consequence of having already ascertained it.

The difficulty is not avoided by having recourse to the popular theory of a natural faculty, a sense or instinct, informing us of right and wrong. For- besides that the existence of such- a moral instinct is itself one of the matters in disputethose believers in it who have any pretensions to philosophy, have been obliged to abandon the idea that it discerns what is right or wrong in the particular case in hand, as our other senses discern the sight or sound actually present. Our moral faculty, according to all those of its interpreters who are entitled to the name of thinkers, supplies us only with the general principles of moral judgments; it is a branch of our reason, not of our sensitive faculty; and must be looked to for the abstract doctrines of morality, not for perception of it in

the concrete. The intuitive, no less than what may be termed the inductive, school of ethics, insists on the necessity of general laws. They both agree that the morality of an individual action is not a question of direct perception, but of the application of a law to an individual case. They recognise also, to a great extent, the same moral laws; but differ as to their evidence, and the source from which they derive their authority.

According to the one opinion, the principles of morals are evident a priori, requiring nothing to command assent, except that the meaning of the terms be understood. According to the other doctrine, right and wrong, as well as truth and falsehood, are questions of observation and experience. But both hold equally that morality must be deduced from principles; and the intuitive school affirm as strongly as the inductive, that there is a science of morals. Yet they seldom attempt to make out a list of the a priori principles which are to serve as the premises of the science; still more rarely do they make any effort to reduce those various principles to one first principle, or common ground of obligation. They either assume the ordinary precepts of morals as of a priori authority, or they lay down as the common groundwork of those maxims, some generality much less obviously authoritative than the maxims themselves, and which has never succeeded in gaining popular acceptance. Yet to support their pretensions there ought either to be some one fundamental principle or law, at the root of all morality, or if there be several, there should be a determinate order of precedence among them; and the one principle, or the rule for deciding between the various principles when they conflict, ought to be self-evident.

To inquire how far the bad effects of this deficiency have been mitigated in practice, or to what extent the moral beliefs of mankind have been vitiated or made uncertain by the absence of any distinct recognition of an ultimate standard, would imply a complete survey and criticism, of past and present ethical doctrine.
It would, however, be easy to show that whatever steadiness or consistency these moral beliefs have, attained, has been mainly due to the tacit influence of a standard not recognised. Although the non-existence of an acknowledged first principle has made ethics not so much a guide as a consecration of men's actual sentiments, still, as men's sentiments, both of favour and of aversion, are greatly influenced by what they suppose to be the effects of things upon their happiness, the principle of utility, or as Bentham latterly called it, the greatest happiness principle, has had a large share in forming the moral doctrines even of those who most scornfully reject its authority. Nor is there any school of thought which refuses to admit that the influence of actions on happiness is a most material and even predominant consideration in many of the details of morals, however unwilling to acknowledge it as the fundamental principle of morality, and the source of moral obligation. I might go much further, and say that to all those a priori moralists who deem it necessary to argue at all, utilitarian arguments are indispensable.

It is not my present purpose to criticise these thinkers; but I cannot help referring, for illustration, to a systematic treatise by one of the most illustrious of them, the Metaphysics of Ethics, by Kant. This remarkable man, whose system of thought will long remain one of the landmarks in the history of philosophical speculation, does, in the treatise in question, lay down a universal first principle as the origin and ground of moral obligation; it is this: "So act, that the rule on which thou actest would admit of being adopted as a law by all rational beings." But when he begins to deduce from this precept any of the actual duties of morality, he fails, almost grotesquely, to show that there would be any contradiction, any logical (not to say physical) impossibility, in the adoption by all rational beings of the most outrageously immoral rules of conduct. All

he shows is that the consequences of their universal adoption would be such as no one would choose to incur.

On the present occasion, I shall, without further discussion of the other theories, attempt to contribute something towards the understanding and appreciation of the Utilitarian or Happiness theory, and towards such proof as it is susceptible of. It is evident that this cannot be proof in the ordinary and popular meaning of the term. Questions of ultimate ends are not amenable to direct proof. Whatever can be proved to be good, must be so by being shown to be a means to something admitted to be good without proof. The medical art is proved to be good by its conducing to health; but how is it possible to prove that health is good? The art of music is good, for the reason, among others, that it produces pleasure; but what proof is it possible to give that pleasure is good? If, then, it is asserted that there is a comprehensive formula, including all things which are in themselves good, and that whatever else is good, is not so as an end, but as a mean, the formula may be accepted or rejected, but is not a subject of what is commonly understood by proof. We are not, however, to infer that its acceptance or rejection must depend on blind impulse, or arbitrary choice. There is a larger meaning of the word proof, in which this question is as amenable to it as any other of the disputed questions of philosophy. The subject is within the cognisance of the rational faculty; and neither does that faculty deal with it solely in the way of intuition. Considerations may be presented capable of determining the intellect either to give or withhold its assent to the doctrine; and this is equivalent to proof.

We shall examine presently of what nature are these considerations; in what manner they apply to the case, and what rational grounds, therefore, can be given for accepting or rejecting the utilitarian formula. But it is a preliminary condition of rational acceptance or rejection, that the formula should be correctly understood. I believe that the very imperfect notion ordinarily formed of its meaning, is the chief obstacle which impedes its reception; and that could it be cleared, even from only the grosser misconceptions, the question would be greatly simplified, and a large proportion of its difficulties removed. Before, therefore, I attempt to enter into the philosophical grounds which can be given for assenting to the utilitarian standard, I shall offer some illustrations of the doctrine itself; with the view of showing more clearly what it is, distinguishing it from what it is not, and disposing of such of the practical objections to it as either originate in, or are closely connected with, mistaken interpretations of its meaning. Having thus prepared the ground, I shall afterwards endeavour to throw such light as I can upon the question, considered as one of philosophical theory.

Chapter 2

What Utilitarianism Is

A PASSING remark is all that needs be given to the ignorant blunder of supposing that those who stand up for utility as the test of right and wrong, use the term in that restricted and merely colloquial sense in which utility is opposed to pleasure. An apology is due to the philosophical opponents of utilitarianism, for even the momentary appearance of confounding them with any one capable of so absurd a misconception; which is the more extraordinary, inasmuch as the contrary accusation, of referring everything to pleasure, and that too in its grossest form, is another of the common charges against utilitarianism: and, as has been pointedly remarked by an able writer, the same sort of persons, and often the very same persons, denounce the theory "as impracticably dry when the word utility precedes the word pleasure, and as too practicably voluptuous when the word pleasure precedes the word utility." Those who know anything about the matter are aware that every writer, from Epicurus to Bentham, who maintained the theory of utility, meant by it, not something to be contradistinguished from pleasure, but pleasure itself, together with exemption from pain; and instead of opposing the useful to the agreeable or the ornamental, have always declared that the useful means these, among other things. Yet the common herd, including the herd of writers, not only in newspapers and periodicals, but in books of weight and pretension, are perpetually falling into this shallow mistake. Having caught up the word utilitarian, while knowing nothing whatever about it but its sound, they habitually express by it the rejection, or the neglect, of pleasure in some of its forms; of beauty, of ornament, or of amusement. Nor is the term thus ignorantly misapplied solely in disparagement, but occasionally in compliment; as though it implied superiority to frivolity and the mere pleasures of the moment. And this perverted use is the only one in which the word is popularly known, and the one from which the new generation are acquiring their sole notion of its meaning.

Those who introduced the word, but who had for many years discontinued it as a distinctive appellation, may well feel themselves called upon to resume it, if by doing so they can hope to contribute anything towards rescuing it from this utter degradation. 1

1
The author of this essay has reason for believing himself to be the first person who brought the word utilitarian into use. He did not invent it, but adopted it from a passing expression in Mr. Galt's Annals of the Parish. After using it as a designation for several years, he and others abandoned it from a growing dislike to anything resembling a badge or watchword of sectarian distinction. But as a name for one single opinion, not a set of opinions- to denote the recognition of utility as a standard, not any particular way of applying it- the term supplies a want in the language, and offers, in many cases, a convenient mode of avoiding tiresome circumlocution.

The creed which accepts as the foundation of morals, Utility, or the Greatest Happiness Principle, holds that actions are right in proportion as they tend to promote happiness, wrong as they tend to produce the reverse of happiness. By happiness is intended

pleasure, and the absence of pain; by unhappiness, pain, and the privation of pleasure. To give a clear view of the moral standard set up by the theory, much more requires to be said; in particular, what things it includes in the ideas of pain and pleasure; and to what extent this is left an open question. But these supplementary explanations do not affect the theory of life on which this theory of morality is grounded- namely, that pleasure, and freedom from pain, are the only things desirable as ends; and that all desirable things (which are as numerous in the utilitarian as in any other scheme) are desirable either for the pleasure inherent in themselves, or as means to the promotion of pleasure and the prevention of pain.

Now, such a theory of life excites in many minds, and among them in some of the most estimable in feeling and purpose, inveterate dislike. To suppose that life has (as they express it) no higher end than pleasure- no better and nobler object of desire and pursuit- they designate as utterly mean and grovelling; as a doctrine worthy only of swine, to whom the followers of Epicurus were, at a very early period, contemptuously likened; and modern holders of the doctrine are occasionally made the subject of equally polite comparisons by its German, French, and English assailants.

When thus attacked, the Epicureans have always answered, that it is not they, but their accusers, who represent human nature in a degrading light; since the accusation supposes human beings to be capable of no pleasures except those of which swine are capable. If this supposition were true, the charge could not be gainsaid, but would then be no longer an imputation; for if the sources of pleasure were precisely the same to human beings and to swine, the rule of life which is good enough for the one would be good enough for the other. The comparison of the Epicurean life to that of beasts is felt as degrading, precisely because a beast's pleasures do not satisfy a human being's conceptions of happiness. Human beings have faculties more elevated than the animal appetites, and when once made conscious of them, do not regard anything as happiness which does not include their gratification. I do not, indeed, consider the Epicureans to have been by any means faultless in drawing out their scheme of consequences from the utilitarian principle. To do this in any sufficient manner, many Stoic, as well as Christian elements require to be included. But there is no known Epicurean theory of life which does not assign to the pleasures of the intellect, of the feelings and imagination, and of the moral sentiments, a much higher value as pleasures than to those of mere sensation. It must be admitted, however, that utilitarian writers in general have placed the superiority of mental over bodily pleasures chiefly in the greater permanency, safety, uncostliness, etc., of the former- that is, in their circumstantial advantages rather than in their intrinsic nature. And on all these points utilitarians have fully proved their case; but they might have taken the other, and, as it may be called, higher ground, with entire consistency. It is quite compatible with the principle of utility to recognise the fact, that some kinds of pleasure are more desirable and more valuable than others. It would be absurd that while, in estimating all other things, quality is considered as well as quantity, the estimation of pleasures should be supposed to depend on quantity alone.

If I am asked, what I mean by difference of quality in pleasures, or what makes one pleasure more valuable than another, merely as a pleasure, except its being greater in amount, there is but one possible answer. Of two pleasures, if there be one to which all or almost all who have experience of both give a decided preference, irrespective of any feeling of moral obligation to prefer it, that is the more desirable pleasure. If one of the two is, by those who are competently acquainted with both, placed so far above the other that they prefer it, even though knowing it to be attended with a greater amount of discontent, and would not resign it for any quantity of the other pleasure which their

nature is capable of, we are justified in ascribing to the preferred enjoyment a superiority in quality, so far outweighing quantity as to render it, in comparison, of small account.

Now it is an unquestionable fact that those who are equally acquainted with, and equally capable of appreciating and enjoying, both, do give a most marked preference to the manner of existence which employs their higher faculties. Few human creatures would consent to be changed into any of the lower animals, for a promise of the fullest allowance of a beast's pleasures; no intelligent human being would consent to be a fool, no instructed person would be an ignoramus, no person of feeling and conscience would be selfish and base, even though they should be persuaded that the fool, the dunce, or the rascal is better satisfied with his lot than they are with theirs. They would not resign what they possess more than he for the most complete satisfaction of all the desires which they have in common with him. If they ever fancy they would, it is only in cases of unhappiness so extreme, that to escape from it they would exchange their lot for almost any other, however undesirable in their own eyes. A being of higher faculties requires more to make him happy, is capable probably of more acute suffering, and certainly accessible to it at more points, than one of an inferior type; but in spite of these liabilities, he can never really wish to sink into what he feels to be a lower grade of existence. We may give what explanation we please of this unwillingness; we may attribute it to pride, a name which is given indiscriminately to some of the most and to some of the least estimable feelings of which mankind are capable: we may refer it to the love of liberty and personal independence, an appeal to which was with the Stoics one of the most effective means for the inculcation of it; to the love of power, or to the love of excitement, both of which do really enter into and contribute to it: but its most appropriate appellation is a sense of dignity, which all human beings possess in one form or other, and in some, though by no means in exact, proportion to their higher faculties, and which is so essential a part of the happiness of those in whom it is strong, that nothing which conflicts with it could be, otherwise than momentarily, an object of desire to them.

Whoever supposes that this preference takes place at a sacrifice of happinessthat the superior being, in anything like equal circumstances, is not happier than the inferior-confounds the two very different ideas, of happiness, and content. It is indisputable that the being whose capacities of enjoyment are low, has the greatest chance of having them fully satisfied; and a highly endowed being will always feel that any happiness which he can look for, as the world is constituted, is imperfect. But he can learn to bear its imperfections, if they are at all bearable; and they will not make him envy the being who is indeed unconscious of the imperfections, but only because he feels not at all the good which those imperfections qualify. It is better to be a human being dissatisfied than a pig satisfied; better to be Socrates dissatisfied than a fool satisfied. And if the fool, or the pig, are a different opinion, it is because they only know their own side of the question. The other party to the comparison knows both sides.

It may be objected, that many who are capable of the higher pleasures, occasionally, under the influence of temptation, postpone them to the lower. But this is quite compatible with a full appreciation of the intrinsic superiority of the higher.

Men often, from infirmity of character, make their election for the nearer good, though they know it to be the less valuable; and this no less when the choice is between two bodily pleasures, than when it is between bodily and mental. They pursue sensual indulgences to the injury of health, though perfectly aware that health is the greater good.

It may be further objected, that many who begin with youthful enthusiasm for everything noble, as they advance in years sink into indolence and selfishness.

But I do not believe that those who undergo this very common change, voluntarily choose the lower description of pleasures in preference to the higher. I believe that before they devote themselves exclusively to the one, they have already become incapable of the other. Capacity for the nobler feelings is in most natures a very tender plant, easily killed, not only by hostile influences, but by mere want of sustenance; and in the majority of young persons it speedily dies away if the occupations to which their position in life has devoted them, and the society into which it has thrown them, are not favourable to keeping that higher capacity in exercise. Men lose their high aspirations as they lose their intellectual tastes, because they have not time or opportunity for indulging them; and they addict themselves to inferior pleasures, not because they deliberately prefer them, but because they are either the only ones to which they have access, or the only ones which they are any longer capable of enjoying. It may be questioned whether any one who has remained equally susceptible to both classes of pleasures, ever knowingly and calmly preferred the lower; though many, in all ages, have broken down in an ineffectual attempt to combine both.

From this verdict of the only competent judges, I apprehend there can be no appeal. On a question which is the best worth having of two pleasures, or which of two modes of existence is the most grateful to the feelings, apart from its moral attributes and from its consequences, the judgment of those who are qualified by knowledge of both, or, if they differ, that of the majority among them, must be admitted as final. And there needs be the less hesitation to accept this judgment respecting the quality of pleasures, since there is no other tribunal to be referred to even on the question of quantity. What means are there of determining which is the acutest of two pains, or the intensest of two pleasurable sensations, except the general suffrage of those who are familiar with both? Neither pains nor pleasures are homogeneous, and pain is always heterogeneous with pleasure. What is there to decide whether a particular pleasure is worth purchasing at the cost of a particular pain, except the feelings and judgment of the experienced? When, therefore, those feelings and judgment declare the pleasures derived from the higher faculties to be preferable in kind, apart from the question of intensity, to those of which the animal nature, disjoined from the higher faculties, is suspectible, they are entitled on this subject to the same regard.

I have dwelt on this point, as being a necessary part of a perfectly just conception of Utility or Happiness, considered as the directive rule of human conduct.

But it is by no means an indispensable condition to the acceptance of the utilitarian standard; for that standard is not the agent's own greatest happiness, but the greatest amount of happiness altogether; and if it may possibly be doubted whether a noble character is always the happier for its nobleness, there can be no doubt that it makes other people happier, and that the world in general is immensely a gainer by it. Utilitarianism, therefore, could only attain its end by the general cultivation of nobleness of character, even if each individual were only benefited by the nobleness of others, and his own, so far as happiness is concerned, were a sheer deduction from the benefit. But the bare enunciation of such an absurdity as this last, renders refutation superfluous.

According to the Greatest Happiness Principle, as above explained, the ultimate end, with reference to and for the sake of which all other things are desirable (whether we are

considering our own good or that of other people), is an existence exempt as far as possible from pain, and as rich as possible in enjoyments, both in point of quantity and quality; the test of quality, and the rule for measuring it against quantity, being the preference felt by those who in their opportunities of experience, to which must be added their habits of self-consciousness and self-observation, are best furnished with the means of comparison. This, being, according to the utilitarian opinion, the end of human action, is necessarily also the standard of morality; which may accordingly be defined, the rules and precepts for human conduct, by the observance of which an existence such as has been described might be, to the greatest extent possible, secured to all mankind; and not to them only, but, so far as the nature of things admits, to the whole sentient creation.

Against this doctrine, however, arises another class of objectors, who say that happiness, in any form, cannot be the rational purpose of human life and action; because, in the first place, it is unattainable: and they contemptuously ask, what right hast thou to be happy? a question which Mr. Carlyle clenches by the addition, What right, a short time ago, hadst thou even to be? Next, they say, that men can do without happiness; that all noble human beings have felt this, and could not have become noble but by learning the lesson of Entsagen, or renunciation; which lesson, thoroughly learnt and submitted to, they affirm to be the beginning and necessary condition of all virtue.

The first of these objections would go to the root of the matter were it well founded; for if no happiness is to be had at all by human beings, the attainment of it cannot be the end of morality, or of any rational conduct. Though, even in that case, something might still be said for the utilitarian theory; since utility includes not solely the pursuit of happiness, but the prevention or mitigation of unhappiness; and if the former aim be chimerical, there will be all the greater scope and more imperative need for the latter, so long at least as mankind think fit to live, and do not take refuge in the simultaneous act of suicide recommended under certain conditions by Novalis. When, however, it is thus positively asserted to be impossible that human life should be happy, the assertion, if not something like a verbal quibble, is at least an exaggeration. If by happiness be meant a continuity of highly pleasurable excitement, it is evident enough that this is impossible. A state of exalted pleasure lasts only moments, or in some cases, and with some intermissions, hours or days, and is the occasional brilliant flash of enjoyment, not its permanent and steady flame. Of this the philosophers who have taught that happiness is the end of life were as fully aware as those who taunt them. The happiness which they meant was not a life of rapture; but moments of such, in an existence made up of few and transitory pains, many and various pleasures, with a decided predominance of the active over the passive, and having as the foundation of the whole, not to expect more from life than it is capable of bestowing. A life thus composed, to those who have been fortunate enough to obtain it, has always appeared worthy of the name of happiness. And such an existence is even now the lot of many, during some considerable portion of their lives. The present wretched education, and wretched social arrangements, are the only real hindrance to its being attainable by almost all.

The objectors perhaps may doubt whether human beings, if taught to consider happiness as the end of life, would be satisfied with such a moderate share of it.

But great numbers of mankind have been satisfied with much less. The main constituents of a satisfied life appear to be two, either of which by itself is often found sufficient for the purpose: tranquillity, and excitement. With much tranquillity, many find that they can be content with very little pleasure: with much excitement, many can

reconcile themselves to a considerable quantity of pain. There is assuredly no inherent impossibility in enabling even the mass of mankind to unite both; since the two are so far from being incompatible that they are in natural alliance, the prolongation of either being a preparation for, and exciting a wish for, the other. It is only those in whom indolence amounts to a vice, that do not desire excitement after an interval of repose: it is only those in whom the need of excitement is a disease, that feel the tranquillity which follows excitement dull and insipid, instead of pleasurable in direct proportion to the excitement which preceded it. When people who are tolerably fortunate in their outward lot do not find in life sufficient enjoyment to make it valuable to them, the cause generally is, caring for nobody but themselves. To those who have neither public nor private affections, the excitements of life are much curtailed, and in any case dwindle in value as the time approaches when all selfish interests must be terminated by death: while those who leave after them objects of personal affection, and especially those who have also cultivated a fellow-feeling with the collective interests of mankind, retain as lively an interest in life on the eve of death as in the vigour of youth and health. Next to selfishness, the principal cause which makes life unsatisfactory is want of mental cultivation. A cultivated mind- I do not mean that of a philosopher, but any mind to which the fountains of knowledge have been opened, and which has been taught, in any tolerable degree, to exercise its faculties- finds sources of inexhaustible interest in all that surrounds it; in the objects of nature, the achievements of art, the imaginations of poetry, the incidents of history, the ways of mankind, past and present, and their prospects in the future. It is possible, indeed, to become indifferent to all this, and that too without having exhausted a thousandth part of it; but only when one has had from the beginning no moral or human interest in these things, and has sought in them only the gratification of curiosity.

Now there is absolutely no reason in the nature of things why an amount of mental culture sufficient to give an intelligent interest in these objects of contemplation, should not be the inheritance of every one born in a civilised country. As little is there an inherent necessity that any human being should be a selfish egotist, devoid of every feeling or care but those which centre in his own miserable individuality. Something far superior to this is sufficiently common even now, to give ample earnest of what the human species may be made. Genuine private affections and a sincere interest in the public good, are possible, though in unequal degrees, to every rightly brought up human being. In a world in which there is so much to interest, so much to enjoy, and so much also to correct and improve, every one who has this moderate amount of moral and intellectual requisites is capable of an existence which may be called enviable; and unless such a person, through bad laws, or subjection to the will of others, is denied the liberty to use the sources of happiness within his reach, he will not fail to find this enviable existence, if he escape the positive evils of life, the great sources of physical and mental suffering- such as indigence, disease, and the unkindness, worthlessness, or premature loss of objects of affection. The main stress of the problem lies, therefore, in the contest with these calamities, from which it is a rare good fortune entirely to escape; which, as things now are, cannot be obviated, and often cannot be in any material degree mitigated. Yet no one whose opinion deserves a moment's consideration can doubt that most of the great positive evils of the world are in themselves removable, and will, if human affairs continue to improve, be in the end reduced within narrow limits. Poverty, in any sense implying suffering, may be completely extinguished by the wisdom of society, combined with the good sense and providence of individuals. Even that most intractable of enemies, disease, may be indefinitely reduced in dimensions by good physical and moral education, and proper control of noxious influences; while the progress of science holds out a promise for the future of still more direct conquests over

this detestable foe. And every advance in that direction relieves us from some, not only of the chances which cut short our own lives, but, what concerns us still more, which deprive us of those in whom our happiness is wrapt up. As for vicissitudes of fortune, and other disappointments connected with worldly circumstances, these are principally the effect either of gross imprudence, of ill-regulated desires, or of bad or imperfect social institutions.

All the grand sources, in short, of human suffering are in a great degree, many of them almost entirely, conquerable by human care and effort; and though their removal is grievously slow- though a long succession of generations will perish in the breach before the conquest is completed, and this world becomes all that, if will and knowledge were not wanting, it might easily be made- yet every mind sufficiently intelligent and generous to bear a part, however small and unconspicuous, in the endeavour, will draw a noble enjoyment from the contest itself, which he would not for any bribe in the form of selfish indulgence consent to be without.

And this leads to the true estimation of what is said by the objectors concerning the possibility, and the obligation, of learning to do without happiness. Unquestionably it is possible to do without happiness; it is done involuntarily by nineteen-twentieths of mankind, even in those parts of our present world which are least deep in barbarism; and it often has to be done voluntarily by the hero or the martyr, for the sake of something which he prizes more than his individual happiness. But this something, what is it, unless the happiness of others or some of the requisites of happiness? It is noble to be capable of resigning entirely one's own portion of happiness, or chances of it: but, after all, this self-sacrifice must be for some end; it is not its own end; and if we are told that its end is not happiness, but virtue, which is better than happiness, I ask, would the sacrifice be made if the hero or martyr did not believe that it would earn for others immunity from similar sacrifices? Would it be made if he thought that his renunciation of happiness for himself would produce no fruit for any of his fellow creatures, but to make their lot like his, and place them also in the condition of persons who have renounced happiness? All honour to those who can abnegate for themselves the personal enjoyment of life, when by such renunciation they contribute worthily to increase the amount of happiness in the world; but he who does it, or professes to do it, for any other purpose, is no more deserving of admiration than the ascetic mounted on his pillar. He may be an inspiriting proof of what men can do, but assuredly not an example of what they should.

Though it is only in a very imperfect state of the world's arrangements that any one can best serve the happiness of others by the absolute sacrifice of his own, yet so long as the world is in that imperfect state, I fully acknowledge that the readiness to make such a sacrifice is the highest virtue which can be found in man. I will add, that in this condition the world, paradoxical as the assertion may be, the conscious ability to do without happiness gives the best prospect of realising, such happiness as is attainable. For nothing except that consciousness can raise a person above the chances of life, by making him feel that, let fate and fortune do their worst, they have not power to subdue him: which, once felt, frees him from excess of anxiety concerning the evils of life, and enables him, like many a Stoic in the worst times of the Roman Empire, to cultivate in tranquillity the sources of satisfaction accessible to him, without concerning himself about the uncertainty of their duration, any more than about their inevitable end.

Meanwhile, let utilitarians never cease to claim the morality of self

devotion as a possession which belongs by as good a right to them, as either to the Stoic or to the Transcendentalist. The utilitarian morality does recognise in human beings the power of sacrificing their own greatest good for the good of others. It only refuses to admit that the sacrifice is itself a good. A sacrifice which does not increase, or tend to increase, the sum total of happiness, it considers as wasted. The only self-renunciation which it applauds, is devotion to the happiness, or to some of the means of happiness, of others; either of mankind collectively, or of individuals within the limits imposed by the collective interests of mankind.

I must again repeat, what the assailants of utilitarianism seldom have the justice to acknowledge, that the happiness which forms the utilitarian standard of what is right in conduct, is not the agent's own happiness, but that of all concerned. As between his own happiness and that of others, utilitarianism requires him to be as strictly impartial as a disinterested and benevolent spectator. In the golden rule of Jesus of Nazareth, we read the complete spirit of the ethics of utility. To do as you would be done by, and to love your neighbour as yourself, constitute the ideal perfection of utilitarian morality. As the means of making the nearest approach to this ideal, utility would enjoin, first, that laws and social arrangements should place the happiness, or (as speaking practically it may be called) the interest, of every individual, as nearly as possible in harmony with the interest of the whole; and secondly, that education and opinion, which have so vast a power over human character, should so use that power as to establish in the mind of every individual an indissoluble association between his own happiness and the good of the whole; especially between his own happiness and the practice of such modes of conduct, negative and positive, as regard for the universal happiness prescribes; so that not only he may be unable to conceive the possibility of happiness to himself, consistently with conduct opposed to the general good, but also that a direct impulse to promote the general good may be in every individual one of the habitual motives of action, and the sentiments connected therewith may fill a large and prominent place in every human being's sentient existence. If the, impugners of the utilitarian morality represented it to their own minds in this its, true character, I know not what recommendation possessed by any other morality they could possibly affirm to be wanting to it; what more beautiful or more exalted developments of human nature any other ethical system can be supposed to foster, or what springs of action, not accessible to the utilitarian, such systems rely on for giving effect to their mandates.

The objectors to utilitarianism cannot always be charged with representing it in a discreditable light. On the contrary, those among them who entertain anything like a just idea of its disinterested character, sometimes find fault with its standard as being too high for humanity. They say it is exacting too much to require that people shall always act from the inducement of promoting the general interests of society. But this is to mistake the very meaning of a standard of morals, and confound the rule of action with the motive of it. It is the business of ethics to tell us what are our duties, or by what test we may know them; but no system of ethics requires that the sole motive of all we do shall be a feeling of duty; on the contrary, ninety-nine hundredths of all our actions are done from other motives, and rightly so done, if the rule of duty does not condemn them. It is the more unjust to utilitarianism that this particular misapprehension should be made a ground of objection to it, inasmuch as utilitarian moralists have gone beyond almost all others in affirming that the motive has nothing to do with the morality of the action, though much with the worth of the agent. He who saves a fellow creature from drowning does what is morally right, whether his motive be duty, or the hope of being paid for his trouble; he who betrays the friend that trusts him, is guilty of a crime, even if his object be to serve another friend to whom he is under greater obligations.

But to speak only of actions done from the motive of duty, and in direct obedience to principle: it is a misapprehension of the utilitarian mode of thought, to conceive it as implying that people should fix their minds upon so wide a generality as the world, or society at large. The great majority of good actions are intended not for the benefit of the world, but for that of individuals, of which the good of the world is made up; and the thoughts of the most virtuous man need not on these occasions travel beyond the particular persons concerned, except so far as is necessary to assure himself that in benefiting them he is not violating the rights, that is, the legitimate and authorised expectations, of any one else. The multiplication of happiness is, according to the utilitarian ethics, the object of virtue: the occasions on which any person (except one in a thousand) has it in his power to do this on an extended scale, in other words to be a public benefactor, are but exceptional; and on these occasions alone is he called on to consider public utility; in every other case, private utility, the interest or happiness of some few persons, is all he has to attend to. Those alone the influence of whose actions extends to society in general, need concern themselves habitually about large an object. In the case of abstinences indeed- of things which people forbear to do from moral considerations, though the consequences in the particular case might be beneficial- it would be unworthy of an intelligent agent not to be consciously aware that the action is of a class which, if practised generally, would be generally injurious, and that this is the ground of the obligation to abstain from it. The amount of regard for the public interest implied in this recognition, is no greater than is demanded by every system of morals, for they all enjoin to abstain from whatever is manifestly pernicious to society.

The same considerations dispose of another reproach against the doctrine of utility, founded on a still grosser misconception of the purpose of a standard of morality, and of the very meaning of the words right and wrong. It is often affirmed that utilitarianism renders men cold and unsympathising; that it chills their moral feelings towards individuals; that it makes them regard only the dry and hard consideration of the consequences of actions, not taking into their moral estimate the qualities from which those actions emanate. If the assertion means that they do not allow their judgment respecting the rightness or wrongness of an action to be influenced by their opinion of the qualities of the person who does it, this is a complaint not against utilitarianism, but against having any standard of morality at all; for certainly no known ethical standard decides an action to be good or bad because it is done by a good or a bad man, still less because done by an amiable, a brave, or a benevolent man, or the contrary. These considerations are relevant, not to the estimation of actions, but of persons; and there is nothing in the utilitarian theory inconsistent with the fact that there are other things which interest us in persons besides the rightness and wrongness of their actions. The Stoics, indeed, with the paradoxical misuse of language which was part of their system, and by which they strove to raise themselves above all concern about anything but virtue, were fond of saying that he who has that has everything; that he, and only he, is rich, is beautiful, is a king. But no claim of this description is made for the virtuous man by the utilitarian doctrine. Utilitarians are quite aware that there are other desirable possessions and qualities besides virtue, and are perfectly willing to allow to all of them their full worth. They are also aware that a right action does not necessarily indicate a virtuous character, and that actions which are blamable, often proceed from qualities entitled to praise. When this is apparent in any particular case, it modifies their estimation, not certainly of the act, but of the agent. I grant that they are, notwithstanding, of opinion, that in the long run the best proof of a good character is good actions; and resolutely refuse to consider any mental disposition as good, of which the predominant tendency is to produce bad conduct. This makes them unpopular with

many people; but it is an unpopularity which they must share with every one who regards the distinction between right and wrong in a serious light; and the reproach is not one which a conscientious utilitarian need be anxious to repel.

If no more be meant by the objection than that many utilitarians look on the morality of actions, as measured by the utilitarian standard, with too exclusive a regard, and do not lay sufficient stress upon the other beauties of character which go towards making a human being lovable or admirable, this may be admitted.

Utilitarians who have cultivated their moral feelings, but not their sympathies nor their artistic perceptions, do fall into this mistake; and so do all other moralists under the same conditions. What can be said in excuse for other moralists is equally available for them, namely, that, if there is to be any error, it is better that it should be on that side. As a matter of fact, we may affirm that among utilitarians as among adherents of other systems, there is every imaginable degree of rigidity and of laxity in the application of their standard: some are even puritanically rigorous, while others are as indulgent as can possibly be desired by sinner or by sentimentalist. But on the whole, a doctrine which brings prominently forward the interest that mankind have in the repression and prevention of conduct which violates the moral law, is likely to be inferior to no other in turning the sanctions of opinion again such violations. It is true, the question, What does violate the moral law? is one on which those who recognise different standards of morality are likely now and then to differ. But difference of opinion on moral questions was not first introduced into the world by utilitarianism, while that doctrine does supply, if not always an easy, at all events a tangible and intelligible mode of deciding such differences.

It may not be superfluous to notice a few more of the common misapprehensions of utilitarian ethics, even those which are so obvious and gross that it might appear impossible for any person of candour and intelligence to fall into them; since persons, even of considerable mental endowments, often give themselves so little trouble to understand the bearings of any opinion against which they entertain a prejudice, and men are in general so little conscious of this voluntary ignorance as a defect, that the vulgarest misunderstandings of ethical doctrines are continually met with in the deliberate writings of persons of the greatest pretensions both to high principle and to philosophy. We not uncommonly hear the doctrine of utility inveighed against as a godless doctrine. If it be necessary to say anything at all against so mere an assumption, we may say that the question depends upon what idea we have formed of the moral character of the Deity. If it be a true belief that God desires, above all things, the happiness of his creatures, and that this was his purpose in their creation, utility is not only not a godless doctrine, but more profoundly religious than any other. If it be meant that utilitarianism does not recognise the revealed will of God as the supreme law of morals, I answer, that a utilitarian who believes in the perfect goodness and wisdom of God, necessarily believes that whatever God has thought fit to reveal on the subject of morals, must fulfil the requirements of utility in a supreme degree. But others besides utilitarians have been of opinion that the Christian revelation was intended, and is fitted, to inform the hearts and minds of mankind with a spirit which should enable them to find for themselves what is right, and incline them to do it when found, rather than to tell them, except in a very general way, what it is; and that we need a doctrine of ethics, carefully followed out, to interpret to us the will God. Whether this opinion is correct or not, it is superfluous here to discuss; since whatever aid religion, either natural or revealed, can afford to ethical investigation, is as open to the utilitarian moralist as to any other. He can use it as the testimony of God to the usefulness or hurtfulness of any

given course of action, by as good a right as others can use it for the indication of a transcendental law, having no connection with usefulness or with happiness.

Again, Utility is often summarily stigmatised as an immoral doctrine by giving it the name of Expediency, and taking advantage of the popular use of that term to contrast it with Principle. But the Expedient, in the sense in which it is opposed to the Right, generally means that which is expedient for the particular interest of the agent himself; as when a minister sacrifices the interests of his country to keep himself in place. When it means anything better than this, it means that which is expedient for some immediate object, some temporary purpose, but which violates a rule whose observance is expedient in a much higher degree. The Expedient, in this sense, instead of being the same thing with the useful, is a branch of the hurtful. Thus, it would often be expedient, for the purpose of getting over some momentary embarrassment, or attaining some object immediately useful to ourselves or others, to tell a lie. But inasmuch as the cultivation in ourselves of a sensitive feeling on the subject of veracity, is one of the most useful, and the enfeeblement of that feeling one of the most hurtful, things to which our conduct can be instrumental; and inasmuch as any, even unintentional, deviation from truth, does that much towards weakening the trustworthiness of human assertion, which is not only the principal support of all present social well-being, but the insufficiency of which does more than any one thing that can be named to keep back civilisation, virtue, everything on which human happiness on the largest scale depends; we feel that the violation, for a present advantage, of a rule of such transcendant expediency, is not expedient, and that he who, for the sake of a convenience to himself or to some other individual, does what depends on him to deprive mankind of the good, and inflict upon them the evil, involved in the greater or less reliance which they can place in each other's word, acts the part of one of their worst enemies. Yet that even this rule, sacred as it is, admits of possible exceptions, is acknowledged by all moralists; the chief of which is when the withholding of some fact (as of information from a malefactor, or of bad news from a person dangerously ill) would save an individual (especially an individual other than oneself) from great and unmerited evil, and when the withholding can only be effected by denial. But in order that the exception may not extend itself beyond the need, and may have the least possible effect in weakening reliance on veracity, it ought to be recognised, and, if possible, its limits defined; and if the principle of utility is good for anything, it must be good for weighing these conflicting utilities against one another, and marking out the region within which one or the other preponderates.

Again, defenders of utility often find themselves called upon to reply to such objections as this- that there is not time, previous to action, for calculating and weighing the effects of any line of conduct on the general happiness. This is exactly as if any one were to say that it is impossible to guide our conduct by Christianity, because there is not time, on every occasion on which anything has to be done, to read through the Old and New Testaments. The answer to the objection is, that there has been ample time, namely, the whole past duration of the human species. During all that time, mankind have been learning by experience the tendencies of actions; on which experience all the prudence, as well as all the morality of life, are dependent. People talk as if the commencement of this course of experience had hitherto been put off, and as if, at the moment when some man feels tempted to meddle with the property or life of another, he had to begin considering for the first time whether murder and theft are injurious to human happiness. Even then I do not think that he would find the question very puzzling; but, at all events, the matter is now done to his hand.

It is truly a whimsical supposition that, if mankind were agreed in considering utility to be the test of morality, they would remain without any agreement as to what is useful, and would take no measures for having their notions on the subject taught to the young, and enforced by law and opinion. There is no difficulty in proving any ethical standard whatever to work ill, if we suppose universal idiocy to be conjoined with it; but on any hypothesis short of that, mankind must by this time have acquired positive beliefs as to the effects of some actions on their happiness; and the beliefs which have thus come down are the rules of morality for the multitude, and for the philosopher until he has succeeded in finding better. That philosophers might easily do this, even now, on many subjects; that the received code of ethics is by no means of divine right; and that mankind have still much to learn as to the effects of actions on the general happiness, I admit, or rather, earnestly maintain. The corollaries from the principle of utility, like the precepts of every practical art, admit of indefinite improvement, and, in a progressive state of the human mind, their improvement is perpetually going on.

But to consider the rules of morality as improvable, is one thing; to pass over the intermediate generalisations entirely, and endeavour to test each individual action directly by the first principle, is another. It is a strange notion that the acknowledgment of a first principle is inconsistent with the admission of secondary ones. To inform a traveller respecting the place of his. ultimate destination, is not to forbid the use of landmarks and direction-posts on the way. The proposition that happiness is the end and aim of morality, does not mean that no road ought to be laid down to that goal, or that persons going thither should not be advised to take one direction rather than another. Men really ought to leave off talking a kind of nonsense on this subject, which they would neither talk nor listen to on other matters of practical concernment. Nobody argues that the art of navigation is not founded on astronomy, because sailors cannot wait to calculate the Nautical Almanack. Being rational creatures, they go to sea with it ready calculated; and all rational creatures go out upon the sea of life with their minds made up on the common questions of right and wrong, as well as on many of the far more difficult questions of wise and foolish. And this, as long as foresight is a human quality, it is to be presumed they will continue to do. Whatever we adopt as the fundamental principle of morality, we require subordinate principles to apply it by; the impossibility of doing without them, being common to all systems, can afford no argument against any one in particular; but gravely to argue as if no such secondary principles could be had, and as if mankind had remained till now, and always must remain, without drawing any general conclusions from the experience of human life, is as high a pitch, I think, as absurdity has ever reached in philosophical controversy.

The remainder of the stock arguments against utilitarianism mostly consist in laying to its charge the common infirmities of human nature, and the general difficulties which embarrass conscientious persons in shaping their course through life. We are told that a utilitarian will be apt to make his own particular case an exception to moral rules, and, when under temptation, will see a utility in the breach of a rule, greater than he will see in its observance. But is utility the only creed which is able to furnish us with excuses for evil doing, and means of cheating our own conscience? They are afforded in abundance by all doctrines which recognise as a fact in morals the existence of conflicting considerations; which all doctrines do, that have been believed by sane persons. It is not the fault of any creed, but of the complicated nature of human affairs, that rules of conduct cannot be so framed as to require no exceptions, and that hardly any kind of action can safely be laid down as either always obligatory or always condemnable. There is no ethical creed which does not temper the rigidity of its laws, by giving a certain latitude, under the moral responsibility of the agent, for accommodation

to peculiarities of circumstances; and under every creed, at the opening thus made, self-deception and dishonest casuistry get in. There exists no moral system under which there do not arise unequivocal cases of conflicting obligation. These are the real difficulties, the knotty points both in the theory of ethics, and in the conscientious guidance of personal conduct. They are overcome practically, with greater or with less success, according to the intellect and virtue of the individual; but it can hardly be pretended that any one will be the less qualified for dealing with them, from possessing an ultimate standard to which conflicting rights and duties can be referred. If utility is the ultimate source of moral obligations, utility may be invoked to decide between them when their demands are incompatible.

Though the application of the standard may be difficult, it is better than none at all: while in other systems, the moral laws all claiming independent authority, there is no common umpire entitled to interfere between them; their claims to precedence one over another rest on little better than sophistry, and unless determined, as they generally are, by the unacknowledged influence of considerations of utility, afford a free scope for the action of personal desires and partialities. We must remember that only in these cases of conflict between secondary principles is it requisite that first principles should be appealed to. There is no case of moral obligation in which some secondary principle is not involved; and if only one, there can seldom be any real doubt which one it is, in the mind of any person by whom the principle itself is recognised.

Chapter 3

Of the Ultimate Sanction of the Principle of Utility

THE QUESTION is often asked, and properly so, in regard to any supposed moral standard- What is its sanction? what are the motives to obey it? or more specifically, what is the source of its obligation? whence does it derive its binding force? It is a necessary part of moral philosophy to provide the answer to this question; which, though frequently assuming the shape of an objection to the utilitarian morality, as if it had some special applicability to that above others, really arises in regard to all standards. It arises, in fact, whenever a person is called on to adopt a standard, or refer morality to any basis on which he has not been accustomed to rest it. For the customary morality, that which education and opinion have consecrated, is the only one which presents itself to the mind with the feeling of being in itself obligatory; and when a person is asked to believe that this morality derives its obligation from some general principle round which custom has not thrown the same halo, the assertion is to him a paradox; the supposed corollaries seem to have a more binding force than the original theorem; the superstructure seems to stand better without, than with, what is represented as its foundation. He says to himself, I feel that I am bound not to rob or murder, betray or deceive; but why am I bound to promote the general happiness? If my own happiness lies in something else, why may I not give that the preference? If the view adopted by the utilitarian philosophy of the nature of the moral sense be correct, this difficulty will always present itself, until the influences which form moral character have taken the same hold of the principle which they have taken of some of the consequences- until, by the improvement of education, the feeling of unity with our fellow-creatures shall be (what it cannot be denied that Christ intended it to be) as deeply rooted in our character, and to our own consciousness as completely a part of our nature, as the horror of crime is in an ordinarily well brought up young person. In the meantime, however, the difficulty has no peculiar application to the doctrine of utility, but is inherent in every attempt to analyse morality and reduce it to principles; which, unless the principle is already in men's minds invested with as much sacredness as any of its applications, always seems to divest them of a part of their sanctity.

The principle of utility either has, or there is no reason why it might not have, all the sanctions which belong to any other system of morals. Those sanctions are either external or internal. Of the external sanctions it is not necessary to speak at any length. They are, the hope of favour and the fear of displeasure, from our fellow creatures or from the Ruler of the Universe, along with whatever we may have of sympathy or affection for them, or of love and awe of Him, inclining us to do his will independently of selfish consequences. There is evidently no reason why all these motives for observance should not attach themselves to the utilitarian morality, as completely and as powerfully as to any other. Indeed, those of them which refer to our fellow creatures are sure to do so, in proportion to the amount of general intelligence; for whether there be any other ground of moral obligation than the general happiness or not, men do desire happiness; and however imperfect may be their own practice, they desire and commend all conduct in others towards themselves, by which they think their happiness is promoted. With regard to the religious motive, if men believe, as most profess to do, in the goodness of God, those who think that conduciveness to the general happiness is the essence, or even only the criterion of good, must necessarily believe that it is also that which God approves. The whole force therefore of external reward and punishment, whether physical or moral, and whether proceeding from God or from our fellow men,

together with all that the capacities of human nature admit of disinterested devotion to either, become available to enforce the utilitarian morality, in proportion as that morality is recognised; and the more powerfully, the more the appliances of education and general cultivation are bent to the purpose.

So far as to external sanctions. The internal sanction of duty, whatever our standard of duty may be, is one and the same- a feeling in our own mind; a pain, more or less intense, attendant on violation of duty, which in properly cultivated moral natures rises, in the more serious cases, into shrinking from it as an impossibility. This feeling, when disinterested, and connecting itself with the pure idea of duty, and not with some particular form of it, or with any of the merely accessory circumstances, is the essence of Conscience; though in that complex phenomenon as it actually exists, the simple fact is in general all encrusted over with collateral associations, derived from sympathy, from love, and still more from fear; from all the forms of religious feeling; from the recollections of childhood and of all our past life; from self-esteem, desire of the esteem of others, and occasionally even self-abasement. This extreme complication is, I apprehend, the origin of the sort of mystical character which, by a tendency of the human mind of which there are many other examples, is apt to be attributed to the idea of moral obligation, and which leads people to believe that the idea cannot possibly attach itself to any other objects than those which, by a supposed mysterious law, are found in our present experience to excite it. Its binding force, however, consists in the existence of a mass of feeling which must be broken through in order to do what violates our standard of right, and which, if we do nevertheless violate that standard, will probably have to be encountered afterwards in the form of remorse. Whatever theory we have of the nature or origin of conscience, this is what essentially constitutes it.

The ultimate sanction, therefore, of all morality (external motives apart) being a subjective feeling in our own minds, I see nothing embarrassing to those whose standard is utility, in the question, what is the sanction of that particular standard? We may answer, the same as of all other moral standards- the conscientious feelings of mankind. Undoubtedly this sanction has no binding efficacy on those who do not possess the feelings it appeals to; but neither will these persons be more obedient to any other moral principle than to the utilitarian one. On them morality of any kind has no hold but through the external sanctions. Meanwhile the feelings exist, a fact in human nature, the reality of which, and the great power with which they are capable of acting on those in whom they have been duly cultivated, are proved by experience. No reason has ever been shown why they may not be cultivated to as great intensity in connection with the utilitarian, as with any other rule of morals.

There is, I am aware, a disposition to believe that a person who sees in moral obligation a transcendental fact, an objective reality belonging to the province of "Things in themselves," is likely to be more obedient to it than one who believes it to be entirely subjective, having its seat in human consciousness only. But whatever a person's opinion may be on this point of Ontology, the force he is really urged by is his own subjective feeling, and is exactly measured by its strength.

No one's belief that duty is an objective reality is stronger than the belief that God is so; yet the belief in God, apart from the expectation of actual reward and punishment, only operates on conduct through, and in proportion to, the subjective religious feeling. The sanction, so far as it is disinterested, is always in the mind itself; and the notion therefore of the transcendental moralists must be, that this sanction will not exist in the mind unless it is believed to have its root out of the mind; and that if a person is able to

say to himself, This which is restraining me, and which is called my conscience, is only a feeling in my own mind, he may possibly draw the conclusion that when the feeling ceases the obligation ceases, and that if he find the feeling inconvenient, he may disregard it, and endeavour to get rid of it. But is this danger confined to the utilitarian morality? Does the belief that moral obligation has its seat outside the mind make the feeling of it too strong to be got rid of? The fact is so far otherwise, that all moralists admit and lament the ease with which, in the generality of minds, conscience can be silenced or stifled. The question, Need I obey my conscience? is quite as often put to themselves by persons who never heard of the principle of utility, as by its adherents.

Those whose conscientious feelings are so weak as to allow of their asking this question, if they answer it affirmatively, will not do so because they believe in the transcendental theory, but because of the external sanctions.

It is not necessary, for the present purpose, to decide whether the feeling of duty is innate or implanted. Assuming it to be innate, it is an open question to what objects it naturally attaches itself; for the philosophic supporters of that theory are now agreed that the intuitive perception is of principles of morality and not of the details. If there be anything innate in the matter, I see no reason why the feeling which is innate should not be that of regard to the pleasures and pains of others. If there is any principle of morals which is intuitively obligatory, I should say it must be that. If so, the intuitive ethics would coincide with the utilitarian, and there would be no further quarrel between them. Even as it is, the intuitive moralists, though they believe that there are other intuitive moral obligations, do already believe this to one; for they unanimously hold that a large portion of morality turns upon the consideration due to the interests of our fellow-creatures.

Therefore, if the belief in the transcendental origin of moral obligation gives any additional efficacy to the internal sanction, it appears to me that the utilitarian principle has already the benefit of it.

On the other hand, if, as is my own belief, the moral feelings are not innate, but acquired, they are not for that reason the less natural. It is natural to man to speak, to reason, to build cities, to cultivate the ground, though these are acquired faculties. The moral feelings are not indeed a part of our nature, in the sense of being in any perceptible degree present in all of us; but this, unhappily, is a fact admitted by those who believe the most strenuously in their transcendental origin.

Like the other acquired capacities above referred to, the moral faculty, if not a part of our nature, is a natural outgrowth from it; capable, like them, in a certain small degree, of springing up spontaneously; and susceptible of being brought by cultivation to a high degree of development. Unhappily it is also susceptible, by a sufficient use of the external sanctions and of the force of early impressions, of being cultivated in almost any direction: so that there is hardly anything so absurd or so mischievous that it may not, by means of these influences, be made to act on the human mind with all the authority of conscience. To doubt that the same potency might be given by the same means to the principle of utility, even if it had no foundation in human nature, would be flying in the face of all experience.

But moral associations which are wholly of artificial creation, when intellectual culture goes on, yield by degrees to the dissolving force of analysis: and if the feeling of duty, when associated with utility, would appear equally arbitrary; if there were no leading

department of our nature, no powerful class of sentiments, with which that association would harmonise, which would make us feel it congenial, and incline us not only to foster it in others (for which we have abundant interested motives), but also to cherish it in ourselves; if there were not, in short, a natural basis of sentiment for utilitarian morality, it might well happen that this association also, even after it had been implanted by education, might be analysed away.

But there is this basis of powerful natural sentiment; and this it is which, when once the general happiness is recognised as the ethical standard, will constitute the strength of the utilitarian morality. This firm foundation is that of the social feelings of mankind; the desire to be in unity with our fellow creatures, which is already a powerful principle in human nature, and happily one of those which tend to become stronger, even without express inculcation, from the influences of advancing civilisation. The social state is at once so natural, so necessary, and so habitual to man, that, except in some unusual circumstances or by an effort of voluntary abstraction, he never conceives himself otherwise than as a member of a body; and this association is riveted more and more, as mankind are further removed from the state of savage independence. Any condition, therefore, which is essential to a state of society, becomes more and more an inseparable part of every person's conception of the state of things which he is born into, and which is the destiny of a human being.

Now, society between human beings, except in the relation of master and slave, is manifestly impossible on any other footing than that the interests of all are to be consulted. Society between equals can only exist on the understanding that the interests of all are to be regarded equally. And since in all states of civilisation, every person, except an absolute monarch, has equals, every one is obliged to live on these terms with somebody; and in every age some advance is made towards a state in which it will be impossible to live permanently on other terms with anybody. In this way people grow up unable to conceive as possible to them a state of total disregard of other people's interests. They are under a necessity of conceiving themselves as at least abstaining from all the grosser injuries, and (if only for their own protection) living in a state of constant protest against them. They are also familiar with the fact of co-operating with others and proposing to themselves a collective, not an individual interest as the aim (at least for the time being) of their actions. So long as they are co-operating, their ends are identified with those of others; there is at least a temporary feeling that the interests of others are their own interests. Not only does all strengthening of social ties, and all healthy growth of society, give to each individual a stronger personal interest in practically consulting the welfare of others; it also leads him to identify his feelings more and more with their good, or at least with an even greater degree of practical consideration for it. He comes, as though instinctively, to be conscious of himself as a being who of course pays regard to others. The good of others becomes to him a thing naturally and necessarily to be attended to, like any of the physical conditions of our existence. Now, whatever amount of this feeling a person has, he is urged by the strongest motives both of interest and of sympathy to demonstrate it, and to the utmost of his power encourage it in others; and even if he has none of it himself, he is as greatly interested as any one else that others should have it. Consequently the smallest germs of the feeling are laid hold of and nourished by the contagion of sympathy and the influences of education; and a complete web of corroborative association is woven round it, by the powerful agency of the external sanctions.

This mode of conceiving ourselves and human life, as civilisation goes on, is felt to be more and more natural. Every step in political improvement renders it more so, by removing the sources of opposition of interest, and levelling those inequalities of legal

privilege between individuals or classes, owing to which there are large portions of mankind whose happiness it is still practicable to disregard.

In an improving state of the human mind, the influences are constantly on the increase, which tend to generate in each individual a feeling of unity with all the rest; which, if perfect, would make him never think of, or desire, any beneficial condition for himself, in the benefits of which they are not included. If we now suppose this feeling of unity to be taught as a religion, and the whole force of education, of institutions, and of opinion, directed, as it once was in the case of religion, to make every person grow up from infancy surrounded on all sides both by the profession and the practice of it, I think that no one, who can realise this conception, will feel any misgiving about the sufficiency of the ultimate sanction for the Happiness morality. To any ethical student who finds the realisation difficult, I recommend, as a means of facilitating it, the second of M. Comte's two principle works, the Traite de Politique Positive. I entertain the strongest objections to the system of politics and morals set forth in that treatise; but I think it has superabundantly shown the possibility of giving to the service of humanity, even without the aid of belief in a Providence, both the psychological power and the social efficacy of a religion; making it take hold of human life, and colour all thought, feeling, and action, in a manner of which the greatest ascendancy ever exercised by any religion may be but a type and foretaste; and of which the danger is, not that it should be insufficient but that it should be so excessive as to interfere unduly with human freedom and individuality.

Neither is it necessary to the feeling which constitutes the binding force of the utilitarian morality on those who recognise it, to wait for those social influences which would make its obligation felt by mankind at large. In the comparatively early state of human advancement in which we now live, a person cannot indeed feel that entireness of sympathy with all others, which would make any real discordance in the general direction of their conduct in life impossible; but already a person in whom the social feeling is at all developed, cannot bring himself to think of the rest of his fellow creatures as struggling rivals with him for the means of happiness, whom he must desire to see defeated in their object in order that he may succeed in his. The deeply rooted conception which every individual even now has of himself as a social being, tends to make him feel it one of his natural wants that there should be harmony between his feelings and aims and those of his fellow creatures. If differences of opinion and of mental culture make it impossible for him to share many of their actual feelings- perhaps make him denounce and defy those feelings- he still needs to be conscious that his real aim and theirs do not conflict; that he is not opposing himself to what they really wish for, namely their own good, but is, on the contrary, promoting it. This feeling in most individuals is much inferior in strength to their selfish feelings, and is often wanting altogether. But to those who have it, it possesses all the characters of a natural feeling. It does not present itself to their minds as a superstition of education, or a law despotically imposed by the power of society, but as an attribute which it would not be well for them to be without. This conviction is the ultimate sanction of the greatest happiness morality. This it is which makes any mind, of well-developed feelings, work with, and not against, the outward motives to care for others, afforded by what I have called the external sanctions; and when those sanctions are wanting, or act in an opposite direction, constitutes in itself a powerful internal binding force, in proportion to the sensitiveness and thoughtfulness of the character; since few but those whose mind is a moral blank, could bear to lay out their course of life on the plan of paying no regard to others except so far as their own private interest compels.

Chapter 4

Of what sort of Proof the Principle of Utility is Susceptible

IT HAS already been remarked, that questions of ultimate ends do not admit of proof, in the ordinary acceptation of the term. To be incapable of proof by reasoning is common to all first principles; to the first premises of our knowledge, as well as to those of our conduct. But the former, being matters of fact, may be the subject of a direct appeal to the faculties which judge of fact- namely, our senses, and our internal consciousness. Can an appeal be made to the same faculties on questions of practical ends? Or by what other faculty is cognisance taken of them? Questions about ends are, in other words, questions what things are desirable.

The utilitarian doctrine is, that happiness is desirable, and the only thing desirable, as an end; all other things being only desirable as means to that end. What ought to be required of this doctrine- what conditions is it requisite that the doctrine should fulfil- to make good its claim to be believed? The only proof capable of being given that an object is visible, is that people actually see it. The only proof that a sound is audible, is that people hear it: and so of the other sources of our experience. In like manner, I apprehend, the sole evidence it is possible to produce that anything is desirable, is that people do actually desire it. If the end which the utilitarian doctrine proposes to itself were not, in theory and in practice, acknowledged to be an end, nothing could ever convince any person that it was so. No reason can be given why the general happiness is desirable, except that each person, so far as he believes it to be attainable, desires his own happiness. This, however, being a fact, we have not only all the proof which the case admits of, but all which it is possible to require, that happiness is a good: that each person's happiness is a good to that person, and the general happiness, therefore, a good to the aggregate of all persons. Happiness has made out its title as one of the ends of conduct, and consequently one of the criteria of morality.

But it has not, by this alone, proved itself to be the sole criterion. To do that, it would seem, by the same rule, necessary to show, not only that people desire happiness, but that they never desire anything else. Now it is palpable that they do desire things which, in common language, are decidedly distinguished from happiness. They desire, for example, virtue, and the absence of vice, no less really than pleasure and the absence of pain. The desire of virtue is not as universal, but it is as authentic a fact, as the desire of happiness. And hence the opponents of the utilitarian standard deem that they have a right to infer that there are other ends of human action besides happiness, and that happiness is not the standard of approbation and disapprobation.

But does the utilitarian doctrine deny that people desire virtue, or maintain that virtue is not a thing to be desired? The very reverse. It maintains not only that virtue is to be desired, but that it is to be desired disinterestedly, for itself. Whatever may be the opinion of utilitarian moralists as to the original conditions by which virtue is made virtue; however they may believe (as they do) that actions and dispositions are only virtuous because they promote another end than virtue; yet this being granted, and it having been decided, from considerations of this description, what is virtuous, they not only place virtue at the very head of the things which are good as means to the ultimate end, but they also recognise as a psychological fact the possibility of its being, to the individual, a good in itself, without looking to any end beyond it; and hold, that the mind is not in a right state, not in a state conformable to Utility, not in the state most

conducive to the general happiness, unless it does love virtue in this manner- as a thing desirable in itself, even although, in the individual instance, it should not produce those other desirable consequences which it tends to produce, and on account of which it is held to be virtue. This opinion is not, in the smallest degree, a departure from the Happiness principle. The ingredients of happiness are very various, and each of them is desirable in itself, and not merely when considered as swelling an aggregate. The principle of utility does not mean that any given pleasure, as music, for instance, or any given exemption from pain, as for example health, is to be looked upon as means to a collective something termed happiness, and to be desired on that account. They are desired and desirable in and for themselves; besides being means, they are a part of the end. Virtue, according to the utilitarian doctrine, is not naturally and originally part of the end, but it is capable of becoming so; and in those who love it disinterestedly it has become so, and is desired and cherished, not as a means to happiness, but as a part of their happiness.

To illustrate this farther, we may remember that virtue is not the only thing, originally a means, and which if it were not a means to anything else, would be and remain indifferent, but which by association with what it is a means to, comes to be desired for itself, and that too with the utmost intensity. What, for example, shall we say of the love of money? There is nothing originally more desirable about money than about any heap of glittering pebbles. Its worth is solely that of the things which it will buy; the desires for other things than itself, which it is a means of gratifying. Yet the love of money is not only one of the strongest moving forces of human life, but money is, in many cases, desired in and for itself; the desire to possess it is often stronger than the desire to use it, and goes on increasing when all the desires which point to ends beyond it, to be compassed by it, are falling off. It may, then, be said truly, that money is desired not for the sake of an end, but as part of the end. From being a means to happiness, it has come to be itself a principal ingredient of the individual's conception of happiness. The same may be said of the majority of the great objects of human life- power, for example, or fame; except that to each of these there is a certain amount of immediate pleasure annexed, which has at least the semblance of being naturally inherent in them; a thing which cannot be said of money. Still, however, the strongest natural attraction, both of power and of fame, is the immense aid they give to the attainment of our other wishes; and it is the strong association thus generated between them and all our objects of desire, which gives to the direct desire of them the intensity it often assumes, so as in some characters to surpass in strength all other desires. In these cases the means have become a part of the end, and a more important part of it than any of the things which they are means to. What was once desired as an instrument for the attainment of happiness, has come to be desired for its own sake. In being desired for its own sake it is, however, desired as part of happiness. The person is made, or thinks he would be made, happy by its mere possession; and is made unhappy by failure to obtain it. The desire of it is not a different thing from the desire of happiness, any more than the love of music, or the desire of health. They are included in happiness. They are some of the elements of which the desire of happiness is made up. Happiness is not an abstract idea, but a concrete whole; and these are some of its parts. And the utilitarian standard sanctions and approves their being so. Life would be a poor thing, very ill provided with sources of happiness, if there were not this provision of nature, by which things originally indifferent, but conducive to, or otherwise associated with, the satisfaction of our primitive desires, become in themselves sources of pleasure more valuable than the primitive pleasures, both in permanency, in the space of human existence that they are capable of covering, and even in intensity.

Virtue, according to the utilitarian conception, is a good of this description.

There was no original desire of it, or motive to it, save its conduciveness to pleasure, and especially to protection from pain. But through the association thus formed, it may be felt a good in itself, and desired as such with as great intensity as any other good; and with this difference between it and the love of money, of power, or of fame, that all of these may, and often do, render the individual noxious to the other members of the society to which he belongs, whereas there is nothing which makes him so much a blessing to them as the cultivation of the disinterested love of virtue. And consequently, the utilitarian standard, while it tolerates and approves those other acquired desires, up to the point beyond which they would be more injurious to the general happiness than promotive of it, enjoins and requires the cultivation of the love of virtue up to the greatest strength possible, as being above all things important to the general happiness.

It results from the preceding considerations, that there is in reality nothing desired except happiness. Whatever is desired otherwise than as a means to some end beyond itself, and ultimately to happiness, is desired as itself a part of happiness, and is not desired for itself until it has become so. Those who desire virtue for its own sake, desire it either because the consciousness of it is a pleasure, or because the consciousness of being without it is a pain, or for both reasons united; as in truth the pleasure and pain seldom exist separately, but almost always together, the same person feeling pleasure in the degree of virtue attained, and pain in not having attained more. If one of these gave him no pleasure, and the other no pain, he would not love or desire virtue, or would desire it only for the other benefits which it might produce to himself or to persons whom he cared for.

We have now, then, an answer to the question, of what sort of proof the principle of utility is susceptible. If the opinion which I have now stated is psychologically true- if human nature is so constituted as to desire nothing which is not either a part of happiness or a means of happiness, we can have no other proof, and we require no other, that these are the only things desirable. If so, happiness is the sole end of human action, and the promotion of it the test by which to judge of all human conduct; from whence it necessarily follows that it must be the criterion of morality, since a part is included in the whole.

And now to decide whether this is really so; whether mankind do desire nothing for itself but that which is a pleasure to them, or of which the absence is a pain; we have evidently arrived at a question of fact and experience, dependent, like all similar questions, upon evidence. It can only be determined by practised self-consciousness and self-observation, assisted by observation of others. I believe that these sources of evidence, impartially consulted, will declare that desiring a thing and finding it pleasant, aversion to it and thinking of it as painful, are phenomena entirely inseparable, or rather two parts of the same phenomenon; in strictness of language, two different modes of naming the same psychological fact: that to think of an object as desirable (unless for the sake of its consequences), and to think of it as pleasant, are one and the same thing; and that to desire anything, except in proportion as the idea of it is pleasant, is a physical and metaphysical impossibility.

So obvious does this appear to me, that I expect it will hardly be disputed: and the objection made will be, not that desire can possibly be directed to anything ultimately except pleasure and exemption from pain, but that the will is a different thing from desire; that a person of confirmed virtue, or any other person whose purposes are fixed,

carries out his purposes without any thought of the pleasure he has in contemplating them, or expects to derive from their fulfilment; and persists in acting on them, even though these pleasures are much diminished, by changes in his character or decay of his passive sensibilities, or are outweighed by the pains which the pursuit of the purposes may bring upon him. All this I fully admit, and have stated it elsewhere, as positively and emphatically as any one. Will, the active phenomenon, is a different thing from desire, the state of passive sensibility, and though originally an offshoot from it, may in time take root and detach itself from the parent stock; so much so, that in the case of an habitual purpose, instead of willing the thing because we desire it, we often desire it only because we will it. This, however, is but an instance of that familiar fact, the power of habit, and is nowise confined to the case of virtuous actions. Many indifferent things, which men originally did from a motive of some sort, they continue to do from habit. Sometimes this is done unconsciously, the consciousness coming only after the action: at other times with conscious volition, but volition which has become habitual, and is put in operation by the force of habit, in opposition perhaps to the deliberate preference, as often happens with those who have contracted habits of vicious or hurtful indulgence.

Third and last comes the case in which the habitual act of will in the individual instance is not in contradiction to the general intention prevailing at other times, but in fulfilment of it; as in the case of the person of confirmed virtue, and of all who pursue deliberately and consistently any determinate end. The distinction between will and desire thus understood is an authentic and highly important psychological fact; but the fact consists solely in this- that will, like all other parts of our constitution, is amenable to habit, and that we may will from habit what we no longer desire for itself or desire only because we will it. It is not the less true that will, in the beginning, is entirely produced by desire; including in that term the repelling influence of pain as well as the attractive one of pleasure. Let us take into consideration, no longer the person who has a confirmed will to do right, but him in whom that virtuous will is still feeble, conquerable by temptation, and not to be fully relied on; by what means can it be strengthened? How can the will to be virtuous, where it does not exist in sufficient force, be implanted or awakened? Only by making the person desire virtue- by making him think of it in a pleasurable light, or of its absence in a painful one. It is by associating the doing right with pleasure, or the doing wrong with pain, or by eliciting and impressing and bringing home to the person's experience the pleasure naturally involved in the one or the pain in the other, that it is possible to call forth that will to be virtuous, which, when confirmed, acts without any thought of either pleasure or pain. Will is the child of desire, and passes out of the dominion of its parent only to come under that of habit. That which is the result of habit affords no presumption of being intrinsically good; and there would be no reason for wishing that the purpose of virtue should become independent of pleasure and pain, were it not that the influence of the pleasurable and painful associations which prompt to virtue is not sufficiently to be depended on for unerring constancy of action until it has acquired the support of habit. Both in feeling and in conduct, habit is the only thing which imparts certainty; and it is because of the importance to others of being able to rely absolutely on one's feelings and conduct, and to oneself of being able to rely on one's own, that the will to do right ought to be cultivated into this habitual independence. In other words, this state of the will is a means to good, not intrinsically a good; and does not contradict the doctrine that nothing is a good to human beings but in so far as it is either itself pleasurable, or a means of attaining pleasure or averting pain.

But if this doctrine be true, the principle of utility is proved. Whether it is so or not, must now be left to the consideration of the thoughtful reader.

Chapter 5

On the Connection between Justice and Utility

IN ALL ages of speculation, one of the strongest obstacles to the reception of the doctrine that Utility or Happiness is the criterion of right and wrong, has been drawn from the idea of justice. The powerful sentiment, and apparently clear perception, which that word recalls with a rapidity and certainty resembling an instinct, have seemed to the majority of thinkers to point to an inherent quality in things; to show that the just must have an existence in Nature as something absolute, generically distinct from every variety of the Expedient, and, in idea, opposed to it, though (as is commonly acknowledged) never, in the long run, disjoined from it in fact.

In the case of this, as of our other moral sentiments, there is no necessary connection between the question of its origin, and that of its binding force. That a feeling is bestowed on us by Nature, does not necessarily legitimate all its promptings. The feeling of justice might be a peculiar instinct, and might yet require, like our other instincts, to be controlled and enlightened by a higher reason. If we have intellectual instincts, leading us to judge in a particular way, as well as animal instincts that prompt us to act in a particular way, there is no necessity that the former should be more infallible in their sphere than the latter in theirs: it may as well happen that wrong judgments are occasionally suggested by those, as wrong actions by these. But though it is one thing to believe that we have natural feelings of justice, and another to acknowledge them as an ultimate criterion of conduct, these two opinions are very closely connected in point of fact. Mankind are always predisposed to believe that any subjective feeling, not otherwise accounted for, is a revelation of some objective reality. Our present object is to determine whether the reality, to which the feeling of justice corresponds, is one which needs any such special revelation; whether the justice or injustice of an action is a thing intrinsically peculiar, and distinct from all its other qualities, or only a combination of certain of those qualities, presented under a peculiar aspect.

For the purpose of this inquiry it is practically important to consider whether the feeling itself, of justice and injustice, is sui generis like our sensations of colour and taste, or a derivative feeling, formed by a combination of others. And this it is the more essential to examine, as people are in general willing enough to allow, that objectively the dictates of justice coincide with a part of the field of General Expediency; but inasmuch as the subjective mental feeling of justice is different from that which commonly attaches to simple expediency, and, except in the extreme cases of the latter, is far more imperative in its demands, people find it difficult to see, in justice, only a particular kind or branch of general utility, and think that its superior binding force requires a totally different origin.

To throw light upon this question, it is necessary to attempt to ascertain what is the distinguishing character of justice, or of injustice: what is the quality, or whether there is any quality, attributed in common to all modes of conduct designated as unjust (for justice, like many other moral attributes, is best defined by its opposite), and distinguishing them from such modes of conduct as are disapproved, but without having that particular epithet of disapprobation applied to them. If in everything which men are accustomed to characterise as just or unjust, some one common attribute or collection of attributes is always present, we may judge whether this particular attribute or

combination of attributes would be capable of gathering round it a sentiment of that peculiar character and intensity by virtue of the general laws of our emotional constitution, or whether the sentiment is inexplicable, and requires to be regarded as a special provision of Nature. If we find the former to be the case, we shall, in resolving this question, have resolved also the main problem: if the latter, we shall have to seek for some other mode of investigating it.

To find the common attributes of a variety of objects, it is necessary to begin by surveying the objects themselves in the concrete. Let us therefore advert successively to the various modes of action, and arrangements of human affairs, which are classed, by universal or widely spread opinion, as Just or as Unjust.

The things well known to excite the sentiments associated with those names are of a very multifarious character. I shall pass them rapidly in review, without studying any particular arrangement.
In the first place, it is mostly considered unjust to deprive any one of his personal liberty, his property, or any other thing which belongs to him by law. Here, therefore, is one instance of the application of the terms just and unjust in a perfectly definite sense, namely, that it is just to respect, unjust to violate, the legal rights of any one. But this judgment admits of several exceptions, arising from the other forms in which the notions of justice and injustice present themselves.

For example, the person who suffers the deprivation may (as the phrase is) have forfeited the rights which he is so deprived of: a case to which we shall return presently. But also, Secondly; the legal rights of which he is deprived, may be rights which ought not to have belonged to him; in other words, the law which confers on him these rights, may be a bad law. When it is so, or when (which is the same thing for our purpose) it is supposed to be so, opinions will differ as to the justice or injustice of infringing it. Some maintain that no law, however bad, ought to be disobeyed by an individual citizen; that his opposition to it, if shown at all, should only be shown in endeavouring to get it altered by competent authority. This opinion (which condemns many of the most illustrious benefactors of mankind, and would often protect pernicious institutions against the only weapons which, in the state of things existing at the time, have any chance of succeeding against them) is defended, by those who hold it, on grounds of expediency; principally on that of the importance, to the common interest of mankind, of maintaining inviolate the sentiment of submission to law. Other persons, again, hold the directly contrary opinion, that any law, judged to be bad, may blamelessly be disobeyed, even though it be not judged to be unjust, but only inexpedient; while others would confine the licence of disobedience to the case of unjust laws: but again, some say, that all laws which are inexpedient are unjust; since every law imposes some restriction on the natural liberty of mankind, which restriction is an injustice, unless legitimated by tending to their good. Among these diversities of opinion, it seems to be universally admitted that there may be unjust laws, and that law, consequently, is not the ultimate criterion of justice, but may give to one person a benefit, or impose on another an evil, which justice condemns. When, however, a law is thought to be unjust, it seems always to be regarded as being so in the same way in which a breach of law is unjust, namely, by infringing somebody's right; which, as it cannot in this case be a legal right, receives a different appellation, and is called a moral right. We may say, therefore, that a second case of injustice consists in taking or withholding from any person that to which he has a moral right.

Thirdly, it is universally considered just that each person should obtain that (whether good or evil) which he deserves; and unjust that he should obtain a good, or be made to undergo an evil, which he does not deserve. This is, perhaps, the clearest and most emphatic form in which the idea of justice is conceived by the general mind. As it involves the notion of desert, the question arises, what constitutes desert? Speaking in a general way, a person is understood to deserve good if he does right, evil if he does wrong; and in a more particular sense, to deserve good from those to whom he does or has done good, and evil from those to whom he does or has done evil. The precept of returning good for evil has never been regarded as a case of the fulfilment of justice, but as one in which the claims of justice are waived, in obedience to other considerations.

Fourthly, it is confessedly unjust to break faith with any one: to violate an engagement, either express or implied, or disappoint expectations raised by our conduct, at least if we have raised those expectations knowingly and voluntarily. Like the other obligations of justice already spoken of, this one is not regarded as absolute, but as capable of being overruled by a stronger obligation of justice on the other side; or by such conduct on the part of the person concerned as is deemed to absolve us from our obligation to him, and to constitute a forfeiture of the benefit which he has been led to expect.

Fifthly, it is, by universal admission, inconsistent with justice to be partial; to show favour or preference to one person over another, in matters to which favour and preference do not properly apply. Impartiality, however, does not seem to be regarded as a duty in itself, but rather as instrumental to some other duty; for it is admitted that favour and preference are not always censurable, and indeed the cases in which they are condemned are rather the exception than the rule. A person would be more likely to be blamed than applauded for giving his family or friends no superiority in good offices over strangers, when he could do so without violating any other duty; and no one thinks it unjust to seek one person in preference to another as a friend, connection, or companion. Impartiality where rights are concerned is of course obligatory, but this is involved in the more general obligation of giving to every one his right. A tribunal, for example, must be impartial, because it is bound to award, without regard to any other consideration, a disputed object to the one of two parties who has the right to it. There are other cases in which impartiality means, being solely influenced by desert; as with those who, in the capacity of judges, preceptors, or parents, administer reward and punishment as such. There are cases, again, in which it means, being solely influenced by consideration for the public interest; as in making a selection among candidates for a government employment. Impartiality, in short, as an obligation of justice, may be said to mean, being exclusively influenced by the considerations which it is supposed ought to influence the particular case in hand; and resisting the solicitation of any motives which prompt to conduct different from what those considerations would dictate.

Nearly allied to the idea of impartiality is that of equality; which often enters as a component part both into the conception of justice and into the practice of it, and, in the eyes of many persons, constitutes its essence. But in this, still more than in any other case, the notion of justice varies in different persons, and always conforms in its variations to their notion of utility. Each person maintains that equality is the dictate of justice, except where he thinks that expediency requires inequality. The justice of giving equal protection to the rights of all, is maintained by those who support the most outrageous inequality in the rights themselves.
Even in slave countries it is theoretically admitted that the rights of the slave, such as they are, ought to be as sacred as those of the master; and that a tribunal which fails to enforce them with equal strictness is wanting in justice; while, at the same time,

institutions which leave to the slave scarcely any rights to enforce, are not deemed unjust, because they are not deemed inexpedient. Those who think that utility requires distinctions of rank, do not consider it unjust that riches and social privileges should be unequally dispensed; but those who think this inequality inexpedient, think it unjust also. Whoever thinks that government is necessary, sees no injustice in as much inequality as is constituted by giving to the magistrate powers not granted to other people. Even among those who hold levelling doctrines, there are as many questions of justice as there are differences of opinion about expediency. Some Communists consider it unjust that the produce of the labour of the community should be shared on any other principle than that of exact equality; others think it just that those should receive most whose wants are greatest; while others hold that those who work harder, or who produce more, or whose services are more valuable to the community, may justly claim a larger quota in the division of the produce. And the sense of natural justice may be plausibly appealed to in behalf of every one of these opinions.

Among so many diverse applications of the term justice, which yet is not regarded as ambiguous, it is a matter of some difficulty to seize the mental link which holds them together, and on which the moral sentiment adhering to the term essentially depends. Perhaps, in this embarrassment, some help may be derived from the history of the word, as indicated by its etymology.

In most, if not in all, languages, the etymology of the word which corresponds to Just, points distinctly to an origin connected with the ordinances of law. Justum is a form of jussum, that which has been ordered. Dikaion comes directly from dike, a suit at law. Recht, from which came right and righteous, is synonymous with law. The courts of justice, the administration of justice, are the courts and the administration of law. La justice, in French, is the established term for judicature.

I am not committing the fallacy imputed with some show of truth to Horne Tooke, of assuming that a word must still continue to mean what it originally meant. Etymology is slight evidence of what the idea now signified is, but the very best evidence of how it sprang up. There can, I think, be no doubt that the idee mere, the primitive element, in the formation of the notion of justice, was conformity to law. It constituted the entire idea among the Hebrews, up to the birth of Christianity; as might be expected in the case of a people whose laws attempted to embrace all subjects on which precepts were required, and who believed those laws to be a direct emanation from the Supreme Being. But other nations, and in particular the Greeks and Romans, who knew that their laws had been made originally, and still continued to be made, by men, were not afraid to admit that those men might make bad laws; might do, by law, the same things, and from the same motives, which if done by individuals without the sanction of law, would be called unjust. And hence the sentiment of injustice came to be attached, not to all violations of law, but only to violations of such laws as ought to exist, including such as ought to exist, but do not; and to laws themselves, if supposed to be contrary to what ought to be law. In this manner the idea of law and of its injunctions was still predominant in the notion of justice, even when the laws actually in force ceased to be accepted as the standard of it.

It is true that mankind consider the idea of justice and its obligations as applicable to many things which neither are, nor is it desired that they should be, regulated by law. Nobody desires that laws should interfere with the whole detail of private life; yet every one allows that in all daily conduct a person may and does show himself to be either just or unjust. But even here, the idea of the breach of what ought to be law, still lingers in a

modified shape. It would always give us pleasure, and chime in with our feelings of fitness, that acts which we deem unjust should be punished, though we do not always think it expedient that this should be done by the tribunals. We forego that gratification on account of incidental inconveniences. We should be glad to see just conduct enforced and injustice repressed, even in the minutest details, if we were not, with reason, afraid of trusting the magistrate with so unlimited an amount of power over individuals.

When we think that a person is bound in justice to do a thing, it is an ordinary form of language to say, that he ought to be compelled to do it. We should be gratified to see the obligation enforced by anybody who had the power. If we see that its enforcement by law would be inexpedient, we lament the impossibility, we consider the impunity given to injustice as an evil, and strive to make amends for it by bringing a strong expression of our own and the public disapprobation to bear upon the offender. Thus the idea of legal constraint is still the generating idea of the notion of justice, though undergoing several transformations before that notion, as it exists in an advanced state of society, becomes complete.

The above is, I think, a true account, as far as it goes, of the origin and progressive growth of the idea of justice. But we must observe, that it contains, as yet, nothing to distinguish that obligation from moral obligation in general. For the truth is, that the idea of penal sanction, which is the essence of law, enters not only into the conception of injustice, but into that of any kind of wrong. We do not call anything wrong, unless we mean to imply that a person ought to be punished in some way or other for doing it; if not by law, by the opinion of his fellowcreatures; if not by opinion, by the reproaches of his own conscience. This seems the real turning point of the distinction between morality and simple expediency.
It is a part of the notion of Duty in every one of its forms, that a person may rightfully be compelled to fulfil it. Duty is a thing which may be exacted from a person, as one exacts a debt. Unless we think that it may be exacted from him, we do not call it his duty. Reasons of prudence, or the interest of other people, may militate against actually exacting it; but the person himself, it is clearly understood, would not be entitled to complain. There are other things, on the contrary, which we wish that people should do, which we like or admire them for doing, perhaps dislike or despise them for not doing, but yet admit that they are not bound to do; it is not a case of moral obligation; we do not blame them, that is, we do not think that they are proper objects of punishment. How we come by these ideas of deserving and not deserving punishment, will appear, perhaps, in the sequel; but I think there is no doubt that this distinction lies at the bottom of the notions of right and wrong; that we call any conduct wrong, or employ, instead, some other term of dislike or disparagement, according as we think that the person ought, or ought not, to be punished for it; and we say, it would be right, to do so and so, or merely that it would be desirable or laudable, according as we would wish to see the person whom it concerns, compelled, or only persuaded and exhorted, to act in that manner. 2 This, therefore, being the characteristic difference which marks off, not justice, but morality in general, from the remaining provinces of Expediency and Worthiness; the character is still to be sought which distinguishes justice from other branches of morality. Now it is known that ethical writers divide moral duties into two classes, denoted by the ill-chosen expressions, duties of perfect and of imperfect obligation; the latter being those in which, though the act is obligatory, the particular occasions of performing it are left to our choice, as in the case of charity or beneficence, which we are indeed bound to practise, but not towards any definite person, nor at any prescribed time. In the more precise language of philosophic jurists, duties of perfect obligation are those duties in virtue of which a correlative right resides in some person

or persons; duties of imperfect obligation are those moral obligations which do not give birth to any right. I think it will be found that this distinction exactly coincides with that which exists between jus-

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See this point enforced and illustrated by Professor Bain, in
an admirable chapter (entitled "The Ethical Emotions, or the Moral Sense"), of the second of the two treatises composing
his elaborate and profound work on the Mind.

tice and the other obligations of morality. In our survey of the various popular acceptations of justice, the term appeared generally to involve the idea of a personal right- a claim on the part of one or more individuals, like that which the law gives when it confers a proprietary or other legal right. Whether the injustice consists in depriving a person of a possession, or in breaking faith with him, or in treating him worse than he deserves, or worse than other people who have no greater claims, in each case the supposition implies two things- a wrong done, and some assignable person who is wronged. Injustice may also be done by treating a person better than others; but the wrong in this case is to his competitors, who are also assignable persons.

It seems to me that this feature in the case- a right in some person, correlative to the moral obligation- constitutes the specific difference between justice, and generosity or beneficence. Justice implies something which it is not only right to do, and wrong not to do, but which some individual person can claim from us as his moral right. No one has a moral right to our generosity or beneficence, because we are not morally bound to practise those virtues towards any given individual. And it will be found with respect to this, as to every correct definition, that the instances which seem to conflict with it are those which most confirm it.
For if a moralist attempts, as some have done, to make out that mankind generally, though not any given individual, have a right to all the good we can do them, he at once, by that thesis, includes generosity and beneficence within the category of justice. He is obliged to say, that our utmost exertions are due to our fellow creatures, thus assimilating them to a debt; or that nothing less can be a sufficient return for what society does for us, thus classing the case as one of gratitute; both of which are acknowledged cases of justice. Wherever there is right, the case is one of justice, and not of the virtue of beneficence: and whoever does not place the distinction between justice and morality in general, where we have now placed it, will be found to make no distinction between them at all, but to merge all morality in justice.

Having thus endeavoured to determine the distinctive elements which enter into the composition of the idea of justice, we are ready to enter on the inquiry, whether the feeling, which accompanies the idea, is attached to it by a special dispensation of nature, or whether it could have grown up, by any known laws, out of the idea itself; and in particular, whether it can have originated in considerations of general expediency.

I conceive that the sentiment itself does not arise from anything which would commonly, or correctly, be termed an idea of expediency; but that though the sentiment does not, whatever is moral in it does.

We have seen that the two essential ingredients in the sentiment of justice are, the desire to punish a person who has done harm, and the knowledge or belief that there is some definite individual or individuals to whom harm has been done.

Now it appears to me, that the desire to punish a person who has done harm to some individual is a spontaneous outgrowth from two sentiments, both in the highest degree natural, and which either are or resemble instincts; the impulse of self-defence, and the feeling of sympathy.

It is natural to resent, and to repel or retaliate, any harm done or attempted against ourselves, or against those with whom we sympathise. The origin of this sentiment it is not necessary here to discuss. Whether it be an instinct or a result of intelligence, it is, we know, common to all animal nature; for every animal tries to hurt those who have hurt, or who it thinks are about to hurt, itself or its young. Human beings, on this point, only differ from other animals in two particulars. First, in being capable of sympathising, not solely with their offspring, or, like some of the more noble animals, with some superior animal who is kind to them, but with all human, and even with all sentient, beings. Secondly, in having a more developed intelligence, which gives a wider range to the whole of their sentiments, whether self-regarding or sympathetic. By virtue of his superior intelligence, even apart from his superior range of sympathy, a human being is capable of apprehending a community of interest between himself and the human society of which he forms a part, such that any conduct which threatens the security of the society generally, is threatening to his own, and calls forth his instinct (if instinct it be) of self-defence. The same superiority of intelligence joined to the power of sympathising with human beings generally, enables him to attach himself to the collective idea of his tribe, his country, or mankind, in such a manner that any act hurtful to them, raises his instinct of sympathy, and urges him to resistance.

The sentiment of justice, in that one of its elements which consists of the desire to punish, is thus, I conceive, the natural feeling of retaliation or vengeance, rendered by intellect and sympathy applicable to those injuries, that is, to those hurts, which wound us through, or in common with, society at large. This sentiment, in itself, has nothing moral in it; what is moral is, the exclusive subordination of it to the social sympathies, so as to wait on and obey their call. For the natural feeling would make us resent indiscriminately whatever any one does that is disagreeable to us; but when moralised by the social feeling, it only acts in the directions conformable to the general good: just persons resenting a hurt to society, though not otherwise a hurt to themselves, and not resenting a hurt to themselves, however painful, unless it be of the kind which society has a common interest with them in the repression of.

It is no objection against this doctrine to say, that when we feel our sentiment of justice outraged, we are not thinking of society at large, or of any collective interest, but only of the individual case. It is common enough certainly, though the reverse of commendable, to feel resentment merely because we have suffered pain; but a person whose resentment is really a moral feeling, that is, who considers whether an act is blamable before he allows himself to resent it- such a person, though he may not say expressly to himself that he is standing up for the interest of society, certainly does feel that he is asserting a rule which is for the benefit of others as well as for his own. If he is not feeling this- if he is regarding the act solely as it affects him individually- he is not consciously just; he is not concerning himself about the justice of his actions. This is admitted even by antiutilitarian moralists. When Kant (as before remarked) propounds as the fundamental principle of morals, “So act, that thy rule of conduct might be adopted as a law by all rational beings,” he virtually acknowledges that the interest of mankind collectively, or at least of mankind indiscriminately, must be in the mind of the agent when conscientiously deciding on the morality of the act. Otherwise he uses words without a

meaning: for, that a rule even of utter selfishness could not possibly be adopted by all rational beings- that there is any insuperable obstacle in the nature of things to its adoption- cannot be even plausibly maintained. To give any meaning to Kant's principle, the sense put upon it must be, that we ought to shape our conduct by a rule which all rational beings might adopt with benefit to their collective interest.

To recapitulate: the idea of justice supposes two things; a rule of conduct, and a sentiment which sanctions the rule. The first must be supposed common to all mankind, and intended for their good. The other (the sentiment) is a desire that punishment may be suffered by those who infringe the rule. There is involved, in addition, the conception of some definite person who suffers by the infringement; whose rights (to use the expression appropriated to the case) are violated by it.

And the sentiment of justice appears to me to be, the animal desire to repel or retaliate a hurt or damage to oneself, or to those with whom one sympathises, widened so as to include all persons, by the human capacity of enlarged sympathy, and the human conception of intelligent self-interest. From the latter elements, the feeling derives its morality; from the former, its peculiar impressiveness, and energy of self-assertion.

I have, throughout, treated the idea of a right residing in the injured person, and violated by the injury, not as a separate element in the composition of the idea and sentiment, but as one of the forms in which the other two elements clothe themselves. These elements are, a hurt to some assignable person or persons on the one hand, and a demand for punishment on the other. An examination of our own minds, I think, will show, that these two things include all that we mean when we speak of violation of a right. When we call anything a person's right, we mean that he has a valid claim on society to protect him in the possession of it, either by the force of law, or by that of education and opinion. If he has what we consider a sufficient claim, on whatever account, to have something guaranteed to him by society, we say that he has a right to it. If we desire to prove that anything does not belong to him by right, we think this done as soon as it is admitted that society ought not to take measures for securing it to him, but should leave him to chance, or to his own exertions. Thus, a person is said to have a right to what he can earn in fair professional competition; because society ought not to allow any other person to hinder him from endeavouring to earn in that manner as much as he can. But he has not a right to three hundred a-year, though he may happen to be earning it; because society is not called on to provide that he shall earn that sum. On the contrary, if he owns ten thousand pounds three per cent stock, he has a right to three hundred a-year; because society has come under an obligation to provide him with an income of that amount.

To have a right, then, is, I conceive, to have something which society ought to defend me in the possession of. If the objector goes on to ask, why it ought? I can give him no other reason than general utility. If that expression does not seem to convey a sufficient feeling of the strength of the obligation, nor to account for the peculiar energy of the feeling, it is because there goes to the composition of the sentiment, not a rational only, but also an animal element, the thirst for retaliation; and this thirst derives its intensity, as well as its moral justification, from the extraordinarily important and impressive kind of utility which is concerned. The interest involved is that of security, to every one's feelings the most vital of all interests. All other earthly benefits are needed by one person, not needed by another; and many of them can, if necessary, be cheerfully foregone, or replaced by something else; but security no human being can possibly do without on it we depend for all our immunity from evil, and for the whole value of all

and every good, beyond the passing moment; since nothing but the gratification of the instant could be of any worth to us, if we could be deprived of anything the next instant by whoever was momentarily stronger than ourselves. Now this most indispensable of all necessaries, after physical nutriment, cannot be had, unless the machinery for providing it is kept unintermittedly in active play. Our notion, therefore, of the claim we have on our fellow-creatures to join in making safe for us the very groundwork of our existence, gathers feelings around it so much more intense than those concerned in any of the more common cases of utility, that the difference in degree (as is often the case in psychology) becomes a real difference in kind. The claim assumes that character of absoluteness, that apparent infinity, and incommensurability with all other considerations, which constitute the distinction between the feeling of right and wrong and that of ordinary expediency and inexpediency. The feelings concerned are so powerful, and we count so positively on finding a responsive feeling in others (all being alike interested), that ought and should grow into must, and recognised indispensability becomes a moral necessity, analogous to physical, and often not inferior to it in binding force exhorted, If the preceding analysis, or something resembling it, be not the correct account of the notion of justice; if justice be totally independent of utility, and be a standard per se, which the mind can recognise by simple introspection of itself; it is hard to understand why that internal oracle is so ambiguous, and why so many things appear either just or unjust, according to the light in which they are regarded.

We are continually informed that Utility is an uncertain standard, which every different person interprets differently, and that there is no safety but in the immutable, ineffaceable, and unmistakable dictates of justice, which carry their evidence in themselves, and are independent of the fluctuations of opinion. One would suppose from this that on questions of justice there could be no controversy; that if we take that for our rule, its application to any given case could leave us in as little doubt as a mathematical demonstration. So far is this from being the fact, that there is as much difference of opinion, and as much discussion, about what is just, as about what is useful to society. Not only have different nations and individuals different notions of justice, but in the mind of one and the same individual, justice is not some one rule, principle, or maxim, but many, which do not always coincide in their dictates, and in choosing between which, he is guided either by some extraneous standard, or by his own personal predilections.

For instance, there are some who say, that it is unjust to punish any one for the sake of example to others; that punishment is just, only when intended for the good of the sufferer himself. Others maintain the extreme reverse, contending that to punish persons who have attained years of discretion, for their own benefit, is despotism and injustice, since if the matter at issue is solely their own good, no one has a right to control their own judgment of it; but that they may justly be punished to prevent evil to others, this being the exercise of the legitimate right of self-defence. Mr. Owen, again, affirms that it is unjust to punish at all; for the criminal did not make his own character; his education, and the circumstances which surrounded him, have made him a criminal, and for these he is not responsible. All these opinions are extremely plausible; and so long as the question is argued as one of justice simply, without going down to the principles which lie under justice and are the source of its authority, I am unable to see how any of these reasoners can be refuted. For in truth every one of the three builds upon rules of justice confessedly true. The first appeals to the acknowledged injustice of singling out an individual, and making a sacrifice, without his consent, for other people's benefit. The second relies on the acknowledged justice of self-defence, and the admitted injustice of forcing one person to conform to another's notions of what constitutes his good. The

Owenite invokes the admitted principle, that it is unjust to punish any one for what he cannot help. Each is triumphant so long as he is not compelled to take into consideration any other maxims of justice than the one he has selected; but as soon as their several maxims are brought face to face, each disputant seems to have exactly as much to say for himself as the others. No one of them can carry out his own notion of justice without trampling upon another equally binding.

These are difficulties; they have always been felt to be such; and many devices have been invented to turn rather than to overcome them. As a refuge from the last of the three, men imagined what they called the freedom of the will; fancying that they could not justify punishing a man whose will is in a thoroughly hateful state, unless it be supposed to have come into that state through no influence of anterior circumstances. To escape from the other difficulties, a favourite contrivance has been the fiction of a contract, whereby at some unknown period all the members of society engaged to obey the laws, and consented to be punished for any disobedience to them, thereby giving to their legislators the right, which it is assumed they would not otherwise have had, of punishing them, either for their own good or for that of society. This happy thought was considered to get rid of the whole difficulty, and to legitimate the infliction of punishment, in virtue of another received maxim of justice, Volenti non fit injuria; that is not unjust which is done with the consent of the person who is supposed to be hurt by it. I need hardly remark, that even if the consent were not a mere fiction, this maxim is not superior in authority to the others which it is brought in to supersede. It is, on the contrary, an instructive specimen of the loose and irregular manner in which supposed principles of justice grow up. This particular one evidently came into use as a help to the coarse exigencies of courts of law, which are sometimes obliged to be content with very uncertain presumptions, on account of the greater evils which would often arise from any attempt on their part to cut finer. But even courts of law are not able to adhere consistently to the maxim, for they allow voluntary engagements to be set aside on the ground of fraud, and sometimes on that of mere mistake or misinformation.

Again, when the legitimacy of inflicting punishment is admitted, how many conflicting conceptions of justice come to light in discussing the proper apportionment of punishments to offences. No rule on the subject recommends itself so strongly to the primitive and spontaneous sentiment of justice, as the lex talionis, an eye for an eye and a tooth for a tooth. Though this principle of the Jewish and of the Mahometan law has been generally abandoned in Europe as a practical maxim, there is, I suspect, in most minds, a secret hankering after it; and when retribution accidentally falls on an offender in that precise shape, the general feeling of satisfaction evinced bears witness how natural is the sentiment to which this repayment in kind is acceptable. With many, the test of justice in penal infliction is that the punishment should be proportioned to the offence; meaning that it should be exactly measured by the moral guilt of the culprit (whatever be their standard for measuring moral guilt): the consideration, what amount of punishment is necessary to deter from the offence, having nothing to do with the question of justice, in their estimation: while there are others to whom that consideration is all in all; who maintain that it is not just, at least for man, to inflict on a fellow creature, whatever may be his offences, any amount of suffering beyond the least that will suffice to prevent him from repeating, and others from imitating, his misconduct.

To take another example from a subject already once referred to. In a co-operative industrial association, is it just or not that talent or skill should give a title to superior remuneration? On the negative side of the question it is argued, that whoever does the best he can, deserves equally well, and ought not in justice to be put in a position of

inferiority for no fault of his own; that superior abilities have already advantages more than enough, in the admiration they excite, the personal influence they command, and the internal sources of satisfaction attending them, without adding to these a superior share of the world's goods; and that society is bound in justice rather to make compensation to the less favoured, for this unmerited inequality of advantages, than to aggravate it. On the contrary side it is contended, that society receives more from the more efficient labourer; that his services being more useful, society owes him a larger return for them; that a greater share of the joint result is actually his work, and not to allow his claim to it is a kind of robbery; that if he is only to receive as much as others, he can only be justly required to produce as much, and to give a smaller amount of time and exertion, proportioned to his superior efficiency. Who shall decide between these appeals to conflicting principles of justice? justice has in this case two sides to it, which it is impossible to bring into harmony, and the two disputants have chosen opposite sides; the one looks to what it is just that the individual should receive, the other to what it is just that the community should give. Each, from his own point of view, is unanswerable; and any choice between them, on grounds of justice, must be perfectly arbitrary. Social utility alone can decide the preference.

How many, again, and how irreconcilable, are the standards of justice to which reference is made in discussing the repartition of taxation. One opinion is, that payment to the State should be in numerical proportion to pecuniary means.

Others think that justice dictates what they term graduated taxation; taking a higher percentage from those who have more to spare. In point of natural justice a strong case might be made for disregarding means altogether, and taking the same absolute sum (whenever it could be got) from every one: as the subscribers to a mess, or to a club, all pay the same sum for the same privileges, whether they can all equally afford it or not. Since the protection (it might be said) of law and government is afforded to, and is equally required by all, there is no injustice in making all buy it at the same price. It is reckoned justice, not injustice, that a dealer should charge to all customers the same price for the same article, not a price varying according to their means of payment. This doctrine, as applied to taxation, finds no advocates, because it conflicts so strongly with man's feelings of humanity and of social expediency; but the principle of justice which it invokes is as true and as binding as those which can be appealed to against it. Accordingly it exerts a tacit influence on the line of defence employed for other modes of assessing taxation. People feel obliged to argue that the State does more for the rich than for the poor, as a justification for its taking more from them: though this is in reality not true, for the rich would be far better able to protect themselves, in the absence of law or government, than the poor, and indeed would probably be successful in converting the poor into their slaves. Others, again, so far defer to the same conception of justice, as to maintain that all should pay an equal capitation tax for the protection of their persons (these being of equal value to all), and an unequal tax for the protection of their property, which is unequal. To this others reply, that the all of one man is as valuable to him as the all of another. From these confusions there is no other mode of extrication than the utilitarian.

Is, then the difference between the just and the Expedient a merely imaginary distinction? Have mankind been under a delusion in thinking that justice is a more sacred thing than policy, and that the latter ought only to be listened to after the former has been satisfied? By no means. The exposition we have given of the nature and origin of the sentiment, recognises a real distinction; and no one of those who profess the most

sublime contempt for the consequences of actions as an element in their morality, attaches more importance to the distinction than I do.

While I dispute the pretensions of any theory which sets up an imaginary standard of justice not grounded on utility, I account the justice which is grounded on utility to be the chief part, and incomparably the most sacred and binding part, of all morality. justice is a name for certain classes of moral rules, which concern the essentials of human well-being more nearly, and are therefore of more absolute obligation, than any other rules for the guidance of life; and the notion which we have found to be of the essence of the idea of justice, that of a right residing in an individual implies and testifies to this more binding obligation.

The moral rules which forbid mankind to hurt one another (in which we must never forget to include wrongful interference with each other's freedom) are more vital to human well-being than any maxims, however important, which only point out the best mode of managing some department of human affairs. They have also the peculiarity, that they are the main element in determining the whole of the social feelings of mankind. It is their observance which alone preserves peace among human beings: if obedience to them were not the rule, and disobedience the exception, every one would see in every one else an enemy, against whom he must be perpetually guarding himself. What is hardly less important, these are the precepts which mankind have the strongest and the most direct inducements for impressing upon one another. By merely giving to each other prudential instruction or exhortation, they may gain, or think they gain, nothing: in inculcating on each other the duty of positive beneficence they have an unmistakable interest, but far less in degree: a person may possibly not need the benefits of others; but he always needs that they should not do him hurt. Thus the moralities which protect every individual from being harmed by others, either directly or by being hindered in his freedom of pursuing his own good, are at once those which he himself has most at heart, and those which he has the strongest interest in publishing and enforcing by word and deed. It is by a person's observance of these that his fitness to exist as one of the fellowship of human beings is tested and decided; for on that depends his being a nuisance or not to those with whom he is in contact.

Now it is these moralities primarily which compose the obligations of justice. The most marked cases of injustice, and those which give the tone to the feeling of repugnance which characterises the sentiment, are acts of wrongful aggression, or wrongful exercise of power over some one; the next are those which consist in wrongfully withholding from him something which is his due; in both cases, inflicting on him a positive hurt, either in the form of direct suffering, or of the privation of some good which he had reasonable ground, either of a physical or of a social kind, for counting upon.

The same powerful motives which command the observance of these primary moralities, enjoin the punishment of those who violate them; and as the impulses of self-defence, of defence of others, and of vengeance, are all called forth against such persons, retribution, or evil for evil, becomes closely connected with the sentiment of justice, and is universally included in the idea. Good for good is also one of the dictates of justice; and this, though its social utility is evident, and though it carries with it a natural human feeling, has not at first sight that obvious connection with hurt or injury, which, existing in the most elementary cases of
just and unjust, is the source of the characteristic intensity of the sentiment. But the connection, though less obvious, is not less real. He who accepts benefits, and denies a return of them when needed, inflicts a real hurt, by disappointing one of the most natural

and reasonable of expectations, and one which he must at least tacitly have encouraged, otherwise the benefits would seldom have been conferred. The important rank, among human evils and wrongs, of the disappointment of expectation, is shown in the fact that it constitutes the principal criminality of two such highly immoral acts as a breach of friendship and a breach of promise. Few hurts which human beings can sustain are greater, and none wound more, than when that on which they habitually and with full assurance relied, fails them in the hour of need; and few wrongs are greater than this mere withholding of good; none excite more resentment, either in the person suffering, or in a sympathising spectator. The principle, therefore, of giving to each what they deserve, that is, good for good as well as evil for evil, is not only included within the idea of justice as we have defined it, but is a proper object of that intensity of sentiment, which places the just, in human estimation, above the simply Expedient.

Most of the maxims of justice current in the world, and commonly appealed to in its transactions, are simply instrumental to carrying into effect the principles of justice which we have now spoken of. That a person is only responsible for what he has done voluntarily, or could voluntarily have avoided; that it is unjust to condemn any person unheard; that the punishment ought to be proportioned to
the offence, and the like, are maxims intended to prevent the just principle of evil for evil from being perverted to the infliction of evil without that justification.

The greater part of these common maxims have come into use from the practice of courts of justice, which have been naturally led to a more complete recognition and elaboration than was likely to suggest itself to others, of the rules necessary to enable them to fulfil their double function, of inflicting punishment when due, and of awarding to each person his right.

That first of judicial virtues, impartiality, is an obligation of justice, partly for the reason last mentioned; as being a necessary condition of the fulfilment of the other obligations of justice. But this is not the only source of the exalted rank, among human obligations, of those maxims of equality and impartiality, which, both in popular estimation and in that of the most enlightened, are included among the precepts of justice. In one point of view, they may be considered as corollaries from the principles already laid down. If it is a duty to do to each according to his deserts, returning good for good as well as repressing evil by evil, it necessarily follows that we should treat all equally well (when no higher duty forbids) who have deserved equally well of us, and that society should treat all equally well who have deserved equally well of it, that is, who have deserved equally well absolutely. This is the highest abstract standard of social and distributive justice; towards which all institutions, and the efforts of all virtuous citizens, should be made in the utmost possible degree to converge.

But this great moral duty rests upon a still deeper foundation, being a direct emanation from the first principle of morals, and not a mere logical corollary from secondary or derivative doctrines. It is involved in the very meaning of Utility, or the Greatest Happiness Principle. That principle is a mere form of words without rational signification, unless one person's happiness, supposed equal in degree (with the proper allowance made for kind), is counted for exactly as much as another's. Those conditions being supplied, Bentham's dictum, "everybody to count for one, nobody for more than one," might be written under the principle of utility as an explanatory commentary. 3 The equal claim of everybody to happi-

3

This implication, in the first principle of the utilitarian scheme, of perfect impartiality between persons, is regarded by Mr. Herbert Spencer (in his Social Statics) as a disproof of the pretensions of utility to be a sufficient guide to right; since (he says) the principle of utility presupposes the anterior principle, that everybody has an equal right to happiness. It may be more correctly described as supposing that equal amounts of happiness are equally desirable, whether felt by the same or by different persons. This, however, is not a pre-supposition; not a premise needful to support the principle of utility, but the very principle itself; for what is the principle of utility, if it be not that "happiness" and "desirable" are synonymous terms? If there is any anterior principle implied, it can be no other than this, that the truths of arithmetic are applicable to the valuation of happiness, as of all other measurable quantities.[Mr. Herbert Spencer, in a private communication on the subject of the preceding Note, objects to being considered an opponent of utilitarianism, and states that he regards happiness as the ultimate end of morality; but deems that end only partially attainable by empirical generalisations from the observed results of conduct, and completely attainable only by deducing, from the laws of life and the conditions of existence, what kinds of action necessarily tend to produce happiness, and what kinds to produce unhappiness. What the exception of the word "necessarily," I have no dissent to express from this doctrine; and (omitting that word) I am not aware that any modern advocate of utilitarianism is of a different opinion. Bentham, certainly, to whom in the Social Statics Mr. Spencer particularly referred, is, least of all writers, chargeable with unwillingness to deduce the effect of actions on happiness from the laws of human nature and the universal conditions of human life. The common charge against him is of relying too exclusively upon such deductions, and declining altogether to be bound by the generalisations from specific experience which Mr. Spencer thinks that utilitarians generally confine themselves to. My own opinion (and, as I collect, Mr. Spencer's) is, that in ethics, as in all other branches of scientific study, the

ness in the estimation of the moralist and the legislator, involves an equal claim to all the means of happiness, except in so far as the inevitable conditions of human life, and the general interest, in which that of every individual is included, set limits to the maxim; and those limits ought to be strictly construed. As every other maxim of justice, so this is by no means applied or held applicable universally; on the contrary, as I have already remarked, it bends to every person's ideas of social expediency. But in whatever case it is deemed applicable at all, it is held to be the dictate of justice. All persons are deemed to have a right to equality of treatment, except when some recognised social expediency requires the reverse. And hence all social inequalities which have ceased to be considered expedient, assume the character not of simple inexpediency, but of injustice, and appear so tyrannical, that people are apt to wonder how they ever could have. been tolerated; forgetful that they themselves perhaps tolerate other inequalities under an equally mistaken notion of expediency, the correction of which would make that which they approve seem quite as monstrous as what they have at last learnt to

condemn. The entire history of social improvement has been a series of transitions, by which one custom or institution after another, from being a supposed primary necessity

consilience of the results of both these processes, each corroborating and verifying the other, is requisite to give to
any general proposition the kind degree of evidence
which constitutes scientific proof.]

of social existence, has passed into the rank of a universally stigmatised injustice and tyranny. So it has been with the distinctions of slaves and freemen, nobles and serfs, patricians and plebeians; and so it will be, and in part already is, with the aristocracies of colour, race, and sex.

It appears from what has been said, that justice is a name for certain moral requirements, which, regarded collectively, stand higher in the scale of social utility, and are therefore of more paramount obligation, than any others; though particular cases may occur in which some other social duty is so important, as to overrule any one of the general maxims of justice. Thus, to save a life, it may not only be allowable, but a duty, to steal, or take by force, the necessary food or medicine, or to kidnap, and compel to officiate, the only qualified medical practitioner. In such cases, as we do not call anything justice which is not a virtue, we usually say, not that justice must give way to some other moral principle, but that what is just in ordinary cases is, by reason of that other principle, not just in the particular case. By this useful accommodation of language, the character of indefeasibility attributed to justice is kept up, and we are saved from the necessity of maintaining that there can be laudable injustice.

The considerations which have now been adduced resolve, I conceive, the only real difficulty in the utilitarian theory of morals. It has always been evident that all cases of justice are also cases of expediency: the difference is in the peculiar sentiment which attaches to the former, as contradistinguished from the latter.
If this characteristic sentiment has been sufficiently accounted for; if there is no necessity to assume for it any peculiarity of origin; if it is simply the natural feeling of resentment, moralised by being made coextensive with the demands of social good; and if this feeling not only does but ought to exist in all the classes of cases to which the idea of justice corresponds; that idea no longer presents itself as a stumbling-block to the utilitarian ethics.

Justice remains the appropriate name for certain social utilities which are vastly more important, and therefore more absolute and imperative, than any others are as a class (though not more so than others may be in particular cases); and which, therefore, ought to be, as well as naturally are, guarded by a sentiment not only different in degree, but also in kind; distinguished from the milder feeling which attaches to the mere idea of promoting human pleasure or convenience, at once by the more definite nature of its commands, and by the sterner character of its sanctions.

THE END